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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Luke Johnston has given years of study to the subject of Bible versions and the history of the Bible. He holds a Doctor of Educational Ministry degree and a PhD in Biblical Studies and is completing his final project for the Doctor of Ministry degree at Luther Rice College and Seminary. Most importantly, he received his Bible training under the God-ordained authority of the local church. His mindset, training, and, above all, his faith in the Word of God were formed through the instruction he received within his church. From that foundation, he went on to pursue advanced degrees from accredited institutions. He has found, however, that while these institutions are not ordained of God and often fall into apostasy, they also have a tendency to take the Word of God out of the hands of men, whereas the local church has always done the exact opposite. The church instilled in him a steadfast faith in Scripture and gave him both the training and the desire to defend its authority and preservation. It is out of that conviction, and with a burden to strengthen the faith of others, that he has written this book, to contend for the King James Bible as the preserved and perfect Word of God.

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GLOSSARY OF TERMS

Alexandrian Text (Alexandrian line) — A divergent text-type associated with Alexandria and figures like Origen; championed in codices such as Vaticanus (B) and Sinaiticus (ℵ). It survives in far fewer manuscripts than the Byzantine tradition (Minority Text), and in many disputed passages, modern critical editors—and, by extension, modern Bible versions—give substantial weight to its readings.

Apocrypha (Old Testament apocryphal content) — Jewish religious writings not recognized as inspired Scripture; in later Greek codices, they are intermingled with canonical books, which is one reason those codices are viewed critically in these materials.

Apparatus (critical apparatus) — The notes printed at the foot of a critical edition of the Hebrew or Greek text. They list variant readings, the witnesses that support them, and sometimes proposed corrections. A reading in the apparatus is not the reading printed in the main text, yet modern translators often adopt apparatus readings in their English Bibles.

Ben Chayyim Masoretic Text (Second Rabbinic Bible) — The Hebrew Old Testament edited by Jacob ben Chayyim and printed by Daniel Bomberg at Venice in 1524–25. It became the standard printed Hebrew text for the next four hundred years and is the Hebrew text that underlies the Old Testament of the King James Bible.

Byzantine Text-type (Antiochian/Syrian line) — The form of the Greek New Testament found in the great majority of surviving later Greek manuscripts and widely transmitted throughout the Byzantine Greek-speaking church (Majority

Text). It is a broad manuscript tradition, not one manuscript or one printed edition.

Canon / Canonical — The recognized collection of books received as inspired Scripture. "Canonical" means belonging to that collection; "noncanonical" describes writings outside it.

Clementine Vulgate — The edition of the Latin Vulgate issued under Pope Clement VIII in 1592. It remained Rome's official Latin Bible until the Nova Vulgata of 1979.

Codex — An ancient manuscript made in book form, with leaves joined along one side, as distinguished from a scroll. Vaticanus and Sinaiticus are codices.

Codex Alexandrinus (A) — A fifth-century manuscript from Alexandria; mixed in character—Byzantine in the Gospels and Alexandrian elsewhere.

Codex Sinaiticus (ℵ / Aleph) — A fourth-century uncial manuscript discovered at St. Catherine's, extensively corrected and often at variance with Vaticanus; it also includes noncanonical works.

Codex Vaticanus (B) — A fourth-century uncial manuscript prioritized by modern editors; notable for significant omissions and for containing apocryphal material alongside Scripture. Its New Testament portion is physically lost after Hebrews 9:14. Its Greek Old Testament also contains the Apocrypha.

Coherence-Based Genealogical Method (CBGM) — The computer-assisted method developed at the Institute for New Testament Textual Research in Münster for the Editio Critica Maior. It compares the agreements of whole manuscript texts in order to reconstruct what its editors call the "initial text."

Comma Johanneum — Latin for "the Johannine clause." It refers to the words of 1 John 5:7–8, "in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one. And there are three that bear witness in earth," which the King James Bible contains and the modern critical text omits.

Conflation — A longer reading supposedly formed by combining two shorter readings found in different manuscripts. Westcott and Hort used alleged conflations to argue that the Byzantine Text was late. See the chapter on the two textual streams.

Council of Trent — The Roman Catholic council (1545–1563) called to answer the Reformation. In 1546 it placed the Apocrypha in the canon, set "traditions" beside Scripture, and declared the Latin Vulgate "authentic."

Critical Text (Nestle–Aland / UBS) — The modern eclectic Greek editions of the New Testament (e.g., NA/UBS) that rely heavily on Alexandrian witnesses such as Vaticanus and Sinaiticus and function as the base for modern translations.

Dead Sea Scrolls (including 1QIsa^{a} and 1QIsa^{b} / Isaiah B) — Pre-Christian Hebrew manuscripts from Qumran that substantially align with the Masoretic tradition. The Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa^{a}) and the "Isaiah B" scroll (1QIsa^{b}) closely match the Masoretic Text of the KJV. They are considered to be some of the oldest biblical manuscripts in existence.

Deuterocanonical books — Rome's name for the books of the Apocrypha that the Council of Trent placed in the Old Testament, such as Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Ecclesiasticus, Baruch, and 1–2 Maccabees.

Douay–Rheims — The Roman Catholic English Bible translated from the Latin Vulgate. The New Testament was published at Rheims in 1582 and the Old Testament at Douay in 1609–10.

Dynamic (Functional) Equivalence — A meaning-for-meaning (thought-for-thought) approach that prioritizes conveying the thought of the text being translated rather than mirroring each original word; contrasted with formal equivalence.

Eclectic Text — A text produced by selecting readings from different manuscripts and text traditions rather than following one manuscript or textual tradition throughout. Modern Nestle–Aland and UBS editions are eclectic texts.

Editio Critica Maior (ECM) — The "major critical edition" of the Greek New Testament prepared at Münster. Its published volumes (Acts, the Catholic Letters, Mark, and Revelation) now determine the Nestle–Aland and United Bible Societies text of those books.

Edition — A particular published form of a text prepared by one or more editors. Erasmus's, Stephanus's, Beza's, and the Elzevirs' Greek texts are printed editions, not individual manuscripts.

Formal (Verbal) Equivalence — A translation method aiming for a close, word-for-word rendering from the source language, preserving the original structure and words as much as possible.

Hexapla — Origen's six-column arrangement of the Old Testament (third century A.D.). It set side by side the Hebrew text, the Hebrew written in Greek letters, and the Greek versions of Aquila, Symmachus, the Septuagint as revised by Origen, and Theodotion. Only fragments survive.

Inerrant / Inerrancy — That the Scriptures are without error.

Infallible / Infallibility — That Scripture, as the product of the God who cannot lie, cannot fail or mislead; it is wholly trustworthy in all it teaches.

Initial text (Ausgangstext) — The term now used by the editors of the modern critical text for the text they reconstruct: a hypothetical form of the text from which the surviving manuscripts derive, which they distinguish from the original text written by the author.

Inspiration (including "given by inspiration of God") — God's direct, supernatural action by which the biblical writers received and accurately wrote down His revelation; as God's own "breath," this act is inseparable from His ongoing preservation of those words.

INTF (Institut für Neutestamentliche Textforschung) manuscript counts — The Institute for New Testament Textual Research in Münster maintains the official register of catalogued Greek New Testament witnesses. Its published count lists approximately 5,700 entries, including papyri, majuscules, minuscules, and lectionaries. Most contain only part of the New Testament, and the count changes as manuscripts are discovered, reclassified, combined, or removed.

"Jot and tittle" — Hebrew's smallest letter and smallest stroke of the pen; Jesus used these terms to show that even the minutest marks of the Law stand under God's guarantee.

Lectionaries — Books arranged for the public reading of selected Scripture passages in churches.

Majority Text — A Greek New Testament text produced by following readings supported by the majority or consensus of surviving Greek manuscripts. Majority Text editions represent the Byzantine tradition, but they are not absolutely identical to every Byzantine manuscript, to one another, or to the Textus Receptus, though they are closely connected.

Manuscript — A handwritten copy of all or part of a biblical book. A manuscript may be a complete codex, several leaves, or only a small fragment.

Marginal note / Alternative reading — Information printed beside the biblical text giving another possible translation, a more literal rendering, a cross-reference, or a textual observation. In modern versions, notes that question whether words belong in the text tend to cast doubt in the reader's mind. The 1611 King James Bible also printed marginal notes, giving literal renderings, other possible translations, and some textual information (see the chapter "From the Received Text to the King James Bible").

Masoretic Text (MT) — The traditional Hebrew text preserved by Jewish scribes (Masoretes) using rigorous copying controls; it represents the conservatively guarded Old Testament used among the Jews, and used to translate the Old Testament for the KJV.

Nova Vulgata (New Vulgate) — The revision of the Latin Vulgate promulgated by Pope John Paul II in 1979 as Rome's official edition, corrected where the old Vulgate departed from modern critical editions of the Hebrew and Greek.

Old Latin / Vulgate — "Old Latin" describes the diverse Latin translations that circulated before the Vulgate. The Vulgate is the later standardized Latin Bible associated with Jerome.

Jerome revised the Latin Gospels using Greek manuscripts and translated or revised much of the Old Testament with reference to Hebrew; the history of the remaining New Testament books is more complicated.

Original autographs — The first manuscripts penned by the biblical authors or their authorized scribes; the initial physical writings from which copies were made.

Original languages / Source text — The languages in which Scripture was first written: Hebrew for most of the Old Testament, Aramaic for small portions of the Old Testament, and Greek for the New Testament. "Hebrew text" or "Greek text" refers to wording in those languages, whether found in manuscripts or presented in a printed edition.

Papyrus / Papyri — Writing material made from the papyrus plant, and the manuscripts written on it. The earliest surviving New Testament fragments are papyri, designated P45, P46, P66, P75, and so on. Nearly all of them come from Egypt.

Patristic quotations / Church Fathers — Citations of Scripture found in early Christian writers, used as external witnesses in establishing the text.

Perfect — From the Latin perficere, meaning "complete." The biblical definition follows the same meaning: complete, entire, and lacking nothing needed (e.g., Job 1:1, 8; 2:3; 2 Tim. 3:17).

Peshitta (Syriac) — The standard Syriac translation of the Bible used by several Eastern churches. The New Testament Peshitta probably reached its standard form in the late fourth or early fifth century, but could be as early as the second century. It often supports readings preserved in the Byzantine or Textus Receptus tradition.

Plenary (Plenary Inspiration) — The view that inspiration extends to the entire Bible, not just parts of it; Scripture is wholly inspired in its totality.

Preservation (of Scripture) — God's providential safeguarding of His words through history so that His people continue to possess His Word, in every marking and individual word; tied to His unchangeable nature and promises.

Purification (of God's Word) — The refining of God's words (Ps. 12:6), applied to the historical process by which God's Word is kept pure and recognized among His people.

Reading / Textual variant — A particular wording found in a textual witness. A textual variant is a difference between witnesses, such as spelling, word order, omission, addition, or substitution. Most variants are minor, though some affect larger words or passages.

Recension — A deliberate, organized revision of a text by an editor or group of editors. Westcott and Hort claimed that the Byzantine Text was produced by such a recension at Antioch. No historical record of that event exists.

Revised Version (RV) — The revision of the King James Bible begun under the Convocation of Canterbury in 1870. The New Testament was published in 1881 and the whole Bible in 1885. Its Greek text departed from the Received Text in thousands of places under the influence of Westcott and Hort.

Revision — A translation produced by reviewing and editing an earlier translation rather than beginning entirely anew. The KJV translators revised earlier English Bibles while comparing them with the Hebrew and Greek.

Septuagint (LXX) — A collective label for ancient Greek renderings of the Old Testament; the earliest complete forms appear centuries after the alleged third-century B.C. origin story and include the Apocrypha, reflecting Alexandrian influence rather than a single, unified pre-Christian edition.

Supplied words / Italics — Words needed to express the meaning clearly in English even though they do not correspond to a separate Hebrew or Greek word. Later KJV editions commonly identify these words with italic type.

Text — The actual wording transmitted by a manuscript, translation, or printed edition. A manuscript is the physical object; the text is the wording it contains. Many manuscripts can transmit the same general text while differing in individual readings.

Text-type / Textual tradition — A broad group of manuscripts that share characteristic readings. A text-type is not one manuscript, nor does it mean that every manuscript in the group is identical.

Textual criticism — The scientific, man-made philosophy used to identify the text of Scripture from surviving witnesses; it seeks to answer the question, "What did the original authors write?"

Textual witness — Any source that preserves evidence about the wording of Scripture, including Greek or Hebrew manuscripts, ancient translations, lectionaries, and quotations by early Christian writers.

Textus Receptus (TR) / Received Text — The name given to a succession of closely related printed Greek New Testaments beginning with Erasmus in 1516 and continued through

editions by Stephanus, Beza, and the Elzevirs. The Elzevir edition of 1633 supplied the expression from which "Textus Receptus" was derived. These editions are predominantly Byzantine in character, but they differ from one another slightly and are not absolutely identical to modern Byzantine or Majority Text editions, though they are closely connected.

Traditional Text — A term used by some writers for the Greek New Testament text historically received and used by the church. Because the term is used in different ways, this book uses it broadly for the Byzantine and Received Text tradition while distinguishing the manuscript tradition from the later printed Textus Receptus editions.

Translation / Version — A rendering of Scripture from one language into another. "Translation" may describe either the process or the resulting work; "version" ordinarily identifies a particular translation, such as the Geneva Bible or King James Bible.

Uncials / Minuscules (Greek manuscript categories) — Uncials use large, continuous capital letters; minuscules are later manuscripts written in smaller, cursive-style script.

Waldenses (Vaudois) — Believers of the Alpine valleys of Piedmont and southern France who possessed Scriptures in their own tongue and were persecuted by Rome. In 1532 they joined the Reformation and sponsored Olivétan's French Bible (1535).

For Full Sizes of the Charts in This Book, Scan This QR Code:



WHY THIS BOOK, THOUGH OTHERS EXIST

Some may ask why another book on this subject is needed when shelves already hold volumes that argue for the same conclusion. The answer lies in both method and aim.

1. **Concise yet thorough.** Many books that defend the King James Bible stretch on for hundreds more pages than necessary. Their arguments are often weighed down by commentary, tangents, or extended narrative. While such material may have value in its own place, this book is designed to be "straight over the plate." It says what needs to be said, no less, no more. The goal is to be concise and yet thorough. There are plenty of "weeds" to get into in this subject that are well worth exploring. For these areas, I have provided a recommended reading list at the end.

2. **Documented carefully.** Another weakness found in similar works is the lack of clear documentation. Some provide little to no citation for key claims; others reference sources in ways that are vague or confusing. In contrast, this book points you directly to the evidence. Every crucial statement is accompanied by traceable documentation so that you can verify the key information on this subject. Also, it uses original sourcing wherever possible. Another common trait found in other writings on this subject is the use of "biased" source lists. In this book I tried to avoid this wherever possible.

3. **Up to date.** Some of the best-known works on this topic were written fifty years ago or more. In the time since, hundreds of manuscripts have been catalogued, new archaeological finds have come to light, and much has changed in the field. This book accounts for the most recent

data without discarding the proven testimony of earlier witnesses.

4. **Built on faith, not just evidence.** Many defenders of the King James Bible present strong factual cases but build their argument on the wrong foundation. They start with human reasoning and work their way toward faith. This book takes the opposite path: it begins with the promises of God's Word and lets the evidence follow in its proper place. The structure is deliberately Scripture first, history second. Without that order, even good conclusions will falter under the right challenge.

5. **Not a "pseudo-King James" position.** A final distinction must be made here. Some of the most respected voices in this debate ultimately rest their authority in the Greek Textus Receptus rather than in the King James Bible itself. This opens the door to problems, since there are multiple printed TR editions with notable differences amongst themselves. That position leaves the believer without a final authority. This book does not take that path. It contends unapologetically that the King James Bible itself is the purified, preserved Word of God in English.

6. **Charts and visual aids**. These are used to assist in grasping concepts that might otherwise be difficult to understand.

7. **Balanced tone.** Some books on this topic come across as harsh, attacking anyone who disagrees. Others are so soft that they never make a clear stand. This book tries to avoid both extremes wherever possible by speaking plainly and dealing in the facts of the matter.

INTRODUCTION

The pastor's voice rang out as he lifted his Bible high above the pulpit. "This is the Word of God! Infallible, inerrant, inspired! Trust it with your life, trust it with your eternity!" The congregation erupted with "Amens." Pens underlined words. Children were nudged to listen closely.

A young man sat three rows back, his own Bible open on his lap. He heard the pastor preaching about trusting every word. He believed him, but weeks later, in a membership class, he was handed the church's doctrinal statement. He scanned it until one line stopped him cold:

"We believe the Scriptures are inspired, inerrant, and infallible, **in the original autographs**."

His stomach dropped. He read it again. The originals? Manuscripts written thousands of years ago and long since turned to dust? He looked down at the book in his lap—the same book the pastor had lifted and called "the Word of God." Suddenly, his mind began to race. *If this Bible is not really inerrant, what am I holding?*

He thought of the **safety instructions at the steel mill** where his father worked. If those manuals were "mostly right," men lost fingers. If even one warning line was missing, the furnace could claim a life. He thought of the **prescription label** on his mother's medicine. If it was "accurate in the original notes from the lab," but the copy in the bottle was flawed, what good was it? *One wrong word and the dose could kill.* He thought of his younger brother learning to read from a **phonics chart**. If some of the words were off, just one letter dropped or changed, the

whole foundation would be warped. How could he ever learn the language if he couldn't trust the chart?

And now here he was, being told to trust his eternity, not his body, not his job, not even his brother's reading, but his *soul*, to a book his own church admitted was not truly infallible. The young man stared at his Bible and asked the question that would not leave him:

If the Word of God is only perfect in manuscripts that vanished thousands of years ago, what am I really holding in my hands today?

The Real Issue at Stake

When people debate Bible translations, the talk usually slides into preferences: Which reads easier? Which sounds smoother? Which sells better? Those are side issues. The first questions we have to face are these:

Has God preserved His words, or not? Does a perfect Word of God exist today? And if it does, where can I find it?

Wesley Huff, a well-known voice on manuscripts and textual criticism (MA in Theological Studies; PhD candidate in Theological Studies and Sacred and Canonical Texts, NT concentration), was asked in 2025 whether a perfect Bible exists. His reply:

> "I don't know if I'd use the word 'perfect' because that's kind of a tricky word. The word perfect implies flawless…"[1]

If inspiration is true but perfect preservation of every word is false, then what makes the Bible unique from other books? If God gave His words and then lost them in the sands of Egypt or the vaults of Rome, then His promises ring hollow. But if He both inspired *and preserved* His words, then we can know with certainty that we can have access to the very words of God.

This book is not written for mere academic sparring over manuscripts, methods, lineages, etc., but to instill faith back in the Word of God. For *"faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God"* (**Rom. 10:17**). If the Word is unstable, faith is unstable. If the Word is sure, faith is sure.

Why This Book

This book is not written to score points in debates, nor to stir division among believers. It is written to strengthen faith. It is written for the plowboy Tyndale dreamed of when he said,

> "I defy the pope and all his laws … if God spare my life ere many years, I will cause a boy that driveth the plough, shall know more of the scripture then thou dost."[2]

It is for the ordinary Christian who wants to hold in his hands the very words of God, without doubt. Tyndale again spoke

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[1] "Part 1: Answering King James Only w/ Wes Huff," *Cultish* (YouTube video), January 8, 2025, 33:16–33:33, posted by Apologia Studios, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yLGTS6Q82kE.

[2] John Foxe, *Actes and Monuments* (London: John Day, 1563), 570.

against the "scholarship" of his day and its tendency to take the Word of God out of the hands of common men when he said,

> "In the universities they have ordained that no man shall look on the Scripture until he be nuzzled in heathen learning eight or nine years, and armed with false principles with which he is clean shut out of the understanding of the Scripture."[3]

This book is written to show that preservation and purification are not theories; they are promises kept by God Himself.

The Word Must Be Believed and Obeyed

The issue addressed in this book matters. The Bible a man holds can affect his faith, his doctrine, his preaching, and his understanding of the Lord. Words matter because God chose to reveal Himself through words. A missing word, a changed word, or a weakened statement can affect what a passage teaches.

However, the importance of this issue must never become an excuse for neglecting the rest of what the Bible commands. The Lord Jesus rebuked the Pharisees because they were careful about certain matters while neglecting the weightier matters of the law:

> **Matthew 23:23**

"Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye pay tithe of mint and anise and cummin, and have omitted the weightier matters

---

[3] William Tyndale, *The Practice of Prelates*, in *Expositions and Notes on Sundry Portions of the Holy Scriptures, Together with The Practice of Prelates*, ed. Henry Walter, Parker Society (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1849), 291.

of the law, judgment, mercy, and faith: these ought ye to have done, and not to leave the other undone."

Notice that Christ did not tell them to abandon their obedience. He said, "these ought ye to have done." Their problem was that they emphasized one part while neglecting judgment, mercy, and faith.

The same warning applies to the subject of the Bible. A man may hold the King James Bible, understand the manuscript evidence, explain the differences between Antioch and Alexandria, and still be proud, harsh, uncharitable, disobedient, and spiritually barren. Possessing the right Bible does not excuse a wrong spirit.

Paul wrote:

1 Corinthians 8:1

"…Knowledge puffeth up, but charity edifieth."

Knowledge is good when it brings us into greater submission to God. Knowledge becomes dangerous when it becomes a source of pride. The purpose of understanding the preservation of Scripture is not to make us feel superior to others. It is to make us more certain of what God has said and therefore more emboldened to believe and obey it.

James 1:22 says:

"But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves."

The Bible was not preserved merely so that it could be studied, analyzed, defended, and placed back upon a shelf. It was preserved so that it could be believed, preached, obeyed, memorized, taught to our children, and carried to the lost.

There are sincere believers who use modern versions because they have never studied the textual or translational issues involved. Some of them love Christ, faithfully serve their churches, witness to the lost, give sacrificially, demonstrate humility, and seek to obey the truth they have. Their sincerity does not make every reading in their Bible correct, but neither should their lack of knowledge cause us to judge their heart, their salvation, or their entire Christian life.

We must distinguish between evaluating a Bible and judging the person holding it. A faulty reading does not become true because a sincere believer reads it. At the same time, a sincere believer does not become our enemy merely because he has not yet learned what we have learned.

The servant of the Lord is commanded:

2 Timothy 2:24–25

"And the servant of the Lord must not strive; but be gentle unto all men, apt to teach, patient, In meekness instructing those that oppose themselves; if God peradventure will give them repentance to the acknowledging of the truth;"

Truth is not weakened by meekness. Charity does not require compromise. We are to speak the truth, but we are to speak it "in love" (Eph. 4:15).

The highest position is not merely to say, "I have the right Bible." The highest position is to possess the pure Word of God, understand why it is pure, believe every word of it, obey what it commands, and faithfully give it to others.

We must not become like the servant who buried what his lord had entrusted to him (Matt. 25:18–25). The King James Bible is not a private treasure to be hidden in anger or guarded as a badge of superiority. It is the light that must be carried into a dark world.

Therefore, this book is not merely an argument for possessing the King James Bible. It is a call to believe it, obey it, preach it, defend it with charity, and place it into the hands of others.

To keep the argument clear, here is the whole path before we begin:

1. God inspired His words and markings, not merely His ideas.

2. God promised that those words would be preserved.

3. The Bible itself calls faithful copies Scripture.

4. God committed the Old Testament oracles to the Jews and preserved them in the Hebrew tradition.

5. God placed the New Testament in the life of believing churches, where it was read, copied, preached, and carried.

6. Those words passed from manuscripts into printed Hebrew and Greek texts and then into English translations.

7. Earlier English Bibles prepared the language, and the King James translators brought the preserved text and English Bible tradition together.

8. The result, from the faith-based position of this book, is the King James Bible as the preserved and purified Word of God in English.

The historical process may be pictured simply:

Original writings → handwritten copies → textual traditions → printed Hebrew and Greek texts → English translations

As you will see throughout this book, English Bibles may differ for two main reasons: first, because they follow different Hebrew or Greek readings, and second, because they translate the same reading differently. In many cases, both factors are involved.

The Bible is not just a book; it is the Book. It is the foundation for all doctrine, the sword in all spiritual warfare, the seed of all revival; it is everything we need for life and godliness (**2 Pet. 1:3**). The central question before us is not whether man has been faithful in guarding it; he has not. The question is whether God has been faithful in keeping His promise to preserve it. This book contends He has. And that preserved Word, for the English-speaking world, is the King James Bible.

PART I: FAITH-BASED

INSPIRATION: WHAT GOD DID ONCE

For nearly all of church history, Christians have been in broad agreement concerning the **inspiration** of Scripture. Inspiration literally means "**God-breathed**." It refers to the **original writing** of Scripture as the Holy Ghost moved men to record the very words of God.

We see this in such verses as **2 Peter 1:21**, which says:

> *"For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost."*

Another familiar passage concerning inspiration is **2 Timothy 3:15–17**:

> *"And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures, which are able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus. All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works."*

David testified of this process in **2 Samuel 23:2:**

> *"The Spirit of the LORD spake by me, and his word was in my tongue."*

Notice the precision of David's statement. He did not say that God merely gave him the general idea of what to say. He declared that the **Spirit Himself spoke through him** and placed the **very words** upon his tongue.

The prophet Jeremiah spoke the same truth in **Jeremiah 1:9**:

> *"Then the LORD put forth his hand, and touched my mouth. And the LORD said unto me, Behold, I have put my words in thy mouth."*

These men understood that what flowed from their lips was not their invention, but God's words.

The Lord Jesus Christ Himself confirmed this view of inspiration. In **Matthew 22:43–44**, when debating the Pharisees, He rooted His argument on a single word from **Psalm 110**:

> *"How then doth David in spirit call him Lord…?"*

Christ based the entire doctrine of His Lordship on the Spirit's exact wording through David. He did not treat Scripture as a general thought but as though every word mattered.

In **Hebrews 3:7** we read,

> *"Wherefore (as the Holy Ghost saith, To day if ye will hear his voice, Harden not your hearts…)."*

Yet the quotation that follows comes from **Psalm 95**. David wrote it, but Hebrews says the Holy Ghost is the one speaking. When God moved in David to write those words, they were not the words of David; they were the words of God; this is inspiration.

That is why Jesus declared in **Matthew 4:4**,

> *"Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God."*

Our Lord did not say "every thought," but "every word." Inspiration reaches to the level of words, even to the smallest strokes of letters, as He also said in **Matthew 5:18**:

> *"Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled."*

God breathes out words, not simply concepts.

An Early Witness: "The Scriptures Are Perfect"

This high view of the words of Scripture is not a modern invention of King James Bible believers. In the second century, Irenaeus of Lyons, a disciple of Polycarp, wrote:

> "The Scriptures are indeed perfect, since they were spoken by the Word of God and His Spirit."[4]

Irenaeus did not place that perfection in a set of autographs that had already begun to pass away. He spoke of the Scriptures his churches possessed and read, and he called them perfect because of their source: the Word of God and the Spirit of God. Edward Hills observed that such "has always been the attitude of all branches of the Christian Church toward the New Testament."[5]

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[4] Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 2.28.2; 3.1.1, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 1:399, 414.

[5] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), introduction, "Textual Criticism and Christian Faith," under "The Importance of Doctrine," e-book.

Christ Promised the New Testament Before It Was Written

The writing of the New Testament was not an unexpected development that arose years after Christ returned to heaven. Before His crucifixion, the Lord Jesus promised that the Holy Ghost would guide the apostles in remembering, recording, explaining, and completing His revelation.

> **John 14:25–26**
>
> *"These things have I spoken unto you, being yet present with you. But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in my name, he shall teach you all things, and bring all things to your remembrance, whatsoever I have said unto you."*

The Gospels were not produced merely by the memories of aging men. Christ promised that the Holy Ghost would bring His words to their remembrance. The disciples would not be forced to depend upon imperfect recollection. The same Spirit who originally gave the words would supervise their faithful recording.

Christ continued:

> **John 15:26–27**
>
> *"But when the Comforter is come, whom I will send unto you from the Father, even the Spirit of truth, which proceedeth from the Father, he shall testify of me: And ye also shall bear witness, because ye have been with me from the beginning."*

This promise reaches beyond the recording of Christ's spoken words. The apostles would bear an inspired witness concerning His life, death, resurrection, ascension, and the work He

continued through the early church. The book of Acts records that Spirit-led witness.

Jesus then said:

> **John 16:12–13**
>
> *"I have yet many things to say unto you, but ye cannot bear them now. Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak: and he will shew you things to come."*

The apostles had not yet received everything Christ intended to reveal. The Holy Ghost would guide them into all truth and would show them things to come. This promise provides the foundation for the doctrinal teaching of the Epistles and the prophetic revelation that reaches its completion in the book of Revelation.

These passages should not be divided into rigid compartments as though one verse referred only to the Gospels and another only to Acts. Together they establish the complete promise:

- The Holy Ghost would bring Christ's words to remembrance.
- The Holy Ghost would testify of Christ through the apostles.
- The Holy Ghost would guide them into all truth.
- The Holy Ghost would show them things to come.

Christ is the divine source of the New Testament. The Holy Ghost is the divine superintendent of its writing. The apostles

and prophets are the human instruments through whom those words were written.

The New Testament is therefore not a collection of uncertain memories, developing traditions, or later theological reflections. It is the promised written witness of Jesus Christ, given through the Holy Ghost exactly as He said it would be.

The Apostles Knew They Were Writing Scripture

The apostles themselves recognized that what they wrote carried the authority of God. Paul wrote, "If any man think himself to be a prophet, or spiritual, let him acknowledge that the things that I write unto you are the commandments of the Lord" (1 Cor. 14:37). Peter placed Paul's epistles alongside the Old Testament when he warned that the unlearned and unstable wrest them, "as they do also the other scriptures, unto their own destruction" (2 Pet. 3:16). Paul did the same with the words of Christ recorded by Luke: "For the scripture saith, Thou shalt not muzzle the ox that treadeth out the corn. And, The labourer is worthy of his reward" (1 Tim. 5:18). The first statement comes from Deuteronomy 25:4. The second is the Lord's own saying recorded in Luke 10:7, "the labourer is worthy of his hire." Paul called both "scripture."

Within the lifetime of the apostles, then, the New Testament writings were already being received, read, and quoted as Scripture. This matters for everything that follows. The churches that received these writings as the Word of God were the same churches that copied, read, and passed them on.

If the Bible were only partially inspired, or only in its "ideas," then we could never be sure which parts were trustworthy and which parts were human opinion. But because inspiration

extends to every word, we can open our Bibles with the confidence that we are hearing God's own voice.

However, a serious problem arises when modern scholarship affirms inspiration but limits the inerrancy of every word to the original writings alone. Many churches and seminaries describe the Bible as inspired, inerrant, infallible, and plenary, yet qualify those claims with three tragic words: "in the originals." When asked where the perfect Word of God exists today, they generally give one of two answers.

1. Perfection Existed Only in the Originals

According to this view, only the individual books first written by the biblical authors were completely pure and without error. Later copies and translations are considered reliable only to the extent that they reproduce those originals. Those original writings, however, disappeared long ago and have not existed for thousands of years. Furthermore, because they were written by different men in different places over many centuries, the complete set of original writings was never gathered into one Bible that anyone could see, read, and hold. Under this view, no complete and perfectly preserved Bible has ever existed as a single book.

2. Perfection Exists Collectively among the Evidence

Others argue that God's words have been preserved collectively among the thousands of surviving manuscripts, ancient versions, and modern translations. The perfect text is said to exist somewhere within all this evidence. Yet no single manuscript, Greek or Hebrew text, or translation is identified as containing every word perfectly. The perfect Word therefore exists only in a scattered form that no believer can see, read, or hold.

These views differ in where they place the pure Word of God, but they reach the same practical conclusion. The first places perfection in original writings that no longer exist; the second places it collectively among manuscripts and translations without identifying a single perfect form. Neither view points the believer to a presently available Bible and says without qualification, "This is the perfect, preserved Word of God, as promised by God Himself."

Thus, the prophecy of Amos is fulfilled:

> **Amos 8:11–12**
>
> *"Behold, the days come, saith the Lord GOD, that I will send a famine in the land, not a famine of bread, nor a thirst for water, but of hearing the words of the LORD: And they shall wander from sea to sea, and from the north even to the east, they shall run to and fro to seek the word of the LORD, and shall not find it."*

In the world we live in today, according to that line of thinking, nobody can find the Word of God, because in order to find it you would have to build a time machine and travel back thousands of years to the original inspired copy of Scripture. As soon as that copy was destroyed, within 20, 30, 40, 50, or even 100 years, the Word of God ceased to exist in that perfect form that was described.

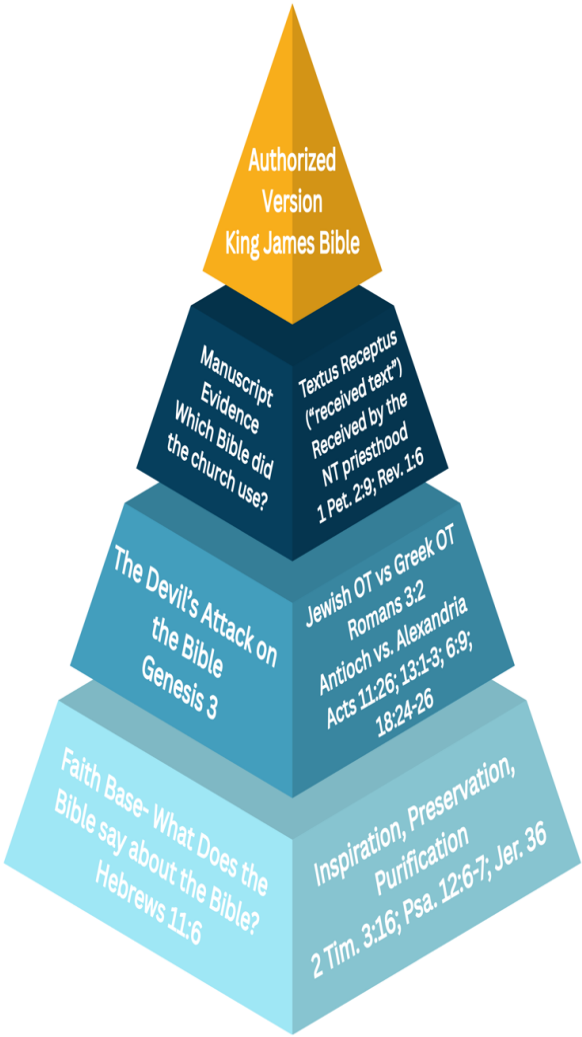
And so the question arises: What good, then, would inspiration be if it only existed in that form for those few years that the original copy lasted?

Wesley Huff, the New Testament manuscript scholar, once again said,

> "Here's the question that modern translators want to get down to, and this is the question when I do textual research that I want to get down to: What did the original author say?"[6]

However, the question we must answer throughout this book is: Is that a biblical view of the Word of God or is there more to the Bible than simply the inspiration and the original copy that lasted for only a few short years?

[6] "Part 2: Answering King James Only w/ Wes Huff," *Cultish* (YouTube video), January 14, 2025, 15:12–15:28, posted by Apologia Studios, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uC2vQkzgkco.


Authorized Version King James Bible
Manuscript Evidence Which Bible did the church use?
Textus Receptus ("received text") Received by the NT priesthood 1 Pet. 2:9; Rev. 1:6
The Devil's Attack on the Bible Genesis 3
Jewish OT vs Greek OT Romans 3:2 Antioch vs. Alexandria Acts 11:26; 13:1-3; 6:9; 18:24-26
Faith Base- What Does the Bible say about the Bible? Hebrews 11:6
Inspiration, Preservation, Purification 2 Tim. 3:16; Psa. 12:6-7; Jer. 36

Faith-Based?

My position, to put it simply, is this: I believe that the perfect, inerrant, infallible, plenary Word of God exists in the world today, and you can find it in a book. You can find it, every jot and every tittle, exactly as God preserved it, as He promised to. And I arrived at this position from a faith-based view of the Word of God.

The position begins with the promises of the Word of God and the principles taught in the Word of God, and then moves into the evidence from history. With a position that is founded in faith through the principles in the Bible, we can interpret this issue in history from God's perspective, not mankind's.

In Colossians we are told that as we received Christ Jesus the Lord, so we should walk in Him, rooted and established in the faith.

> **Colossians 2:6–7**
>
> *"As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in him: Rooted and built up in him, and stablished in the faith, as ye have been taught, abounding therein with thanksgiving."*

In Hebrews we are told that without faith it is impossible to please God.

> **Hebrews 11:6**
>
> *"But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him."*

From the very beginning of our Christian existence, from the very moment of regeneration, we were called to walk in faith and by faith.

So then, where does that faith come from? The Bible tells us:

> **Romans 10:17**
>
> *"So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God."*

Everything that we do ought to come from a faith-based relationship with God that is established in the Word of God.

Most Christians would admit to believing that. However, when it comes to "Where can I go and read, in a book, that plenary, perfect, infallible, inspired, inerrant Word of God that has been promised through Scripture?"—there is much hesitation.

Think about it: I am placing my eternity in the hands of the contents of this book. This book is supposed to be a reflection of God Himself. We see in John chapter 1 that the Word is God:

> **John 1:1, 14**
>
> *"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God… And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."*

Also, in John's first epistle, we see:

1 John 5:7

> *"For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one."*

And in **Psalm 138:2** we are told:

> *"…for thou hast magnified thy word above all thy name."*

How could God do this? Why would He do this, making His Word equal to Himself and even establishing His Word above His name? The answer is actually very simple: because our God is a perfect God, and when He speaks, He speaks perfectly. He does not take anything back, and there would be no reason He would separate Himself from what He says. He cannot say things that contradict Himself, and so He is inseparable from His Word, as established in the Word of God.

The Incarnate Word and the Inscripturated Word

The Bible uses the expression "the Word" in more than one closely related way. Jesus Christ is the Incarnate Word. The Bible is the inscripturated Word.

The word incarnate means "made flesh." **As John 1:1** and **John 1:14** have already shown, the eternal Word did not begin to exist in Bethlehem; He took upon Himself human nature while remaining fully God.

Revelation 19:13 gives Christ the same title at His return:

> *"And he was clothed with a vesture dipped in blood: and his name is called The Word of God."*

Jesus Christ is therefore the Incarnate Word, the eternal Word personally revealed in human flesh.

The Bible may properly be called the inscripturated Word because God caused His words to be committed to writing. The term does not mean that paper, ink, leather, or a printed volume became divine. It means that the revelation and words of God were placed into written form through the prophets and apostles under the inspiration of the Holy Ghost.

The Incarnate Word and the inscripturated Word must be distinguished, *but they must never be separated*.

Jesus Christ is a divine Person. The Bible is not a fourth person of the Godhead. Christ is not merely a book, and a printed Bible is not Jesus Christ in physical form. We must not confuse the Person of Jesus with the written revelation He has given.

Yet the two are inseparably joined in source, truth, authority, testimony, and purpose.

The Incarnate Word gave the inscripturated Word.

Jesus said to the Father:

> **John 17:8**
>
> *"For I have given unto them the words which thou gavest me; and they have received them…"*

Again, He said:

> **John 17:14**
>
> *"I have given them thy word…"*

And in **John 17:17**:

> *"Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth."*

The words of Scripture come from the same God who was manifested in the flesh. Christ cannot lie, and the Scriptures through which He speaks cannot lie. Christ is *"the truth"* (**John 14:6**), and He declared of the Father, *"thy word is truth"* (**John 17:17**).

The Scriptures reveal Christ.

Jesus told the Jews:

> **John 5:39–40**
>
> *"Search the scriptures; for in them ye think ye have eternal life: and they are they which testify of me. And ye will not come to me, that ye might have life."*

The Scriptures are not an end separated from Christ. They testify of Him. Moses wrote of Him. The prophets foretold Him. The sacrifices pictured Him. The Psalms spoke of His sufferings and glory. The Gospels reveal His earthly ministry. The Epistles explain His work. Revelation unveils His return and kingdom.

After His resurrection, Christ demonstrated this relationship:

> **Luke 24:27**
>
> *"And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself."*

Later in the chapter He said:

> **Luke 24:44**
>
> *"…all things must be fulfilled, which were written in the law of Moses, and in the prophets, and in the psalms, concerning me."*

The written Word bears witness to the Incarnate Word, and the Incarnate Word confirms, fulfills, explains, and authenticates the written Word.

Christ also attached final judgment to His spoken words:

> **John 12:48**
>
> *"He that rejecteth me, and receiveth not my words, hath one that judgeth him: the word that I have spoken, the same shall judge him in the last day."*

A man cannot honestly claim to receive Christ while knowingly rejecting the words by which Christ speaks. To reject His words is to reject His authority. To correct His words is to place human judgment above His. To disobey His words is to disobey Him.

At the same time, a man may possess the Scriptures, search the Scriptures, argue about the Scriptures, and still refuse the Christ of whom they testify. That was the error of the unbelieving Jews in **John 5**. They possessed the written word while rejecting the One revealed by it.

Therefore, two errors must be avoided:

Claiming to honor Christ while doubting, correcting, or disobeying His written Word.

Claiming to honor the written Word while refusing to come to Christ, obey Christ, and demonstrate the character of Christ.

The Incarnate Word and the inscripturated Word are not identical in their manner of existence. One is the eternal Son of God; the other is His written revelation. Yet they cannot be separated in authority or testimony. The same God who

revealed Himself in Christ has revealed Himself through Scripture.

Edward Hills expressed this principle by arguing that God reveals not merely information about Himself through Scripture, but Himself.[7] That does not make the Bible a member of the Godhead. It means that Scripture is the God-appointed means by which the living Christ is truthfully revealed.

This connection also strengthens the doctrine of preservation. If God gave the Scriptures so that sinners could know Christ, believe the gospel, and receive eternal life, then He would not allow that written witness to disappear or become corrupted. A lost or permanently uncertain Bible would leave the testimony of Christ uncertain.

The same Christ who is perfect gave a perfect Word. The same Christ who cannot lie speaks through Scriptures that cannot lie. The same Christ who lives forever declared that His words would not pass away.

The perfect character of the Incarnate Word guarantees the perfect character of the inscripturated Word.

And so today, so that we can please our God by living in faith, and so that we can walk as He called us to in Colossians, "as ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in him," and so that we can reverence the Word of God as we would God Himself, we must hold the same opinion of the

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[7] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 2, under "The Protestant Reformers and the Living Word of God."

Word of God that we hold of God: that it is perfect as He is perfect, that it is eternal as He is eternal, and so on.

Therefore, we will seek to establish a foundation from the Bible itself as to where we can find the Word of God today. Any man-made or scientific system of trying to establish where the Word of God is today will inevitably fall short, because it is not grounded in faith. Any view of the Word of God that is not grounded in faith is not spiritually understood and therefore will always fall short.

What we will find is that the Bible has much to say about itself, where we can find it, promises about the Word of God, and God's attachment of Himself to it through preservation and purification, so that we are not left guessing about where the Word of God is, or whether it exists today.

Shared Attributes	Written Word — Scripture (KJV)	Living Word — Jesus Christ (KJV)
Called "the Word of God"	1 Thes 2:13; Mk 7:13; Lk 8:21	Rev 19:13; Jn 1:1,14
Creator / Agent of creation	Ps 33:6,9; Heb 11:3	Jn 1:3; Col 1:16; Heb 1:2
Sustains / Upholds	Ps 119:89–91,116; Ps 147:15–18	Heb 1:3; Col 1:17
Living & powerful	Heb 4:12	Lk 4:32; Jn 6:63
Truth	Jn 17:17; Ps 119:160	Jn 14:6; Rev 3:14
Enduring	1 Pet 1:23,25; Ps 119:89	Mt 24:35; Heb 13:8
Light	Ps 119:105; Prov 6:23	Jn 8:12; Jn 12:46
Life-giving	Deut 8:3; 1 Pet 2:2; Jer 15:16	Jn 6:35,63; Jn 10:10
Saves / Brings new birth	Jas 1:18; 1 Pet 1:23; Rom 1:16	Mt 1:21; Jn 3:16–17; Acts 4:12
Judges / Standard of judgment	Heb 4:12; Jn 12:48	Jn 5:22,27; 2 Cor 5:10
Sanctifies / Cleanses	Jn 17:17; Eph 5:26	Eph 5:25–27; Heb 13:12
Pure / Without flaw	Ps 12:6; Prov 30:5; Ps 18:30	1 Pet 1:19; Heb 7:26
Heals	Ps 107:20	Mt 8:16–17; Lk 7:7; Jn 4:50
Sword	Eph 6:17; Heb 4:12	Rev 1:16; Rev 2:12; Rev 19:15
Produces faith / Faith's object	Rom 10:17; 1 Thes 2:13	Jn 20:31; Jn 3:16; Acts 20:21; Heb 12:2
Peace & Joy	Ps 119:165; Jer 15:16	Jn 14:27; Jn 15:11
Freedom / Liberty	Ps 119:45; Jas 1:25	Jn 8:31–32,36
Cleansing by the word	Ps 119:9; Eph 5:26	Jn 15:3
Central to "revelation"	2 Tim 3:16–17; Rom 15:4	Heb 1:1–2; Jn 1:18
Searches and Discerns hearts	Heb 4:12	Rev 2:23
Abides in believers	1 Jn 2:14; Col 3:16	Jn 15:4–5; Gal 2:20 (Christ living in me)
Gives hope/comfort	Rom 15:4; Ps 119:49–50	1 Tim 1:1; Col 1:27; Jn 14:18
Honored / Magnified	Ps 138:2	Jn 5:23
Tried / Proven	Ps 18:30; Prov 30:5	Isa 28:16; 1 Pet 2:6; Heb 4:15
Commands obedience	Jas 1:22; Ps 119:4	Jn 14:15; Lk 6:46
Blessing to doers	Jas 1:25; Ps 1:1–3	Lk 11:28; Mt 7:24–25
Spirit-empowered / Spirit-given	2 Pet 1:21; Eph 6:17	Lk 4:18; Acts 10:38; Jn 3:34
Fire	Jer 23:29	Lk 12:49; Rev 1:14; Rev 19:15

PRESERVATION: WHAT GOD PROMISED TO CONTINUE

At this point, most of modern scholarship ceases to understand the promises concerning the Word of God from the Bible itself. On almost any website you would find (whether from a Christian church, a non-denominational group, or any denomination really) that they believe in the inspiration of the Word of God as taught in the Scriptures, but they do not go so far as to believe in the preservation promises of the Word of God as the Bible discusses them.

Again, what a shame this is. The inspiration of the Bible, to put it simply, is of no use if it was only going to promise us a generation or less of the perfect, infallible, inerrant Word of God.

Edward Hills, who gave his life to the study of the New Testament text, pressed the same point with a simple question:

> "If God has not preserved the Scriptures by His special providence, why would He have infallibly inspired them in the first place?"[8]

Inspiration and preservation stand or fall together. A God who breathed out every word for the salvation of men would not abandon those words within a generation.

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[8] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 8, "The Textus Receptus and the King James Version," under "Maximum Certainty versus Maximum Uncertainty," e-book.

But good news for us: the Bible does promise us more than just the inspiration of the words of God.

The Promises of Preservation

Psalm 12:6–7

"The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever."

Psalm 119:89

"For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven."

Psalm 119:152

"Concerning thy testimonies, I have known of old that thou hast founded them for ever."

Psalm 119:160

"Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever."

Isaiah 40:8

"The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever."

Isaiah 59:21

"As for me, this is my covenant with them, saith the LORD; My spirit that is upon thee, and my words which I have put in thy mouth, shall not depart out of thy mouth, nor out of

the mouth of thy seed, nor out of the mouth of thy seed's seed, saith the LORD, from henceforth and for ever."

Matthew 5:18

"For verily I say unto you, Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled."

Luke 16:17

"And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass, than one tittle of the law to fail."

Matthew 24:35 (cf. Mark 13:31; Luke 21:33)

"Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away."

John 10:35

"…the scripture cannot be broken;"

1 Peter 1:23–25

"Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever. For all flesh is as grass, and all the glory of man as the flower of grass. The grass withereth, and the flower thereof falleth away: But the word of the Lord endureth for ever. And this is the word which by the gospel is preached unto you."

A Historic Baptist Confession of Preservation

This doctrine did not begin with the modern King James Bible debate. In 1689, the Second London Baptist Confession declared

that the Hebrew Old Testament and Greek New Testament were "by his singular care and providence kept pure in all ages,"[9] and were therefore authoritative for the church. The confession joined inspiration and preservation together: the same God who originally gave His words continued to preserve them.

It also stated that the Scriptures should be translated into the common language of every nation so that all God's people could read and understand them. The confession did not identify one particular English edition, but it clearly shows that historic Baptists believed both in the providential preservation of Scripture and in its faithful translation for ordinary believers. Preservation was not a later doctrine invented to defend the King James Bible; it was already part of the historic doctrine of Scripture.

The Canon and the Text Stand Together

Every Bible-believing Christian agrees that God guided His people to recognize the right books of the Bible and to reject the false ones. Hills showed that the same reasoning applies to the words within those books:

> "It would have been passing strange if God had guided His people in regard to the New Testament canon but had withheld from them His divine assistance in the matter of the New Testament text. This would mean that Bible believing Christians today could have no certainty concerning the New Testament text but

[9] *The Second London Baptist Confession of Faith* (1689), 1.8.

> would be obliged to rely on the hypotheses of modern, naturalistic critics."[10]

A correct list of books with uncertain words inside them would be of little comfort. The God who preserved the canon also preserved the text.

God Preserved His Words, Not the Material

God's promise of preservation is attached to His words, not to the continued existence of every sheet, scroll, or manuscript upon which those words were written. **Isaiah 40:8** declares,

> *"The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever."*

Peter repeats this idea in **1 Peter 1:24–25**:

> *"The grass withereth, and the flower thereof falleth away: But the word of the Lord endureth for ever."*

The material things of this world perish, but the words God gave do not.

This provides a fitting illustration of how Scripture was transmitted. Many ancient manuscripts were written on papyrus, a writing material manufactured from a marsh plant; others were written on parchment.[11] In these passages, God is telling us that the very things that are used to transmit His

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[10] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "The Preservation of the New Testament Text."

[11] Rebecca Capua, "Papyrus-Making in Egypt," Heilbrunn Timeline of Art History, Metropolitan Museum of Art, March 2015, https://www.metmuseum.org/essays/papyrus-making-in-egypt.

words will perish, but His words will not. Both materials could wear out, decay, burn, or be destroyed. God never promised that every original page or every individual copy would survive. He promised that His words would. A manuscript could disappear while its words continued in faithful copies and in the Bibles read, preached, and received by God's people.

Therefore, the age of a surviving manuscript cannot by itself determine whether its readings are true. Older is not automatically better, just as later is not automatically worse. The central question is not merely, "Which piece of material is oldest?" but, "Which words did God preserve through the believing people who copied, received, read, and preached them?" The material may wither like grass, but the Word of God endureth forever.

All of these promises are clear: the Word of God, even down to the very jot and tittle, the smallest of strokes in Hebrew letters, would not pass away, but would be completely kept, perfect and sure, every single letter, every single word, forever.

Now, the hard part about these promises is not understanding them but believing them. The Bible is very clear in its teaching on the keeping of the Word of God. Again, it tells us not only that the ideas would be kept, or the teachings would be kept and preserved, but that the very words, down to the very letters and strokes of the pen, would be kept.

By faith, this is to be believed. If you are not somebody who is interested in grounding your beliefs about the Bible in faith, and you are only interested in the science of textual criticism and understanding things from man's perspective and in man's wisdom, then this book may not be of interest to you.

This book seeks to understand this subject from one foundation only, from faith in the promises about the Word of God, from the Word of God itself. Not science, not the wisdom of man, not textual criticism, not anything other than the foundation of the Bible. That will be the foundation of this argument.

We will, however, get into the details of the manuscripts and the facts of history later on. But for now we must establish this: if we cannot, by faith, believe God's promises about preserving His Word and purifying His Word, just as we do about inspiring His Word, then understanding those more technical issues is of no benefit.

Copies as Scripture

We find many different Scripture passages that testify to the fact that both the originals and copies of the originals are seen as Scripture in the Bible. This goes directly against the idea that the originals are to be emphasized, and that the originals are the only things that are inspired or the very Word of God.

Copies of Scripture are all over the Bible, elevated to the place of Scripture, nothing less.

> **Deuteronomy 17:18–19**
>
> *"And it shall be, when he sitteth upon the throne of his kingdom, that he shall write him a copy of this law in a book out of that which is before the priests the Levites: And it shall be with him, and he shall read therein all the days of his life: that he may learn to fear the LORD his God, to keep all the words of this law and these statutes, to do them:"*

2 Kings 22:8, 11, 13

(v. 8) "And Hilkiah the high priest said unto Shaphan the scribe, I have found the book of the law in the house of the LORD. And Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan, and he read it."

(v. 11) "And it came to pass, when the king had heard the words of the book of the law, that he rent his clothes."

(v. 13) "Go ye, enquire of the LORD for me, and for the people, and for all Judah, concerning the words of this book that is found: for great is the wrath of the LORD that is kindled against us, because our fathers have not hearkened unto the words of this book, to do according unto all that which is written concerning us."

Ezra 7:14

"…according to the law of thy God which is in thine hand;"

Nehemiah 8:8

"So they read in the book in the law of God distinctly, and gave the sense, and caused them to understand the reading."

Proverbs 25:1

"These are also proverbs of Solomon, which the men of Hezekiah king of Judah copied out."

Here the Bible itself tells us that the chapters that follow were copied out by scribes in Hezekiah's day, more than two centuries after Solomon. The copy made by "the men of Hezekiah" is the text God placed in our Bibles, and no one suggests that Proverbs 25–29 is less

than Scripture because it reached us through a later copy.[12]

Luke 4:17–21

"And there was delivered unto him the book of the prophet Esaias. And when he had opened the book, he found the place where it was written… And he began to say unto them, This day is this scripture fulfilled in your ears."

Acts 8:28–35

"…and sitting in his chariot read Esaias the prophet. Then the Spirit said unto Philip, Go near, and join thyself to this chariot… The place of the scripture which he read was this, He was led as a sheep to the slaughter… Then Philip opened his mouth, and began at the same scripture, and preached unto him Jesus."

Acts 17:11

"These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so."

2 Timothy 3:15–16

"And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures, which are able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus. All scripture is given by inspiration

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[12] Jack Moorman notes, citing this verse, that the books of Solomon appear to have been "collected together and carefully kept at Jerusalem." Jack Moorman, *Forever Settled: A Survey of the Documents and History of the Bible* (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 1985), 3, e-book.

of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness:"

The testimony is undeniable: the Bible calls *copies "Scripture."* It never restricts inspiration and authority to the vanished *"original autographs."* God promised to preserve His Word forever, and He did so in the copies His people held, read, preached, and believed.

Translations Can Still Be Scripture

The Bible not only calls copies Scripture but also demonstrates that the words of Scripture may pass from one language into another without ceasing to be the words of God.

Translation is often viewed as an obstacle to preserving the exact words of God. Yet God's power and promises are greater than the limitations of human translation. If God promised to preserve every word of Scripture, then we can trust that those words have been faithfully and perfectly preserved, even through translation. Just as God gave His Word in the common language of the people at the time, such as Greek, we can expect His preserved Word to be available in the common language of people today, including English. God's promise of preservation is not limited by language but extends through translation by His great power.

Pentecost Demonstrates God's Concern for Every Language

At Babel, God divided human languages. At Pentecost, He demonstrated that the gospel would cross those divisions.

Acts 2:6

"Every man heard them speak in his own language."

Acts 2:8

"How hear we every man in our own tongue, wherein we were born?"

Acts 2:11

"We do hear them speak in our tongues the wonderful works of God."

God was not defeated by the existence of multiple languages. The Holy Ghost enabled the wonderful works of God to be understood in the languages of the hearers.

The Great Commission itself requires translation. Christ commanded the church to teach all nations. Most nations do not speak biblical Hebrew or Greek. If the Word of God could not be faithfully carried into other languages, obedience to the Great Commission would be impossible.

Hills drew the same conclusion from the Great Commission itself:

> "Implied in this solemn charge is the promise that through the working of God's providence the Church will always be kept in possession of an infallible record of Jesus' words and works."[13]

Christ did not command His church to teach all nations and then leave it without a sure record of what He commanded.

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[13] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "The Providential Presentation of the Scriptures."

A Biblical Picture of Translation

The English words *translate*, *translated*, and *translation* form an instructive pattern in the King James Bible.

> **2 Samuel 3:10**
>
> *"To translate the kingdom from the house of Saul, and to set up the throne of David…"*

The kingdom was transferred from the failing house of Saul to the throne of David, the man God had chosen.

> **Colossians 1:13**
>
> *"Who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son."*

The believer is translated from the power of darkness into the kingdom of God's dear Son.

> **Hebrews 11:5**
>
> *"By faith Enoch was translated that he should not see death."*

Enoch was translated so that he would not experience death.

This study of translation in the Bible gives us insight into how God views and uses the concept of translation. Scripture does not present translation as a process of decline, corruption, or deterioration. Instead, these passages describe a God-ordained movement from one state or place into another, consistently in a positive sense: from Saul's house to David's throne, from the power of darkness into Christ's kingdom, and from earthly life directly into God's presence without experiencing death.

Translation, under the hand of God, does not mean degradation. It describes faithful transfer, deliverance, advancement, and entrance into a better condition.

It is therefore not surprising that God could use faithful translation as part of the preservation and purification of His Word. The words do not become weaker merely because they cross into another language. Under God's providence, they are carried faithfully and clearly into the language of the people who need them.

This does not mean that every translation is pure. It means that a pure translation is possible.

PURIFICATION: HOW GOD ACTIVELY REFINES THE BIBLE

Now, in this subject of the Word of God and what the Bible says about the keeping of the Word of God and our grounding faith on the subject, we take a turn that most others never dare. The majority of Christianity today does not take the promises about the Bible past the point of inspiration into preservation. Even fewer take it past the promises of preservation into purification.

The irony of this is that the Bible speaks explicitly about the purification of the Word of God, just as it does about the preceding promises of inspiration and preservation.

Again, we look at **Psalm 12:6–7**:

> *"The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever."*

God explicitly promises in these verses that He is going to **purify** His Word, not just keep it, not just write it in an original form and then let it go to the wayside in a short amount of time and be gone forever, but He tells us that He is going to preserve it and, in fact, even purify it "seven times."

If you do a study of the number seven in the Bible, you will find that it represents perfection or completeness. Therefore, God is going to purify His Word until it reaches its final form—perfect, complete, and needing no further purification.

Keeping the Three Terms Separate

Inspiration is God's initial giving of His words through the prophets and apostles. **Preservation** is God's keeping of those

words through history so that they do not pass away. **Purification** is God's providential work of bringing the preserved words through copying, printing, translation, comparison, and reception until they stand in a settled form for His people. Purification does not mean that later translators became prophets, received new revelation, or produced a second inspired Bible.

> ➢ **NOTE**
>
> This process of purification can also be traced in the history of the English Bible. God did not give us the King James Bible all at once; rather, He refined His Word step by step through earlier English translations until it reached its final, purified form in 1611. Many have noticed how this storyline echoes the "seven times" purification in **Psalm 12**. Looking back, you can see seven big steps that led up to the King James:

1. **Wycliffe (1382) — first complete English Bible, translated from the Old Latin.**[14]

2. **Tyndale (1525) —** first English from Hebrew and Greek; laid the groundwork.

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[14] Gail Riplinger, *In Awe of Thy Word* (Ararat, VA: AV Publications, 2003), 788–96. Riplinger explains that the myth of Wycliffe's Bible being taken from Jerome's Latin Vulgate arose from the 1850 Forshall–Madden edition, which placed the misleading phrase "made from the Latin Vulgate" on its title page. She contrasts this with a 1380 Bible title page, preserved in Foxe's *Acts and Monuments*, which reads: "translated into English from the vulgar Latin, by John Wycliffe, D.D. Rector of Lutterworth 1380" (Foxe, vol. 3, p. 64 n. 2), showing it was from the Old Latin (vulgar Latin), not Jerome's Vulgate.

3. **Coverdale (1535) —** first complete printed English Bible, building on Tyndale.

4. **Matthew's (1537) —** a blend of Tyndale and Coverdale (John Rogers).

5. **Great Bible (1539) —** first "authorized" English Bible, placed in churches.

6. **Geneva (1560) —** the people's Bible, loved by the Puritans, loaded with notes.

7. **Bishops' (1568) —** a Church of England revision.

Even scholars who do not share the faith-based position of this book have recognized this long refining process. Sir Frederic Kenyon, director of the British Museum and one of the leading textual scholars of his generation, wrote of the Authorized Version:

> "It was the work, not of one man, nor of one age, but of many labourers, of diverse and even opposing views, over a period of ninety years. It was watered with the blood of martyrs, and its slow growth gave time for the casting off of imperfections and for the full accomplishment of its destiny as the Bible of the English nation."[15]

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[15] Frederic G. Kenyon, *Our Bible and the Ancient Manuscripts: Being a History of the Text and Its Translations*, 4th ed. (London: Eyre and Spottiswoode, 1903), 234.

Kenyon was writing history, not prophecy. Yet his words describe exactly what this chapter calls purification: a "slow growth" that gave time for "the casting off of imperfections."

> **For more on this process of purification, see the chapter FROM THE RECEIVED TEXT TO THE KING JAMES BIBLE.**

We see in **Proverbs 30:5–6**:

> *"Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him. Add thou not unto his words, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar."*

He is commanding that we not add to His words, but He is telling us that His Word is pure (it has been purified).

We also see in **Psalm 18:30**:

> *"As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all those that trust in him."*

The Word of the LORD is tried. There are different ways you could take this, but again, in the context of seeing it as a purified, tried Book, we can see the same premise being taught here.

Dr. Edward Hills also discussed an example of this process in his book *The King James Version Defended*:

> "Through the influence of the Latin-speaking Church Erasmus and his successors were providentially guided to follow the Latin Vulgate here and there in those few places in which the Latin Church usage rather than the Greek Church usage had preserved the genuine reading. Hence the Textus Receptus was a further step

> in the providential preservation of the New Testament. In it the few errors of any consequence occurring in the Traditional Greek Text were corrected by the providence of God operating through the usage of the Latin speaking Church of Western Europe."[16]

Purification in the Printed Editions

The same refining can be traced through the printed Greek editions that followed Erasmus. In his third edition, Robert Stephanus printed in the margin variant readings drawn from the Complutensian edition and fourteen manuscripts, yet he did not adopt them into his text. Hills observed:

> "It was the influence no doubt of this common faith which restrained Stephanus from adopting any of the variant readings which he had collected."[17]

Theodore Beza owned Codex Bezae and Codex Claromontanus, yet according to Eduard Reuss his text departs from Stephanus's fourth edition only thirty-eight times. Hills called this "a remarkable fact which shows the hold which the common faith had upon Beza's mind."[18]

The King James translators then weighed these editions against one another. According to F. H. A. Scrivener, in 252 places where the printed sources differ enough to affect the English rendering, the King James Bible agrees with Beza against

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[16] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "The Preservation of the New Testament Text."

[17] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "Robert Stephanus—His Four Editions of the Textus Receptus."

[18] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "Theodore Beza's Ten Editions of the New Testament."

Stephanus 113 times, with Stephanus against Beza 59 times, and 80 times with Erasmus, the Complutensian Polyglot, or the Latin Vulgate against both.[19] The translators did not simply reprint one man's Greek text. They compared, judged, and settled. Hills drew the conclusion:

> "Hence the King James Version ought to be regarded not merely as a translation of the Textus Receptus but also as an independent variety of the Textus Receptus."[20]

The believer need not choose among these editions; their settled form in English is the King James Bible.

We will look into the specific examples of where this took place in history later in this book.

Case Study: Showing Purification in Action

> **Jeremiah 36:27–28, 32**
>
> *"Then the word of the LORD came to Jeremiah, after that the king had burned the roll, and the words which Baruch wrote at the mouth of Jeremiah, saying, Take thee again another roll, and write in it all the former words that were in the first roll, which Jehoiakim the king of Judah hath burned. Then took Jeremiah another roll, and gave it to Baruch the scribe, the son of Neriah; who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of*

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[19] F. H. A. Scrivener, *The Authorized Edition of the English Bible (1611): Its Subsequent Reprints and Modern Representatives* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1884), 60.

[20] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "The King James Version a Variety of the Textus Receptus."

Judah had burned in the fire: ***and there were added besides unto them many like words.***"

Lessons from Jeremiah

In this peculiar story in the book of Jeremiah, we learn many things.

We learn that those who emphasize the originals over everything else, and those who say the only goal is to recover the original words of the original author written down thousands of years ago are not standing on a biblical premise but a man-made construct.

When you put this story together with the other verses in the Bible promising the purification of the Word of God, you find that God is not in the business of emphasizing the "originals."

In fact, you could draw a correlation between man's obsession with the originals and the Israelites' obsession with artifacts: the sword that David killed Goliath with, the armor of Goliath, or the brazen serpent that Moses erected in the wilderness. We tend to cling to artifacts, but God does not emphasize the originals.

In this story, God did something very peculiar. He gave Jeremiah His Word and had Baruch write it down. Then He allowed that original roll to be cut up and burned, completely destroyed. So now the original copy was gone. That original manuscript, containing the verbally and plenarily inspired, inerrant words God had given Jeremiah, had been completely destroyed.

But God had promised to preserve His Word. And so He told Jeremiah to write another roll with all the former words in it.

This is one of the Bible's greatest examples of preservation and purification in action.

Yet something very interesting also happened. God added to that second copy *"many like words."*

What This Shows

This means that if modern scholars had their wish, and they had the "original copy" of Jeremiah, they would in fact be missing out on the complete revelation of God, because it was the second, purified copy that had the fullness of His words.

Ask yourself: Why would God allow this to happen? Could He not have prevented the destruction of the coveted "original" copy? Could He not have just had it rewritten exactly as it was in the "original"? Why did He not include the "added" words in the original copy? God is all-knowing, all-powerful, perfect, etc. Why would He add to what He said the first time?

The answer is that God was showing us something important: that the original copy is not to be exalted or worshipped. Instead, He demonstrates His promises of preservation and purification. His Word would be preserved, and even purified through time under His guiding hand.

He gave us a case study of inspiration, preservation, and purification.

To Review:

1. The coveted "Original" Written

"Then Jeremiah called Baruch the son of Neriah: and Baruch wrote from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the LORD, which he had spoken unto him, upon a roll of a book." (**Jer. 36:4**)

2. The coveted "Original" Destroyed

"And it came to pass, that when Jehudi had read three or four leaves, he cut it with the penknife, and cast it into the fire… until all the roll was consumed in the fire that was on the hearth." (**Jer. 36:23**)

3. The Second Roll Written (preserved copy)

"Take thee again another roll, and write in it all the former words that were in the first roll, which Jehoiakim the king of Judah hath burned." (**Jer. 36:28**)

4. Additional Words Added (purified/preserved copy)

"Then took Jeremiah another roll… who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire: ***and there were added besides unto them many like words." (Jer. 36:32)***

This shows God's work of ***purification.*** *The second roll was not less than the first, but greater; it contained the complete revelation God wanted preserved.*

"Double Inspiration"?

Those who poke fun at the idea of the King James Bible often say its defenders believe in "double inspiration." Nothing could be further from the truth.

Inspiration is, by definition, the initial act of God breathing out His Word. That happened once, in the originals.

But what many critics miss are the principles of **preservation** and especially **purification** as they are taught in the Bible.

God can and does providentially purify His Word, just as He did here in Jeremiah, and just as He did through history in the pure line of manuscripts and Bibles, as opposed to the corrupt line of manuscripts and Bibles.

This is not "double inspiration." It is purification. It is biblical. And it is faith-based.

Purification and Providence in the King James Bible

The same pattern we saw in Jeremiah's rolls—inspiration, destruction, preservation, and purification—can be traced throughout the history of God's dealings with His Word. Just as God added "many like words" to Jeremiah's second roll, He has, in His providence, brought His Word through a refining process in history until it reached its purified form in the English tongue.

Over the centuries, copies of the biblical text were multiplied, copied, and sometimes corrupted through human error or neglect. Yet at every turn, God intervened to **preserve and purify** His Word through faithful believers, translators, and churches who refused to let the Scriptures be lost. This culminated in what we now recognize as the **King James Bible of 1611**, not as a new inspiration, but as the *purified* and *preserved* text God promised.

Just as the first roll in Jeremiah's day was destroyed but replaced and expanded by the hand of God, so too did many original manuscripts of the New Testament perish in time. Yet the words they contained were never lost. God preserved them through faithful copies, translations, and even through unexpected means such as the **Latin Church's transmission of key readings**. Dr. Edward Hills explained this very principle:

> "Through the influence of the Latin-speaking Church Erasmus and his successors were providentially guided to follow the Latin Vulgate here and there in those few places in which the Latin Church usage rather than the Greek Church usage had preserved the genuine reading."[21]

One of the clearest examples of this is found in **1 John 5:7**, the famous Trinitarian passage known as the *Comma Johanneum*:

> *"For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one."*

Although the verse had fallen out of many Greek copies by the Middle Ages, it continued to be preserved in the **Old Latin** and **Vulgate traditions**. When Erasmus compiled his first edition of the *Textus Receptus* in 1516, this verse was absent because it was missing in the limited Greek manuscripts available to him. Yet believers across Europe raised a strong objection, pointing to its presence in Latin manuscripts and its quotation by early church fathers such as Cyprian (A.D. 250). When later shown Greek evidence that contained the verse (now known as Codex 61, *Montfortianus*), Erasmus included it in his third edition of 1522, thereby restoring what had been preserved outside the Alexandrian stream.

This is a vivid demonstration of God's purifying hand: **what appeared lost was brought back**. As Hills noted, the providence of God was operating through both the Greek and Latin lines to restore the full, genuine reading of Scripture. Through that process of weighing, refining, and reuniting the

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[21] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "The Preservation of the New Testament Text."

witness of the faithful manuscripts, God purified His Word for the English-speaking world.

When the King James translators began their monumental work in 1604, they built upon this purified text, the *Textus Receptus* of Erasmus, Stephanus, and Beza, and upon the purified stream of English Bibles that preceded it (Wycliffe through Geneva). In this we see not mere human scholarship, but God still at work in the process. God's promise in **Psalm 12:6–7** was once again proven true:

> *"The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever."*

The King James Bible stands as the fruit of that sevenfold purification, both linguistically and textually. It is not the result of "double inspiration," but rather of **purification**, a perfect reflection of God's own nature and His faithfulness to preserve His words in every generation.

The Choice: Purification or Degradation

The process was filled with textual, translational, and manuscript decisions, each of which required faith. Whether it was Erasmus in his handling of **1 John 5:7**, the KJV translators weighing variant readings, or generations of believers discerning which line of manuscripts to follow, the question always comes down to this:

Do you believe God is still in the process?

If you believe that He is, then you must also believe that God has fulfilled His promise to preserve and purify His Word. That

means there is, today, a perfect Book in English you can trust 100 percent—pure, infallible, inerrant, and complete in every word/marking (jot/tittle), ***not just in the message, ideas, or main teachings*** **(this is not what the Bible teaches)**. God's hand did not stop moving in the first century; His promise did not expire when the last apostle died. The same God who inspired His Word has also preserved and purified it through time, language, and translation.

If, however, you believe that God is no longer in the process, then you are left with the unavoidable conclusion that **no perfect Bible exists today—that what we hold** is, at best, a fallible approximation of the lost originals. That view makes the Bible a product of man's imperfection rather than God's preservation.

There are only two mindsets when it comes to the Word of God:

Preservation and Purification	**Reconstruction and Degradation**
Begins with God's promises	Begins with human critical judgment
Believes God preserved His words	Believes the original wording must be reconstructed
Evidence is understood through Scripture	Scripture is treated like other ancient literature
Follows the Traditional/Byzantine stream	Follows the modern eclectic Critical Text
Associated with Antioch	Associated with Egypt
Receives the text copied and used by the churches	Takes readings from manuscripts that disagree and that were rejected by the church
Sees the received text as settled	Keeps the text open to continuing revision
Emphasizes formal, word-for-word translation	Emphasizes thought-for-thought translation
Produces confidence in a Bible that can be trusted as perfect	Produces doubt and uncertainty about what the Bible really should say
Points to the KJV as the preserved English Bible	Does not identify one perfect and settled English Bible

Either God has kept His promise, or He has not. Either His Word today is pure and preserved, or it is partial and polluted.

FAITH BASED VIEW OF SCRIPTURE

By Faith we Believe God's Promise that He Inspired his word

2 Timothy 3:16 – All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness:
2 Peter 1:21 – For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost.
Acts 1:16 – Men and brethren, this scripture must needs have been fulfilled, which the Holy Ghost by the mouth of David spake before concerning Judas, which was guide to them that took Jesus.
Acts 28:25 – And when they agreed not among themselves, they departed, after that Paul had spoken one word, Well spake the Holy Ghost by Esaias the prophet unto our fathers,
Acts 3:18 – But those things, which God before had shewed by the mouth of all his prophets, that Christ should suffer, he hath so fulfilled.
Mark 12:36 – For David himself said by the Holy Ghost, The LORD said to my Lord, Sit thou on my right hand, Till I make thine enemies thy footstool.

By Faith we Believe God's Promise to Preserve His inspired word

Matthew 24:35 – Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away.
1 Peter 1:23 – Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever.
Psalm 12:6-7 – The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever.
Psalm 111:7-8 – The works of his hands are verity and judgment; all his commandments are sure. They stand fast for ever and ever, and are done in truth and uprightness.
Psalm 117:2 – For his merciful kindness is great toward us: and the truth of the LORD endureth for ever. Praise ye the LORD.
Psalm 119:152, 160 – Concerning thy testimonies, I have known of old that thou hast founded them for ever. Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever.

By Faith we Believe God's Promise to Purify His word

Psalm 12:6-7 – The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever.
Jeremiah 36 – ... "Then took Jeremiah another roll, and gave it to Baruch the scribe, the son of Neriah; who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire: and there were added besides unto them many like words."
Psalm 66:10 – For thou, O God, hast proved us: thou hast tried us, as silver is tried.
Psalm 18:30 – As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all those that trust in him.
2 Samuel 22:31 – As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all them that trust in him.
Proverbs 30:5 – Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him.

By Faith we Believe God is Inseparable from His word

Psalm 138:2 – I will worship toward thy holy temple, and praise thy name for thy lovingkindness and for thy truth: for thou hast magnified thy word above all thy name.
Titus 1:2 – In hope of eternal life, which God, that cannot lie, promised before the world began;
Numbers 23:19 – God is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent: hath he said, and shall he not do it? or hath he spoken, and shall he not make it good?
1 Samuel 15:29 – And also the Strength of Israel will not lie nor repent: for he is not a man, that he should repent.
John 1:1,14 – In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth.

All different versions of the Bible say different things. They all can't be 100% correct because they say different things, and in many places opposite things; that would be impossible. Would you be confident placing your eternity in the hands of a book you can only trust 90% of the time, or even 99% of the time? You don't have to settle for less than 100% certainty. Because of the promises of God we have concerning his word, you can know which one to trust 100% of the time!

WAR ON WORDS

While God is committed to purifying His words, the devil is committed to corrupting them. This has been true from Genesis onward.

I put this section underneath the faith-based view of the Word of God because I believe that not understanding this issue in the Bible will ultimately be a detriment to anybody who endeavors to study the Word of God in its transmission through time, and where it exists today. To not understand the spiritual warfare on the Word of God from the Bible itself will leave you lacking in your ability to discern what the Word of God is, where it is, where the work of God is throughout history, and where the work of the devil is.

In the same 2025 interview, Wesley Huff said:

> "There aren't people behind the scenes who are mischievously trying to take out verses of our Bible to hide things or create contradictions. If that were true, then if you look at the so-called missing verses, they're doing a really bad job of it. They're basically taking out inconsequential verses while leaving in some pretty big verses that have major doctrinal effects. So if this is a nefarious conspiracy to remove doctrines or ideas from Scripture, whoever is taking these verses out is doing a pretty bad job of it."[22]

This statement again lacks a biblical, spiritual, faith-based understanding on this subject. Scholars who seek to understand this issue only from the carnal viewpoint of man, science,

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[22] "Part 1: Answering King James Only w/ Wes Huff," 30:31–31:21.

philosophy, and textual criticism and not through the lens of the Word of God will be left in the dark.

By faith, we believe that the Bible teaches that there is a pointed and concerted effort from the forces of spiritual wickedness to corrupt the Word of God.

God's Repeated Warnings

God, from the very beginning of His Word, warns mankind not to add to His Word or take away from His Word. In the very middle of His Word, in the book of Proverbs, He gives the same warning (**Prov. 30:5–6**). At the very end, in the book of Revelation, He gives it again (**Rev. 22:18–19**). All throughout the Bible, God places warnings against adding to or taking away from His words.

False Letters in the Early Church

Even in the days of the apostles, the integrity of God's Word was under attack. Paul had to warn believers about false letters that were being circulated in his name. In **2 Thessalonians 2:2**, he cautions the church not to be *"shaken in mind"* or deceived by *"spirit, nor by word, nor by* ***letter as from us****."* Later, in **2 Thessalonians 3:17**, he made it a point to identify his own hand in writing, so that the churches could recognize the true Word from counterfeit documents. These warnings show that even while the New Testament was being penned and circulated, Satan was already working to undermine its authority by slipping in corrupted *"copies."*

The Devil's First Appearance

The very first time that the devil shows up in the Bible is in **Genesis 3**, and right from the start, he is attacking the foundation of our faith: the Word of God.

1. **He Questions the Word of God**

"Yea, hath God said…?" (Gen. 3:1)

I've spent a significant amount of time in colleges and seminaries and listening to various opinions on the Bible itself, manuscript evidence, and textual criticism. And I found that this is the core question of textual criticism: *"Yea, hath God said?"*

There's just enough doubt inserted as to what was originally said, whether it exists today, and where it is found in the manuscripts, that it creates confusion in the mind of the reader. It causes them to doubt the authenticity of the Bible, or at least specific passages. This is exactly what it did in the mind of Eve.

2. **He Contradicts the Word of God**

"…Yea, hath God said, Ye shall not eat of every tree of the garden?" (**Genesis 3:1**)

That twist was the point. God had not said they were forbidden to eat of every tree. Eve initially corrected the claim, saying that only one tree was off-limits. But the seed of doubt and contradiction had already been planted.

3. **He Changes the Word of God**

"Ye shall not surely die." (**Genesis 3:4**)

God had been perfectly clear that in the day they ate of the tree, they would die. Satan contradicted this directly, convincing Eve that God was withholding something from her.

Eve's Addition

Notice also that Eve, in her response, added to God's Word:

"…neither shall ye touch it, lest ye die." (**Genesis 3:3**)

God never said they could not *touch* it. But with the devil questioning, contradicting, and changing God's Word, Eve herself misquoted Him, adding something He never commanded.

The Pattern

So in just a few verses we see the entire satanic strategy:

- Question the Word of God.
- Contradict the Word of God.
- Change the Word of God.

This pattern has never stopped. It is the same today as it was then.

The devil convinced Eve that God was holding out on her, hiding knowledge from her, by questioning His Word, contradicting it, and then changing it. Through this, the human race fell from perfection and intimate fellowship with Christ in the garden into the chaos, sin, and death we now see. And all it took was an attack on the Word of God.

The Continuing Attack

I submit to you that the devil has not stopped his attack on the Word of God from that very day. From the very beginning of Scripture's writing, there have been attacks on the Word of God. To deny this is to miss one of the central themes of the Bible: the devil is in the business of corrupting what God has spoken. Scholars may say, "There is nobody out there trying to corrupt your Bible or your manuscripts." But the Bible itself tells us otherwise. To not believe that the devil is trying to change what God said, contradict what God said, or question what God said in order to cause us to sin or to waver from the faith, is to reject the testimony of Scripture. By faith, we believe that there is a pointed attack on the Word of God today by the devil and his angels.

Corruption Recognized by the Early Church

The claim that no one ever tampered with the text of Scripture did not begin with today's scholars. Fenton John Anthony Hort wrote that "there are no signs of deliberate falsification of the text for dogmatic purposes."[23] The Christians who lived nearest to the apostles said otherwise.

Dionysius, bishop of Corinth (d. c. A.D. 176), complained that his own letters had been tampered with by men who cut out some things and added others, and he said it was no wonder that some had also attempted to corrupt the writings of the

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[23] Brooke Foss Westcott and Fenton John Anthony Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek*, vol. 2, *Introduction and Appendix* (London: Macmillan, 1881), 282.

Lord.[24] Gaius, an orthodox writer at the end of the second century, named Asclepiades, Theodotus, Hermophilus, and Apollonides as heretics who prepared corrupted copies of the Scriptures, which their disciples then multiplied.[25] Irenaeus defended a single reading in Revelation 13:18 by appealing to "all the most approved and ancient copies" and warned that "there shall be no light punishment upon him who either adds or subtracts anything from the Scriptures."[26] Even Bruce Metzger acknowledged:

> "Irenaeus, Clement of Alexandria, Tertullian, Eusebius, and many other Church fathers accused the heretics of corrupting the Scriptures in order to have support for their special views."[27]

Scholars who have studied the manuscripts closely also agree on when the damage was done. E. C. Colwell wrote:

> "The overwhelming majority of readings were created before the year 200."[28]

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[24] Dionysius of Corinth, quoted in Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 4.23.12, trans. Arthur Cushman McGiffert, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 1, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1890), 201.

[25] Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 5.28.13–19, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., 1:248.

[26] Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 5.30.1, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, 1:558–59.

[27] Bruce M. Metzger and Bart D. Ehrman, *The Text of the New Testament: Its Transmission, Corruption, and Restoration*, 4th ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), 265.

[28] E. C. Colwell, "Method in Establishing the Nature of Text-Types of New Testament Manuscripts," in *Studies in Methodology in Textual Criticism of the New Testament*, New Testament Tools and Studies 9 (Leiden: Brill, 1969), 55.

F. H. A. Scrivener agreed:

> "The worst corruptions to which the [New Testament] has ever been subjected originated within a hundred years after it was composed."[29]

That is the very period in which Paul had already warned of "many, which corrupt the word of God" (2 Cor. 2:17). Dean Burgon summed it up:

> "Vanquished by the Word Incarnate, Satan next directed his subtle malice against the Word written."[30]

Note:

Many claim that this issue of Bible versions is overblown and that the versions all tend to say the same things, teach the same things, and have no major differences. The irony of this is that we find not "small changes" but outright opposite teachings within the ***same chapter*** where God shows us Satan's method of attacking the Word of God.

Example: Genesis 3:16

In the King James Bible, God's judgment upon the woman is clear:

> *"Unto the woman he said, I will greatly multiply thy sorrow and thy conception; in sorrow thou shalt bring forth*

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[29] F. H. A. Scrivener, *A Plain Introduction to the Criticism of the New Testament*, 4th ed., ed. Edward Miller, 2 vols. (London: George Bell and Sons, 1894), 2:264.

[30] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 334.

> *children;* ***and thy desire shall be to thy husband, and he shall rule over thee."*** (**Gen. 3:16**)

The KJV renders this as the wife's desire being *toward* her husband, fitting the natural, God-ordained order of marriage. The consequence of the Fall is pain in childbearing and a struggle of submission, but the structure is consistent: her desire is *to her husband,* and he shall rule over her.

Now compare the English Standard Version (ESV):

> *"To the woman he said, 'I will surely multiply your pain in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children.* ***Your desire shall be contrary to your husband, but he shall rule over you.'" (Gen. 3:16, ESV 2016)***

This was the ESV's wording from 2016 until 2025. In 2025 Crossway changed the verse back to "Your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you," with a footnote that still offers "against" as a possible meaning. For about nine years ESV readers carried the opposite meaning in their Bibles. The King James Bible has read the same way since 1611.

Notice the difference: instead of being *to her husband,* the woman's desire is rendered as *contrary to her husband.* That is not a minor adjustment of language; it is the exact opposite. In one, the wife's desire is directed *toward* her husband. In the other, her desire is set *against* him.

TEXTUAL TRANSMISSION AND THE TWO TEXTUAL STREAMS: ANTIOCH AND ALEXANDRIA

How Scripture Reached Us

Before examining the two lines of manuscripts, we must understand how the words of Scripture moved from the original writings to an English Bible.

The **original documents** written by the prophets and apostles are commonly called the **autographs**. ***Those physical documents are no longer known to exist***, but their words were copied and circulated in manuscripts.

A **manuscript** is a handwritten copy containing all or part of a biblical book. Because manuscripts were copied by hand, variations, called **textual variants**, occurred in some of them. A variant may involve a single letter, the order of words, a missing or duplicated word, or something as long as a sentence. The existence of a variant does not mean that the entire Bible was lost; it means that the surviving copies must be compared.

As manuscripts were copied and passed on, manuscripts that repeatedly **shared similar readings** formed recognizable textual traditions, also called text forms or **text types**. Two principal traditions considered in this book are the **Byzantine text** and the **Alexandrian text**. The Byzantine text is the form of the Greek New Testament found in the majority of surviving Greek manuscripts. The Alexandrian text represents a different group of readings associated especially with manuscripts preserved in Egypt. These names describe general patterns of readings; they do not mean that every manuscript within a group is identical.

From Manuscripts to Printed Greek Texts

The invention of movable-type printing revolutionized the way the biblical text was circulated. Instead of producing one handwritten manuscript at a time, printers could publish many identical copies of a complete Greek New Testament.

The first published Greek New Testament was issued in 1516 by Desiderius Erasmus, who released revised editions in 1519, 1522, 1527, and 1535. Robert Estienne, or Stephanus, then published four editions in 1546, 1549, 1550, and 1551. Theodore Beza followed with a series of Greek New Testament editions. His 1588–89 and 1598 editions were particularly influential and were used extensively by the King James translators.[31] [32]

These editions were closely related, although they did not agree in every reading. Collectively, this family of printed Greek editions later became known as the **Textus Receptus**, or "Received Text." The name derives from the Latin wording in the preface to the Elzevir edition of 1633: "Therefore you have the text now received by all" (*Textum ergo habes, nunc ab omnibus receptum*).[33]

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[31] Bruce M. Metzger and Bart D. Ehrman, *The Text of the New Testament: Its Transmission, Corruption, and Restoration*, 4th ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), 142–52.

[32] Lincoln H. Blumell, "The Greek New Testament Text of the King James Version," in *New Testament History, Culture, and Society: A Background to the Texts of the New Testament*, ed. Lincoln H. Blumell (Provo, UT: Religious Studies Center, Brigham Young University; Salt Lake City: Deseret Book, 2019), 691–92.

[33] J. K. Elliott, "'Novum Testamentum editum est': The Five-Hundredth Anniversary of Erasmus's New Testament," *The Bible Translator* 67, no. 1 (2016): 24, https://doi.org/10.1177/2051677016628242.

The Textus Receptus is therefore not one ancient manuscript or one completely uniform printed edition. It is a family of closely related printed Greek New Testaments produced during and after the Reformation. Because the manuscripts and earlier editions used by its editors predominantly represented the Byzantine tradition, the Textus Receptus is predominantly Byzantine rather than Alexandrian in character.

The terms Byzantine Text, Majority Text, and Textus Receptus are closely related, but they are not completely interchangeable. The Byzantine Text is a textual tradition represented by a large body of manuscripts. The Majority Text refers to the readings found in the majority of surviving manuscripts and, by extension, to modern printed Greek editions constructed from those readings. The Textus Receptus refers to the family of printed Greek editions associated particularly with Erasmus, Stephanus, Beza, and the Elzevirs.

F. H. A. Scrivener's Greek New Testament came later than the King James Bible. Scrivener did not provide the Greek text used by the KJV translators. He compared the New Testament of the KJV with the earlier printed Greek editions and reconstructed what he believed to be the Greek text underlying the KJV's readings.[34]

Modern critical editions follow a different editorial approach. The Nestle–Aland 28th edition and the United Bible Societies' 5th edition—commonly called NA28 and UBS5—present essentially the same edited Greek text. They compare evidence

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[34] F. H. A. Scrivener, ed., *The New Testament in the Original Greek according to the Text Followed in the Authorised Version, Together with the Variations Adopted in the Revised Version* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1881), vii–xii, 648–56.

from several manuscript traditions but give greater weight to manuscripts commonly associated with the Alexandrian text type. Many modern English New Testaments are translated from this Critical Text.

From Printed Texts to English Translations

Translation is the next step. Translators take a printed Hebrew or Greek text and render its words into another language. Therefore, a difference between two English Bibles may arise for either of two reasons: the translators may be using different underlying Hebrew or Greek readings, or they may translate the same reading differently.

The process may be summarized as follows:

> ***Original writings → handwritten manuscripts → textual variants → textual traditions → printed Hebrew and Greek texts → English translations***

This order matters. Manuscripts are the handwritten witnesses. A text type identifies a recognizable pattern of readings shared among manuscripts. A printed Greek text presents the readings selected by its editors. An English Bible then translates that printed text into English.

With this process established, we can now examine the two principal textual traditions at issue in this book.

Two Starting Points: Preservation or Reconstruction

Before examining Antioch and Alexandria, we must understand that the difference between the two textual streams is not merely geographical. Behind them stand two different ways of approaching the Word of God.

The Naturalistic Method

The naturalistic method treats the text of the New Testament according to the same basic rules used for other ancient literature. It may acknowledge that the Bible is religiously important, but it does not permit the doctrines of inspiration and preservation to determine the method by which the text is established.

Under this approach, the textual critic begins with the surviving manuscripts and reconstructs what he believes the original authors most likely wrote. No presently received text is treated as final. Every reading remains open to reconsideration when new evidence, theories, or methods arise.

This method may be followed by men who personally profess belief in inspiration. The issue is not merely the private profession of the scholar. The issue is whether his method consciously submits to what the Bible teaches concerning its own inspiration and preservation.

When inspiration and preservation are removed from the method of textual criticism, the Bible is treated as though its textual history were essentially no different from that of Homer, Plato, or any other ancient work. The result is a text reconstructed according to scholarly probability rather than a received text approached in light of God's promises concerning His Word.

But the Bible is not an ordinary book. Its prophetic, historical, doctrinal, and even scientific claims bear a character that cannot adequately be explained as being a human construct. Because Scripture is self-authenticating, we therefore allow what the Bible says about itself to shape the way we approach its textual history. This is not a circular argument; it begins with the self-

evidencing character of Scripture and then takes seriously its own teachings concerning inspiration, preservation, the priesthood of believers, and the significance of places such as Antioch and Alexandria. If these biblical doctrines and historical patterns are meaningful, then they should not be excluded when considering manuscripts, textual criticism, and Bible versions.

The Faith-Based Method

Edward Hills called the alternatives "the consistently Christian method and the naturalistic method."

The consistently Christian method begins with what God has revealed concerning His Word:

- God inspired His words.
- God promised to preserve those words.
- Christ declared that His words would not pass away.
- Scripture cannot be broken.
- God placed the Old Testament in the custody of the Jews.
- God placed the New Testament in the life and usage of believing churches.

This method does not reject manuscript evidence, ancient versions, church fathers, grammar, history, or careful scholarship. It rejects the idea that these things may be interpreted independently of Scripture.

The evidence must be understood through the truth God has already revealed.

Why the Starting Point Determines the Result

If a man begins by assuming that the Bible was transmitted like any other book, he will naturally search for the oldest surviving materials and attempt to reconstruct the original wording from them.

If a man begins by believing that God preserved His Word publicly for His people, he will naturally ask which text was continuously read, copied, preached, translated, and received by the churches.

The two men may examine the same manuscript and reach different conclusions because they are asking different questions.

One asks:

> "Which reading appears most probable according to the principles of textual criticism?"

The other asks:

> "Which reading fits the promises of preservation and the historical usage of God's people?"

This is the deeper issue behind the two textual streams.

With these two starting points established, we can now examine the cities, manuscripts, men, and historical fruit associated with each stream.

Byzantine (Antiochian) vs. Alexandrian Text Types

When you trace the history of the Bible, it becomes clear that there has always been a battle over the text. This battle is not new. From the Garden of Eden, the very first recorded words of the serpent were: *"Yea, hath God said?"* (**Gen. 3:1**). Satan's strategy has not changed in six thousand years. The question before us is not whether there are different manuscripts, languages, or translations. The real question is: **Why are there conflicting lines of manuscripts? Why do some say one thing and other lines from other areas say other things? Can we ground our understanding of which lines we should trust in the Word of God (faith-based)? If we can, then we can see where God is purifying His Word versus where Satan is corrupting His Word.**

The evidence of Scripture and history says yes. When you study the story of the transmission of the Bible, it comes down to a tale of two cities: **Antioch** and **Alexandria**. One city represents missions, evangelism, and doctrinal purity. The other represents philosophy, corruption, and compromise. This is not just a matter of geography; it is a matter of spiritual lineage and biblical principles (faith-based). The manuscripts that come from these places bear the fruit of the soil in which they grew.

Antioch: The Line of Preservation

The Bible itself highlights Antioch as a city of great spiritual importance.

- **Acts 11:26** tells us, *"the disciples were called Christians first in Antioch."* The very name *"Christian"* was born there, not in Jerusalem, Rome, or Alexandria.

- In **Acts 13:1–3**, Antioch becomes the **missions hub** of the New Testament. It was from Antioch that Paul and Barnabas were sent out by the Holy Ghost on the first missionary journey. This city was the launching pad of gospel expansion. The light of world evangelism began to blaze from Antioch.

It is no coincidence that the **text of Scripture preserved and used by the churches** came from this same region. Antioch represents the spirit of obedience to the Word of God. It represents evangelism, church planting, doctrinal faithfulness, and biblical literalism. Historically, the manuscripts associated with Antioch became the **Byzantine Text**, later known as the **Textus Receptus**. Over 5,000 Greek manuscripts (80–95 percent of the evidence) agree with this line of text.[35] [36]

These were the Scriptures preached in the Greek-speaking churches. They were the basis of the Old Latin Bible (Itala, second century) and the Syriac Peshitta (second century).[37] Early church fathers quoted them thousands of times. Polycarp, a direct disciple of the apostle John, quoted readings found in the Textus Receptus. His disciple, Irenaeus (A.D. 130–200), did the same. Irenaeus and Cyprian quoted controversial passages such as 1 John 5:7 and Mark 16:9–20, which modern critical texts

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[35] Wilbur N. Pickering, *The Identity of the New Testament Text IV* (Brasília: Wilbur N. Pickering, 2014), 114–15.

[36] Zane C. Hodges and Arthur L. Farstad, eds., *The Greek New Testament According to the Majority Text*, 2nd ed. (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 1985), v–vi.

[37] Hills, King James Version Defended, chap. 7, under "The Providence of God in the Syrian Church."

leave out.[38] This proves that these verses are not *"later additions,"* but part of the Bible known and received in the earliest centuries.

Dean John Burgon, who collated these manuscripts in the nineteenth century, wrote in *The Revision Revised*:[39]

> "Lectionaries abound, which establish the Text which has been publicly read in the churches of the East, from at least A.D. 400 until the time of the invention of printing."

In the same work, Burgon wrote:[40]

> "…the Text which, by the good Providence of GOD, was universally employed throughout Europe for the first 300 years after the invention of printing… being practically identical with the Text which … was in popular use at the end of three centuries from the date of the sacred autographs themselves: in other words, being more than 1500 years old."

The Textus Receptus is the text that the body of Christ used, copied, and believed through the centuries. It is called the "Received Text" because the churches received it as the Word of God.

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[38] Irenaeus, Against Heresies 3.10.5, in Ante-Nicene Fathers, 1:426; Cyprian, On the Unity of the Church 6, in Ante-Nicene Fathers, 5:423.

[39] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 11.

[40] Burgon, *Revision Revised*, 386.

What About Heresy in Antioch?

Some critics answer this contrast by pointing to Paul of Samosata and to later Arian or semi-Arian figures associated with Antioch and Syria. Their argument is that Antioch also experienced heresy and therefore should not be contrasted with Alexandria as the standard. However, the argument in this section is faith-based: it concerns the pattern established by Scripture, not the claim that every person who ever lived in Antioch was doctrinally sound. The Bible never presents Antioch as a source or symbol of corruption. Instead, it consistently presents the church at Antioch as an example of early Christian faithfulness, teaching, missions, and service.

Antioch was where the disciples were first called Christians, where Barnabas and Paul taught many people, and where believers provided relief for suffering brethren in Judaea (**Acts 11:26–30**). It was also from Antioch that the Holy Ghost sent Paul and Barnabas on their missionary work, and it was there that they returned and reported what God had done (**Acts 13:1–3**; 14:26–28). The church later received the decision of the Jerusalem council and rejoiced in its confirmation of the truth (**Acts 15:22–35**). Later heresies associated with that region do not erase the consistently positive biblical testimony concerning Antioch or invalidate the faith-based contrast being made.

Alexandria: The Line of Corruption

The Law of First Mention: Egypt as Bondage and Compromise

The law of first mention is a Bible study principle: the first time a subject shows up in Scripture, it often sets the tone for how it's treated later. Egypt's first appearance is **Genesis 12:10**. Abraham "*went down into Egypt*" during a famine, and there he slipped into fear and lies about Sarah. That opening scene isn't

an accident; it frames Egypt as a place where God's people are tempted to compromise.

The thread keeps running through the Bible:

- **Exodus 12–14 —** Israel's greatest rescue is *out of* Egypt: out of slavery, idolatry, and paganism.

- **Exodus 12:12 —** The plagues are God's judgment on Egypt's gods.

- **Isaiah 31:1; Jeremiah 42:19 —** The prophets warn, again and again: don't go back to Egypt for help.

Put simply, the Bible does not paint Egypt in a positive light. Throughout the Bible, Egypt is repeatedly connected with bondage, idolatry, compromise, and trusting in something other than God.

- God says in **Exodus 20:2**: *"I am the LORD thy God, which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage."* Egypt is bondage.

- **Isaiah 30:1–2** warns God's people not to go down to Egypt for help, because it represents dependence on the world instead of on God.

- **Revelation 11:8** calls Jerusalem, in its apostasy, *"spiritually… Egypt."* Egypt is a symbol of corruption, apostasy, and worldliness.

So, it is no surprise that when we study the history of Bible manuscripts, those that come out of Alexandria are marked by doctrinal corruption.

The book of Acts gives us hints of this:

- **Acts 6:9** records that some of the false witnesses who disputed with Stephen came from the *"synagogue of the Libertines, and Cyrenians, and Alexandrians."* The opposition to God's preacher came out of Alexandria.

- **Acts 18:24–26** tells us of Apollos, an eloquent preacher from Alexandria, who knew the Scriptures but had doctrinal deficiencies. He needed Aquila and Priscilla to *"expound unto him the way of God more perfectly."* Again, the Bible subtly points out that Alexandria, Egypt, produced men eloquent in speech but tied to false doctrine.

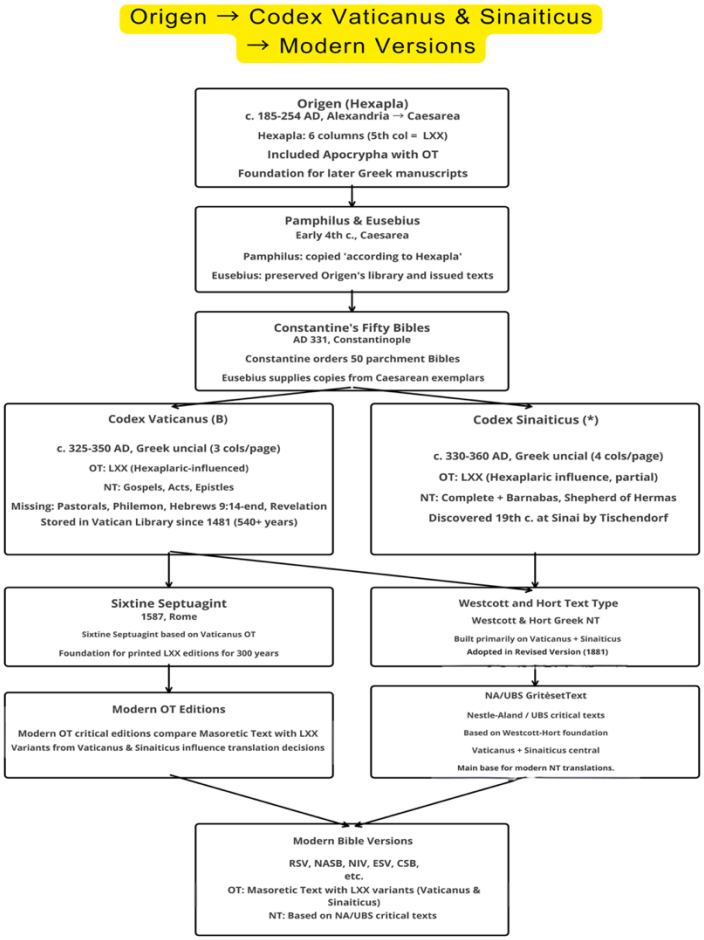
But Egypt Is Not Always Bad, Right?

Some critics point out that Egypt is not presented negatively in every passage. Under Joseph, Egypt became God's means of preserving Jacob's family during the famine (**Gen. 45:5–8**; 46:3–4). It later provided temporary shelter for the young Lord Jesus from Herod (**Matt. 2:13–15**), and Isaiah records the future blessing, *"Blessed be Egypt my people"* (**Isa. 19:25**).

These exceptions, however, do not erase the dominant biblical pattern concerning Egypt. A biblical pattern is established by the consistent testimony of Scripture, not overturned by a few exceptional circumstances in which God providentially used a place for good. In keeping with the law of first mention, Egypt's first explicit appearance in **Genesis 12:10–20** connects Abraham's descent into Egypt with fear and compromise. Later, Egypt becomes the "house of bondage," the object of God's judgment, and the place to which Israel was repeatedly warned not to return or look for help. **Revelation 11:8** even uses Egypt spiritually as a picture of apostasy. Therefore, although God occasionally used Egypt for protection or preservation, its

dominant biblical identity remains one of bondage, worldly dependence, compromise, and corruption.

The most famous name tied to Alexandria is **Origen (A.D. 184–254)**.



Flowchart shows Origen's Hexapla → Constantine's Fifty Bibles → Codex Vaticanus & Sinaiticus → Sixtine LXX (OT) & Westcott-Hort (NT) → NA/UBS → Modern Versions.

Codex Vaticanus stored in Vatican Library since 1481 (540+ years).

KEY: The main manuscripts and texts that are used in producing modern Bibles can be directly traced back to Alexandria, Egypt, and the work of Origen[41] [42] [43] [44] [45]

Origen was heretical. He denied the literal interpretation of Scripture,[46] taught the pre-existence of souls,[47] flirted with universal salvation,[48] and mutilated the text of Scripture.[49]

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[41] Anneli Aejmelaeus, "New Perspectives on the Textual Character of Codex Vaticanus," *Svensk Exegetisk Årsbok* 85 (2020): 3–17.

[42] Eusebius, *Life of Constantine* 4.36–37, trans. Ernest Cushing Richardson, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 1, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1890), 549.

[43] T. C. Skeat, "The Codex Sinaiticus, the Codex Vaticanus and Constantine," *Journal of Theological Studies*, n.s., 50, no. 2 (1999): 583–625.

[44] Kristin De Troyer, "The Septuagint," in *The New Cambridge History of the Bible*, vol. 1, *From the Beginnings to 600*, ed. James Carleton Paget and Joachim Schaper (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013), 267–88.

[45] Metzger and Ehrman, *Text of the New Testament*, 174–81, especially 179.

[46] Origen, *De Principiis* 4.1.16, trans. Frederick Crombie, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 4, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 365.

[47] Origen, *De Principiis* 1.7.4, 263.

[48] Origen, *De Principiis* 1.6.1–3, 260–62.

[49] "Introductory Note to the Works of Origen," in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, 4:230.

Philip Schaff (professor of church history at Mercersburg and Union Seminary) said this of Origen:[50]

> "The predilection of Origen for Plato misled him into many grand and fascinating errors."

He was more of a philosopher and heretic than he was a Bible believer.

Benjamin Wilkinson summed up the beliefs of Origen well:[51]

> "He taught that the soul existed from eternity before it inhabited the body, and that after death, it migrated to a higher or a lower form of life according to the deeds done in the body; and finally all would return to the state of pure intelligence, only to begin again the same cycles as before. He believed that the devils would be saved, and that the stars and planets had souls, and were, like men, on trial to learn perfection. In fact, he turned the whole law and Gospel into an allegory."

His "great" work, the **Hexapla**, placed the Apocrypha alongside the inspired books and mingled together Greek translations in a way that caused great confusion. From this poisoned spring came much of what later influenced Jerome's Vulgate,[52] the

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[50] Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 2, *Ante-Nicene Christianity, A.D. 100–325* (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1910), 791.

[51] Benjamin G. Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated* (Washington, DC: n.p., 1930), 17–18.

[52] Henry Barclay Swete, *An Introduction to the Old Testament in Greek* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1900), 69–72.

Vatican manuscript tradition, and ultimately the modern critical text.

The Alexandrian manuscripts themselves bear this corruption:

- **Codex Vaticanus (B)** breaks off at Hebrews 9:14 and now has no Pastoral Epistles, Philemon, or Revelation.

- **Codex Sinaiticus (ℵ)**, discovered in a wastebasket at St. Catherine's monastery, contains thousands of corrections by multiple hands.

- **Codex Alexandrinus (A)**, a later manuscript, mixes text types and is riddled with inconsistencies.

These manuscripts form less than 2 percent of the evidence, yet they are exalted by modern critics as "older and better." The truth is that most are not in fact older; and the few that are older are only so because they were rejected and unused by the churches. Like an unused tool left to rust in a closet, they survived because they were never trusted or worn out in preaching, copying, and evangelism.

Kirsopp Lake, who studied the Gospel manuscripts in the ancient monastic collections, asked why so few Byzantine manuscripts earlier than the tenth century survive when thousands must once have existed. He found it "hard to resist the conclusion that the scribes usually destroyed their exemplars when they had copied the sacred books."[53] Hills drew the conclusion:

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[53] Kirsopp Lake, Robert P. Blake, and Silva New, "The Caesarean Text of the Gospel of Mark," *Harvard Theological Review* 21, no. 4 (1928): 349.

> "If Lake's hypothesis is correct, then the manuscripts most likely to be destroyed would be those containing the Traditional Text. For these were the ones which were copied most during the period between the 4th and the 10th centuries, as is proved by the fact that the vast majority of the later Greek New Testament manuscripts are of the Traditional type."[54]

Of the earliest copies of the true text, Hills wrote that they "were read to pieces by the believing Bible students of antiquity."[55]

In discussing the corruption of Egypt and its manuscripts, Dr. Edward Hills stated,[56]

> "Thus we see that it is unwise in present-day translators to base the texts of their modern versions on recent papyrus discoveries or on B and Aleph. For all these documents come from Egypt, and Egypt during the early Christian centuries was a land in which heresies were rampant. So much was this so that, as Bauer (1934) and van Unnik (1958) have pointed out, later Egyptian Christians seem to have been ashamed of the heretical past of their country and to have drawn a veil of silence across it. This seems to be why so little is known of the history of early Egyptian Christianity. In view, therefore, of the heretical character of the early

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[54] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 7, under "Lost Manuscripts of the Traditional Text."

[55] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 7, under "The Early History of the True Text."

[56] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "The Only Begotten Son versus Only Begotten God."

> Egyptian Church, it is not surprising that the papyri, B, Aleph, and other manuscripts which hail from Egypt are liberally sprinkled with heretical readings."

Tale of Two Cities

When you put the pieces together, the contrast could not be clearer:

- Antioch is where believers were first called Christians. Alexandria is where false doctrine thrived.
- Antioch was the hub of missions. Alexandria was the center of philosophy.
- Antioch gave us the Textus Receptus and the Bibles of the Reformation. Alexandria gave us Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and the critical text that underlies modern versions.
- Antioch's line has borne the fruit of revival, missions, and doctrinal clarity. Alexandria's line has borne the fruit of skepticism, confusion, and doctrinal erosion.

Jesus said: "*Ye shall know them by their fruits*" (**Matt. 7:16**). Look at the fruits. The Reformation, the Great Awakenings, the missionary movements, all came from the Antiochian line of Bibles. In contrast, the line of Alexandria produced a stream of corrupted manuscripts, the rationalism of the Enlightenment, the skepticism of higher criticism, and a flood of modern versions that contradict one another and erode doctrines such as the deity of Christ, the virgin birth, the blood atonement, and the Trinity.

This is why the issue of "two lines of Bibles" is not about academic trivialities. It is a spiritual battlefield. The Word of

God has always had enemies. But praise God, He has always preserved His Word for His people.

As we will see later in this book, this second line did not stop at Alexandria. It ran through Jerome to Rome, through Trent and the Rheims New Testament of 1582, and back into the modern versions through the scholars of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.

"Reasoned Eclecticism" and Why the Issue Still Matters

Some readers today argue that the discussion over *Alexandrian* versus *Byzantine* manuscripts is outdated because modern editors of the Greek New Testament supposedly no longer rely on an "Alexandrian text," but on a method called reasoned eclecticism. On the surface, this seems to represent a break from the nineteenth-century theories of Westcott and Hort. In reality, however, it is largely a continuation of the same critical approach under a new name.

Reasoned eclecticism is the method employed in the Nestle–Aland (NA28/NA29) and United Bible Societies (UBS5) texts. It claims to "weigh" each variant reading on both *external* evidence (the age and quality of the manuscripts) and *internal* evidence (which reading best fits the author's style or the immediate context). In theory, this method allows any reading, from any text type, to be adopted if it seems to have the best combined support. Yet in practice, the same pattern seen since 1881 continues: the editors almost always prefer readings found in Vaticanus (B), Sinaiticus (א), and their Alexandrian allies.

Dr. Bruce Metzger, who served on the UBS Editorial Committee, repeatedly describes these favored witnesses as "the *earliest and best*," and commends readings "absent from the

earliest and best authorities."[57] This phrase appears throughout the UBS textual commentary, showing that *reasoned eclecticism* still operates from the same presupposition: that the Alexandrian manuscripts are superior by virtue of their age and Egyptian provenance.

Likewise, Kurt and Barbara Aland, architects of the modern Nestle–Aland text, formally classify nearly all Byzantine manuscripts as Category V, defining them as "purely or predominantly Byzantine" and therefore "irrelevant for textual criticism, at least for establishing the original form of the text."[58] Their system ensures that, even under an "eclectic" model, Byzantine readings are almost always excluded before the process of weighing begins.

The result is that the Nestle–Aland/UBS text of today *is 98–99 percent identical to the Westcott and Hort text of 1881*.[59] As Gregory Lanier demonstrates in his comparative study, the modern critical text has remained remarkably stable since the late nineteenth century, differing only minimally in the Catholic Epistles and Acts, where newer computer-assisted methods

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[57] Bruce M. Metzger, *A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament*, 2nd ed. (Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 1994), 50 (Matt. 23:14), 179 (John 5:3b–4).

[58] Kurt Aland and Barbara Aland, *The Text of the New Testament: An Introduction to the Critical Editions and to the Theory and Practice of Modern Textual Criticism*, 2nd ed., trans. Erroll F. Rhodes (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans; Leiden: Brill, 1989), 106, 142.

[59] Gregory R. Lanier, "The Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT: Stability, Change, and Implications," *Tyndale Bulletin* 71, no. 1 (2020): 50–51, https://doi.org/10.53751/001c.27734.

such as the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method (CBGM) have been introduced.[60]

Even these new tools such as the CBGM, however, have not shifted the overall Alexandrian base of the text. Although the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method represents a major change in textual-critical method, its results have not produced a radically different Greek New Testament. Gregory Lanier compared the NA28 text, together with the CBGM-assisted ECM text of Acts, against Westcott and Hort's 1881 text. In randomly selected passages covering approximately 5.5 percent of the New Testament, he found an overall agreement of 98.5 percent. Agreement was 97.2 percent in Acts and 98.1 percent in the Catholic Epistles, the two portions most directly affected by the CBGM at the time of his study.[61] The new method therefore creates a text that remains overwhelmingly similar to Westcott and Hort's original text.

In other words, "reasoned eclecticism" has not produced a new or balanced text; it has simply refined the same Alexandrian-dominated critical text first championed by Westcott and Hort. The terminology has changed, but the foundation remains the same. The overwhelming majority of readings in the NA/UBS editions still descend from the same Egyptian manuscripts once favored by those earlier editors.

For that reason, the core argument of this book still stands. Whether it is called the *Alexandrian text*, the *critical text*, or the *eclectic text*, the underlying issue has never changed: Has God preserved His Word through the manuscripts received and

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[60] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 49–52.

[61] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 49–50.

used by the believing Church, or must His Word be reconstructed by modern scholarship from manuscripts the Church historically rejected? The method may sound scientific, but it is built on the same rationalistic assumptions.

How large is the difference? D. A. Waite counted the changes Westcott and Hort made to the Received Text, using Scrivener's edition of the Greek text underlying the King James Bible. He found 5,604 places of difference: 1,952 omissions, 467 additions, and 3,185 changes. Together they involve 9,970 Greek words, about 7 percent of the 140,521 words of the Received Text, an average of 15.4 words on every page of the Greek New Testament.[62] Because the modern critical text remains overwhelmingly the same as Westcott and Hort's, the great bulk of those changes still stand in the Greek text behind the modern versions.

Theories Used to Dismiss the Byzantine Text

Several theories have been used to argue that the Byzantine Text is late and was not the original wording, but was added to and "conflated" through the years.[63]

Prefer the Shorter Reading

A commonly repeated rule says that the shorter reading should be preferred because scribes were more likely to add words

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[62] D. A. Waite, *Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority – Texts, Translators, Technique, Theology*, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 71, e-book.

[63] Brooke Foss Westcott and Fenton John Anthony Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek*, vol. 2, *Introduction and Appendix* (London: Macmillan, 1881), 93–107, 132–35.

than remove them. However, scribes could also omit words, phrases, or entire lines accidentally or purposefully.

James Royse examined six important early papyri and found that every one of their scribes omitted material more often than he added it. Other studies have reached similar conclusions. Therefore, the shorter reading may sometimes be correct, but its shortness alone does not prove that it is original. The same caution applies to the so-called "harder reading," since a copying error can make a reading more difficult without making it more ancient.[64]

E. C. Colwell, one of the leading American textual critics of the twentieth century, described the copyist of Papyrus 45 this way:

> "As an editor the scribe of P45 wielded a sharp axe. . . . The dispensable word is dispensed with."[65]

Colwell added that this scribe "shortens the text in at least fifty places in singular readings alone."[66] If one of the oldest papyri was produced by a scribe who habitually cut words out, then a rule that automatically prefers the shorter reading will automatically favor the work of such scribes.

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[64] James R. Royse, *Scribal Habits in Early Greek New Testament Papyri*, New Testament Tools, Studies and Documents 36 (Leiden: Brill, 2008), 734–35; Andrew Wilson, "Scribal Habits in Greek New Testament Manuscripts," *Filología Neotestamentaria* 24 (2011): 117.

[65] E. C. Colwell, "Method in Evaluating Scribal Habits: A Study of P45, P66, P75," in *Studies in Methodology*, 118–19.

[66] Moorman, *Forever Settled*, 79.

Supposed Conflated Readings

A conflation is a longer reading supposedly made by combining parts of two shorter readings. Westcott and Hort used several alleged Byzantine conflations to argue that the Byzantine Text was produced by later editors.

Harry Sturz showed why this argument is incorrect. Conflated readings are not limited to Byzantine manuscripts, and some readings that appear to be conflations are supported by early papyri. In **John 10:19** and **John 10:31**, for example, Papyrus 66, commonly dated around A.D. 200, supports the fuller reading later preserved in the Byzantine tradition. A longer reading may be the result of conflation, but its length cannot by itself prove that it is late.[67]

Dean Burgon raised the obvious objection as soon as Westcott and Hort published their theory. If combining readings was a regular practice of the makers of the Traditional Text, why could the two editors, after searching the Gospels for decades, produce only eight examples?[68] Later study did not rescue the theory. E. A. Hutton's *Atlas of Textual Criticism* (1911) listed 821 places where the Alexandrian, Western, and Byzantine texts each have a different reading. Only a handful of these can even be proposed as Byzantine conflations, a ratio of about one hundred to one.[69] Burgon also noted that where the Byzantine reading is fuller, the other manuscripts often supply nothing from which it could have been built:

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[67] Harry A. Sturz, *The Byzantine Text-Type and New Testament Textual Criticism* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 1984), 82–89, especially 84.

[68] Moorman, *Forever Settled*, 58.

[69] Moorman, *Forever Settled*, 58–59.

> "Bricks cannot be made without clay. The materials actually existing are those of the Traditional Text itself."[70]

The Supposed Lucian Recension

Another theory claims that *Lucian of Antioch*, or scholars associated with him, created the Byzantine Text through a planned revision around A.D. 300. Such a planned revision is called a recension.

However, no surviving historical account describes Lucian revising the Greek New Testament, identifies the manuscripts he supposedly used, or explains the rules he followed. Sturz emphasized this lack of historical evidence. The Lucian recension therefore should not be presented as an established historical fact.[71]

Sir Frederic Kenyon, who did not defend the Received Text, admitted the problem plainly:

> "We know the names of several revisers of the Septuagint and the Vulgate, and it would be strange if historians and Church writers had all omitted to record or mention such an event as the deliberate revision of the New Testament in its original Greek."[72]

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[70] John William Burgon, *The Traditional Text of the Holy Gospels Vindicated and Established*, ed. Edward Miller (London: George Bell and Sons, 1896), 229.

[71] Sturz, *Byzantine Text-Type*, 122–26.

[72] Frederic G. Kenyon, *Handbook to the Textual Criticism of the New Testament*, 2nd ed. (London: Macmillan, 1912), 325.

Early Byzantine Readings

Sturz catalogued approximately 150 readings that he classified as distinctively Byzantine and that receive support from early papyri. He was not claiming that these papyri were complete Byzantine manuscripts. His narrower point was that readings later preserved by the Byzantine tradition existed long before the proposed fourth-century revision.[73]

Günther Zuntz, whose study of Paul's epistles remains a standard work, reached the same conclusion from Papyrus 46:

> "A number of Byzantine readings, most of them genuine, which previously were discarded as 'late', are anticipated by P46."[74]

In a note Zuntz added that "the same is true of the sister-manuscript P45."[75] Readings the critics had labeled "late" turned out to be older than Vaticanus and Sinaiticus.

The evidence therefore establishes an important principle: the later date of a manuscript does not prove that its readings are late. The shorter reading is not automatically original; a fuller reading is not automatically a conflation; and the Lucian recension is not a documented event. The Byzantine tradition must be judged by the evidence rather than dismissed by theories imposed upon it.

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[73] Sturz, *Byzantine Text-Type*, 55–69, 145–59.

[74] G. Zuntz, *The Text of the Epistles: A Disquisition upon the Corpus Paulinum* (London: Oxford University Press, 1953), 55.

[75] Zuntz, *Text of the Epistles*, 55n4.

These theories have undoubtedly weakened confidence in the antiquity and originality of Byzantine readings. By portraying the Byzantine Text as late, conflated, and artificially constructed, they provided a basis for dismissing it as late and not original. Yet the historical record and manuscript evidence do not support such a conclusion. Westcott and Hort and, later, Kurt and Barbara Aland repeatedly treated the Byzantine tradition as inferior and assigned its witnesses little weight. However, the evidence says otherwise. The Byzantine Text therefore should not be dismissed on the basis of theories that assume its inferiority before its evidence is fairly examined.

Simply put, the discovery of Byzantine readings in early manuscripts—especially the papyri—decisively overturned theories that they arose through later expansion, conflation, or a Lucianic recension. Their early presence shows that these readings existed before the period in which they were supposedly created.

CHART KEY	
GREEN- KING JAMES BIBLE MANUSCRIPTS	RED- ALL MODERN BIBLE MANUSCRIPTS

Age Chart for Manuscripts

Old Testament Manuscripts		
Masoretic Text	Isaiah Scroll B (1QIsab)	175-100 BC
	The Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsaa)	175-100 BC
W&H Text Type (Septuagint or LXX)	Septuagint	Claims to be dated 200-250 BC
	Ryland Manuscript (fragment of Deuteronomy)	150 BC
	Origen's Hexapla	200 AD
New Testament Manuscripts		
Textus Receptus (Byzantian/Antiochan Text)	Peshitta Syriac	100-150 AD
	P66	100-200 AD
	P45	150-200 AD
	Church Father Quotes (2,630x)	69-400 AD
W&H Text Type (Alexandrian Texts)	Codex Vaticanus (B)	350-375 AD
	Codex Sinaiticus (א (Aleph))	300-400 AD
	Codex Alexandrinus (A)	400-500 AD

OLD TESTAMENT MANUSCRIPTS

Septuagint (Origen's Hexapla)

250-300 AD
Also known as the Greek LXX
The actual existence of this MSS (manuscript) is highly debated. The only historical record of it ever existing comes from a "Letter from Aristeas" where Aristeas writes to his brother Philocrates about how the Pharaoh of Egypt at the time, Ptolemy Philadelphia, was trying to get a Greek translation of the OT Hebrew scriptures for their library. The story states that **72 Jewish elders** (six from each of the twelve tribes) were hired for the job to go to **Alexandria, Egypt** to translate this great work. They supposedly translated it all in **72 days** and gave it to the Pharaoh. It became known as the Septuagint because of the 72 translators who created the translation (inaccurately so, since Septuagint means **"70"** and there were 72 translators who took **72 days**).

Origen's Hexapla

The OT of new versions of the Bible are actually translated from a document known as **Origen's Hexapla** in his **5th column** (Hexapla - 5 columns). He poorly tried to translate the Hebrew OT all on his own! He was from the philosophical, bible rejecting, heretical college at **Alexandria, Egypt**. All modern bible versions OT are based on his translation of the OT into Greek

Who was Origen?

- Believed Genesis 1-3 was not literal
- Believed in the allegorical interpretation method
- Believed Jesus was a created sub-god, not God
- Believed the Holy Spirit was a created being
- Believed in Salvation by works, not grace
- Believed in baptismal regeneration and sprinkling of babies
- Believed that Jesus' death was a ransom paid to Satan
- Believed in "purgatory" and not in a literal Hell
- Believed in universal salvation for all mankind
- Believed that Satan would be saved one day
- Believed that there is no bodily resurrection, but spiritual only
- Believed that there is no millennial kingdom of Jesus Christ

These manuscripts contained the Apocrypha mixed in amongst the canonical books (inspired/preserved books) (**Luke 24:27,44**)
Ultimately used by Westcott & Hort, two Bible rejecting, spiritualistic, heretics, to create the first Bible revision in **1885** (274 years after the KJV) the English Revised Version
Subsequently used to translate all new versions of the Bible since **1885**

Masoretic Text

The entirely Hebrew OT kept by the conservative Jewish group, the Masoretes
The keeping of the scriptures, specifically as it pertains to the OT, was committed to the Jews: specifically to the Levites, priests, scribes, and the Jews as a whole (Rom 3:2; Deut. 17:18; 31:24-26; Neh. 8:7-8; Deut. 4:1-2)

175 BC	**100 BC**
Isaiah A (Dead Sea Scrolls)	**Isaiah B** (Dead Sea Scrolls)

Some rules they followed when copying the OT

• A roll must be written on the skins of a clean animal
• It must be prepared for use by a Jew
• It must be fastened together with strings from a clean animal

• Every skin must contain a certain number of columns and they must be equal throughout the entire codex (MSS document)
• The length of every column must be 48 and 60 lines long
• The length of each line must be exactly 30 letters
• The whole copy must be lined
• The ink must be black prepared according to a particular recipe (non metallic)

• An authorized copy must be the exemplar (one being copied from)
• No word, not even a letter, can be written from memory
• Between every letter there must be the space of a hair or thread
• Between every new section there must be the space of 9 letters
• Between every book there must be 3 lines
• The 5th book of Moses (Deuteronomy) must end exactly with a line

• The copyist must sit in full Jewish dress
• The copyist must have just washed his whole entire body
• The copyist must write the name of God with a pen newly dipped in ink. He must again wash his whole body before writing the name of the Lord. And should a king address him while he is writing that name, he must ignore the king

Used to translate the KJV in 1611

NEW TESTAMENT MANUSCRIPTS

Alexandrian Texts

Also known as "Western Texts"
The 3 Main MSS in use by scholars for translating new versions of the Bible are: Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus. Vaticanus is the most heavily relied on MSS

Vaticanus
300-375 AD
Leaves out over 1,000 sentences
Adds over 600 words
Changed approximately 2,000 words
In 17,000 places it differs from Sinaiticus
It leaves out books of the NT and adds in books that are not found in the Bible

Sinaiticus
300-400 AD
Found at the base of Mt. Sinai in Egypt in a kindling bin in a monastery
Leaves out 4,000 words from the Gospels alone
Adds over 1,000 words
Changes the reading of the text in 1,600 other places

Alexandrinus
400-500 AD
Created in Alexandria Egypt at the school there
Created in an environment of textual criticism and heresy
Does not differ greatly from the other two main MSS and for that reason is used less for translating than the other two

They are all traced back to Alexandria, Egypt. This was a place of heresy and all bad things in the Bible. Also a picture of the world in the Bible. (Gen. 12:10; 13:10; Rev. 11:8)

They are also a part of what is called the "Minority Text". This is because they account for only 45/5,255 extant (in existence) MSS

Ultimately used by Westcott & Hort, two Bible rejecting, spiritualistic, heretics, to create the first Bible revision in 1885 (274 years after the KJV) the English Revised Version

Subsequently used to translate all new versions of the Bible since 1885

Antiochian Texts

Also known as Byzantine, Eastern, and Syrian texts
Come from Antioch, Syria where they were first called Christians (Acts 11:26)
MSS from this line date back as far as 100 AD

Peshitta Syriac
100-150 AD

Papyrus #66
100-200 AD

2,680 Quotes from church fathers
69-500 AD

These texts are known as the Textus Receptus "Received Text". They got their name due to the fact that Christians as a whole, through the aid of the Holy Ghost, accepted these MSS as scripture. The NT scripture is determined by the NT priesthood just as the OT was through OT priesthood (Rev. 1:6; 20:6; 1 Pet. 2:9)

They are also a part of what is called the "Majority Text". This is because they account for a staggering 5,210/5,255 extant MSS

Antioch was also the center for missions work in the early church (Acts 13:1-3)

Used to translate the KJV in 1611

REFER TO MSS COPYING CHART FOR MORE DETAILS ON HOW THE TWO MSS FAMILIES WERE PASSED/ COPIED

Other Ancient witnesses
P45: AD 200
P46: AD 175–225
Old Latin/Itala: second century
Sinaitic Syriac (sys): AD 300–400
Gothic version: AD 350
W (032): c. AD 300–400
Q (026), D (05), A (02, Gospels): c. AD 400–450
Other uncials in comparison: C, D(06)

Witnesses to individual readings, not all complete Byzantine manuscripts.
Book: pp. 97, 150–52.

PART II: THE OLD TESTAMENT

TO THE JEW WERE COMMITTED THE ORACLES

The starting point for any honest study of the Old Testament text must be God's own testimony concerning those to whom its custody was given. We are not left to guesswork or merely to the shifting opinions of textual critics. Scripture itself tells us plainly:

"What advantage then hath the Jew? or what profit is there of circumcision? Much every way: chiefly, because that unto them were committed the oracles of God." (**Romans 3:1–2**)

The apostle Paul states that Israel's greatest privilege was not their land, their kings, or even their temple, but that the very Word of God had been entrusted to them. The Old Testament was not scattered carelessly among the nations, nor was its keeping given to pagan philosophers. God committed it to the Jews, especially to the priests and Levites.

The phrase "were committed" speaks of custody. God gave the Old Testament through Jewish prophets and placed its keeping in the hands of the Jewish people. The priests, Levites, scribes, and teachers of the law were responsible to preserve, read, copy, and teach it.

The Hebrew text later known as the **Masoretic Text** stands in that same line of Jewish transmission. The Masoretes received the traditional consonantal Hebrew text that had been carefully passed down before them.

Custody Given by God Himself

From the beginning, God tied the keeping of His words to His covenant people.

- **Deut. 31:24–26 —** When Moses finished the law, he gave it to the Levites to keep beside the ark.

- **Mal. 2:7 —** The priest's lips "should keep knowledge," and people should seek the law from him.

- **Deut. 17:18–19 —** Even kings were required to copy the law from the text kept "before the priests the Levites."

The pattern is consistent: Moses delivered the written law to the Levites; kings copied from the text kept before them; Ezra served as a ready scribe in the law of Moses; the law was read publicly to the people; and Paul later said that the oracles were committed to the Jews. God placed the Hebrew Scriptures in Jewish custody and expected them to be preserved and taught.

Jewish scribes did not treat copying as ordinary bookwork. They counted lines, words, and letters; followed careful rules for columns and spacing; recorded textual notes; and rejected defective scrolls rather than pass them on. The Masoretes continued this conservative work by adding vowels and accents to protect the public reading of the text. Their methods show deliberate, careful stewardship of the Hebrew Scriptures.[76]

The rules recorded in the Talmud for copying the synagogue rolls show how seriously this custody was taken. H. S. Miller summarized eight of them, including these:

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[76] The rules governing the production of sacred scrolls were later gathered in the tractate *Soferim*. See Emanuel Tov, *Scribal Practices and Approaches Reflected in the Texts Found in the Judean Desert*, Studies on the Texts of the Desert of Judah 54 (Leiden: Brill, 2004), 10–12, 261.

> "No word nor letter could be written from memory; the scribe must have an authentic copy before him, and he must read and pronounce aloud each word before writing it."
>
> "One mistake on a sheet condemned the sheet; if three mistakes were found on any page, the entire manuscript was condemned."
>
> "Every word and every letter was counted, . . . and if a letter were omitted, an extra letter inserted, or if one letter touched another, the manuscript was condemned and destroyed at once."[77]

Miller concluded:

> "Some of these rules may appear extreme and absurd, yet they show how sacred the Holy Word of the Old Testament was to its custodians, the Jews (Rom. 3:2), and they give us strong encouragement to believe that we have the real Old Testament, the same one which our Lord had and which was originally given by inspiration of God."[78]

Hills recalls that Augustine called these Jewish scribes the librarians of the Christian church. In the providence of God

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[77] H. S. Miller, *General Biblical Introduction: From God to Us*, rev. ed. (Houghton, NY: Word-Bearer Press, 1960), 184–85, quoted in D. A. Waite, *Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority – Texts, Translators, Technique, Theology*, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 55–56, e-book.

[78] Miller, *General Biblical Introduction*, 185, quoted in Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 56.

they kept the Hebrew Scriptures until the Reformation brought them back into general Christian use.[79]

The Contrast with Greek Handling of the Text

Modern critics often give the **Septuagint** great authority. Yet Scripture never says that Gentile kings or Alexandrian scholars were entrusted with preserving the Old Testament. God chose the Jews to guard His oracles.

The question of authority therefore does not begin with the *Letter of Aristeas* or with fourth-century Greek codices. It begins with Scripture's own statement that the oracles of God were committed to the Jews.

The Character of Jewish Transmission

The Jewish scribes, including the later Masoretes, copied the Hebrew text with meticulous care. They counted letters, checked columns, and rejected defective scrolls. Millar Burrows, writing in 1948 about the Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa[a]), stated that "the whole book is here, and it is substantially the book preserved in the Masoretic text." He noted differences in spelling and some forms, but the wording remained remarkably

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[79] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 4, "A Christian View of the Biblical Text," under "How the Priests Preserved the Old Testament Text," e-book; Augustine, *Expositions on the Book of Psalms*, Ps. 57, sec. 7, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 8, ed. Philip Schaff (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Company, 1888), 227.

close. The Second Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa[b]) agreed even more closely with the Masoretic Text.[80] [81] [82]

This evidence shows that the Hebrew text later known as the Masoretic Text had been carefully transmitted within the Jewish community long before the medieval Masoretic codices. The Qumran scrolls contain more than one textual form, but they also preserve a clearly recognizable Masoretic line centuries before Christ.

A Faith-Based Conclusion

The Bible is not silent about who had custody of the Old Testament. The oracles were committed to the Jews, who read, copied, taught, and preserved the Hebrew Scriptures through the centuries.

The line of transmission is clear: God committed the Hebrew Scriptures to the Jews; Jewish scribes carefully copied and guarded them; the Masoretes continued that conservative work; printed Hebrew editions carried the same received text into the Reformation; **and the King James translators used that Hebrew text for the Old Testament**.

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[80] Babylonian Talmud, Kiddushin 30a, in *The Talmud of Babylonia: A Translation and Commentary*, ed. Jacob Neusner (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2011).

[81] Millar Burrows, "Variant Readings in the Isaiah Manuscript," *Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research*, no. 111 (October 1948): 16.

[82] W. F. Albright, "New Light on Early Recensions of the Hebrew Bible," *Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research*, no. 140 (December 1955): 30.

This is why the King James Bible rests on the Masoretic Text. Its Old Testament comes from the Hebrew text preserved in the line of custody God gave to the Jewish people.

MASORETIC TEXT AND THE DEAD SEA SCROLLS

The Old Testament of the King James Bible is based on the Masoretic Text, the traditional Hebrew text carefully copied and preserved by Jewish scribes. The Masoretic manuscripts include vowel points, accents, and marginal notes that help preserve the reading of the ancient consonantal text. The Dead Sea Scrolls provide an earlier witness to that same Hebrew tradition.

Long before the Dead Sea Scrolls were discovered, the medieval Hebrew manuscripts had been examined on a massive scale. Benjamin Kennicott published at Oxford in 1776–80 the readings of 634 Hebrew manuscripts, and Giovanni de Rossi followed in 1784–88 with collations of 825 more. Hills reports:

> "No substantial variation among the manuscripts was detected by either of these two scholars."[83]

Nearly fifteen hundred manuscripts, copied in many lands over many centuries, bore witness to one received Hebrew text.

The Dead Sea Scrolls Confirm the Masoretic Text

When the Dead Sea Scrolls were discovered between 1947 and 1956, they gave scholars Hebrew biblical manuscripts more than a thousand years older than the great medieval Masoretic codices. Rather than overturning the Masoretic Text, they

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[83] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 4, "A Christian View of the Biblical Text," under "Manuscripts of the Hebrew Old Testament—The Dead Sea Scrolls," e-book.

showed how carefully much of the Hebrew Bible had been transmitted.[84]

- The Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa[a]), dated to about 125 B.C., contains all sixty-six chapters of Isaiah in their traditional order. Its text generally agrees with the Masoretic version, while also containing spelling differences, scribal corrections, and some variant readings. Gleason Archer estimated that the two Isaiah manuscripts from Qumran Cave 1 were word-for-word identical with the standard Hebrew Bible in more than 95 percent of their text, with most remaining differences involving spelling or obvious scribal slips.[85]

- The Second Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa[b]) agrees even more closely with the Masoretic Text. Jacobs counted 157 variants among 4,627 preserved words, a variation rate of about 3.4 percent. Peter Flint and Eugene Ulrich classify the scroll as proto-Masoretic because of its general agreement with the received Masoretic Text. This is direct evidence of the careful transmission of the Hebrew text before Christ.[86] [87]

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[84] Emanuel Tov, *Textual Criticism of the Hebrew Bible*, 3rd ed., rev. and exp. (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2012), 29–32, 107–10.

[85] Gleason L. Archer Jr., *A Survey of Old Testament Introduction*, updated and rev. ed. (Chicago: Moody Press, 1994), 29.

[86] Jarod T. Jacobs, "The Balance of Probability: A Statistically Based Analysis of the Linguistic Character of the 'Biblical' Dead Sea Scrolls" (PhD diss., University of Manchester, 2015), 91–96.

[87] Peter W. Flint and Eugene Ulrich, "The Variant Textual Readings in the Hebrew University Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa[b])," *Journal of Jewish Studies* 60, no. 1 (2009): 60–79, esp. 60.

- Studies of the biblical scrolls commonly classify about 60 percent as proto-Masoretic, while only a much smaller number, about 5 percent, align closely with distinctive Septuagint readings.[88] [89] [90]

More than a century before Christ, Jewish communities were therefore using a Hebrew text that closely agrees with the Masoretic tradition.

Not every Dead Sea Scroll agrees with the Masoretic Text in every detail, but that does not weaken the central point. The scrolls show that the Hebrew text later preserved in the Masoretic manuscripts had already been passed down within the Jewish community for centuries.

Millar Burrows, who had published the Great Isaiah Scroll, later assessed the whole range of Qumran texts this way:

> "The Proto-Masoretic text existed at Qumran and elsewhere along with the divergent texts; on the whole it is fair to say that it was the trunk and they were branches that had sprung out of it. The greatest

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[88] Emanuel Tov, *Textual Criticism of the Hebrew Bible* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1992), 115. Tov revised these categories in the third edition (2012), 107–10.

[89] Bruce K. Waltke, "How We Got the Hebrew Bible: The Text and Canon of the Old Testament," in *The Bible at Qumran: Text, Shape, and Interpretation*, ed. Peter W. Flint, with the assistance of Tae Hun Kim (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2001), 38.

[90] Lawrence H. Schiffman, *Reclaiming the Dead Sea Scrolls* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1994), 138. Roughly 60 percent of the scrolls are proto-Masoretic, 5 percent proto-Samaritan, 5 percent Septuagintal, and the rest non-aligned or in the Qumran scribal practice.

> contribution of the Dead Sea Scrolls to textual criticism is still their demonstration of this fact."[91]

Scholars who reject the King James position acknowledge the same thing. In an interview with Wesley Huff, Gregory Lanier, professor of New Testament at Reformed Theological Seminary and co-chair of the Evangelical Theological Society's Septuagint Studies Group, said of the Great Isaiah Scroll:

> "There are hundreds of differences, but none of them are significant. They're all like spelling differences."[92]

He concluded that "the Masoretic text has very very ancient roots."[93]

Archaeological Support

Other archaeological evidence also shows the conservative character of this Hebrew tradition:

- The Tel Dan Stele, an inscription from the ninth century B.C., spells David's name as "DWD" (דוד). The Great Isaiah Scroll, from about 125 B.C., sometimes uses the fuller spelling "DWYD" (דויד), while the Masoretic Text preserves the older spelling "DWD." This is one example of a later manuscript preserving an

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[91] Millar Burrows, *More Light on the Dead Sea Scrolls* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1958), 162.

[92] Gregory R. Lanier, interview by Wesley Huff, "What the Septuagint Is and Isn't | Wes Huff & Dr. Greg Lanier," YouTube video, 38:04–38:08, posted by Wesley Huff, September 2, 2026, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o-P2jnAUTCY.

[93] Lanier, "What the Septuagint Is and Isn't," 39:20–39:28.

older Hebrew form. The date of a surviving copy does not by itself determine the age of the text it preserves.

- In 2021, additional fragments of Zechariah and Nahum were recovered from the "Cave of Horror" near the Dead Sea. Although they are Greek fragments, the Hebrew text behind them reflects an early Jewish scribal tradition closely related to the Masoretic base.[94] [95]

Together, these discoveries show a Hebrew text handled conservatively within Jewish custody. The Masoretic Text represents that carefully transmitted tradition, the same line of Hebrew Scripture entrusted to the priests, Levites, and Jewish scribes.

Which Hebrew Text? The King James Old Testament and the Modern Editions

The Hebrew text used by the King James translators was the Masoretic Text edited by Jacob ben Chayyim and printed by Daniel Bomberg at Venice in 1524–25, often called the Second Rabbinic Bible. For four hundred years it was the standard printed Hebrew Old Testament. Rudolf Kittel's *Biblia Hebraica* used this same Ben Chayyim text in its first two editions (1906 and 1912). In 1937, however, the editors changed the base text to

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[94] Israel Antiquities Authority, "A Challenging Israel Antiquities Authority Operation Has Uncovered Thrilling Finds in the Judean Desert Nature Reserve," news release, March 16, 2021, https://www.friendsofiaa.org/news/2021/3/16/a-challenging-israel-antiquities-authority-operation-has-uncovered-thrilling-finds-in-the-judean-desert-nature-reserve.

[95] Israel Antiquities Authority, "Challenging Israel Antiquities Authority Operation."

the Leningrad manuscript of A.D. 1008, from the Ben Asher tradition, and the *Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia* (1967/77) follows the same manuscript.[96]

These modern editions also print suggested changes in their footnotes. Waite estimated fifteen to twenty per page, between 20,000 and 30,000 in all, and modern translators openly use them.[97] The preface of the New International Version names the Dead Sea Scrolls, the Samaritan Pentateuch, ancient scribal traditions, variant readings in the Hebrew margin, the Septuagint, Symmachus, Theodotion, the Vulgate, the Syriac Peshitta, the Targums, and Jerome's Latin Psalms as sources the translators consulted and at times followed, and it adds that "some words were read with a different set of vowels."[98] In a study of 103 places where the American Standard Version, the New American Standard Version, and the New International Version depart from the Masoretic Hebrew text, Waite found that the Septuagint was preferred over the Hebrew 73 times (35 percent), that 67 departures (32 percent) rested on conjecture with no manuscript support at all, and that the Syriac was followed 20 times.[99]

Isaiah 9:3 shows the result. The written Hebrew text contains the word "not," and the King James translators rendered exactly what was written: "Thou hast multiplied the nation, and not increased the joy." The modern versions remove the word

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[96] D. A. Waite, *Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority – Texts, Translators, Technique, Theology*, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 57–58, e-book.

[97] Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 51, 58.

[98] *The Holy Bible: New International Version* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1978), preface, viii–ix.

[99] Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 59–60.

"not."[100] The King James Old Testament rests on the received Hebrew text as the Jews handed it down. The modern versions rest on an edited text that their translators feel free to correct from Greek, Latin, Syriac, and conjecture. Hills gave the right counsel:

> "Instead of depending on such inconstant allies, Bible-believing Christians should develop their own type of Old Testament textual criticism, a textual criticism which takes its stand on the teachings of the Old Testament itself and views the evidence in the light of these teachings."[101]

Jesus and the Hebrew Text Preserved by the Jews

Jesus and the apostles treated the Hebrew Scriptures preserved among the Jews as the authoritative Old Testament.

- ***Matthew 5:18*** *— "Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled." Christ's reference to jots and tittles points to the Hebrew form of the law.*

- ***Luke 24:44*** *— Jesus described the Old Testament by its three Hebrew divisions: "the law of Moses, and the prophets, and the psalms." This is the traditional Hebrew*

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[100] Waite, Defending the King James Bible, 62; see also Albert Barnes, Notes on the Old Testament, on Isa. 9:3: "The Masoretes here read in the margin לוֹ lô 'to it,' instead of לֹא lo' 'not,'" accessed December 1, 2025, https://biblehub.com/commentaries/isaiah/9-3.htm.

[101] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "Manuscripts of the Hebrew Old Testament—The Dead Sea Scrolls."

arrangement, without the Apocrypha being placed within the canon.

- ***Matthew 23:35*** *— Jesus charged His generation with "all the righteous blood shed upon the earth, from the blood of righteous Abel unto the blood of Zacharias son of Barachias." Abel's death is recorded in Genesis, the first book of the Hebrew Bible, and the stoning of Zechariah in 2 Chronicles 24:20–22, in the book that closes the Hebrew canon. From first to last, Christ spoke of the Old Testament in the order of the Hebrew Bible, not in the order of the Greek codices.*[102]

Hills stated what Christ's words mean for the Hebrew text:

> "Here our Lord assures us that the Old Testament text in common use among the Jews during His earthly ministry was an absolutely trustworthy reproduction of the original text written by Moses and the other inspired authors. Nothing had been lost from that text, and nothing ever would be lost."[103]

Robert Dick Wilson of Princeton Seminary, who mastered some forty-five languages and dialects, reached the same conclusion:

> "The result of those thirty years' study which I have given to the text has been this: I can affirm that there is not a page of the Old Testament concerning which we need have any doubt. We can be absolutely certain that substantially we have the text of the Old Testament

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[102] D. A. Waite, quoted in Moorman, *Forever Settled*, 17.

[103] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "The Providential Presentation of the Scriptures."

> that Christ and the Apostles had, and which was in existence from the beginning."[104]

The Masoretic Text therefore represents the Hebrew Bible carefully passed down by the Jewish people. Its agreement with the Dead Sea Scrolls, its conservative scribal features, and its continuity with the Hebrew Scriptures recognized by Christ all support its use as the Old Testament foundation of the King James Bible.

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[104] Robert Dick Wilson, quoted in Henry W. Coray, "The Incomparable Wilson: The Man Who Mastered Forty-Five Languages and Dialects," in *Which Bible?*, ed. David Otis Fuller, 5th ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Grand Rapids International Publications, 1975), 43–44.

WHAT THE SEPTUAGINT IS (AND ISN'T)

The **Septuagint** (LXX) is often presented as one complete **Greek Old Testament** translated in Alexandria around 250 B.C. and later used by Jesus, the apostles, and the early church. Greek translations of parts of the Old Testament certainly existed before Christ, but the surviving evidence does not support so simple a picture.

The question is not whether Jewish people translated any Scripture into Greek. They did. The question is whether one complete and fixed Greek Old Testament existed before Christ, matched the later codices, and carried greater authority than the Hebrew text kept by the Jews. The evidence does not establish those claims.

The Modern Claim

If you read a seminary textbook, you will often see statements like:

- "The Septuagint was translated around 250 B.C. in Alexandria by seventy-two Jewish scholars."
- "Jesus and the apostles quoted from the Septuagint."
- "The Septuagint was the Bible of the early church."

These statements bring together three different things: the early Greek translation of the Law, later Greek translations of other books, and the fourth- and fifth-century codices commonly used to reconstruct the Septuagint today. Evidence for one should not automatically be treated as evidence for all three.

What the Historical Evidence Shows

The *Letter of Aristeas*

The traditional account comes from the *Letter of Aristeas*. It says that Ptolemy II Philadelphus brought seventy-two Jewish elders to Alexandria to translate the Hebrew Law into Greek for his library. Even in the letter, the work described is the Law, the first five books of Moses, not the complete Old Testament.

The letter was written after the event it describes and is generally regarded as pseudepigraphical. It may preserve an older tradition, but it cannot by itself establish whether or not a complete Greek translation of the Old Testament was circulating before Jesus' day.[105]

At most, the account supports the existence of an early Greek Pentateuch. It does not tell us what Greek text was used for Isaiah, Psalms, the Prophets, or the later codices. It also does not change the biblical fact that **God committed the Hebrew Scriptures to the Jews**.

Later Accounts and the Extent of the Translation

Philo and Josephus repeat the translation story, and Eusebius records it much later. Their testimony shows that the tradition was well known. It still does not prove that the entire Old

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[105] Henry Barclay Swete, *An Introduction to the Old Testament in Greek* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1900), 15–17.

Testament had been translated at one time or existed in one fixed form before Christ.[106] [107] [108]

Hebrew scholar Dr. Paul Kahle argued against the idea of one original, complete, fixed Septuagint that was in existence in Jesus' day.[109] [110]

The term "Septuagint" therefore needs to be used carefully. It may refer to the early Greek Pentateuch, to Greek translations of other Old Testament books made at different times, or to a modern printed text reconstructed largely from later Christian codices.

Septuagint specialists now say much the same. Gregory Lanier explained that when he and William Ross wrote a book on the subject, they wanted its title to speak of "a loose and heterogeneous mixture of Greek translations and their subsequent revision histories." He warned against the impression that in antiquity "you could go to the bookshop . . . and like buy a Septuagint," adding, "That's not true. It's way

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[106] Josephus, *Jewish Antiquities* 12.11–118, trans. Ralph Marcus, in *Josephus*, vol. 7, Loeb Classical Library 365 (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; London: William Heinemann, 1943), 9–58.

[107] Philo of Alexandria, *On the Life of Moses* 2.25–44, trans. F. H. Colson, in *Philo*, vol. 6, Loeb Classical Library 289 (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; London: William Heinemann, 1935), 460–72.

[108] Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 5.8.10–15, trans. Arthur Cushman McGiffert, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 1, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1890), 223–24.

[109] Paul E. Kahle, *The Cairo Geniza*, 2nd ed. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1959), 264.

[110] Kahle, *Cairo Geniza*, 264.

more complicated than that." He also said that the translation of the Hebrew Bible into Greek "didn't finish even until probably after the time of Jesus."[111] Paul Kahle's case against a single original Greek Old Testament was strong enough that even Sir Frederic Kenyon wrote:

> "It must be admitted that Kahle makes out a very strong case."[112]

The Earliest Surviving Greek Fragments

No complete Greek Old Testament manuscript survives from before the Christian era.

- The Rylands Greek Papyrus 458, usually dated to the second century B.C., preserves only small portions of Deuteronomy.[113]

- Other pre-Christian fragments show that portions of Scripture circulated in Greek. They do not show that a complete and uniform Greek Old Testament existed.

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[111] Gregory R. Lanier, interview by Wesley Huff, "What the Septuagint Is and Isn't | Wes Huff & Dr. Greg Lanier," YouTube video, 2:01–2:10; 3:05–3:14; 3:56–4:00, posted by Wesley Huff, September 2, 2026, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o-P2jnAUTCY.

[112] Frederic G. Kenyon, *Our Bible and the Ancient Manuscripts*, 5th ed., rev. A. W. Adams (London: Eyre and Spottiswoode, 1958), 111. This sentence was added in the revised fifth edition; it is not in the 1903 edition cited elsewhere in this book.

[113] Papyrus Rylands 458 (P.Ryl. 458) is generally accepted as the earliest extant manuscript of the Septuagint. C. H. Roberts, ed., *Two Biblical Papyri in the John Rylands Library, Manchester* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1936), 11.

- The first nearly complete Greek Old Testament witnesses are the corrupt fourth- and fifth-century Christian codices, **Vaticanus and Sinaiticus**, dated several centuries after the date traditionally assigned to the translation in Alexandria.

For that reason, the wording of Vaticanus or Sinaiticus cannot simply be projected backward to 250 B.C. as though every reading came from one original translation.

The quality and history of these Greek translations also argue against giving them authority over the Hebrew. Drawing on D. W. Gooding's article in *The New Bible Dictionary*, Moorman writes:

> "Isaiah as a translation is bad; Esther, Job, Proverbs are free paraphrases."[114]

The Greek text was also revised again and again. In the second century Aquila, Symmachus, and Theodotion produced new Greek versions, and in Isaiah 7:14 they abandoned the Septuagint's *parthenos* ("virgin") for *neanis*, a word that may be applied to a young married woman.[115] For that reason Gooding cautioned:

> "The expositor who . . . appeals to some LXX word or phrase must be sure that it was not introduced by a reviser after New Testament times."[116]

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[114] Moorman, *Forever Settled*, 11.

[115] Moorman, *Forever Settled*, 11–13.

[116] D. W. Gooding, "Texts and Versions," in *The New Bible Dictionary*, ed. J. D. Douglas (London: Inter-Varsity Fellowship, 1962), 1260.

Origen's Hexapla and the Septuagint

Origen, the third-century Alexandrian scholar, compiled the Hexapla, a large comparison of the Hebrew text, a Greek transliteration, and several Greek translations. The full work has not survived, but portions are known from fragments and later quotations.[117]

The Greek Old Testament text found in Codices Vaticanus and Sinaiticus reflects this same Alexandrian tradition and shows the influence of Origen's textual work ***(see the chapter "The Alexandrian Cluster (B, ℵ, A) in Context").*** Therefore, the earliest surviving examples of a nearly complete Greek Old Testament do not lead back to a single, unchanged translation from the third century B.C. Instead, they lead to the later Alexandrian textual corruptor, Origen.

Septuagint scholars confirm the connection. Gooding observed:

> "Even the great uncials B, A, and Aleph are not immune from pre-Origen revision. Vaticanus follows the Hexapla in Isaiah while in Judges it represents a 4th century AD revision."[118]

Lanier likewise acknowledged that the printed Septuagint most scholars consult, the Rahlfs–Hanhart edition, "is basically the text of Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and Alexandrinus," and that for many people those three great codices simply "are the

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[117] On the Hexapla, see Frederic G. Kenyon, *Our Bible and the Ancient Manuscripts: Being a History of the Text and Its Translations*, 4th ed. (London: Eyre and Spottiswoode, 1903), 54–56.

[118] Gooding, "Texts and Versions," 1260.

Septuagint."[119] When a modern writer says, "The Septuagint reads," he is usually quoting fourth- and fifth-century Christian codices.

This connects directly with the earlier discussion of Alexandria. The issue is not that the Old Testament was translated into Greek. The issue is the manner in which the Greek text was handled. In Alexandria, different readings and translations were brought together and altered, while the Hebrew text remained under the careful and conservative custody of the Jewish scribes.

The Great Uncials Are Later and Not Uniform

Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus are the earliest great codices to preserve most of the **Greek Old Testament**. They are not identical copies of one fixed text, however.

- They differ from one another in wording, order, contents, and corrections.
- They contain different collections of apocryphal or deuterocanonical books alongside the Old Testament.
- They date from the fourth and fifth centuries, roughly six or seven centuries after the traditional translation date.

Why the Hebrew Text Remains the Standard

- **Jewish custody**. God committed His oracles to the Jews, not to a pagan king or an Alexandrian library.

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[119] Lanier, "What the Septuagint Is and Isn't," 25:13–25:21; 4:08–4:19.

- **Canon**. The nearly complete Greek codices include books that were not part of the Hebrew canon and were never treated as Scripture by Jesus or the apostles.

- **Textual unity**. The surviving Greek witnesses (Vaticanus and Sinaiticus) do not present one uniform text. They differ in thousands of places. Therefore, if all of these differing witnesses are said to represent "the Septuagint," then what exactly is the Septuagint?

- **Method**. It is circular to use a later Greek codex to correct the Hebrew text and then cite that corrected reading as proof that the Hebrew is wrong.

The Greek translations differ from the Masoretic Text in wording, length, and arrangement. Some differences may reflect an ancient interpretation or another Hebrew form, but the existence of a difference does not give the Greek reading authority over the Hebrew text kept by the Jews.

Did Jesus and the Apostles Use Greek Translations?

The New Testament was written in Greek, and many Old Testament quotations resemble known Greek translations. That does not prove that Jesus and the apostles used one complete Alexandrian Greek Bible as their final authority.

- Many quotations agree closely with the traditional Hebrew wording.

- Some agree with known Greek forms.

- Others differ in form because the inspired writers translate, shorten, combine, explain, or apply the Old Testament passage.

Terence Brown, a strong defender of the Masoretic Text who nevertheless believed that a pre-Christian Greek translation existed, counted about 263 direct Old Testament quotations in the New Testament and found that only 88 correspond closely to the Septuagint. Others agree more closely with the Hebrew or differ from both.[120] Brown concluded:

> "From this it is evident that the Holy Spirit exercises independence of all human versions when He guides His Apostles to quote in the New Testament that which He had caused to be written in the Old."[121]

Lanier, who values the Septuagint far more highly than this book does, still warned that "quoting the Septuagint . . . communicates that it's a singular stable text and it's identical and it's not. Rarely is it identical." Asked how often the New Testament quotes the Septuagint, he said, "I avoid quantifying it." He also pointed to Matthew's citation of Hosea 11:1, "Out of Egypt have I called my son" (Matt. 2:15), which "doesn't match the Septuagint."[122]

Hebrews 1:6 is often cited as proof that the apostles quoted a Greek text against the Hebrew. Hills showed why that conclusion is not necessary. The clause is found in Codex

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[120] Terence H. Brown, *The Septuagint and the Modern Versions*, Article no. 30 (London: Trinitarian Bible Society, n.d.), under "Use of the Septuagint in the New Testament," accessed September 29, 2026, https://www.tbsbibles.org/page/TheSeptuagintAndTheModernVersions. Brown's categories account for 225 of these quotations.

[121] Brown, *Septuagint and the Modern Versions*, under "Use of the Septuagint in the New Testament."

[122] Lanier, "What the Septuagint Is and Isn't," 28:28–28:36; 51:30–51:35; 50:48–50:53.

Vaticanus as an addition to Deuteronomy 32:43, but Codex Alexandrinus reads differently there. Hills wrote:

> "If the reading of A is correct, then the text of B must have been changed at this point to agree with Heb. 1:6, and the author of the Epistle to the Hebrews could not be quoting it."[123]

The passage the writer had in view may be Psalm 97:7, "worship him, all ye gods," which stands in the Hebrew Bible.

When Jesus read in the synagogue at Nazareth, Luke describes a scroll of Isaiah. The passage does not identify a fourth-century Alexandrian codex. Christ also spoke of **Hebrew "jots" and "tittles"** and described the Old Testament by its Hebrew divisions: the law of Moses, the prophets, and the psalms.[124]

Conclusion of the Old Testament Section

The evidence does not show that Greek translations were absent before Christ. It shows that the common picture of one complete, fixed, and universally received pre-Christian Septuagint goes beyond what the surviving evidence proves.

- God committed His Old Testament oracles to the Jews.

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[123] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 4, "A Christian View of the Biblical Text," under "The Greek Old Testament (Septuagint)," e-book.

[124] Craig A. Evans, *Jesus and His World: The Archaeological Evidence* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2012), 81.

- The Masoretic Text represents the carefully preserved Hebrew tradition passed down in their custody.

- The Dead Sea Scrolls show the antiquity and stability of that Hebrew tradition.

- The earliest Greek evidence is fragmentary, while the nearly complete Greek codices are later, differ from one another, and reflect continued revision.

- New Testament quotations do not remove the authority of the Hebrew text or prove that the apostles followed one complete Alexandrian Greek Old Testament.

When the King James translators based the Old Testament on the Masoretic Hebrew text, they followed the Hebrew Bible carefully transmitted by the Jewish people. That is the line of custody Scripture itself identifies.

THE CANON OF SCRIPTURE: WHY SIXTY-SIX BOOKS AND NOT THE APOCRYPHA

Preservation concerns more than the words inside the books of the Bible. It also concerns the books themselves. Edward Hills made this point: it would be "passing strange" if God had guided His people concerning the canon but had left them without help concerning the text.[125] The reverse is also true. A pure text inside the wrong collection of books would leave the believer as uncertain as a correct list of books with uncertain words inside them.

The King James Bible contains sixty-six books: thirty-nine in the Old Testament and twenty-seven in the New. Rome's Bible contains more. At the Council of Trent in 1546 Rome placed Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Ecclesiasticus, Baruch, and the two books of Maccabees among the sacred books, and it received Esther and Daniel "entire with all their parts," as the Latin Vulgate contained them, with the additions found only in the Greek. It did all this under pain of anathema. The great Greek codices of the fourth and fifth centuries already mingled these writings with Scripture, and the modern agreement between the Vatican and the United Bible Societies provides for them in joint Bibles: an edition bearing the imprimatur of Roman Catholic authorities "must contain the deuterocanonical texts."[126] So the

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[125] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 4, "A Christian View of the Biblical Text," under "The Preservation of the New Testament Text," e-book.

[126] Secretariat for Promoting Christian Unity and United Bible Societies, *Guidelines for Interconfessional Cooperation in Translating the Bible*, new rev. ed. (Vatican City, 1987), 2 (sec. 1.1.2), accessed September 25, 2026,

question of the canon is not a side issue. It is one more place where the two lines part company.

The Canon Is Received, Not Created

The word "canon" comes from the Greek *kanōn* (κανών). Thayer defines it first as "a measuring rod, rule," and then, in its figurative sense, as "any rule or standard, a principle or law of investigating, judging, living, acting."[127] Paul uses the word in that sense: "And as many as walk according to this rule, peace be on them, and mercy" (Gal. 6:16). The canon of Scripture is the rule by which everything else is measured. It cannot be measured by something higher than itself.

That is why the order matters. God gives His words, and His people receive them. The Lord Jesus said to the Father, "For I have given unto them the words which thou gavest me; and they have received them" (John 17:8). Paul thanked God that the Thessalonians, "when ye received the word of God which ye heard of us, ye received it not as the word of men, but as it is in truth, the word of God" (1 Thess. 2:13). The church is "the pillar and ground of the truth" (1 Tim. 3:15). A pillar holds up what rests on it. It does not create it.

Rome reverses the order. At Trent the council declared that it "receives and venerates with an equal affection of piety, and reverence, all the books both of the Old and of the New Testament," and in the same sentence, "the said traditions, as

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https://www.christianunity.va/content/unitacristiani/en/documenti/altri-testi/en.pdf.

[127] Joseph Henry Thayer, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (New York: American Book Company, 1889), s.v. "κανών."

well those appertaining to faith as to morals."[128] When a church places its own traditions on the same level as the written Word, it will not hesitate to decide which books belong in that Word. The believer's question is simpler: which books did God give, and which books did His people receive as His words from the beginning?

The Old Testament That Christ Received

Paul answers the first part of that question for the Old Testament: "unto them were committed the oracles of God" (Rom. 3:2). The word is *logia* (λόγια), the utterances of God. The custody of the Old Testament text was given to Israel, and so was the custody of the Old Testament canon. The Scriptures the Lord Jesus read, quoted, and fulfilled were the Scriptures in the hands of the Jews.

Christ described those Scriptures by their Hebrew divisions: "all things must be fulfilled, which were written in the law of Moses, and in the prophets, and in the psalms, concerning me" (Luke 24:44). He also marked their first and last pages. When He charged His generation with the blood of the prophets, He spoke of "the blood of Abel unto the blood of Zacharias, which perished between the altar and the temple" (Luke 11:51). Abel's death is recorded in Genesis and the stoning of Zechariah in 2 Chronicles 24, the book that closes the Hebrew Bible. From the first book to the last, the Lord spoke of the Old Testament as the Jews had it. He did not reach beyond it.

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[128] *The Canons and Decrees of the Sacred and Oecumenical Council of Trent*, trans. J. Waterworth (London: C. Dolman, 1848), 18 (session 4).

Neither did His apostles. The New Testament introduces the law, the prophets, and the psalms with "it is written," "the scripture saith," and "as saith the Holy Ghost." It never introduces a line of Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Ecclesiasticus, Baruch, or the Maccabees in that way. Two passages are sometimes offered as exceptions, and they deserve an honest answer. Jude quotes the prophecy of Enoch (Jude 14–15), but the book called Enoch is not part of the Apocrypha, and Jude cites what Enoch prophesied, not a book he calls Scripture. Hebrews speaks of those who "were tortured, not accepting deliverance; that they might obtain a better resurrection" (Heb. 11:35), words often connected with the martyrs of the Maccabean period. An inspired writer may refer to true events of history, just as Paul named Jannes and Jambres, who withstood Moses (2 Tim. 3:8), without turning the source of that history into Scripture.

The Jews of the first century testified to the same canon. Josephus, writing near the end of that century, told his Greek readers:

> "For we have not an innumerable multitude of books among us, disagreeing from and contradicting one another, [as the Greeks have,] but only twenty-two books, which contain the records of all the past times; which are justly believed to be divine.… It is true, our history hath been written since Artaxerxes very particularly, but hath not been esteemed of the like authority with the former by our forefathers, because

> there hath not been an exact succession of prophets since that time."[129]

Josephus did not name the twenty-two books, but Jerome, who learned the Hebrew order from the Jews, did. He counted twenty-two books, "five of Moses, eight of the prophets, nine of the Hagiographa," and noted that some reckoned twenty-four by counting Ruth and Lamentations separately. His list contains the same thirty-nine books found in the Old Testament of the King James Bible, counted in the Hebrew manner.[130] Josephus also gave the reason the later books were set aside: there had been no "exact succession of prophets" since the days of Artaxerxes. The Apocrypha were written after that time.

The Apocrypha Testifies Against Itself

The strongest witness against the Apocrypha is the Apocrypha. The first book of Maccabees, the most sober history among them, admits three times that there was no prophet in Israel in its day. When the defiled altar was pulled down, the stones were laid up "until there should come a prophet to shew what should be done with them" (1 Macc. 4:46). After the death of Judas "there was a great affliction in Israel, the like whereof was not since the time that a prophet was not seen among them" (1 Macc. 9:27). Simon was made governor and high priest "until there should arise a faithful prophet" (1 Macc. 14:41).[131] The

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[129] Josephus, *Against Apion* 1.8 (Niese 1.38–41), in *The Works of Flavius Josephus*, trans. William Whiston (1737; repr., Project Gutenberg, 2001), https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2849.

[130] Jerome, "Preface to the Books of Samuel and Kings," in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 6, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1893), 489–90.

[131] Quotations from the Apocrypha in this chapter are from the Authorized Version of 1611 in its standard text, as reproduced in

book that tells us most plainly about this period tells us that God was not then speaking through prophets.

The author of the second book of Maccabees closes with an apology no inspired writer ever made:

> "And if I have done well, and as is fitting the story, it is that which I desired: but if slenderly and meanly, it is that which I could attain unto." (2 Macc. 15:38)

Compare that with Peter's description of Scripture: "For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost" (2 Pet. 1:21). The word "moved" is *pheromenoi* (φερόμενοι), borne along. A man borne along by the Holy Ghost does not end his work by hoping he has done well enough.

The doctrine of these books tells the same story. The same second book of Maccabees commends prayer and a sin offering for the dead. Judas sent money to Jerusalem "to offer a sin offering," and the writer adds, "For if he had not hoped that they that were slain should have risen again, it had been superfluous and vain to pray for the dead… Whereupon he made a reconciliation for the dead, that they might be delivered from sin" (2 Macc. 12:43–45). Tobit teaches that "alms doth deliver from death, and shall purge away all sin" (Tobit 12:9), and Ecclesiasticus that "alms maketh an atonement for sins" (Ecclus. 3:30). Scripture says, "without shedding of blood is no

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Deuterocanonical Books of the Bible, Project Gutenberg eBook no. 124, accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/124.

remission" (Heb. 9:22), and "the blood of Jesus Christ his Son cleanseth us from all sin" (1 John 1:7).

In Tobit an angel sent from God introduces himself with a false name and a false family: "I am Azarias, the son of Ananias the great, and of thy brethren" (Tobit 5:12). Later he admits, "I am Raphael, one of the seven holy angels, which present the prayers of the saints" (Tobit 12:15). The same angel teaches that the smoke of a fish's heart and liver will drive away a devil: "if a devil or an evil spirit trouble any, we must make a smoke thereof before the man or the woman, and the party shall be no more vexed" (Tobit 6:7). The Lord Jesus cast out devils "by the Spirit of God" (Matt. 12:28), and the Scripture knows only "one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (1 Tim. 2:5). The Wisdom of Solomon teaches that the soul existed before the body: "For I was a witty child, and had a good spirit. Yea rather, being good, I came into a body undefiled" (Wisdom 8:19–20). Judith prays, "Smite by the deceit of my lips the servant with the prince" (Judith 9:10).

These are not the words of the God who "cannot lie" (Titus 1:2). But notice which of these teachings Rome has found useful. The *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, after stating that Rome "formulated her doctrine of faith on Purgatory especially at the Councils of Florence and Trent," supports the doctrine with this passage: "This teaching is also based on the practice of prayer for the dead, already mentioned in Sacred Scripture: 'Therefore [Judas Maccabeus] made atonement for the dead, that they might be delivered from their sin.'"[132] Purgatory, prayers for the

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[132] *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), nos. 1031–32, accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/__P2N.HTM. The Catechism cites the verse as 2 Macc. 12:46, following the verse

dead, the merit of alms, and angels who present the prayers of the saints all find a home in these books. The counterfeit religion needs the counterfeit canon.

The Witness of the Early Christians

The early Christians did not all agree about the Apocrypha, and this chapter will not pretend that they did. But the clearest witnesses followed the canon of the Jews.

Melito, bishop of Sardis in the second century, wrote to a friend who wanted "an accurate statement of the ancient books, as regards their number and their order." He explained, "when I went East and came to the place where these things were preached and done, I learned accurately the books of the Old Testament." His list contains no book of the Apocrypha. It names "the Proverbs of Solomon," which he also calls "Wisdom," an ancient name for the book of Proverbs. His list does not name Esther.[133]

In A.D. 367 Athanasius of Alexandria sent his churches a list of the books of Scripture. After naming the books of both Testaments, including the twenty-seven books of our New Testament, no more and no fewer, he wrote:

> "These are fountains of salvation, that they who thirst may be satisfied with the living words they contain. In

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numbering of Catholic Bibles; in the Authorized Version it is 2 Macc. 12:45.

[133] Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 4.26.13–14, trans. Arthur Cushman McGiffert, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 1, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1890), 206. The translator notes that "Wisdom" in Melito's list refers to the book of Proverbs.

> these alone is proclaimed the doctrine of godliness. Let no man add to these, neither let him take ought from these."[134]

He then named other books, "not indeed included in the Canon, but appointed by the Fathers to be read by those who newly join us," and among them he placed the Wisdom of Solomon, the Wisdom of Sirach, Judith, and Tobit.[135] Athanasius did not reckon every book exactly as the Hebrew canon does, but he drew the line between Scripture and the Apocrypha in the right place, and he knew the difference between a book read for instruction and a book that is the Word of God.

The most important witness of all is Jerome, because Rome would later declare his Latin Bible "authentic." Jerome learned the canon from the Hebrew and would not follow the Greek codices. In the preface he called his "helmeted" introduction to the Old Testament, he wrote:

> "This preface to the Scriptures may serve as a 'helmeted' introduction to all the books which we turn from Hebrew into Latin, so that we may be assured that what is not found in our list must be placed amongst the Apocryphal writings. Wisdom, therefore, which generally bears the name of Solomon, and the

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[134] Athanasius, *Letter* 39.6, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 4, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1892), 552.

[135] Athanasius, *Letter* 39.7, 552. Athanasius placed Esther among these books as well, and his Old Testament list joins Baruch and the Epistle of Jeremiah to the book of Jeremiah.

> book of Jesus, the Son of Sirach, and Judith, and Tobias, and the Shepherd are not in the canon."[136]

In his preface to the books of Solomon he gave the rule that the Church of England would later repeat:

> "As, then, the Church reads Judith, Tobit, and the books of Maccabees, but does not admit them among the canonical Scriptures, so let it read these two volumes for the edification of the people, not to give authority to doctrines of the Church."[137]

Others in the Latin West went the other way. Augustine counted Tobias, Judith, the two books of Maccabees, Wisdom, and Ecclesiasticus among the canonical books, and his rule for deciding the question was to "follow the judgment of the greater number of catholic churches."[138] The difference between Jerome and Augustine is the difference between the two lines. One asked what God had committed to the Jews. The other asked what the churches of his day were reading from their Greek and Latin collections.

Trent Settles the Question for Rome

Rome bound the question on all her people when the Reformers challenged her. At its fourth session, on April 8, 1546, the Council of Trent listed the books it received. Among them were "Tobias, Judith, Esther, Job," "Wisdom, Ecclesiasticus, Isaias,

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[136] Jerome, "Preface to the Books of Samuel and Kings," 490.

[137] Jerome, "Preface to the Books of Solomon," in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., 6:492.

[138] Augustine, *On Christian Doctrine* 2.8.12–13, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 2, ed. Philip Schaff (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Company, 1887), 538–39.

Jeremias, with Baruch," and "two books of the Machabees, the first and the second." Then it pronounced:

> "But if anyone receive not, as sacred and canonical, the said books entire with all their parts, as they have been used to be read in the Catholic Church, and as they are contained in the old Latin Vulgate edition; and knowingly and deliberately contemn the traditions aforesaid; let him be anathema."[139]

The irony is plain. The council declared Jerome's Latin Bible "authentic," yet placed under its curse the very judgment Jerome had written in the prefaces to that Bible. The man whose translation Rome canonized had said that Wisdom, Sirach, Judith, and Tobit "are not in the canon." Trent said that whoever agreed with him was anathema.

The Reformation and the King James Bible

The Reformers answered by returning to the canon of the Hebrew Bible, and the Church of England did so in Jerome's own words. The sixth of its Articles of Religion lists the canonical books of the Old Testament and then says:

> "And the other Books (as Hierome saith) the Church doth read for example of life and instruction of manners; but yet doth it not apply them to establish any doctrine."[140]

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[139] *Canons and Decrees*, 18–19.

[140] Church of England, *Articles of Religion* (1571), art. 6, in *The Book of Common Prayer* (1662), accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.churchofengland.org/prayer-and-worship/worship-texts-and-resources/book-common-prayer/articles-religion.

The article then names the books of the Apocrypha, among them Tobias, Judith, Wisdom, Jesus the son of Sirach, Baruch, and the two books of Maccabees. This was the confession of the church in which the King James translators served. The 1611 edition printed these books as a separate section between the Testaments, under the heading "The Books Called Apocrypha," and never among the books of Scripture. The Westminster Confession of 1647 put it more plainly still: "The books commonly called Apocrypha, not being of divine inspiration, are no part of the canon of the Scripture," and the Baptist Confession of 1689 repeated the statement.[141]

The line of truth did not canonize the Apocrypha. It set it apart, as Jerome had advised, and most Protestant Bibles printed since have left it out altogether. The line of Rome did the opposite. It placed the Apocrypha inside the Old Testament, bound it there with an anathema, and built doctrines upon it.

The New Testament Canon

The New Testament shows how the churches received the apostolic writings, and it shows that they did so from the beginning. Peter placed the epistles of Paul beside "the other scriptures" (2 Pet. 3:15–16). Paul wrote, "For the scripture saith, Thou shalt not muzzle the ox that treadeth out the corn. And, The labourer is worthy of his reward" (1 Tim. 5:18). The first saying is from Deuteronomy 25:4. The second is the saying of the Lord Jesus found in Luke 10:7, "for the labourer is worthy of his hire," where the same Greek words appear. Within the

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[141] Westminster Assembly, *The Westminster Confession of Faith* (1647), 1.3; *The Second London Baptist Confession of Faith* (1689), 1.3.

lifetime of the apostles, the words of the Gospel stood beside the words of Moses as "the scripture."

No council created the New Testament. The churches received the writings of the apostles and those who wrote with them, read them in their assemblies, and copied them. By the time Athanasius wrote his list in 367, the twenty-seven books were known and named. Later councils recognized what the churches had already received.

Here too the Alexandrian manuscripts blurred the line. Codex Sinaiticus includes the Epistle of Barnabas and the Shepherd of Hermas along with the New Testament. The Shepherd is the same book Athanasius placed among those to be read and Jerome placed outside the canon. The "oldest and best" manuscript of the modern critics could not keep the canon of the New Testament clean.

The Two Lines and the Canon

The two lines traced throughout this book appear again in the question of the canon. One line runs from the oracles committed to the Jews, through the Scriptures the Lord Jesus named, through the writings the churches received from the apostles, through Melito, Athanasius, and Jerome, through the Reformation confessions, and into the King James Bible, which kept the Apocrypha apart from the Word of God. The other line runs through the Alexandrian codices that mingled the Apocrypha with Scripture, through the councils that followed the reading of the day rather than the oracles of God, through Trent's anathema, and into the interconfessional Bibles of today, which again make room for the books Rome added.

God did not leave His people to guess which words He gave, and He did not leave them to guess which books He gave. The

warning at the close of the Bible covers both: "If any man shall add unto these things, God shall add unto him the plagues that are written in this book: And if any man shall take away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God shall take away his part out of the book of life" (Rev. 22:18–19). Solomon gave the same warning long before: "Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him. Add thou not unto his words, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar" (Prov. 30:5–6).

The canon, like the text, is settled by the Word itself. "To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them" (Isa. 8:20).

PART III: THE NEW TESTAMENT

THE TEXT THE CHURCH ACTUALLY USED

When critics discuss New Testament manuscripts, they often focus on the so-called "oldest and best" Alexandrian codices: Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus. The main question is not only which surviving manuscript is oldest, but what text the churches actually received, read, preached, and copied.

Scripture itself provides the standard for how this works:

- **Acts 2:42 —** "*And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine…*"
- **2 Timothy 2:2 —** Paul charged Timothy to entrust the words he had heard to "*faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also.*"
- **Colossians 4:16 —** Letters were circulated among the churches and read publicly.

From the beginning, the New Testament was a living text in the churches. Believers read it aloud, copied it, memorized it, preached it, and passed it on.

Scripture connects preservation with reception and proclamation. The Thessalonians received the apostolic message "*not as the word of men, but as it is in truth, the word of God*" (**1 Thess. 2:13**). Paul ordered his letters to be read in the churches (**Col. 4:16**; **1 Thess. 5:27**), and Jude spoke of "*the faith which was once delivered unto the saints*" (**Jude 3**). God's Word was placed in the life of the church.

The pattern is simple: the words were heard, received, read publicly, taught to faithful men, carried to other churches, and

passed to the next generation. This is the text the church actually used.

This helps explain why the Traditional or Majority Text is not always represented by the oldest surviving copies, though early evidence for its readings does exist. These manuscripts were used, recopied, and often worn out. The surviving Alexandrian codices were preserved under very different circumstances. The traditional line came to be called the Textus Receptus, the "Received Text," because it was the text received and used in the churches.

As noted earlier, Burgon pointed to the lectionaries as evidence that this text was read publicly in the churches of the East. He also showed how the Textus Receptus was widely employed throughout Europe for the first three centuries after the invention of printing and was more than 1,500 years old.[142]

That is the testimony of the church's public use of the text.

The Byzantine manuscripts themselves show how faithfully this text was copied. After years of collating them, Kirsopp Lake, who was no defender of the Received Text, reported:

> "The scribes who were responsible for the variations in the Byzantine text introduced remarkably few and unimportant changes, they shunned all originality."[143]

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[142] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 11.

[143] Kirsopp Lake and Silva Lake, "The Byzantine Text of the Gospels," in *Mémorial Lagrange* (Paris: J. Gabalda, 1940), 256.

The copyists who produced the great majority of our manuscripts were not editors reshaping the text but servants handing it on.

Just as the priests and Levites were entrusted with the Old Testament law, the New Testament Scriptures were placed in the care of the church. The "*royal priesthood*" (**1 Pet. 2:9**; **Rev. 1:6**) read, taught, copied, and passed them down. In the argument of this book, that received text is the Traditional or Byzantine line that later stood behind the Textus Receptus and the King James Bible.

The church did not make Scripture inspired by receiving it. Rather, its reception is part of the historical evidence of preservation. A text read in worship, quoted in preaching, translated for missions, and copied through generations has a different history from a manuscript that disappeared from church use for centuries.

The chain can be followed through the churches: the apostolic writings were circulated; early translations carried their readings into other languages; lectionaries preserved what was read publicly; Christian writers quoted the text; Byzantine manuscripts multiplied it throughout the Greek-speaking world; and the printing press brought that traditional text into the Reformation as the Textus Receptus.

Who Did God Leave the Keeping of the Bible To? Edward Hills on Naturalism and Faith

Edward Hills was trained in New Testament textual criticism at Yale, Westminster, and Harvard. Yet he believed that the prevailing naturalistic method failed to account for inspiration and providential preservation. In The King James Version

Defended, he contrasted that method with what he called the consistently Christian, or faith-based, approach to the text.

The Naturalistic Method

Hills defined the naturalistic method as one that treats the New Testament like any other ancient human book. He wrote:

> "This naturalistic textual criticism requires us to study the New Testament text in the same way in which we study the texts of secular books which have *not* been preserved by God's special providence."[144]

This method treats the New Testament text as though it were preserved no differently from any other ancient book. Hills believed that this starting point leaves the question of the text entirely to human reconstruction and gives no place to God's special providence.

He saw the same assumption in the principles of Westcott and Hort, whose Greek text became the foundation for later critical editions. They wrote:

> "For ourselves, we dare not introduce considerations which could not reasonably be applied to other ancient texts, supposing them to have documentary attestation of equal amount, variety, and antiquity."[145]

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[144] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 9, under "Why Believing Bible Students Must Use the King James Version—A Recapitulation."

[145] Brooke Foss Westcott and Fenton John Anthony Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek*, vol. 2, *Introduction and Appendix* (London: Macmillan, 1881), 277.

That statement shows their starting point: the New Testament was to be handled by the same rules as any other ancient writing, without allowing inspiration or providential preservation to shape the method.

Daniel Wallace expressed the same principle when he wrote:

> "I would question whether it is an epistemologically sound principle to allow one's presuppositions to dictate his text-critical methodology. This is neither honest to a historical investigation nor helpful to our evangelical heritage."[146]

He also stated,

> "A theological a priori has no place in textual criticism."[147]

According to this approach, theological convictions about preservation should not determine how the text is established. The decision is left to the methods and judgments of textual scholars.

Hills believed the result was continued revision and uncertainty. If the text must always be reconstructed by specialists, ordinary believers are left without a settled Bible they can confidently receive as the preserved Word of God.

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[146] Daniel B. Wallace, "Challenges in New Testament Textual Criticism for the Twenty-First Century," *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society* 52, no. 1 (March 2009): 93.

[147] Wallace, "Challenges," 86.

The Faith-Based (Consistently Christian) Method

In contrast, Hills argued that Christians must approach the biblical text through faith in the God who both inspired and preserved it.

> "The consistently Christian method, interprets the materials of New Testament textual criticism in accordance with the doctrines of the divine inspiration and providential preservation of the Scriptures. The naturalistic method interprets these same materials in accordance with its own doctrine that the New Testament is nothing more than a human book."[148]

The difference, Hills explained, is the starting point. The naturalistic method begins with the surviving evidence alone; the Christian method begins with the God who inspired Scripture and promised to preserve it, then interprets the evidence within that faith.

The Priesthood of Believers and the Preservation of Scripture

Hills connected this faith-based approach with the priesthood of believers. In his view, God did not leave the keeping of His Word only to an academic class, but to the believing church. He wrote:

> "When Christ died upon the cross, the Old Testament priesthood was abolished. In the New Testament dispensation every believer is a priest under Christ the great High Priest. Hence the New Testament text has

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[148] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, introduction, under "Two Methods of New Testament Textual Criticism."

> been preserved by the universal priesthood of believers, by faithful Christians in every walk of life."[149]

Hills believed this explains why the Traditional or Byzantine Text stands as the providentially preserved text. It was received, copied, read, and guarded throughout the life of the church. His point was not that scholarship has no value, but that scholarship must remain under the authority of Scripture and the faith of God's people.

Simply put, the New Testament was not left only to specialists with access to languages and manuscripts. It was entrusted to faithful believers and churches who read it, taught it, copied it, and passed it on.

From the Church's Received Text to the King James Bible

The same pattern continued from manuscript to print. The Byzantine text spread throughout the Greek-speaking churches; its readings appear in lectionaries, ancient versions, and early Christian quotations; and that broad traditional stream became the printed Textus Receptus during the Reformation. The name "Received Text" describes its historical place as the text received and used by the churches.

When the King James translators brought the Masoretic Hebrew Old Testament and the Received Greek New Testament into the English Bible tradition, that process reached its final received form for the English-speaking world. The King James Bible was read in homes, believed in churches, preached from pulpits, memorized, printed by the millions, carried through revivals,

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[149] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "The Principles of Consistently Christian New Testament Textual Criticism."

and used throughout the great English-speaking missionary movement.[150]

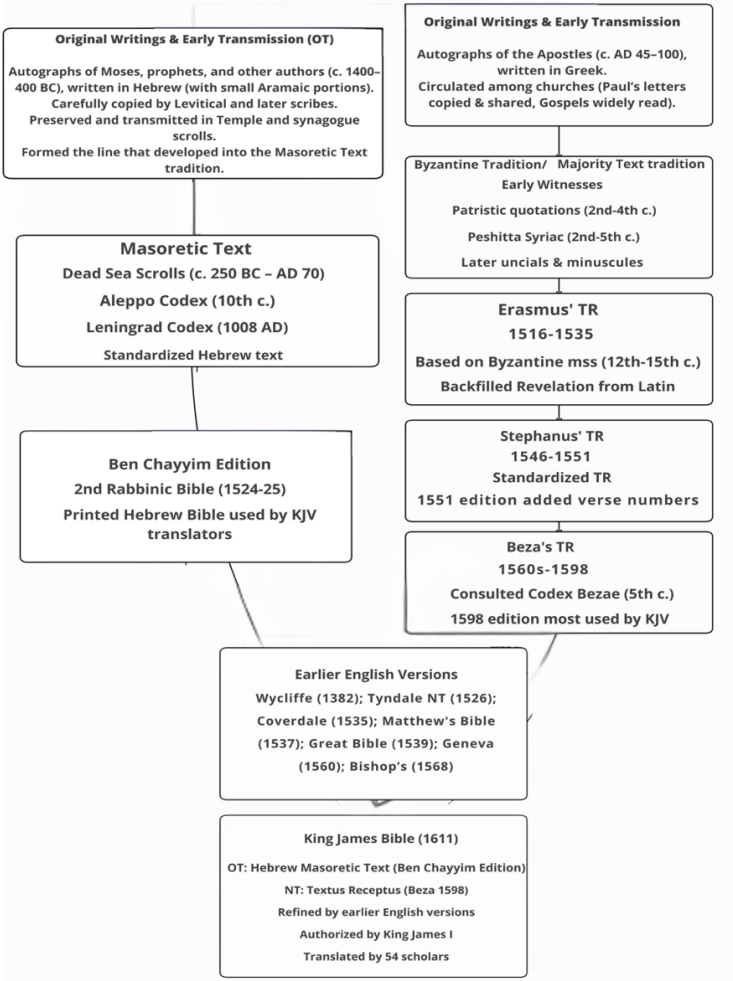
This fruit follows the biblical pattern. God's words are passed through faithful men who teach others also (**2 Tim. 2:2**); the church is *"the pillar and ground of the truth"* (**1 Tim. 3:15**); and faith comes by hearing the Word of God (**Rom. 10:17**). At the height of the English language and the missionary movement, the Bible received by English-speaking churches was the King James Bible.

Erasmus, Stephanus, and Beza were important parts of the process, but none of their individual editions became the final English authority. Within the position presented in this book, the final received text in English is the King James Bible, read, believed, preached, copied, carried, and confirmed in the life and mission of the church.

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[150] For the KJV's reception and public influence, see Gordon Campbell, *Bible: The Story of the King James Version, 1611–2011* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 4, 170; and David Crystal, *Begat: The King James Bible and the English Language* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 257–60.

Transmission of Texts to the King James Bible (1611)



Old Testament: Masoretic Codices → Ben Chayyim (1524-25)
New Testament: Early Witnesses (Patristic, Syriac) → Byzantine Manuscripts → TR (Erasmus, Stephanus, Beza)
English Tradition: Tyndale → Geneva → Bishops' → merged into the Authorized Version (1611).

EVIDENCE: MANUSCRIPTS, VERSIONS, AND FATHERS

1. Manuscript Evidence

This chapter uses three kinds of witnesses:

- A Greek manuscript is a handwritten copy of all or part of the New Testament in Greek. Its date tells when that copy was made.

- An ancient version is a translation into another language, such as Latin, Syriac, or Gothic. A translation can be much older than its oldest surviving copy. The Gothic version was translated in the fourth century, but its most famous copy, the Codex Argenteus, was written in the early sixth century.

- A quotation is a verse cited by an early Christian writer. It shows that a reading was known in his time and place.

Together, these three kinds of witnesses show what the churches read.

The numbers speak loudly:

- There are **5,700 catalogued Greek NT manuscripts** at the Institute for New Testament Textual Research.[151]

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[151] Institute for New Testament Textual Research (INTF), "The Greek Manuscripts of the New Testament," New Testament Virtual Manuscript Room (NTVMR), University of Münster, accessed June 30, 2026, https://ntvmr.uni-muenster.de/.

- The readings in these manuscripts reflect the Byzantine text-type used for the Textus Receptus and the KJV, **anywhere from 80 to 95 percent** of the time.[152] [153] [154]

- Fewer than **50 manuscripts** reflect the Alexandrian text type exclusively, and among those, only **three (B, ℵ, A)** truly form the backbone of the modern critical text.[155]

The sheer weight of numbers indicates what the church used, copied, and passed down.

Zane Hodges (former **professor of New Testament at Dallas Theological Seminary**) wrote this about the Majority Text:

> "The manuscript tradition of an ancient book will, under any but the most exceptional conditions, multiply in a reasonably regular fashion with the result that the copies nearest the autograph will normally have the largest number of descendants… Thus the Majority text, upon which the King James Version is based, has in reality the strongest claim possible to be

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[152] Wilbur N. Pickering, *The Identity of the New Testament Text IV* (Brasília: Wilbur N. Pickering, 2014), 114–15.

[153] D. A. Waite, *Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority – Texts, Translators, Technique, Theology*, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 41, 56, e-book.

[154] Zane C. Hodges and Arthur L. Farstad, eds., *The Greek New Testament According to the Majority Text*, 2nd ed. (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 1985), v–vi.

[155] Waite speaks of "B" and "Aleph" together with "their some forty-three allies." Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 58.

> regarded as an authentic representation of the original text."[156]

What they are saying is that the manuscripts that are most numerous will, by their very nature, resemble the original writings the most. This is the Majority Text, the base for the New Testament of the King James Bible.

This same idea was acknowledged by Fenton John Anthony Hort, one of the two originators of the first "modern version" of the Bible, using the Alexandrian manuscripts:

> "A theoretical presumption indeed remains that a majority of extant documents is more likely to represent a majority of ancestral documents at each stage of transmission than vice versa."[157]

2. Early Readings

The common claim of scholars is that the modern versions are based on "older and better manuscripts." While, as we have shown, this argument of antiquity does not ultimately matter, we also see that it is not in fact true. The early readings of the Byzantine Text abound.

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[156] Zane C. Hodges, "The Greek Text of the King James Version," in *Which Bible?*, ed. David Otis Fuller, 5th ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Grand Rapids International Publications, 1975), 36.

[157] Brooke Foss Westcott and Fenton John Anthony Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek*, vol. 2, *Introduction and Appendix* (London: Macmillan, 1881), 45.

- **Peshitta Syriac (A.D. 100–150) —** aligns with the Byzantine tradition.[158]

- **Sinaitic Syriac** (**sys**) (**A.D. 300–400**).[159] [160]

- **Codex Argenteus (Gothic Version) (A.D. 350).**[161]

- **P66 (A.D. 100–200) —** aligns with the TR in more places than any Alexandrian MSS in mutually extant passages.[162] [163] [164] [165]

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[158] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 7, "The Traditional New Testament Text," under "The Evidence of the Peshitta Syriac Version," e-book.

[159] F. Crawford Burkitt, *Evangelion da-Mepharreshe: The Curetonian Version of the Four Gospels, with the Readings of the Sinai Palimpsest and the Early Syriac Patristic Evidence*, vol. 2 (Cambridge: University Press, 1904), 225.

[160] Harry A. Sturz, *The Byzantine Text-Type and New Testament Textual Criticism* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 1984), 55–56.

[161] Frederic G. Kenyon, *Handbook to the Textual Criticism of the New Testament*, 2nd ed. (London: Macmillan, 1912), 240.

[162] Bruce M. Metzger, "Lucian and the Lucianic Recension of the Greek Bible," *New Testament Studies* 8 (1962): 202–3.

[163] Bruce M. Metzger, *Chapters in the History of New Testament Textual Criticism* (Leiden: Brill, 1963), 38.

[164] J. Neville Birdsall, *The Bodmer Papyrus of the Gospel of John* (London: The Tyndale Press, 1960), 17.

[165] A. F. J. Klijn, *A Survey of the Researches into the Western Text of the Gospels and Acts*, pt. 2, *1949–1969* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1969), 45–48, cited in Pickering, *Identity of the New Testament Text IV*, 43–44.

- **P45 (A.D. 200)** — aligns with the TR in more places than any Alexandrian MSS in mutually extant passages.[166] [167] [168] [169]

- **P46 (A.D. 175–225**).[170] [171]

- **Old Latin (Itala, second century)** — reflects the Received Text.[172]

- **A (02) — Codex Alexandrinus: fifth century (c. A.D. 400–450)—predominantly Byzantine in the Gospels.**[173]

- **W (032) — Codex Washingtonianus (Freer Gospels): fourth century (c. A.D. 300–400).**[174]

- **Q (026) — Codex Guelferbytanus B: fifth century (c. A.D. 400–450).**[175]

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[166] Klijn, *Survey of the Researches*, 45–48, cited in Pickering, *Identity of the New Testament Text IV*, 43–44.

[167] G. Zuntz, *The Text of the Epistles: A Disquisition upon the Corpus Paulinum* (London: Oxford University Press, 1953), 55.

[168] Metzger, "Lucian and the Lucianic Recension," 202–3.

[169] "The Chester Beatty Papyri," *Journal of Theological Studies* 34 (October 1933): 363–68.

[170] Metzger, *Chapters in the History*, 38–39.

[171] Zuntz, *Text of the Epistles*, 55–56.

[172] Frederic G. Kenyon, *The Text of the Greek Bible* (London: Duckworth, 1937), 216–18.

[173] Kurt Aland and Barbara Aland, *The Text of the New Testament: An Introduction to the Critical Editions and to the Theory and Practice of Modern Textual Criticism*, 2nd ed., trans. Erroll F. Rhodes (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans; Leiden: Brill, 1989), 107, 109.

[174] Aland and Aland, *Text of the New Testament*, 113.

[175] Aland and Aland, *Text of the New Testament*, 113.

- **D (05) — Codex Bezae Cantabrigiensis: fifth century** (**c. A.D. 400–450**).[176] [177]

- ***Over 150 distinctly Byzantine readings*** *in the "oldest and best" Egyptian papyri.*[178]

- A study by Dr. Jack Moorman in his work Early Manuscripts, Church Fathers, and the Authorized Version shows the agreement of the "Great/Old Uncials" (א, A, C, D(05), and D(06)) with the TR vs. Vaticanus in passages where they differ. The results showed that the "oldest and best" agree with the Textus Receptus 7,909 times, whereas they agree with Vaticanus only 5,924 times.[179]

    - What does this mean? The Textus Receptus has a large amount of support in the so-called "oldest and best" manuscripts as compared to the base manuscript for all modern Bibles (Vaticanus).

These Byzantine readings circulated in living Christian communities, showing what believers on the ground actually read and preached. This also shows that the "older and better" claims are simply untrue.

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[176] Aland and Aland, *Text of the New Testament*, 109–10.

[177] Jack A. Moorman, *Early Manuscripts, Church Fathers, and the Authorized Version: With Manuscript Digests and Summaries* (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2005), 45–51.

[178] Sturz, *Byzantine Text-Type*, 61, 145–59.

[179] Moorman, *Early Manuscripts, Church Fathers, and the Authorized Version*, 45–51.

3. Patristic Quotations

The church fathers quote the Byzantine/TR line extensively. ("Fathers" is not a term I like to use here, in view of Matthew 23:9, but I use it for clarity, since that is how they are referred to in history.)

- Among the Greek and Latin fathers who died before **A.D. 400**, Edward Miller counted **2,630 quotations** supporting the Received Text against 1,753 supporting the Westcott–Hort text.[180]

- Irenaeus (A.D. 130–200), disciple of Polycarp, quoted verses like **Mark 16:9–20** as Scripture, verses cut out of modern critical editions.[181]

- Tertullian (c. A.D. 200) built his teaching on John 5:3b–4, the account of the angel who troubled the water at Bethesda, a passage modern versions move to the footnotes: "Having been washed in the water by the angel, we are prepared for the Holy Spirit." Tatian (c. A.D. 175) had already included the passage in his *Diatessaron*.[182]

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[180] Frederic G. Kenyon, *Handbook to the Textual Criticism of the New Testament*, 2nd ed. (London: Macmillan, 1912), 321–22.

[181] Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 3.10.5, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 1:426.

[182] Tertullian, *On Baptism* 6, as translated in Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 6, "Dean Burgon and the Traditional New Testament Text," under "The Angel at the Pool (John 5:3b–4)," e-book; compare *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, 3:672.

- Cyprian (A.D. 200–258) referenced the Trinity of **1 John 5:7** (*"and these three are one"*), centuries before Vaticanus and Sinaiticus would omit it.[183]

The figure of 2,630 comes from Edward Miller's tabulation of the patristic quotations collected by Dean Burgon, whose index contained 86,489 quotations. Sir Frederic Kenyon, who opposed Burgon's conclusions, summarized Miller's results:

> "Taking the Greek and Latin (not the Syriac) Fathers who died before A.D. 400, their quotations are found to support the Traditional Text in 2630 instances, the 'neologian' in 1753. Nor is this majority due solely to the writers who belong to the end of this period. On the contrary, if only the earliest writers be taken, from Clement of Rome to Irenaeus and Hippolytus, the majority in favour of the Traditional Text is proportionately even greater, 151 to 84."[184]

Kenyon also reported Miller's finding that when thirty important passages were examined in detail, the early evidence favored the Traditional Text by "no less than 530 to 170, a quite overwhelming majority." Miller concluded that the evidence showed "not only that the Traditional Text was in existence, but that it was predominant, during the period under review."[185] Thus, the claim that these readings are "late additions" is

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[183] Cyprian, *On the Unity of the Church* 6, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 5:423.

[184] Kenyon, *Handbook*, 322.

[185] Edward Miller, in Burgon, *Traditional Text*, 116; Kenyon, *Handbook*, 322.

demolished by the very voices of the earliest post-apostolic generations.

THE ALEXANDRIAN CLUSTER (B, א, A) IN CONTEXT

Modern textual critics place great weight on three manuscripts: Codex Vaticanus (B, c. A.D. 325–350), Codex Sinaiticus (א, c. A.D. 330–360), and Codex Alexandrinus (A, c. A.D. 400–450). They are often called the "oldest and best." Yet each is connected with Egypt and the Alexandrian textual corruption discussed earlier.

Vaticanus (B)

Codex Vaticanus, designated B, is one of the two manuscripts most heavily relied upon in the modern critical text, along with Sinaiticus. Its readings have had a major influence on the Greek text behind the NIV, ESV, NASB, CSB, and other modern translations.

Vaticanus is generally dated to the **fourth century** (**around A.D. 325–350**).[186] Some scholars believe it may have been one of the fifty copies of Scripture that the **Roman emperor Constantine** ordered to be made for the churches of Constantinople, as recorded by the historian **Eusebius**.[187] A. T. Robertson was convinced this was the origin of Vaticanus:[188]

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[186] Kurt Aland and Barbara Aland, *The Text of the New Testament: An Introduction to the Critical Editions and to the Theory and Practice of Modern Textual Criticism*, 2nd ed., trans. Erroll F. Rhodes (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans; Leiden: Brill, 1989), 109.

[187] Eusebius, *Life of Constantine* 4.36–37, trans. Ernest Cushing Richardson, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 1, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1890), 549.

[188] A. T. Robertson, *An Introduction to the Textual Criticism of the New Testament* (Nashville: Sunday School Board of the Southern Baptist Convention, 1925), 80.

> "Constantine himself ordered fifty Greek Bibles from Eusebius, Bishop of Caesarea, for the churches in Constantinople. It is quite possible that א and B are two of these fifty, though the actual copying was probably done in Egypt or by Egyptian scribes."

Its very origin story highlights the difference between a Bible handed down through the Spirit-led people of God and one produced under the influence of a pagan Roman emperor.

The manuscript itself bears the marks of corruption and incompleteness. It is **missing large portions** of the New Testament: everything from **Hebrews 9:14** onward, the Pastoral Epistles (1–2 Timothy, Titus), Philemon, and the book of Revelation. In addition to these omissions, Vaticanus includes **apocryphal** material alongside canonical Scripture, mixing the inspired Word of God with uninspired writings.

After its production, Vaticanus eventually came to rest in **Rome**, where it was placed in the **Vatican** Library. Remarkably, it sat there for centuries unused, until appearing in a catalog in 1481. Unlike the manuscripts copied and worn thin through centuries of church use, Vaticanus survived precisely because it was not trusted or used in the life of the churches. It was a shelf relic, not a living text among the people of God.

And yet, despite this history of neglect, modern scholarship now exalts Vaticanus as one of the "oldest and best" witnesses to the New Testament text. In reality, its survival tells a different story: it was preserved by disuse, not by providential transmission through the believing church. To rest the authority of modern Bibles on such a manuscript, rather than on the Received Text preserved and used in the churches for fifteen

centuries, is to lean on a witness rejected by the very body of Christ.

Sinaiticus (א)

Codex Sinaiticus, designated א (Aleph), is the other principal manuscript behind the modern critical text. J. F. Fenlon wrote about the origin of Sinaiticus in Alexandria, Egypt, connecting it back to Origen as well:

> "It seems to have been at one time at Caesarea; one of the correctors (probably of seventh century) adds this note at the end of Esdras: 'This codex was compared with a very ancient exemplar which had been corrected by the hand of the holy martyr Pamphilus [d. 309]; which exemplar contained at the end the subscription in his own hand: "Taken and corrected according to the Hexapla of Origen: Antonius compared it: I, Pamphilus, corrected it."' … The text of Codex Sinaiticus bears a very close resemblance to that of Codex Vaticanus…"[189]

Together, these two manuscripts form the backbone of the Nestle–Aland and UBS critical editions of the Greek New Testament, which in turn underlie nearly every modern Bible translation (NIV, ESV, NASB, CSB, etc.). In practice, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus are given priority over the thousands of manuscripts that agree with the Traditional Text, making them the "pillars" of the modern text-critical approach.

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[189] J. F. Fenlon, "Codex Sinaiticus," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 4 (New York: Robert Appleton, 1908), 85–86.

Sinaiticus is generally dated to the mid-**fourth century (c. A.D. 330–360**),[190] with many scholars suggesting it, too, may have been among the fifty Bibles ordered by Constantine and produced in Alexandria. It is written in Greek uncials on vellum and originally contained the entire Old and New Testaments, though much of the Old Testament has been lost. Unlike the manuscripts faithfully copied and worn out through centuries of church use, Sinaiticus survived because it was preserved in obscurity.

The discovery story itself underscores its questionable history. In the mid-nineteenth century, Constantin von Tischendorf famously found parts of the manuscript at St. Catherine's Monastery at Mount Sinai, some of which, according to his own report, were sitting in a wastebasket, destined to be burned. Other portions he retrieved later under circumstances still disputed. This means one of the primary witnesses for modern Bibles literally comes from a trash pile, rejected even by monks who were otherwise careful to preserve manuscripts.

The text of Sinaiticus reveals why it was discarded. It contains **thousands of corrections** made by different scribes over centuries, with some estimating more than **14,000 individual alterations**. In some places, Sinaiticus **contradicts itself within just a few verses**, and in others, it departs radically from the Traditional Text and from parallel passages. For example, in the Gospels it frequently shortens or alters verses, and in the New Testament as a whole it shows a tendency toward omissions, particularly in Christological passages.

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[190] Aland and Aland, *Text of the New Testament*, 107.

In addition to the canonical Scriptures, Sinaiticus includes books not recognized as inspired: the *Epistle of Barnabas* and the *Shepherd of Hermas*. Their presence once again blurs the line between God's Word and uninspired writings.

And yet, despite its origin in neglect, its internal contradictions, and its long centuries of obscurity, Codex Sinaiticus is treated by modern scholarship as one of the "oldest and best" witnesses. In reality, its checkered history and heavily corrected text argue the opposite: it survived not by providence through the churches, but by disuse, rejection, and accident.

Alexandrinus (A)

Codex Alexandrinus, designated **A**, is usually dated to the early **fifth century (c. A.D. 400–440**).[191] Unlike Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, it surfaced earlier in the West and was presented to King James I's successor, Charles I of England, in 1627. Today it resides in the British Library. While often cited by modern textual critics, Alexandrinus has always been considered less consistent and less "pure" than Vaticanus or Sinaiticus.

The manuscript was likely produced in Alexandria, Egypt, and, true to its origin, it shows a **mixture of text types** rather than a unified, reliable witness. In the Gospels, Alexandrinus leans toward the Byzantine text-type (closer to the Traditional Text), but in Acts and the Epistles it frequently follows Alexandrian readings, and in Revelation it exhibits a unique text all its own. This inconsistency makes it an unstable witness, sometimes supporting the Received Text, sometimes departing from it in favor of Alexandrian corruption.

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[191] Aland and Aland, *Text of the New Testament*, 107, 109.

Like the other "great uncials," Alexandrinus also contains the **Apocrypha** intermixed with canonical books, once again blurring the lines between inspired and uninspired writings. Its inclusion of noncanonical works is another reminder that these manuscripts were not safeguarded by the churches of God, but arose from the Alexandrian stream where human philosophy and textual alteration flourished.

While Vaticanus and Sinaiticus are the primary authorities leaned upon by modern editors, Alexandrinus is treated as a secondary witness, valuable when it agrees with their preferred readings, but inconsistent and less trusted overall. Yet despite its mixed character, modern translations will still occasionally follow Alexandrinus where it supports a critical variant against the Traditional Text.

In the end, Alexandrinus stands as another example of a manuscript preserved not by faithful usage in the churches, but by storage in obscure collections, reflecting the instability of the Alexandrian textual tradition.

Critics hail these codices as "old" and therefore superior. But age without use is no virtue. These manuscripts were preserved in good condition precisely because the churches rejected them. They were locked away or abandoned, not worn out in service.

Burgon again remarked:

> "It is in fact easier to find two consecutive verses in which B and ℵ differ, than two consecutive verses in which they agree."[192]

Herman Hoskier devoted some 450 pages to the errors of Codex B and another 400 to those of Codex Aleph. He found that in the Gospels alone the two manuscripts differ well over 3,000 times, not counting minor matters such as spelling.[193] If Vaticanus is right in those places, Sinaiticus is wrong; if Sinaiticus is right, Vaticanus is wrong.

These manuscripts also add words. In Luke 15:21, Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Bezae put into the mouth of the prodigal son the words, "make me as one of thy hired servants." Following Hoskier, Hills called this a "tasteless Alexandrian addition" that "spoils the narrative," and he explained why:

> "In the true text the prodigal never pronounces the words which he had formulated in vs. 19. As soon as he beholds his father's loving face, they die on his lips."[194]

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[192] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 12.

[193] H. C. Hoskier, *Codex B and Its Allies: A Study and an Indictment*, 2 vols. (London: Bernard Quaritch, 1914), 2:1; Jack Moorman, *Forever Settled: A Survey of the Documents and History of the Bible* (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 1985), 55, e-book.

[194] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 5, "The Facts of New Testament Textual Criticism," under "Early Alterations in the Alexandrian Text," e-book; see also H. C. Hoskier, *Codex B and Its Allies*, 1:278.

The "oldest and best" manuscripts are not only shorter where they omit. They are sometimes longer where they add.

The problem is not only that these manuscripts disagree with the text preserved and used by the churches; they also disagree with one another. **Codex Sinaiticus (ℵ)** has layer upon layer of corrections made by different scribes over the centuries. In some places, whole sections were rewritten multiple times, showing confusion rather than stability. **Codex Vaticanus (B)** is marked by unusual omissions and even cancellations, and its copyists left notes in the margins warning readers about questionable spots, hardly the sign of a manuscript people fully trusted. And when Vaticanus and Sinaiticus do "agree," they just as often contradict one another a few lines later. Together they do not form a strong, consistent witness, but a shaky and shifting one. Their very inconsistency helps explain why these books were left unused long enough to survive. That is not the mark of the "oldest and best"; it is the mark of instability.

Chapter Summary Visual

The contrast may be summarized in two streams:

The Majority/Byzantine Line (Antioch → TR → Reformation Bibles → KJV)

> More than 5,000 Greek manuscripts, with the Byzantine text forming the large majority.
>
> Supported by early versions such as Old Latin and Syriac.
>
> Quoted extensively by early Christian writers such as Polycarp, Irenaeus, and Cyprian.

Carried into the Reformation Bibles and the King James Bible.

The Minority/Alexandrian Line (Alexandria → Vaticanus/Sinaiticus → Critical Text → Modern Versions)

A small group of manuscripts centered especially on Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus.

Often disagreeing with the Traditional Text ***and with one another***.

Preserved chiefly in libraries and institutions rather than through broad church use.

Forms the main basis of the modern critical text and modern Bible versions.

Conclusion of the New Testament Section

The central question is not merely, "Which surviving manuscript is oldest?" but, "Which text did the church actually receive and use?" The manuscript numbers, early versions, patristic quotations, and history of church use all point to the Traditional or Received Text rather than the Alexandrian cluster.

The New Testament text of the King James Bible is not an accident of history. It stands in the line received, copied, preached, and carried through the life of the church.

"Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away" (**Matt. 24:35**).

His words have not passed away.

THE SHIFTING CRITICAL TEXT: FROM "ORIGINAL TEXT" TO "INITIAL TEXT"

Earlier chapters showed that the modern critical text is, in substance, still the text of Westcott and Hort. Gregory Lanier's sampling found about 98.5 percent agreement between the current editions and the Greek text of 1881.[195] That is one side of the picture: the foundation has not moved. This chapter looks at the other side. While the foundation has stayed where Westcott and Hort laid it, the editors have changed what they say they are building, and the building itself is never finished.

The difference between the two lines of Bibles can be put in two words. The Received Text is received. The critical text is reconstructed. A received text can be settled, because it is a text God's people already have. A reconstruction is never settled, because it is only as final as the latest edition, and there is always another edition coming.

The Promise of 1881: "The Original Greek"

Westcott and Hort did not lack confidence. They titled their work *The New Testament in the Original Greek*, and Hort opened his introduction with this sentence:

[195] Gregory R. Lanier, "The Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT: Stability, Change, and Implications," *Tyndale Bulletin* 71, no. 1 (2020): 50, https://doi.org/10.53751/001c.27734.

> "This edition is an attempt to present exactly the original words of the New Testament, so far as they can now be determined from surviving documents."[196]

He went on to say that the words "in our opinion still subject to doubt only make up about one sixtieth of the whole New Testament," and that what could "in any sense be called substantial variation" could "hardly form more than a thousandth part of the entire text."[197] The goal was the original text, and the editors believed they had very nearly reached it.

That was the promise that persuaded the revisers of 1881 and, after them, the scholars and seminaries of the English-speaking world. The King James Bible was set aside in favor of a text that claimed to be closer to what the apostles wrote. It is fair to ask whether the editors of that text still make the same claim.

A Text That Keeps Changing

The Greek New Testament used by most modern translators is published in two forms that share the same text: the Nestle–Aland *Novum Testamentum Graece* and the United Bible Societies' *Greek New Testament*. Their text is prepared in connection with the Institute for New Testament Textual Research in Münster, Germany, whose large *Editio Critica Maior* now governs it book by book. That text has been revised again and again.

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[196] Brooke Foss Westcott and Fenton John Anthony Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek*, vol. 2, *Introduction and Appendix* (London: Macmillan, 1881), 1.

[197] Westcott and Hort, *New Testament in the Original Greek*, 2:2.

In the introduction to the twenty-sixth edition of the Nestle–Aland text, the editors wrote that "more than five hundred changes have been introduced."[198] The twenty-seventh edition (1993) kept the same text. The twenty-eighth edition (2012) changed the text of the Catholic Letters, James through Jude, in thirty-four places, according to the report Klaus Wachtel of the Münster institute gave when the edition was presented.[199] The *Editio Critica Maior*, the large Münster edition on which the hand editions now depend, then introduced fifty-two changes in the book of Acts.[200]

The latest step came in 2025. The sixth edition of the United Bible Societies' text adopts the Münster editions of Mark, Acts, the Catholic Letters, and Revelation. Its publisher states that it "differs from the fifth edition in well over 100 places," and that its text "is identical to that of the forthcoming 29th edition of the Novum Testamentum Graece (Nestle-Aland), scheduled for release in 2026."[201] The Gospels of Matthew, Luke, and John and the epistles of Paul have not yet passed through the new

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[198] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 49, quoting the introduction to the twenty-sixth edition of *Novum Testamentum Graece*, 42*.

[199] Daniel B. Wallace, "Nestle-Aland 28: The New Standard in Critical Texts of the Greek New Testament," *Daniel B. Wallace* (blog), December 17, 2012, https://danielbwallace.com/2012/12/17/259/. Lanier, counting from the editors' introduction to the Catholic Letters, gives the number as thirty-three ("Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 49).

[200] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 49.

[201] Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, "Greek New Testament (GNT / UBS), Publications," accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.die-bibel.de/en/greek-new-testament-gnt-ubs-publications.

method, so further changes are expected as each new volume appears.

None of these changes is enormous by itself, and this book will not pretend otherwise. But a Bible reader who owns an English version translated from the twenty-seventh edition already owns a translation of a Greek text that its own editors have since corrected. And he is told to expect more corrections.

From "Original Text" to "Initial Text"

More important than the number of changes is the change in the goal. The Münster editors no longer describe their work as a reconstruction of the original text. They describe it as a reconstruction of the "initial text," a translation of the German *Ausgangstext*.

What is the initial text? Tommy Wasserman and Peter Gurry, whose introduction to the new method is widely used, define it as "the hypothetical witness from which all the extant witnesses derive." Klaus Wachtel of the Münster institute explained that the term "must be carefully distinguished from the archetype of the tradition, on the one hand, and from the original text of the author, on the other," and he added: "The initial text is the hypothetical reconstruction of the text as it was before the archetype of the tradition emerged."[202]

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[202] Tommy Wasserman and Peter J. Gurry, *A New Approach to Textual Criticism: An Introduction to the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method* (Atlanta: SBL Press, 2017), glossary, s.v. "initial text"; Klaus Wachtel, "Conclusions," in *The Textual History of the Greek New Testament: Changing Views in Contemporary Research*, ed. Klaus Wachtel and Michael W. Holmes (Atlanta: Society of Biblical Literature, 2011), 219.

Notice the words. The initial text is "hypothetical." It is a "reconstruction." And it is to be distinguished from "the original text of the author." The editors hope, of course, that the two are very close. But they no longer claim to print the original.

When the twenty-eighth edition was presented to scholars in 2012, the change was summarized this way. The aim of the twenty-seventh edition had been a "more secure reconstruction of the original text." The aim of the twenty-eighth was "formulated as a hypothesis about the initial text (at many passages left open)." The presentation also stated that "the present reconstruction is a hypothesis about the text of the authors."[203] The scholars themselves have written whole essays on the shift, with titles such as "The Multivalence of the Term 'Original Text' in New Testament Textual Criticism" and "From 'Original Text' to 'Initial Text.'"[204]

The newest edition speaks the same way. The introduction to the 2025 edition says that single brackets mark words where the editors are in "particular doubt… as to whether the enclosed word, words, or parts of words are to be reconstructed as the

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[203] Tommy Wasserman, "Presentation of NA28 (SBL Chicago)," *Evangelical Textual Criticism* (blog), February 25, 2013, http://evangelicaltextualcriticism.blogspot.com/2013/02/presentation-of-na28-sbl-chicago.html, summarizing the presentation of Klaus Wachtel.

[204] Eldon Jay Epp, "The Multivalence of the Term 'Original Text' in New Testament Textual Criticism," *Harvard Theological Review* 92, no. 3 (1999): 245–81; Michael W. Holmes, "From 'Original Text' to 'Initial Text': The Traditional Goal of New Testament Textual Criticism in Contemporary Discussion," in *The Text of the New Testament in Contemporary Research: Essays on the Status Quaestionis*, 2nd ed., ed. Bart D. Ehrman and Michael W. Holmes (Leiden: Brill, 2013), 637–88.

earliest form of text," and it describes the whole project as "an edition whose aim is to come as close as possible to the origin of the text's history."[205] In 1881 the goal was "exactly the original words." In 2025 it is to come "as close as possible."

Where the Editors Cannot Decide

The new editions also mark places where the editors could not choose between two readings. In the *Editio Critica Maior* these are called "split guiding lines," and in the Nestle–Aland text they are marked with a diamond. Peter Gurry, who defends the new method, explains that the diamonds in the twenty-eighth edition "mark places where the editors couldn't decide on the initial text."[206] Lanier counts 155 split guiding lines in the Münster edition of Acts alone.[207]

What is printed in the main text at such places? At the presentation of the twenty-eighth edition someone asked that very question. The answer given was that it was done "for practical reasons": the reading printed was the reading of the previous edition, because "it would have been a worse alternative to print a new reading."[208] In other words, at places where the editors could not decide what the apostles wrote, the reader's Greek text keeps the old choice because a text must

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[205] *The Greek New Testament: A Reader's Edition*, rev. ed. (Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2025), introduction, vii–viii. The introduction states that its Greek text is identical to that of UBS6 and NA29.

[206] Peter Gurry, "List of Conjectures Accepted in Nestle Editions," *Evangelical Textual Criticism* (blog), January 29, 2018, http://evangelicaltextualcriticism.blogspot.com/2018/01/list-of-conjectures-accepted-in-nestle.html.

[207] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 49.

[208] Wasserman, "Presentation of NA28."

print something. The English reader who meets that verse in his modern version is never told.

Readings No Greek Manuscript Contains

The critical text has gone further still. At 2 Peter 3:10 the King James Bible reads, "the earth also and the works that are therein shall be burned up." The twenty-eighth edition of the Nestle–Aland text prints a reading that means the earth and its works "will not be found." Daniel Wallace, no friend of the King James position, wrote of that reading: "This is not found in any Greek witnesses."[209] The Münster editors adopted it anyway. Lanier lists it among the conjectural emendations adopted by the Münster editors, and Peter Gurry names two more, at Acts 16:12 and Acts 13:33.[210]

Even the modern translators do not always follow their own base text. The preface to the English Standard Version says that it is based on the twenty-eighth edition, but at 2 Peter 3:10 it reads "will be exposed," with a footnote: "Greek *found*; some manuscripts *will be burned up*."[211] So at this verse the ESV follows neither the Received Text nor the edition it names as its base; it keeps the reading of the earlier critical edition. That is what reconstruction looks like at the level of a single verse.

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[209] Wallace, "Nestle-Aland 28."

[210] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 61n63; Gurry, "List of Conjectures Accepted in Nestle Editions."

[211] *The Holy Bible, English Standard Version* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2016), 2 Pet. 3:10 and footnote.

Who Led Israel out of Egypt?

Jude 5 shows the same instability in another way. The Received Text and the King James Bible read, "how that the Lord, having saved the people out of the land of Egypt, afterward destroyed them that believed not." The twenty-seventh edition of the Nestle–Aland text also read "Lord." The twenty-eighth edition changed the word to "Jesus."[212] The ESV, which had already chosen "Jesus" from the apparatus when it first appeared in 2001, reads, "Jesus, who saved a people out of the land of Egypt," with a note that some manuscripts read "the Lord."[213]

This book does not claim that the reading "Jesus" denies any doctrine. It does not. The point here is different. Within one edition, the critical text changed the name of the One who brought Israel out of Egypt, and the modern versions do not agree with one another on it. The King James Bible has read the same way since 1611.

The Verses That Came Back in Brackets

The most surprising change in the newest edition concerns verses that Westcott and Hort removed from the text in 1881. For well over a century, the Nestle text, and later the United Bible Societies text, left out verses such as Acts 8:37, the eunuch's confession, and modern versions either dropped them

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[212] Wallace, "Nestle-Aland 28."

[213] *English Standard Version*, Jude 5 and footnote; Elijah Hixson, "A Myth/Mistake about the ESV," *Evangelical Textual Criticism* (blog), March 9, 2021, http://evangelicaltextualcriticism.blogspot.com/2021/03/a-mythmistake-about-esv.html.

to the margin or omitted them. The 2025 edition prints them again. Its introduction explains:

> "Double brackets in the text indicate that the enclosed passages are not considered by the editors to be a part of the earliest text, but an addition at an early stage of the tradition. Unlike in earlier editions of the Nestle-Aland and the UBS Greek New Testament, including the Reader's Edition, all verses assigned a number within the New Testament are now integrated into the text in double brackets."[214]

The same introduction announces that the order of the books has been changed. The Catholic Letters now follow Acts, and Hebrews now stands before the Pastoral Epistles, because the order "known from older editions of the Nestle-Aland, the UBS Greek New Testament and, in fact, from almost all modern Bible translations, goes back to Erasmus in the early 16th century."[215] The critical text now departs even from the order of books in the English Bibles translated from it.

At the presentation of the twenty-eighth edition, Wachtel also said something that ought to be heard by every reader of this book. He described the twenty-seventh edition as displaying a "prejudice against the Byzantine tradition," while the twenty-eighth recognized the "reliability of the mainstream tradition."[216] The mainstream tradition is the Traditional Text of the Greek churches, the text behind the King James Bible. For generations Christians were told that this text was late and

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[214] *Greek New Testament: A Reader's Edition*, introduction, viii.

[215] *Greek New Testament: A Reader's Edition*, introduction, vii.

[216] Wallace, "Nestle-Aland 28," reporting Wachtel's presentation; see also Wasserman, "Presentation of NA28."

inferior. Now the editors of the critical text speak of the prejudice of their own earlier edition.

The Foundation Has Not Moved

After all these changes, one thing has stayed the same. Lanier, after decades of new method, new collations, and new editions, observed that Westcott and Hort had presented a text drawn largely from the great uncials, "and even then, the text was often, for all practical purposes, that of Vaticanus. Decades later, the same is still true." He reported an estimate that the current Nestle–Aland and *Editio Critica Maior* text "fully agrees with Vaticanus at a rate of 96.3%."[217]

That is the whole situation in a sentence. The goal has moved from the "original text" to a hypothetical "initial text." The printed text changes with each edition. The editors mark places where they cannot decide and print readings no Greek manuscript contains. But the foundation is still the manuscript that sat for centuries in the Pope's library.

What a Reconstructed Text Means for the Believer

Luke wrote his Gospel to Theophilus "that thou mightest know the certainty of those things, wherein thou hast been instructed" (Luke 1:4). The word for "certainty" is *asphaleia* (ἀσφάλεια), which Thayer defines as "firmness, stability" and, in this verse, "certainty, undoubted truth." In Greek, Luke speaks of the certainty of the *logōn* (λόγων), the words.[218] God did not give

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[217] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 62.

[218] Joseph Henry Thayer, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (New York: American Book Company, 1889), s.v. "ἀσφάλεια."

His people a Word that they would have to wait for scholars to finish. He gave them a Word that is "settled in heaven" (Ps. 119:89) and that "liveth and abideth for ever" (1 Pet. 1:23).

The critical text cannot give that certainty, and its editors do not claim that it can. They offer a hypothesis, stated with great learning and revised with each new volume. The believer who rests on that text rests on the latest edition. The believer who rests on the Received Text rests on what God's people have already received, copied, preached, and translated. The King James translators did not need to wait for the next edition of anything. Neither do we.

FROM THE RECEIVED TEXT TO THE KING JAMES BIBLE

The preceding chapters have traced the Traditional Text and examined the Alexandrian manuscripts. The next step is to follow the received Hebrew and Greek texts into the English Bible and finally to the King James Bible. The printed Greek text supplied the New Testament foundation, while earlier English Bibles supplied much of the vocabulary, phrasing, and form.

The English Bible Prepared the Way

From a providential standpoint, several clear milestones show how the English Bible developed toward the KJV.

The Wycliffite Bible was the first full translation of the Bible into English. It was translated in manuscript form from the Old Latin, and some 250 surviving complete or partial manuscripts exist today.[219]

In 1526, Tyndale published the first printed complete English New Testament translated from Greek. This was followed by his 1530 translation of the Pentateuch, or the Five Books of Moses, from Hebrew into English. One detailed study examining eighteen sample sections indicated that Tyndale is responsible for approximately 84 percent of the words in the KJV New Testament, and about 76 percent of his words are still in the KJV Old Testament books that he translated.[220]

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[219] Anne Hudson, "The First Complete English Bible," *Tyndale Society Journal*, no. 2 (June 1995): 20–23; Mary Dove, *The First English Bible: The Text and Context of the Wycliffite Versions* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 281–306.

[220] Jon Nielson and Royal Skousen, "How Much of the King James Bible Is William Tyndale's? An Estimation Based on Sampling,"

Coverdale's Bible, published in 1535, was the first complete printed English Bible, and Matthew's Bible (1537) combined the work of Tyndale and Coverdale and added summaries and cross-references. The Great Bible, published in 1539, revised Matthew's Bible for use in public in England's churches and used brackets and smaller type to mark certain readings from the Latin Vulgate that were found neither in the Hebrew nor the Greek.[221]

The 1560 Geneva Bible took the English Bible to a yet more accessible level of study by being the first complete English Bible with numbered verses, marking each verse as a separate, indented paragraph, using readable roman print, and indicating in italics supplied words—that is, words added to convey the meaning in English although not represented by a separate Hebrew or Greek word. This Bible also contained detailed notes, cross-references, maps, and tables.[222] [223]

Reformation 3, no. 1 (1998): 49–74, https://doi.org/10.1179/ref_1998_3_1_004.

[221] Ezra Horbury, "The Bible Abbreviated: Summaries in Early Modern English Bibles," *Harvard Theological Review* 112, no. 2 (2019): 235–60; Miles Coverdale, Richard Grafton, and William Gray to Thomas Cromwell, August 9, 1538, in *Records of the English Bible: The Documents Relating to the Translation and Publication of the Bible in English, 1525–1611*, ed. Alfred W. Pollard (London: Oxford University Press, 1911), 237–38.

[222] Kent P. Jackson, Frank F. Judd Jr., and David R. Seely, "Chapters, Verses, Punctuation, Spelling, and Italics," in *The King James Bible and the Restoration*, ed. Kent P. Jackson (Provo, UT: Religious Studies Center, Brigham Young University, 2011), 95–117.

[223] Bruce M. Metzger, "The Geneva Bible of 1560," *Theology Today* 17, no. 3 (October 1960): 339–52; Jackson, Judd, and Seely, "Chapters, Verses," 101–2, 109–10.

The Bishops' Bible, first published in 1568, was a revision of the Great Bible for church use, and its 1602 edition served as the initial text for the KJV. However, the KJV instructions required the translators to compare this Bible with Tyndale's, Matthew's, Coverdale's, the Great and Geneva Bibles and, further, with the Hebrew and Greek. Norton estimates that approximately 63 percent of the KJV differs from the Bishops' Bible.[224] This work was broken down among six teams of scholars at Westminster, Oxford, and Cambridge. Of these, we know the names of forty-seven translators.

The 1611 edition continued the use of chapter and verse numbers, indented verses, chapter summaries, and extensive cross-references of the previous versions. Since the body of this text was blackletter, roman print, rather than italics, was used to identify the supplied words. When later editions changed the text to roman, the supplied words were indicated in italics. The 1611 version also included 8,422 marginal notes, including 1,018 in the Apocrypha, which provided literal renderings, alternative translations, and textual information.[225]

These seven major English Bibles—Wycliffe, Tyndale, Coverdale, Matthew's, the Great Bible, the Geneva Bible, and the Bishops' Bible—prepared the way for the King James Bible. The KJV brought their best English wording together and

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[224] "The Rules to Be Observed in the Translation of the Bible," in *Records of the English Bible: The Documents Relating to the Translation and Publication of the Bible in English, 1525–1611*, ed. Alfred W. Pollard (London: Oxford University Press, 1911), 53–55; David Norton, *A Textual History of the King James Bible* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 8, 23–24.

[225] F. H. A. Scrivener, *The Authorized Edition of the English Bible (1611): Its Subsequent Reprints and Modern Representatives* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1884), 56, 69–71.

refined it through careful comparison with the Hebrew and Greek. It was the eighth major English Bible in this progression. In Scripture, eight often marks a new beginning, and the KJV opened a new period in English Bible history as it was carried through the greatest era of English-speaking revival and missionary expansion.

How the King James Translators Worked

The work was distributed among six companies located at Westminster, Cambridge, and Oxford. Although the early proposal referred to a larger number of appointed scholars, the surviving lists identify forty-seven translators. Their assignments covered the Old Testament, the Apocrypha, and the New Testament.[226]

The first translation rule directed them to use the Bishops' Bible as their starting English text and to alter it wherever the truth of the original required; copies of the 1602 edition were supplied for the work. Another rule directed them to compare the earlier translations of Tyndale, Matthew, Coverdale, the Great Bible, and the Geneva Bible whenever those versions agreed better with the original text.[227]

Their work proceeded through documented stages. Each translator first examined the assigned passage. The company then met to compare the work and agree upon its reading. Completed books were sent to the other companies for review. Unresolved disagreements could be considered at a final

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[226] David Norton, *The King James Bible: A Short History from Tyndale to Today* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 54–55.

[227] Pollard, *Records of the English Bible*, 53–55.

meeting of leading translators, and difficult passages could be referred to other learned men.

This was a careful and organized system of translation and review. Each portion was examined individually, discussed by a company, reviewed by the other companies, and settled through further consultation when needed. The strength of the work lies in this documented process of repeated comparison.

The Learning of the King James Translators

The review process was only as strong as the men who carried it out, and the King James translators were among the most learned men of any age. Alexander McClure's biographies of the translators, summarized by D. A. Waite, give some examples.[228]

- Lancelot Andrewes, director of the first Westminster company (Genesis–2 Kings), prepared his manual of private devotions wholly in Greek. McClure repeats an old chronicler's verdict: "Such was his skill in all languages, especially the Oriental, that had he been present at the confusion of tongues at Babel, he might have served as interpreter-general." His funeral sermon stated that he "was conversant with fifteen languages."[229]

- William Bedwell, of the same company, was an eminent Arabic scholar. McClure credited him with

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[228] Alexander W. McClure, *The Translators Revived: A Biographical Memoir of the Authors of the English Version of the Holy Bible* (New York: Charles Scribner, 1853), 87–101, 141–43, 164–69, 199–208.

[229] McClure, *Translators Revived*, 87.

"the honor of being the first who considerably promoted and revived the study of the Arabic language and literature in Europe." He spent many years compiling an Arabic lexicon.[230]

- Miles Smith, of the Oxford Old Testament company, was one of the twelve who made the final revision and the author of the preface to the reader. He annotated the Greek and Latin church fathers, and Chaldee, Syriac, and Arabic were almost as familiar to him as his native tongue.[231]

- Sir Henry Savile, of the Oxford New Testament company, was tutor in Greek to Queen Elizabeth and produced the first complete edition of the works of Chrysostom, in eight large folio volumes.[232]

- John Bois had read the Bible in Hebrew by the age of five. He was one of the twelve who made the final revision, and his notes are among the few surviving records of that work. McClure says he was so familiar with the Greek New Testament that he could turn at any time to any word it contained.[233]

McClure concluded that "all the colleges of Great Britain and America, even in this proud day of boastings, could not bring

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[230] McClure, *Translators Revived*, 101.

[231] McClure, *Translators Revived*, 141–43.

[232] McClure, *Translators Revived*, 164–69, especially 165, 167.

[233] McClure, *Translators Revived*, 199–208, especially 200, 206. On Bois's notes, see Ward Allen, *Translating for King James: Notes Made by a Translator of King James's Bible* (Nashville: Vanderbilt University Press, 1969).

together the same number of divines equally qualified by learning and piety for the great undertaking."[234] Even Alexander Geddes, a Roman Catholic priest who attempted his own translation, said of the King James Bible:

> "Every sentence, every word, every syllable, every letter and point, seem to have been weighed with the nicest exactitude; and expressed, either in the text, or margin, with the greatest precision."[235]

Why the Process Ends with the King James Bible

The King James Bible is not presented here as merely one good translation chosen from among many. As we have seen, there is a remarkable pattern of God's providential hand in the manuscript history leading up to the King James Bible, in the circumstances surrounding its translation, in the work itself, and in the reception of the translation.

1. The Masoretic Hebrew text preserved by those God entrusted the Old Testament with: **the Jews**.

2. The Received Greek Text arising from the Traditional or Byzantine stream **used and received by believers and churches.**

3. A formal, **word-for-word** method of translation.

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[234] McClure, *Translators Revived*, 64.

[235] Alexander Geddes, *Prospectus of a New Translation of the Holy Bible* (Glasgow, 1786), 92, quoted in McClure, *Translators Revived*, 238–39.

4. The accumulated strength of the earlier English Bibles.

5. Repeated individual, company, and general review.

6. **Centuries of reception of the KJV** in English-speaking churches, homes, revivals, and missions.

No one of these marks stands alone. Together they explain why the process does not end with Erasmus, one particular TR edition, the Geneva Bible, or an endless series of new translations. The Hebrew and Greek foundations, the refinement of English wording, the translators' method, the review process, and the reception of the finished Bible meet in the King James Bible.

Edward Hills did not go as far as this book does. He allowed that the King James Bible might be corrected in minor details. Yet even he concluded that the believer who takes God's providential preservation seriously is led to one Bible:

> "For we are led by the logic of faith to the Masoretic Hebrew text, to the New Testament Textus Receptus, and to the King James Version."[236]

He called it "the providentially appointed English Bible."[237] This book takes one further step, and believes it is the consistent one: if God appointed the King James Bible as the English Bible

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[236] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 8, "The Textus Receptus and the King James Version," under "Maximum Certainty versus Maximum Uncertainty," e-book.

[237] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "The King James Version—The Providentially Appointed English Bible."

and preserved His words in it, then it is not merely trustworthy. It is the purified Word of God in English.

Within the faith-based view of this issue, the KJV is therefore the settled English result of God's preservation and purification of the words He had already given.

TWO SEEDS, TWO RELIGIONS, TWO BIBLES: THE LINE OF TRUTH AND THE LINE OF ROME

The earlier chapters traced two textual streams, Antioch and Alexandria, and followed the preserved text into the King James Bible. This chapter steps back to look at the whole field. The contest between two lines of Bibles is not an isolated quarrel among scholars. It is one front of a war that began in Eden and runs through the entire Bible: the true seed and the counterfeit seed, true worship and its religious imitation, the Word of God and the words of men dressed up to look like it.

The thesis of this chapter is simple. Just as the Bible shows two lines of seed and two lines of religion, history shows two lines of Bibles. One line runs from the apostles through the churches that used the Traditional Text, through the Syriac and Old Latin Bibles, through the persecuted believers of the Alpine valleys and the Greek-speaking churches, through the Reformation, and into the King James Bible. The other runs from Alexandria through Origen, Eusebius, and Jerome into the Latin Bible of Rome, through Codex Vaticanus in the Pope's library, through the Rheims New Testament of 1582, and through the Greek text of 1881 into the modern versions. Rome did not write every modern Bible. But the line those Bibles stand in is the line Rome kept, defended, and today helps to edit.

As in the rest of this book, three things must be kept separate: what the Bible says, what history records, and the conclusions this book draws from both. Scripture does not name Codex Vaticanus or the Council of Trent. It does give us a pattern, and it tells us that the pattern will continue to the end. History then shows where that pattern has been worked out.

The Pattern Set in the Garden

The first prophecy in the Bible is a prophecy of two seeds:

> "And I will put enmity between thee and the woman, and between thy seed and her seed; it shall bruise thy head, and thou shalt bruise his heel." (Gen. 3:15)

The Hebrew word for "seed" is *zeraʿ* (זֶרַע), the ordinary word for seed sown in a field and for a man's offspring. The word for "enmity" is *ʾêbâh* (אֵיבָה), a settled hostility.[238] God Himself set that hostility in place: "I will put enmity." From this verse forward the Bible follows two lines. One is the line of the promised Seed, which reaches its fulfillment in Christ (Gal. 3:16). The other is the line of the serpent, which our Lord identified in men who were religious, learned, and zealous for their traditions: "Ye are of your father the devil" (John 8:44).

The same picture closes the Bible. After the woman's Child is caught up to God, "the dragon was wroth with the woman, and went to make war with the remnant of her seed, which keep the commandments of God, and have the testimony of Jesus Christ" (Rev. 12:17). The war of the seeds that begins in Genesis 3 is still being fought in Revelation 12.

Seed is also one of the Bible's pictures of the Word. "The seed is the word of God" (Luke 8:11). Peter says believers are "born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever" (1 Pet. 1:23). The

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[238] Francis Brown, S. R. Driver, and Charles A. Briggs, *A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1906), s.v. "זֶרַע" and "אֵיבָה"; James Strong, *The Exhaustive Concordance of the Bible* (New York: Hunt and Eaton, 1890), Hebrew and Chaldee Dictionary, nos. 2233, 342.

word "incorruptible" is *aphthartos* (ἄφθαρτος), not subject to decay. The devil's first work in Eden was to corrupt that seed in Eve's mind, and Paul feared the same thing for the Corinthians: "But I fear, lest by any means, as the serpent beguiled Eve through his subtilty, so your minds should be corrupted from the simplicity that is in Christ" (2 Cor. 11:3). "Corrupted" there is *phtheirō* (φθείρω), from the same family of words as *aphthartos*.[239] God's Word is incorruptible seed. Satan's work is corruption.

Two Lines Through the Whole Bible

Once the pattern is seen in Genesis 3:15, it can be traced through the whole Bible. In nearly every case the counterfeit is not an open denial of God. It is a religious imitation.

It begins with Cain and Abel. Both brothers brought an offering; both were religious. "By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain" (Heb. 11:4). Abel came by blood; Cain came with the fruit of his own labor. John says Cain "was of that wicked one, and slew his brother" (1 John 3:12), and Jude warns of men who "have gone in the way of Cain" (Jude 11). The first murder in history was the religious brother killing the believing brother.

It continues with Ishmael and Isaac. Paul calls this history an allegory of "the two covenants; the one from the mount Sinai, which gendereth to bondage, which is Agar" (Gal. 4:24). The son of the flesh came first; the son of promise came by the power of God. Paul adds: "But as then he that was born after

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[239] Joseph Henry Thayer, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (New York: American Book Company, 1889), s.v. "ἄφθαρτος" and "φθείρω."

the flesh persecuted him that was born after the Spirit, even so it is now" (Gal. 4:29).

In Egypt the counterfeit stood face to face with Moses. When Aaron's rod became a serpent, "the magicians of Egypt, they also did in like manner with their enchantments" (Exod. 7:11). Paul names two of them: "Now as Jannes and Jambres withstood Moses, so do these also resist the truth" (2 Tim. 3:8). They resisted Moses, not by denying the miracles, but by imitating them.

In the divided kingdom the counterfeit built its own altars. Jeroboam did not abolish religion in the northern kingdom; he duplicated it. He made two calves of gold and said, "behold thy gods, O Israel, which brought thee up out of the land of Egypt" (1 Kings 12:28). He "made priests of the lowest of the people, which were not of the sons of Levi," and ordained a feast "in the month which he had devised of his own heart" (1 Kings 12:31, 33). He copied the true feast, the true priesthood, and even the words of the Exodus, and kept the people from going up to the place where God had put His name. In the very next chapter a counterfeit prophet appears. The old prophet at Bethel said, "I am a prophet also as thou art; and an angel spake unto me by the word of the LORD… But he lied unto him" (1 Kings 13:18). A counterfeit "word of the LORD," carried by a man with credentials, killed the man of God who believed it.

The Lord Jesus gave the same pattern in a parable. "But while men slept, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat, and went his way" (Matt. 13:25). When the servants asked where the tares came from, the householder answered, "An enemy hath done this" (Matt. 13:28). The word for tares, *zizanion* (ζιζάνιον), is described by Thayer as "a kind of darnel, bastard wheat," "resembling wheat except that the grains are

black."[240] The enemy did not sow thistles. He sowed an imitation.

The apostles met the same enemy in the churches. Paul warned of "another Jesus… another spirit… another gospel" (2 Cor. 11:4), preached by men "transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ. And no marvel; for Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light" (2 Cor. 11:13–14). And the Bible ends with two women and two cities: the Bride, the Lamb's wife, and "MYSTERY, BABYLON THE GREAT, THE MOTHER OF HARLOTS AND ABOMINATIONS OF THE EARTH" (Rev. 17:5), who is "drunken with the blood of the saints, and with the blood of the martyrs of Jesus" (Rev. 17:6).

From these passages we may draw the marks of the counterfeit. They are drawn from the pattern of Scripture, and they will prove useful when we turn to history. The counterfeit imitates: it looks like the real thing, whether an offering, a priesthood, a feast, a miracle, a prophet, a stalk of wheat, or an apostle. It mixes, keeping enough truth to be believed and adding or removing enough to change the result. It rests on human authority; Jeroboam's feast was "devised of his own heart," and Christ rebuked the Pharisees for "making the word of God of none effect through your tradition" (Mark 7:13).

The counterfeit also looks back to Egypt. Jeroboam presented his calves as the gods "which brought thee up out of the land of Egypt," and the men who withstood Moses were the magicians of Egypt. It persecutes the true: Cain killed Abel, the son of the bondwoman persecuted the son of promise, and Babylon is drunk with the blood of the saints. And it takes the name.

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[240] Thayer, *Greek-English Lexicon*, s.v. "ζιζάνιον."

Jeroboam used God's Exodus words, the false apostles called themselves apostles of Christ, and the harlot wears the name of the church.

If There Are Two Religions, There Will Be Two Bibles

Paul did not only warn about false teachers. He warned about what they were doing with the words of God. "For we are not as many, which corrupt the word of God" (2 Cor. 2:17). The word translated "corrupt" is *kapēleuō* (καπηλεύω), the work of a peddler or petty retailer. Thayer explains that "pedlers were in the habit of adulterating their commodities for the sake of gain," and he points to the Greek of Isaiah 1:22, where the same kind of dealers mix wine with water: "thy wine mixed with water." In 2 Corinthians 4:2 Paul says that he did not handle "the word of God deceitfully," using *doloō* (δολόω), a word Greek writers used for adulterating wine, and which Thayer explains in this verse as corrupting divine truth "by mingling with it wrong notions."[241] These are the words of a man who knew that the Scriptures were already being watered down and mixed. Paul also wrote, "the mystery of iniquity doth already work" (2 Thess. 2:7). The corruption did not wait for the fourth century. It was at work while the apostles lived.

From this pattern, this book draws the following conclusion: a counterfeit religion needs a counterfeit Bible. It cannot live on the pure Word of God, because the pure Word exposes it. It must either take the Scriptures away from the people, or give them a Scripture adjusted to its purposes, or both. History shows that both have happened.

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[241] Thayer, *Greek-English Lexicon*, s.v. "καπηλεύω" and "δολόω."

Benjamin Wilkinson, whose *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated* (1930) remains one of the most important books on this subject, put it this way:

> "Anyone who is interested enough to read the vast volume of literature on this subject, will agree that down through the centuries there were only two streams of manuscripts."[242]

Wilkinson described the first stream as the Received Text, kept by the churches of Judea and Antioch, the Italic Church of northern Italy, the Gallic and Celtic churches, the Waldenses, and the churches of the Reformation, and appearing in English in the King James Bible. The second stream he described this way:

> "(a) In Greek: — The Vatican MS., or Codex B, in the library at Rome; and the Sinaitic, or Codex Aleph (א), its brother.… (b) In Latin: — The Vulgate or Latin Bible of Jerome. (c) In English: — The Jesuit Bible of 1582, which later with vast changes is seen in the Douay, or Catholic Bible. (d) In English again: — In many modern Bibles which introduce practically all the Catholic readings of the Latin Vulgate which were rejected by the Protestants of the Reformation; among these, prominently, are the Revised Versions."[243]

He then summed up the whole history in one sentence:

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[242] Benjamin G. Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated* (Washington, DC: n.p., 1930), 12.

[243] Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 13.

> "So the present controversy between the King James Bible in English and the modern versions is the same old contest fought out between the early church and rival sects; later between the Waldenses and the Papists from the fourth to the thirteenth centuries; and later still, between the Reformers and the Jesuits in the sixteenth century."[244]

The rest of this chapter tests that claim against the documents.

The Line from Alexandria to Rome

Earlier chapters showed how Origen mingled Scripture with philosophy and produced the Hexapla, that a corrector of Codex Sinaiticus noted that it had been compared with an exemplar "corrected according to the Hexapla of Origen," and that Vaticanus and Sinaiticus may have been among the fifty Bibles Constantine ordered from Eusebius, Origen's great admirer. Those facts need not be repeated here. What must be added is where the Alexandrian line went next. It went to Rome.

In A.D. 383 Jerome presented his revised Latin Gospels to Damasus, bishop of Rome. In his preface he admitted that critics would call him "a forger and a profane person" for changing the Bible the Latin churches were reading, and he named two comforts against them. The first was this: "the command is given by you who are the supreme bishop." He also described his method. The Gospels had been "revised by a comparison of the Greek manuscripts. Only early ones have

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[244] Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 13.

been used."[245] The claim that a reading comes from the "earliest manuscripts" is not new. It was Jerome's claim, made to the bishop of Rome, in the preparation of the Latin Bible that Rome would one day declare "authentic."

Jerome did not hide his scholarly sympathies. Henry Barclay Swete, the Cambridge Septuagint scholar, described Jerome as "a Palestinian and an admirer of Origen's critical principles."[246] Jerome settled at Bethlehem, within reach of the library at Caesarea where Origen's Hexapla was kept.

Honesty requires a qualification here, and it strengthens rather than weakens the argument of this chapter. Jerome's Vulgate is not simply an Alexandrian text. Edward Hills regarded the replacement of the Old Latin by Jerome's Vulgate as "a movement toward the Traditional (Byzantine) Text," pointing to the Vulgate's agreement with that text in great passages such as Christ's agony in the garden (Luke 22:43–44) and His prayer from the cross (Luke 23:34).[247] But a counterfeit that differed from the true in every place would deceive no one. Tares must look like wheat. The question is where Rome's Latin Bible

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[245] Jerome, "Preface to the Four Gospels," addressed to Damasus (A.D. 383), in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 6, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1893), 487–88.

[246] Henry Barclay Swete, *An Introduction to the Old Testament in Greek* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1900), 86.

[247] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 7, "The Traditional New Testament Text," under "The Providence of God in the Latin Church," e-book.

departs from the Received Text, and, as we will see, it departs in many of the very places where the modern versions depart.

The Bible of the Believers Outside Rome

While Rome standardized Jerome's Latin Bible, other believers kept the Scriptures in their own languages. The Syriac Peshitta, which Hills describes as "largely of the Traditional (Byzantine) text-type," served the churches of the East.[248] The Old Latin Bibles were in use before Jerome and continued long after him. Augustine wrote of them: "Now among translations themselves the Italian (Itala) is to be preferred to the others, for it keeps closer to the words without prejudice to clearness of expression."[249]

Wilkinson and the older Protestant historians he relied upon connected the Italic Bible with the churches of northern Italy and with the Waldenses, the believers of the Alpine valleys who refused the authority of Rome.[250] Rome answered such believers with councils and with fire. In 1229, in the aftermath of the crusade against the heretics of southern France, the Council of Toulouse decreed:

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[248] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 7, under "The Providence of God in the Syrian Church."

[249] Augustine, *On Christian Doctrine* 2.15.22, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 2, ed. Philip Schaff (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Company, 1887), 542.

[250] Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 35. Wilkinson draws here on Peter Allix, William Gilly, Jean Léger, and Frederick Nolan (31–42). The age of the Waldensian movement and the exact descent of its Scriptures from the Old Latin are disputed among historians. What is not disputed is Rome's own testimony, cited below, that these believers possessed vernacular Scriptures and that Rome worked to take them away.

> "We prohibit also that the laity be permitted to have the books of the Old or New Testament, unless perhaps someone out of devotion should wish to have the Psalter or the Breviary for the divine offices, or the Hours of the Blessed Mary. But we most strictly forbid that they have the aforesaid books translated into the vulgar tongue."[251]

The decree names what Rome feared: not the Latin Bible in the hands of priests, but the Bible in the language of the people. Three and a half centuries later the English College of Rheims confirmed it in its own preface. Tracing the history of Bible translation, the Rheims translators wrote that in France, more than two hundred years earlier, the Bible had been put forth in French "the sooner to shake out of the deceived people's hands, the false heretical translations of a sect called Waldenses."[252] In Rome's own words, the translations of the Waldenses were in the people's hands, and Rome's purpose was to shake them out.

The same preface recalled how Archbishop Thomas Arundel, in a council at Oxford, made "strait provision" that no English version "set forth by Wickliff, or his adherents, should be suffered."[253] The Council of Constance condemned Wycliffe as a heretic in 1415 and ordered his body taken up and burned. John

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[251] Council of Toulouse (1229), canon 14. The Latin text is printed in S. R. Maitland, *Facts and Documents Illustrative of the History, Doctrine, and Rites of the Ancient Albigenses and Waldenses* (London: Rivington, 1832), 501. The translation here is my own.

[252] "The Preface to the Reader," in *The New Testament of Our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, Translated out of the Latin Vulgate … and First Published by the English College of Rheims, Anno 1582* (New York: Jonathan Leavitt, 1834), 9 (hereafter cited as *Rheims New Testament*). This reprint modernizes the spelling of the 1582 original.

[253] "Preface to the Reader," *Rheims New Testament*, 9.

Foxe records that his enemies let him rest in his grave forty-one years "before they ungraved him, and turned him from earth to ashes; which ashes they also took and threw into the river." Foxe added, "though they digged up his body, burnt his bones, and drowned his ashes, yet the word of God, and the truth of his doctrine… they could not burn."[254] William Tyndale, who gave England its first printed New Testament translated from the Greek, was strangled and burned at Vilvoorde in 1536. Foxe records that he was "tied to the stake, and then strangled first by the hangman, and afterwards with fire consumed," "crying thus at the stake with a fervent zeal, and a loud voice, 'Lord! open the king of England's eyes.'"[255]

When the Reformation came, the persecuted line joined hands with it. In 1532, at the synod of Chanforan in the valleys of Piedmont, the Waldenses resolved to join the Reformation and to publish a Bible in French. Pierre Robert Olivétan translated it from the Hebrew and Greek, and it was printed at Neuchâtel in 1535 with a preface by the young John Calvin.[256] Geneva, where the French Bible was revised again and again, also gave the English-speaking world the Geneva Bible of 1560, one of the Bibles the King James translators were instructed to compare.

Edward Hills observed that in the days of Erasmus no one yet drew "the logical but unpalatable conclusion that the Greek

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[254] John Foxe, *The Acts and Monuments of John Foxe*, ed. Stephen Reed Cattley, 8 vols. (London: R. B. Seeley and W. Burnside, 1837–41), 3:94–96. Foxe prints the decree for the exhumation under the year 1425; many historians date the burning of the remains to 1428.

[255] Foxe, *Acts and Monuments*, 5:127. Foxe spells the town "Filford."

[256] Musée protestant, "Olivétan (1506–1538)," accessed September 25, 2026, https://museeprotestant.org/en/notice/olivetan-1506-1538-2/.

Church rather than the Roman Church had been the providentially appointed guardian of the New Testament text."[257] That conclusion is unpalatable only to Rome. The Greek text that Erasmus printed in 1516 had not been kept by the Pope. It had been kept in the manuscripts of the Greek-speaking churches, the churches Rome regarded as schismatic.

Rome's Answer to the Reformation: The Council of Trent

The Reformation printed the Received Text and translated it into the languages of the people. Rome's defenders were ready with their answer. Hills records that Martin Dorp, one of the critics of Erasmus, maintained that the Greek New Testament "had been corrupted by the heretical Greek Church," and that Peter Sutor, once of the Sorbonne, declared, "If in one point the Vulgate were in error, the entire authority of holy Scripture would collapse."[258] At its fourth session in 1546, the Council of Trent made that attitude law. It listed the canon of Scripture, including the Apocrypha, and then pronounced:

> "But if anyone receive not, as sacred and canonical, the said books entire with all their parts, as they have been used to be read in the Catholic Church, and as they are contained in the old Latin Vulgate edition; and knowingly and deliberately contemn the traditions aforesaid; let him be anathema."[259]

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[257] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "Erasmus Guided by the Common Faith—Factors Which Influenced Him."

[258] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "Erasmus Guided by the Common Faith—Factors Which Influenced Him."

[259] *The Canons and Decrees of the Sacred and Oecumenical Council of Trent*, trans. J. Waterworth (London: C. Dolman, 1848), 19 (session 4).

In the same session the council decreed that the Vulgate should be "held as authentic" in public lectures, disputations, sermons, and expositions, "and that no one is to dare or presume to reject it under any pretext whatever." It forbade anyone to interpret Scripture "contrary to that sense which holy mother Church… hath held and doth hold."[260]

The marks of the counterfeit are all present. Trent raised the Apocrypha, the uninspired books that Vaticanus and Sinaiticus mingle with Scripture, to the level of God's Word. It set "traditions" beside the written Word. And it placed a Latin translation, made by an admirer of Origen at the command of a bishop of Rome, above the Hebrew and Greek.

The Rheims New Testament of 1582

Rome's scholars soon realized that they could no longer keep the English people from the Bible. So they produced their own. In 1582 the English College at Rheims, a seminary of English Catholic exiles, published an English New Testament translated, not from the Greek, but from the Latin Vulgate. William Fulke and Thomas Cartwright answered it in the name of the Church of England, and later Protestant writers, including the American editors who reprinted it in 1834 and Benjamin Wilkinson, called its makers "the Jesuits of Rheims" and the book "the Jesuit Bible."[261]

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[260] *Canons and Decrees*, 19.

[261] The principal translator was Gregory Martin, working under William Allen at the English College. The college was a seminary rather than a Jesuit house, but it belonged to the same Counter-Reformation mission to England in which the Jesuits took a leading part. For "the Jesuits of Rheims," see the introductory address in

The preface of the Rheims New Testament is one of the most revealing documents in the history of the English Bible. Its translators said plainly that they did not publish it because they believed the Scriptures ought to be in the common tongue:

> "Which translation we do not for all that publish, upon erroneous opinion of necessity, that the Holy Scriptures should always be in our mother tongue, or that they ought, or were ordained by God to be read indifferently of all, or could be easily understood of every one that readeth or heareth them in a known language…."[262]

They explained that they translated the Latin rather than the Greek, and gave this reason: "It is not only better than all other Latin translations, but than the Greek text itself, in those places where they disagree." Their proof was that "most of the ancient Heretics were Grecians, and therefore the Scriptures in Greek were more corrupted by them."[263] The churches that had copied, read, and preached the Greek New Testament for fifteen centuries were written off as the source of corruption so that the Latin of Rome could be preferred.

Then they went further. They named particular words in the Greek text of their day, the text the Reformers were translating, which they called "superfluities corruptly added to the text of holy Scripture." Their examples were the close of the Lord's Prayer, "For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever" (Matt. 6:13), which they called, repeating a

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Rheims New Testament, 8; for "the Jesuit Bible of 1582," see Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 13.

[262] "Preface to the Reader," *Rheims New Testament*, 9 (sec. 2).

[263] "Preface to the Reader," *Rheims New Testament*, 16 (secs. 26–27).

remark of Erasmus, "trifles"; the sentence "Verily I say unto you, It shall be more tolerable for Sodom and Gomorrha in the day of judgment, than for that city" (Mark 6:11); the words "and to be baptized with the baptism that I am baptized with" (Matt. 20:22–23); the words "or wife" (Mark 10:29); and the second half of Romans 11:6, "But if it be of works, then is it no more grace: otherwise work is no more work."[264]

Now open the English Standard Version, the New International Version, or any Bible built on the modern critical text. Every one of these "superfluities" is gone. The ESV ends the Lord's Prayer with "deliver us from evil" and moves the doxology to a note. Its Mark 6:11 has no sentence about Sodom and Gomorrha. In its Matthew 20:22 the Lord asks only, "Are you able to drink the cup that I am to drink?" In its Mark 10:29 the list reads "house or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or lands," with no wife. And its Romans 11:6 reads only, "But if it is by grace, it is no longer on the basis of works; otherwise grace would no longer be grace."[265]

In 1582 the scholars of Rheims published a list of words they wanted out of the Greek New Testament. In 1881 Westcott and Hort took them out, and the modern versions still leave them out. Consider the last example especially. The clause Rome called a superfluity is the half of Romans 11:6 that closes the door on works from the other side: "if it be of works, then is it no more grace." A system built on merit, penance, and

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[264] "Preface to the Reader," *Rheims New Testament*, 17 (sec. 29).

[265] *The Holy Bible, English Standard Version* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2016), Matt. 6:13; 20:22; Mark 6:11; 10:29; Rom. 11:6.

sacramental works has always had reason to be uncomfortable with that sentence.

1611 Answers 1582

The King James Bible was not born in a quiet library. It was born in the years of controversy over the Rheims New Testament, and its translators knew exactly which line they stood in. The Epistle Dedicatory praised King James for his writing "in defence of the Truth, (which hath given such a blow unto that Man of Sin, as will not be healed)."[266] "Man of sin" is Paul's phrase in 2 Thessalonians 2:3, and the translators applied it, as the Reformers generally did, to the papacy. The Baptists of 1689 confessed the same: "neither can the Pope of Rome in any sense be head thereof, but is that antichrist, that man of sin, and son of perdition, that exalts himself in the church against Christ, and all that is called God."[267]

In "The Translators to the Reader," the King James translators answered Rome directly. They observed that Rome permitted the Scriptures in the mother tongue only by written license, and then only to those approved by their confessors:

> "So much are they afraid of the light of the Scripture, (Lucifugae Scripturarum, as Tertullian speaketh) that they will not trust the people with it, no not as it is set forth by their own sworn men, no not with the Licence of their own Bishops and Inquisitors. Yea, so unwilling they are to communicate the Scriptures to the people's understanding in any sort, that they are not ashamed to

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[266] "The Epistle Dedicatory," in *The Holy Bible* (London: Robert Barker, 1611).

[267] *The Second London Baptist Confession of Faith* (1689), 26.4.

> confess, that we forced them to translate it into English against their wills."[268]

That is exactly what the Rheims preface had said.

The translators also exposed the instability of Rome's "authentic" Latin text. Pope Sixtus V published an edition of the Vulgate in 1590 and decreed that it was the authentic edition intended by Trent. Yet, the translators noted, "Clement the Eighth his immediate successor, publisheth another edition of the Bible, containing in it infinite differences from that of Sixtus, (and many of them weighty and material) and yet this must be authentic by all means."[269] The counterfeit line does not stand still. It revises continually while claiming authority for each revision, a habit the modern critical text has faithfully kept.

Finally, the translators contrasted their plain English with the Latinized vocabulary of Rheims:

> "…we have shunned the obscurity of the Papists, in their Azimes, Tunike, Rational, Holocausts, Praepuce, Pasche, and a number of such like, whereof their late Translation is full, and that of purpose to darken the sense, that since they must needs translate the Bible, yet by the language thereof, it may be kept from being understood. But we desire that the Scripture may speak

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[268] "The Translators to the Reader," in *The Holy Bible* (London: Robert Barker, 1611), under "The Unwillingness of Our Chief Adversaries, That the Scriptures Should Be Divulged in the Mother Tongue."

[269] "Translators to the Reader," under "An Answer to the Imputations of Our Adversaries."

> like itself, as in the language of Canaan, that it may be understood even of the very vulgar."[270]

Rheims translated, but in a way that kept the plowboy in the dark. The King James translators wanted the plowboy to understand. Rome's English Bible lost that contest. As Wilkinson put it, "The Vulgate yielded before the Received Text. The Latin was vanquished before the Greek; the mutilated version before the pure Word. The Jesuits were obliged to shift their line of battle."[271] The new line of battle ran through the scholars.

The Counterfeit Returns Through the Scholars' Door

For more than two centuries after 1611, the Received Text stood as the Greek New Testament of the Protestant world, while Codex Vaticanus sat in the Pope's library. Rome did not hurry to share it. The Protestant scholar Samuel Prideaux Tregelles went to Rome to collate the manuscript and later wrote:

> "I went to Rome, and during the five months that I was there, I sought diligently to obtain permission to collate the MS. accurately, or at least to examine it in the places in which Birch and Bentley differ with regard to its readings. All ended in disappointment. I often saw the MS., but I was hindered from transcribing any of its readings."[272]

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[270] "Translators to the Reader," under "Reasons Inducing Us Not to Stand Curiously upon an Identity of Phrasing."

[271] Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 70.

[272] Samuel Prideaux Tregelles, *An Account of the Printed Text of the Greek New Testament* (London: Samuel Bagster and Sons, 1854), 156.

Rome understood what an appeal to the oldest manuscripts could accomplish. In 1849 Nicholas Wiseman, who would become Cardinal Archbishop of Westminster the following year, reviewed a new Catholic translation of the Gospels. He wrote that "all modern judicious critics will give great weight, and even preference, to the Vulgate, or Latin version, beyond the ordinary Greek text, where the two differ," and he gave the reason: "the oldest and best manuscripts, and the most ancient versions, almost invariably agree with the Vulgate." Then he rejoiced:

> "When we consider the scorn cast by the reformers upon the Vulgate, and their recurrence, in consequence, to the Greek, as the only accurate standard, we cannot but rejoice at the silent triumph which truth has at length gained over clamorous error. For, in fact, the principal writers who have avenged the Vulgate, and obtained for it its critical pre-eminence, are Protestants."[273]

Notice the phrase. Thirty-two years before Westcott and Hort published their Greek text, a Roman Catholic prelate was already using the slogan "the oldest and best manuscripts," and he used it to vindicate Rome's Vulgate against the Reformers' Greek text. Protestant scholars, he said, were doing Rome's work for her.

That is the atmosphere in which the Revised Version was born. The Oxford Movement had spent a generation pulling the

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[273] Nicholas Wiseman, "The Parables of the New Testament," in *Essays on Various Subjects*, vol. 1 (London: Charles Dolman, 1853), 104. The essay first appeared in the *Dublin Review* in September 1849.

Church of England toward Rome, and its most brilliant leader, John Henry Newman, went over to Rome in 1845 and later became a cardinal. When the revisers were chosen in 1870, Newman was invited to join them. He declined.[274]

The two men whose Greek text controlled the revision, Brooke Foss Westcott and Fenton John Anthony Hort, were not Roman Catholics. But their published letters show which way their sympathies ran. At twenty, Hort wrote that "the pure Romish view seems to me nearer, and more likely to lead to, the truth than the Evangelical."[275] At twenty-three, he called the Greek text of the Reformation "the villainous Textus Receptus."[276] In 1858 he wrote that "the positive doctrines even of the Evangelicals seem to me perverted rather than untrue."[277] In 1860 he told Westcott that he regarded "the popular doctrine of substitution" as "an immoral and material counterfeit."[278] In 1864 he reminded Westcott that he had once shocked him and Lightfoot "by expressing a belief that 'Protestantism' is only parenthetical and temporary."[279] And in 1865 he wrote: "I have been persuaded for many years that Mary-worship and 'Jesus'-

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[274] Alan H. Cadwallader, "Star-Cross'd Lovers: John Henry Newman and the Revision of the Bible," *Australian eJournal of Theology* 19, no. 3 (2012): 231, 233.

[275] Hort to John Ellerton, July 6, 1848, in Arthur Fenton Hort, *Life and Letters of Fenton John Anthony Hort*, 2 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1896), 1:76.

[276] Hort to John Ellerton, December 29–30, 1851, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 1:211.

[277] Hort to Rowland Williams, October 21, 1858, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 1:400.

[278] Hort to Westcott, October 15, 1860, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 1:430.

[279] Hort to Westcott, September 23, 1864, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:31.

worship have very much in common in their causes and their results."[280]

Westcott, as a student, entered a small oratory where he found a *Pietà*, "a Virgin and dead Christ," and wrote, "Had I been alone I could have knelt there for hours."[281] In 1865, recalling his visit to La Salette, the site of a reported apparition of Mary, he wrote to Lightfoot: "I wish I could see to what forgotten truth Mariolatry bears witness."[282]

These were the men who gave the English-speaking world a Greek New Testament built on Codex Vaticanus, the manuscript from the Pope's library. Roman Catholics noticed the result. Wilkinson gathered their responses to the Revised Version, among them the words of the Very Rev. Thomas S. Preston of New York: "It is to us a gratification to find that in very many instances they have adopted the reading of the Catholic Version, and have thus by their scholarship confirmed the correctness of our Bible."[283]

As we will see next, their Greek text was placed before the revisers of the English Bible, and it came to replace the Received Text in the scholarship of the English-speaking world.

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[280] Hort to Westcott, October 17, 1865, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:50.

[281] Westcott, letter of 1847, in Arthur Westcott, *Life and Letters of Brooke Foss Westcott*, 2 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1903), 1:81.

[282] Westcott to J. B. Lightfoot, September 27, 1865, in Westcott, *Life and Letters*, 1:251.

[283] Thomas S. Preston, quoted in Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 229. Wilkinson cites "Dr. Warfield's Collection of Opinions," vol. 2, p. 21.

From Cooperation to Co-Editing

In the twentieth century the two lines of modern Bibles, Protestant and Catholic, drew closer still. At the Second Vatican Council, Rome declared that the Church "from the very beginning accepted as her own that very ancient Greek translation of the Old Testament which is called the septuagint" and has always honored "especially the Latin translation known as the vulgate." She then opened the door to a new kind of Bible: "if these translations are produced in cooperation with the separated brethren as well, all Christians will be able to use them."[284]

Notice the two Bibles Rome names as her own: the Septuagint, whose great codices are Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus, and Jerome's Vulgate. They are the same two pillars Wilkinson identified in the second stream.

A formal agreement soon walked through that open door. In 1968 the Vatican's Secretariat for Promoting Christian Unity and the United Bible Societies issued "Guiding Principles for Interconfessional Cooperation in Translating the Bible," revised in 1987. The revised Guidelines, signed at Vatican City by Cardinal Johannes Willebrands, direct joint translation teams to "base their work on the critical edition of the Greek New Testament published by the United Bible Societies, which is itself a joint effort of scholars representing Roman Catholic and other Christian constituencies." Readings of the Byzantine tradition, "as largely represented by the Textus Receptus," may

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[284] Second Vatican Council, *Dei Verbum* (November 18, 1965), 22, accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19651118_dei-verbum_en.html.

be "noted in the translation," but in footnotes. The same document provides for Bible Society editions bearing a Roman Catholic imprimatur to include the deuterocanonical books, that is, the Apocrypha.[285]

The Guidelines did not overstate the case. The Jesuit scholar Carlo Maria Martini, rector of the Pontifical Biblical Institute and later Cardinal Archbishop of Milan, served on the committee that edited that Greek text. His name stands on the title page of the Nestle–Aland twenty-seventh edition beside those of Barbara and Kurt Aland, Johannes Karavidopoulos, and Bruce Metzger.[286] This is the Greek text family that stands behind the NIV, the NASB, the CSB, and the ESV. The ESV's own preface states that it is based on the Greek text in the 2014 editions of the United Bible Societies' *Greek New Testament* and the twenty-eighth edition of *Novum Testamentum Graece*.[287]

Rome then brought her own Latin Bible into line with the same text. In 1979 Pope John Paul II promulgated the New Vulgate (*Nova Vulgata*) as Rome's official edition. His apostolic constitution *Scripturarum Thesaurus* explains that the old Vulgate was kept word for word where it accurately renders the original texts "as they are presented in today's critical editions,"

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[285] Secretariat for Promoting Christian Unity and United Bible Societies, *Guidelines for Interconfessional Cooperation in Translating the Bible*, new rev. ed. (Vatican City, 1987), 1–2 (secs. 1.1.1.1 and 1.1.2), accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.christianunity.va/content/unitacristiani/en/documenti/altri-testi/en.pdf.

[286] *Novum Testamentum Graece*, ed. Barbara Aland, Kurt Aland, Johannes Karavidopoulos, Carlo M. Martini, and Bruce M. Metzger, 27th ed. (Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 1993), title page.

[287] "Preface," *English Standard Version*, accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.esv.org/preface/.

and was "prudently corrected" where it departs from them.[288] The Pope's Latin Bible was conformed to the critical editions; the modern Protestant versions are translated from the critical editions. Both now stand on the same foundation.

The circle closed in our own day. In 2023 the Catholic Bishops' Conference of England and Wales announced a new Lectionary for the Mass, in use from Advent 2024, based on "the English Standard Version – Catholic Edition, already in use in India," and approved by the Vatican's Dicastery for Divine Worship.[289] The version many conservative evangelicals consider the most faithful of the modern Bibles was taken into the Mass in a Catholic edition that adds the deuterocanonical books. A Bible built on the Received Text could not be absorbed into Rome so easily. Rome spent four centuries fighting it.

Same Readings, Same Doctrine

History shows the two lines. The text itself confirms them. In each passage below, the King James Bible stands with the Received Text of the Reformation. The Rheims New Testament

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[288] John Paul II, *Scripturarum Thesaurus* (April 25, 1979), accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.vatican.va/content/john-paul-ii/la/apost_constitutions/documents/hf_jp-ii_apc_19790425_scripturarum-thesaurus.html. The translation of the Latin ("quales in hodiernis editionibus, ad criticam rationem exactis, referuntur; prudenter vero ille est emendatus, ubi de iis deflectit") is my own.

[289] Catholic Bishops' Conference of England and Wales, "New Lectionary to Be Launched in England and Wales for Advent 2024," July 24, 2023, https://www.cbcew.org.uk/new-lectionary-to-be-launched-in-england-and-wales-for-advent-2024/.

of 1582 stands with Rome's Latin Vulgate. And the modern version, here represented by the ESV, stands with Rheims.[290]

Matthew 6:13

KJV: "*And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen.*"

Vulgate: "*Et ne nos inducas in tentationem, sed libera nos a malo. Amen.*"

ESV: "*And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil.*"

The Rheims preface called the doxology "trifles." In the Received Text the Lord's Prayer ends by giving the kingdom, the power, and the glory to God alone. In Rome's Bible and in the modern versions it ends without that confession.

Matthew 19:17

KJV: "*Why callest thou me good? there is none good but one, that is, God.*"

Rheims (1582): "*What askest thou me of good? One is good, God.*"

ESV: "*Why do you ask me about what is good? There is only one who is good.*"

In the Received Text the Lord answers the young man who called Him "Good Master" by pressing the question of His own identity: none is good but God, so who does the young man think He is? The Latin reading turns the conversation into a

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[290] Rheims readings are from *Rheims New Testament*, checked against the Latin of the Clementine Vulgate; ESV readings are from the 2016 text.

discussion of "what is good," and the ESV removes the word "God" from the answer altogether.

1 Corinthians 15:47

KJV: *"The first man is of the earth, earthy: the second man is the Lord from heaven."*

Rheims (1582): *"The first man of earth, earthly: the second man from heaven, heavenly."*

ESV: *"The first man was from the earth, a man of dust; the second man is from heaven."*

This is one of the readings the Rheims preface defended by name against the Greek text, claiming that the Greek reading was "an old corruption of Marcion the Heretic."[291] The modern versions agree with Rheims, and the title "Lord" is gone from the second Man.

Ephesians 3:9

KJV: *"…God, who created all things by Jesus Christ."*

Rheims (1582): *"…God, who created all things."*

ESV: *"…God, who created all things."*

The Received Text names Jesus Christ as the agent of creation. Rome's Bible and the modern versions do not.

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[291] "Preface to the Reader," *Rheims New Testament*, 16 (sec. 27).

Colossians 1:14

KJV: *"In whom we have redemption through his blood, even the forgiveness of sins."*

Rheims (1582): *"In whom we have redemption, the remission of sins."*

ESV: *"In whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins."*

The blood of Christ is missing from the Rheims New Testament and from the modern versions in this verse.[292]

1 Timothy 3:16

KJV: *"God was manifest in the flesh."*

Rheims (1582): *"…which was manifested in flesh."*

ESV: *"He was manifested in the flesh."*

The Vulgate reads *quod manifestatum est*, "which was manifested." The change removes the plain statement that God was manifest in the flesh. Here we see where it stands: with Rome's Latin, against the Received Text.

Hebrews 1:3

KJV: *"…when he had by himself purged our sins, sat down on the right hand of the Majesty on high."*

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[292] The words "through his blood" remain in Eph. 1:7 in all these versions. The Clementine Vulgate of 1592, printed ten years after Rheims, has *per sanguinem ejus* at Col. 1:14; the Rheims translators, working from earlier Latin editions, omitted it.

Rheims (1582): *"…making purgation of sins, sitteth on the right hand of the Majesty in the high places."*

ESV: *"After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."*

The words "by himself" declare that Christ purged our sins personally and completely before He sat down. Rome's Mass claims to re-present that sacrifice daily at the hands of a priest. The two words that stand against that claim are missing from Rome's Latin Bible and from the modern versions.

James 5:16

KJV: *"Confess your faults one to another, and pray one for another, that ye may be healed."*

Rheims (1582): *"Confess therefore your sins one to another: and pray one for another, that you may be saved."*

ESV: *"Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed."*

The Received Text reads *paraptōmata* (παραπτώματα), "faults" or "trespasses." The critical text reads *hamartias* (ἁμαρτίας), "sins." The Rheims translators did not hide why the word mattered to them. Their annotation on this verse says that it is "very probable" James "meaneth" sacramental confession, and complains that "the Protestants fleeing from the very word confession in despite of the Sacrament, translate thus, acknowledge your faults one to another."[293] The modern versions give Rome the word she wanted.

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[293] *Rheims New Testament*, annotation on James 5:16.

1 Peter 2:2

KJV: "*As newborn babes, desire the sincere milk of the word, that ye may grow thereby.*"

Rheims (1582): "*…that in it you may grow unto salvation.*"

ESV: "*…that by it you may grow up into salvation.*"

In the Received Text the believer grows by the Word. In Rome's Bible and the modern versions he grows "into salvation." A religion that presents salvation as a lifelong process sustained by sacraments finds a friend in that reading.

Revelation 22:14

KJV: "*Blessed are they that do his commandments, that they may have right to the tree of life.*"

Rheims (1582): "*Blessed are they that wash their stoles: that their power may be in the tree of life.*"

ESV: "*Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life.*"

Wilkinson summarized this verse well: the reading "was changed in the Rheims New Testament. It was restored by the Authorized, and changed back to the Rheims (Jesuit Bible) by the Revised."[294]

These are not the only such passages. Wilkinson listed others, including Matthew 5:44, Luke 2:33, Luke 4:8, Luke 11:2–4, and

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[294] Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 98.

Acts 16:7.[295] Not every reading of Rome's Bible agrees with the critical text. The Clementine Vulgate, for example, contains 1 John 5:7. But in reading after reading that this book has treated as doctrinally significant, Rome's Latin, Rome's English of 1582, and the modern English versions stand together against the Received Text and the King James Bible.

Answering Objections

"Doesn't the King James Bible also agree with the Latin in places such as 1 John 5:7 and Acts 8:37?"

Yes, and this book has said so openly. Those readings reached the printed Received Text through Latin witnesses, and the earlier chapters showed that they are far older than Rome's standardized Bible. Cyprian cited the heavenly witnesses around A.D. 250, and Irenaeus knew the eunuch's confession in the second century. These were readings of the believing Latin churches, not inventions of the papacy. The difference between the two lines is not that one never touches the Latin and the other always does. The difference is authority. The Reformers tested every witness by the Word and received what the churches had used. Rome, at Trent, bound the Word to her Latin. And modern editors reject the old Latin witnesses when they support the Received Text, as at 1 John 5:7, while following the Latin when it agrees with Vaticanus.

"The translators of the ESV, NIV, and NASB are Protestants. Isn't this guilt by association?"

This chapter is not judging the hearts of translators or of the believers who read their work. This book has insisted on that

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[295] Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated*, 92–94.

distinction from the beginning, and it stands. The question is the line of text. The Greek text they translate is, by its own sponsors' description, a joint Protestant–Catholic product. Its readings match Rheims in the places shown above. And Rome has taken one of these versions into her Mass. Cardinal Wiseman saw it coming in 1849: "the principal writers who have avenged the Vulgate … are Protestants."[296] The counterfeit never needed every worker to be a Roman Catholic. Jeroboam's priests were Israelites.

"Edward Hills said the Vulgate moved toward the Traditional Text. Doesn't that undo this chapter?"

Hills was right that the Vulgate agrees with the Traditional Text in many important places. That is exactly how a counterfeit works. It keeps enough of the true to be trusted. But in the readings listed above the Vulgate and Rheims stand with Vaticanus, and the Rheims preface shows Rome's own scholars asking for the very removals that modern editors later made.

"Wasn't Erasmus himself a Roman Catholic priest?"

He was, and he never left the Roman communion. But Erasmus printed the Greek text of the Greek churches, not the Latin of Rome, and Rome's defenders understood what that meant. Hills records that when his Greek New Testament appeared, the Spanish scholar Stunica accused it of being an open condemnation of the Vulgate.[297] God used the text Erasmus printed, not the church Erasmus belonged to. The same God

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[296] Wiseman, "Parables of the New Testament," 104.

[297] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "Erasmus Guided by the Common Faith—Factors Which Influenced Him."

used Cyrus to rebuild His house and put His words in the mouth of Balaam.

But Erasmus was no friend of Rome's system. Years before Luther, he had taught Europe to laugh at its monks, its schoolmen, and its popes. In *The Praise of Folly* he let Folly herself say that, for the princes of the church, "to instruct the people" was "troublesome" and "to interpret the Scripture, Pedantick." Then she went further:

> "As if the Church had any deadlier enemies than wicked Prelates, who not onely suffer Christ to run out of request for want of preaching him, but hinder his spreading by their multitudes of Laws, meerly contriv'd for their own profit, corrupt him by their forc'd Expositions, and murder him by the evil example of their pestilent life."[298]

He wanted the plowboy to have the Bible, too. In the *Paraclesis*, the exhortation to the reader printed at the front of his Greek New Testament in 1516, Erasmus wrote that he strongly disagreed with those who would not have "the divine Scriptures, translated into the common tongue," read by the unlearned, "as if Christ taught things so tangled that they could scarcely be understood by a handful of theologians." Then he added:

> "I would that even the lowliest women read the Gospel and read the epistles of Paul. And would that these were translated into all the languages of all peoples. …

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[298] Desiderius Erasmus, *The Praise of Folly*, trans. John Wilson (1668), ed. Mrs. P. S. Allen (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1913), 147–48. Wilson's seventeenth-century spelling is kept.

> Would that the farmer sang some of it at his plough, that the weaver hummed some of it at his shuttle, that the traveler lightened the weariness of his journey with stories like these!"[299]

Erasmus's farmer at his plough and Tyndale's "boy that driveth the plough" belong to the same hope. Rome went the other way. The Index of forbidden books issued under Pope Pius IV after the Council of Trent allowed a Bible in the common tongue only to those who had written permission from a bishop or inquisitor, and then only in a version made by Catholic authors. Anyone who read or kept one without that permission could not be absolved of his sins until he had handed it over to his bishop.[300]

Rome's own men drew the line from Erasmus to Luther. The Franciscans of Cologne put the charge in Erasmus's own mouth:

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[299] Desiderius Erasmus, *Paraclesis*, in *Ratio seu methodus compendio perveniendi ad veram theologiam* (Basel: Johann Froben, 1520), 184. The *Paraclesis* first appeared in Erasmus's *Novum Instrumentum* (Basel: Johann Froben, 1516). The English is rendered from the Latin (u and v normalized): "Vehementer enim ab istis dissentio, qui nolint ab idiotis legi divinas literas, in vulgi linguam transfusas, sive quasi Christus tam involuta docuerit, ut vix a pauculis theologis possint intelligi. … Optarim ut omnes mulierculae legant evangelium, legant Paulinas epistolas. Atque utinam haec in omnes omnium linguas essent transfusa. … Utinam hinc ad stivam aliquid decantet agricola, hinc nonnihil ad radios suos moduletur textor, huiusmodi fabulis itineris taedium levet viator."

[300] Franz Heinrich Reusch, ed., *Die Indices librorum prohibitorum des sechzehnten Jahrhunderts*, Bibliothek des Litterarischen Vereins in Stuttgart 176 (Tübingen: Litterarischer Verein in Stuttgart, 1886), 248 (Index of Pius IV, 1564, rule 4). The rule ends: "Qui autem absque tali facultate ea legere seu habere praesumpserit, nisi prius Bibliis ordinario redditis, peccatorum absolutionem percipere non possit."

"I laid the egg; Luther hatched it." Erasmus did not deny laying the egg of the Reformation. He answered, "I laid a hen's egg; Luther hatched a chick of a very different kind." Nor would he take back what he had written: "Was I then to say nothing at all about superstition, about sophistry, about false bishops, about bad monks, for fear that someone might carry it where it ought not to go?"[301]

He said as much to a prince. Foxe records that when Frederick the Wise asked his judgment of Luther, Erasmus answered in jest that Luther had committed two great faults: "first, that he would touch the bellies of monks: the second, that he would touch the pope's crown." Then, he told the duke "that reformation was to be wished, and very necessary in the church: and added moreover, that the effect of his doctrine was true," though he wished Luther would write with more moderation.[302]

That is where Erasmus stopped. He always disliked Luther's violence, and in 1524 he wrote against him on the freedom of the will. In the same letter to Caesarius he described his own position: "I went as far as the shore. Am I inconsistent with

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[301] Erasmus to Johann Caesarius, Basel, December 16, 1524, Ep. 1528, lines 11–13, 18–20, in *Opus epistolarum Des. Erasmi Roterodami*, ed. P. S. Allen and H. M. Allen, vol. 5 (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1924), 609. The English is rendered from the Latin: "'Ego peperi ouum, Lutherus exclusit.' … Ego posui ouum gallinaceum, Lutherus exclusit pullum longe dissimillimum. … An ideo tacendum prorsus erat de superstitione, de sophistica, de pseudoepiscopis, de malis monachis, ne quis haec alio rapiat quam oportet?" Allen notes that this "famous utterance of the Franciscans of Cologne is known only from this source."

[302] Foxe, *Acts and Monuments*, 4:263. Foxe names Caspar Peucer's chronicle, bk. 5, as his source and places the conversation at Cologne, shortly after the coronation of the new emperor.

myself if I will not throw myself headlong into the waves?" And again: "I will not stand with a faction; I will not fail the Gospel."[303] He was a reformer who walked to the water's edge and stayed on the sand.

But the egg had been laid, and God brought more out of it than Erasmus intended. Luther translated his German New Testament of 1522 from Erasmus's second edition,[304] and Tyndale's English New Testament of 1526 followed his third.[305] In England, Thomas Bilney bought Erasmus's New Testament, "allured rather by the Latin than by the word of God." He later told the bishop of London what he found in it:

> "At the first reading (as I well remember) I chanced upon this sentence of St. Paul (O most sweet and comfortable sentence to my soul!) in 1 Tim. i., 'It is a true saying, and worthy of all men to be embraced, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; of whom I am the chief and principal.'"[306]

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[303] Allen, *Opus epistolarum*, 5:609, Ep. 1528, lines 15–17, 24–26, 42–43: "Ego processi vsque ad littus. An ideo videor mihi contrarius, si me nolo praecipitem dare in fluctus? … Factioni non adero, Euangelio non deero." The "Diatribe" Erasmus mentions in line 44 is his *De libero arbitrio*, written against Luther, as Allen notes.

[304] Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 7, *Modern Christianity: The German Reformation*, 2nd ed., rev. (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1910), 356.

[305] Scrivener, *Plain Introduction*, 2:186n1.

[306] Thomas Bilney to Cuthbert Tunstall, bishop of London, in Foxe, *Acts and Monuments*, 4:635. Foxe spells the bishop's name "Tonstal."

Bilney brought Hugh Latimer to Christ, and in 1531 he was burned at the stake.[307] Foxe summed it up in the margin of his history: "Erasmus openeth the way before Luther."[308]

Rome gave her verdict after he was dead. In 1559, twenty-three years after Erasmus died at Basel, the Index of Pope Paul IV placed him among the authors whose books were all forbidden: "Desiderius Erasmus of Rotterdam, with all his commentaries, annotations, scholia, dialogues, letters, censures, translations, books and writings, even if they contain nothing at all against religion or about religion."[309] Even the milder Index of 1564 still banned *The Praise of Folly* by name and kept the rest of his religious writings under ban until the theologians of Paris or Louvain had purged them.[310] Rome did not forbid everything he wrote because every page taught heresy. She forbade the man. Erasmus was not Luther. But Rome was right about his influence on the Reformation.

The Two Lines at a Glance

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[307] Foxe, *Acts and Monuments*, 4:621 (Latimer), 4:654–55 (Bilney's death).

[308] Foxe, *Acts and Monuments*, 4:262 (marginal note).

[309] Reusch, *Indices*, 183 (Index of Paul IV, Rome, 1559), under "Auctores, quorum libri et scripta omnia prohibentur": "Desiderius Erasmus Roterodamus cum universis commentariis, annotationibus, scholiis, dialogis, epistolis, censuris, versionibus, libris et scriptis suis, etiam si nil penitus contra religionem vel de religione contineant." On Erasmus's death at Basel in 1536, see Scrivener, *Plain Introduction*, 2:185.

[310] Reusch, *Indices*, 259 (Index of Pius IV, 1564). The same entry also bans the *Colloquies*, the *Lingua*, the *Institution of Christian Marriage*, and *On Forbidding the Eating of Meat*, and allows the *Adages* only with suspect passages removed.

	The line of truth	The counterfeit line
In Scripture	Abel, Isaac, Moses, Jerusalem, the wheat, the Bride	Cain, Ishmael, the magicians of Egypt, Jeroboam's altars, the tares, the Harlot
Key city	Antioch, where the disciples were first called Christians (Acts 11:26)	Alexandria, and then Rome
Greek text	The Traditional (Byzantine) text of the Greek-speaking churches; the Received Text	Codex Vaticanus in the Vatican Library; Codex Sinaiticus; Origen's Hexapla
Early versions	Syriac Peshitta; Old Latin (Itala)	Jerome's Vulgate, made at the command of Damasus of Rome
Keepers	Believing churches; the Greek churches; the persecuted believers of the valleys	The bishop of Rome and his councils (Toulouse, 1229; Trent, 1546)
The common man	"That it may be understood even of the very vulgar" (1611)	"We do not… publish, upon erroneous opinion of necessity, that the Holy Scriptures should always be in our mother tongue" (1582)
English Bibles	Tyndale, Coverdale, Geneva, King James (1611)	Rheims (1582), Douay (1609–10)
Canon	The Hebrew canon received by Christ; the Apocrypha set apart (1611)	The Apocrypha mingled in the codices; canonized at Trent (1546)
Modern descendants	The King James Bible; printed editions of the Received Text	Westcott–Hort (1881); the UBS/Nestle–Aland text; the Nova Vulgata (1979); the ESV–Catholic Edition Lectionary (2024)

Come Out of Her, My People

Edward Hills opened his final chapter with these words: "As Dean Burgon (1883) pointed out, the history of the New Testament text is the history of a conflict between God and Satan." After the Reformation, he wrote, Satan "staged a clever come-back": "Old corrupt manuscripts, which had been discarded by the God-guided usage of the believing Church, were brought out of their hiding places and re-instated."[311] This chapter has shown where those hiding places were. One was the Pope's library.

The answer to this history is not hatred of Roman Catholic people, for "we wrestle not against flesh and blood" (Eph. 6:12). Millions of Roman Catholics, and millions of sincere Protestants who carry modern versions, have never been told any of this. They are the people Tyndale gave his life to reach. The answer is to put the pure Word of God back into their hands, in their own language, where the plowboy can read it.

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[311] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 9, opening section.

The Lord's call to His people concerning Babylon is still the same: "Come out of her, my people, that ye be not partakers of her sins, and that ye receive not of her plagues" (Rev. 18:4). That call includes her Bible.

The war that began in Eden will not end in a scholar's study. It will end as God said: "it shall bruise thy head" (Gen. 3:15). Paul wrote to the church at Rome, "And the God of peace shall bruise Satan under your feet shortly" (Rom. 16:20). Until that day, the incorruptible seed of the Word of God "liveth and abideth for ever" (1 Pet. 1:23), and God has not left His people without it.

THE REVISION OF 1881: HOW THE RECEIVED TEXT WAS SET ASIDE

The year 1881 is the hinge between the King James Bible and every modern English version. Before 1881, the Received Text stood as the Greek New Testament of the English-speaking churches, and the King James Bible stood as their Bible. After 1881, the Greek text of Westcott and Hort became the foundation of the scholars, and nearly every major modern version since has been built upon its line.

The previous chapter looked at the sympathies of Westcott and Hort and at Rome's welcome of their work. This chapter looks at how the revision itself was carried out. As much as possible, the story is told in the words of the men who did it: the revisers' own preface, the published letters of Westcott and Hort, the tract of a Unitarian reviser, and the reply of Dean John William Burgon.

What Convocation Asked For

The revision began in the Convocation of Canterbury, the governing assembly of the clergy of the southern province of the Church of England. The revisers' preface records that it "had its origin in action taken by the Convocation of the Province of Canterbury in February 1870." On May 3 and 5, 1870, Convocation adopted five resolutions. The first two read, "That it is desirable that a revision of the Authorised Version of the Holy Scriptures be undertaken," and "That the revision be so conducted as to comprise both marginal renderings and such emendations as it may be found necessary to insert in the text of the Authorised Version." The third set a clear limit:

> "That in the above resolutions we do not contemplate any new translation of the Bible, or any alteration of the

> language, except where in the judgement of the most competent scholars such change is necessary."[312]

A committee of Convocation then drew up the rules for the work on May 25, 1870. The first rule was "To introduce as few alterations as possible into the Text of the Authorised Version consistently with faithfulness." The fourth rule concerned the Greek: "That the Text to be adopted be that for which the evidence is decidedly preponderating; and that when the Text so adopted differs from that from which the Authorised Version was made, the alteration be indicated in the margin." The fifth rule required a two-thirds majority for any change on the final revision.[313]

Convocation asked for a revision of an English Bible. It did not ask for a new Greek New Testament. Dean Burgon later pointed this out to the chairman of the New Testament company, Bishop Charles Ellicott. The fundamental resolutions of Convocation, he wrote, "contain no authorization whatever for making changes in the Greek Text." The rule about "decidedly preponderating" evidence was one of the principles agreed to by the committee itself, "a Rule of your own making therefore,—for which Convocation neither was nor is responsible."[314]

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[312] "Preface," in *The New Testament of Our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, Translated out of the Greek: Being the Version Set Forth A.D. 1611, Compared with the Most Ancient Authorities and Revised A.D. 1881* (New York: American Book Exchange, 1881), 7.

[313] "Preface," *Revised New Testament*, 8.

[314] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 399–400.

The revisers did not see it that way. Their preface states: "A revision of the Greek text was the necessary foundation of our work." They explained that the fourth rule "was in effect an instruction to follow the authority of documentary evidence without deference to any printed text of modern times."[315] The "printed text of modern times" that stood in their way was the Received Text.

A Revision That Began at the Lord's Table

The New Testament company began its work on June 22, 1870. That morning the revisers gathered in Westminster Abbey, in Henry VII's Chapel, for a service of the Lord's Supper conducted by Dean Arthur Stanley. Among those who received the bread and the cup was George Vance Smith, a Unitarian minister from York, who denied the deity of Jesus Christ and had been appointed to the company.

Hort described the service to his wife the next day: "It was one of the great services of one's life, as you may imagine; very quiet, but singularly impressive. (We owe it all, I find, to Westcott.)" A footnote by his son explains that this was "the Revisers' inaugural Communion Service, which provoked such a violent controversy."[316] A few weeks later Hort wrote to a friend that "the Communion in Henry VII.'s Chapel was one of those few great services which seem to mark points in one's life."[317]

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[315] "Preface," *Revised New Testament*, 9–10.

[316] Hort to his wife, June 23, 1870, in Arthur Fenton Hort, *Life and Letters of Fenton John Anthony Hort*, 2 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1896), 2:135.

[317] Hort to a friend, July 1870, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:136.

Burgon described the same event differently. The Unitarian, he wrote, "was invited to communicate with his fellow-Revisers in Westminster-Abbey, and did accordingly, on the 22nd of June, 1870, receive the Holy Communion, in Henry VII.'s Chapel, at the hands of Dean Stanley: declaring, next day, that he received the Sacrament on this occasion without 'joining in reciting the Nicene Creed' and without 'compromise' (as he expressed it,) of his principles as an 'Unitarian.'" Burgon added that "so conspicuous a sacrilege led to a public Protest signed by some thousands of the Clergy," and that at its next session the Upper House of Convocation passed a resolution clearing itself of complicity in the scandal.[318]

Westcott and Hort did not regret the Unitarian's presence. In August 1870 Hort wrote to Westcott of "the moral damage that would have been done to the acceptance of the Revision by the laity if Unitarians had been outlawed as such." In the same letter he complained that "in England the Trinity seems to have become the merest dogma," and he blamed "that hapless Quicunque vult," the Athanasian Creed, for it. On September 1 he wrote to Lightfoot: "It is, I think, difficult to measure the weight of acceptance won beforehand for the Revision by the single fact of our welcoming an Unitarian."[319]

When the bishops of the Upper House acted again in February 1871, in a way Westcott regarded as a breach of their pledged word to the revisers, he threatened to resign. "Nothing remains but to assert our complete independence of Convocation," he wrote to Hort. "If the Company accept the dictation of

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[318] Burgon, *Revision Revised*, 507.

[319] Hort to Westcott, August 1870, and Hort to J. B. Lightfoot, September 1, 1870, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:140.

Convocation, my work must end."[320] Vance Smith remained. The revision of the English Bible, the Bible that proclaims "God was manifest in the flesh" (1 Tim. 3:16), began with a Communion shared with a man who denied it.

The Secret Text in the Jerusalem Chamber

Westcott and Hort came to the revision with a Greek text already prepared. Hort wrote in July 1870, "Dr. Westcott and myself have for above seventeen years been preparing a Greek text of the New Testament," and he added that "this English revision has decided us to issue the Gospels separately."[321] His son and biographer explains that the revision "made it a necessity to get forward with the Greek Testament Text, in order that the Company might have the use of it: the text of the Gospels was privately printed for use at the early meetings." Later he states plainly: "Each member of the Company had been supplied with a private copy of Westcott and Hort's Text."[322]

Burgon described the same arrangement in sharper terms. The unpublished text of Westcott and Hort, he wrote, "had been confidentially, and under pledges of the strictest secrecy, placed in the hands of every member of the revising Body." The two editors published their text "within five days" of the Revised New Testament itself, and the copy the revisers had used was

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[320] Westcott to Hort, February 16, 1871, in Arthur Westcott, *Life and Letters of Brooke Foss Westcott*, 2 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1903), 1:394. In an earlier letter of July 1870, Westcott had written of the Abbey service, "I don't think that that wonderful Communion will be lost" (1:393).

[321] Hort to a friend, July 1870, in Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:137.

[322] Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:55, 237.

"entrusted to every member of the New Test. company of Revisionists to guide them in their labours,—under pledge that they should neither show nor communicate its contents to any one else."[323] F. H. A. Scrivener confirmed that the text, "or one almost identical with it, had been submitted to the Revisers of the N. T., and to a few other Biblical students, several years before" it was published.[324]

The churches, which had been promised a careful revision of their English Bible, did not see the Greek text that guided it until the work was done.

Hort and Scrivener

Two men in the company understood the manuscripts better than the rest: Hort and Scrivener. Hort's biographer admits that Scrivener's "method of criticism was widely different from Hort's," and that he "was unable to accept the principles afterwards declared in Westcott and Hort's Introduction."[325] The account of the revision given by William Fiddian Moulton, one of the revisers, and preserved in Hort's biography, shows what happened when the two men met:

> "By tacit consent Dr. Scrivener and Dr. Hort were respectively the exponents and advocates of the opposing principles.… So complete was his success in convincing the Company as to the general soundness of his theory, that Dr. Scrivener in later meetings very

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[323] Burgon, *Revision Revised*, xi–xii, 24.

[324] F. H. A. Scrivener, *A Plain Introduction to the Criticism of the New Testament for the Use of Biblical Students*, ed. Edward Miller, 4th ed., 2 vols. (London: George Bell and Sons, 1894), 2:242.

[325] Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:177.

> often contented himself with the bare mention of the less conspicuous readings advocated by Dr. Hort's school, assuming that they would certainly be accepted by the Company."[326]

Burgon's complaint was that the rest of the company, who had not studied the manuscripts, voted on questions they were not equipped to judge. "Certainly they were not entitled individually to an equal voice with Dr. Scrivener in determining what the text should be," he wrote.[327] Hort's biographer, for his part, described the revisers who followed Hort as those who "had been audacious enough to insist that the new translation should not slavishly adhere to the so-called 'Received' Text."[328]

The Result

The Revised New Testament was published on May 17, 1881.[329] In the same year the University Press at Cambridge published Scrivener's edition of the Greek text followed in the Authorized Version, with the revisers' changes noted at the foot of each page. Burgon, working from those notes, reported that "Scrivener counts 5337 various readings," not including marginal notes and changes of punctuation.[330] Earlier in this book we saw D. A. Waite's count of the differences between the Received Text and the full Westcott–Hort text: 5,604 places. By

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[326] Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:237.

[327] Burgon, *Revision Revised*, 503.

[328] Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:238.

[329] Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:234.

[330] Burgon, *Revision Revised*, 405; F. H. A. Scrivener, ed., *The New Testament in the Original Greek according to the Text Followed in the Authorised Version, Together with the Variations Adopted in the Revised Version* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1881).

either count, a committee asked to make "as few alterations as possible" to the English Bible had changed the Greek beneath it in thousands of places.

Later in this book we will look at what those changes did to particular verses.

A Unitarian's Verdict

In the same year the Revised New Testament appeared, George Vance Smith published a tract through the British and Foreign Unitarian Association called *Texts and Margins of the Revised New Testament Affecting Theological Doctrine Briefly Reviewed*. He began his conclusion by noting that "it has been frequently said that the changes of translation which the work contains are of little importance from a doctrinal point of view;—in other words, that the great doctrines of popular theology remain unaffected, untouched by the results of the revision." He answered: "To the writer any such statement appears to be in the most substantial sense contrary to the facts of the case."[331]

Among his reasons, Smith listed that "the only passage in the New Testament which seemed like a statement of the doctrine of the Trinity, has been removed by the revisers as spurious," referring to 1 John 5:7, and that "one remarkable instance in which the epithet 'God' was given to Christ (1 Tim. iii. 16) has been excluded from the text."[332] Then he asked:

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[331] G. Vance Smith, *Texts and Margins of the Revised New Testament Affecting Theological Doctrine Briefly Reviewed* (London: British and Foreign Unitarian Association, 1881), 45.

[332] Smith, *Texts and Margins*, 45–46.

> "The changes just enumerated are manifestly of great importance, and are they not wholly unfavourable to the popular theology?"[333]

By "the popular theology" Smith meant the doctrine of the Trinity and the deity of Christ. A Unitarian who sat on the revision committee did not think the changes were minor. He thought they helped his cause, and he said so in print.

Burgon's Answer

The strongest reply came from John William Burgon, Dean of Chichester, in three long articles in the *Quarterly Review* in 1881 and 1882. In 1883 he published them together, with a reply to Bishop Ellicott's defense of the revisers, as *The Revision Revised*. In his preface Burgon summarized his case: the new Greek text, "which, in defiance of their instructions, the Revisionists of 'the Authorized English Version' had been so ill-advised as to spend ten years in elaborating,—was a wholly untrustworthy performance: was full of the gravest errors from beginning to end: had been constructed throughout on an entirely mistaken Theory."[334]

Westcott and Hort chose not to answer him. Hort's biographer wrote that Hort "did indeed read and annotate carefully his copy of The Revision Revised, but decided eventually to leave the issue to time."[335] Earlier chapters of this book have drawn on Burgon repeatedly. The two editors whose text he examined

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[333] Smith, *Texts and Margins*, 47.

[334] Burgon, *Revision Revised*, xi.

[335] Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:242.

never answered him in print, and his case, like the Received Text itself, was set aside by the weight of scholarly opinion.

From 1881 to the Modern Versions

The Revised Version itself never displaced the King James Bible in the churches and homes of the English-speaking world. Hort's own biographer, writing in 1896, admitted that "even now it seems premature to forecast what will be the ultimate fate of the Revised Version."[336] But the Greek text behind it lived on, and so did the line of English revisions that began with it.

The modern versions trace their own descent from 1881. The preface to the English Standard Version places it in a stream marked by "the King James Version of 1611 (KJV), the English Revised Version of 1885 (RV), the American Standard Version of 1901 (ASV), and the Revised Standard Version of 1952 and 1971 (RSV)," and states that "the 1971 RSV text" provided "the starting point for our work."[337] The Lockman Foundation's own account of the New American Standard Bible likewise begins with the English Revised Version and "its American counterpart, the American Standard Version," published in 1901.[338] By their own account, the ESV and the NASB descend from the Revised Version, and the Greek text of Westcott and

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[336] Hort, *Life and Letters*, 2:236.

[337] "Preface," *English Standard Version*, accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.esv.org/preface/.

[338] Lockman Foundation, "New American Standard Bible (NASB Bible) – Accuracy, History, Updates," accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.lockman.org/new-american-standard-bible-nasb/.

Hort that guided the revisers remains, in substance, the Nestle–Aland text from which they are translated.

1611 and 1881

Set the two revisions side by side. In 1611 the translators worked in companies, sent their work from company to company for review, and wrote that they never thought they should need "to make a new translation, nor yet to make of a bad one a good one; but to make a good one better." They translated the Hebrew and Greek texts that the churches had received and used for centuries. Their Bible was received by the churches for three hundred years.

In 1881 the revisers were told to make as few changes as possible and made thousands. They were asked to revise an English Bible and replaced its Greek text. They began with a Communion shared with a Unitarian and worked from a Greek text handed to them in private by two men who had spent years preparing it. A Unitarian reviser argued in print that the changes were "wholly unfavourable to the popular theology," and the leading defender of the Traditional Text of the day called the result "a wholly untrustworthy performance."

The Lord Jesus said, "Every plant, which my heavenly Father hath not planted, shall be rooted up" (Matt. 15:13), and "by their fruits ye shall know them" (Matt. 7:20). The fruit of 1611 was a Bible that the English-speaking churches read, preached, memorized, and carried around the world. The fruit of 1881 was a Greek text that has been revised in every generation since, and a family of English versions that have never stopped changing.

ONE TEXT, MANY TONGUES: THE RECEIVED TEXT IN THE BIBLES OF THE REFORMATION

> "Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen." (Matt. 28:19-20)

The earlier chapters followed the Received Text into the English of the King James Bible and then watched the revisers of 1881 set it aside. A natural question follows, and critics often press it as an objection. What about everyone else? If God preserved His words and brought them to their purified form in English in the King James Bible, what did the believers of Germany, France, Spain, Italy, the Netherlands, Bohemia, and Hungary read? Was the Received Text an English peculiarity, a text that only the English-speaking world ever cared about?

History answers that question plainly. In the century of the Reformation and the generation after it, the Protestant churches of Europe put the Bible into their own languages. With remarkable consistency they translated the Old Testament from the Hebrew text the Jews had preserved and the New Testament from the same printed Greek text, the text of Erasmus, Stephanus, and Beza. Where a nation's first Protestant Bible was made from Luther's German, as in Scandinavia, it still rested on that Greek text, because Luther's New Testament did. The King James Bible was not a lonely English exception. It was one member of a large family, the Bibles of the Reformation, and they were translated from the same Received Text.

As in the rest of this book, three things must be kept separate: what Scripture says, what history records, and the conclusions this book draws from both. Scripture does not name Luther, Reina, or the Synod of Dort. It does tell us that the gospel was to be preached to "all nations," and that the words of the Lord would not pass away (Matt. 24:35). History shows which Bible those nations received when the Reformation gave them the Scriptures in their own tongues.

The Lord Gave the Word

One passage in Revelation describes what happened in the sixteenth century better than any historian could:

> "And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write; These things saith he that is holy, he that is true, he that hath the key of David, he that openeth, and no man shutteth; and shutteth, and no man openeth; I know thy works: behold, I have set before thee an open door, and no man can shut it: for thou hast a little strength, and hast kept my word, and hast not denied my name." (Rev. 3:7-8)

In the chapter on preservation, we saw that God was not defeated by the division of languages. At Pentecost the hearers said, "we do hear them speak in our tongues the wonderful works of God" (Acts 2:11). The Reformation was not Pentecost, and no one in the sixteenth century received a gift of tongues. But it was one of the great seasons in which God carried His Word across the barrier of language. Within a few generations the Scriptures were printed in German, French, Spanish, Italian, Dutch, Czech, Hungarian, Danish, Swedish, Icelandic, Finnish, and Welsh. The company of those who published the Word was great indeed (Psa. 68:11).

What matters for the argument of this book is not only that these Bibles were made, but what they were made from. A translation can be no better than the text beneath it. If the Bibles of the Reformation had been translated from texts as different as the Received Text and the modern critical text, the King James position would stand alone. They were not. They stood together. The Reformation was the product of these pure texts that were handed down, copied, and preached. The same texts used in the making of the King James Bible.

One Greek Testament on Every Reformer's Desk

The reason is simple. The Reformation came at the same moment as the printing of the Greek New Testament, and for the whole period in which these Bibles were made, one printed Greek text was in common use. Erasmus published the first edition at Basel in 1516 and revised it four times. Robert Stephanus reprinted the text at Paris and Geneva, adding readings from other manuscripts in his margin, and his edition of 1551 was the first to divide the text into numbered verses. Theodore Beza, Calvin's successor at Geneva, published edition after edition from 1565 to 1604.[339] As an earlier chapter showed, these editions differ from one another only in small matters. They are one text, the Received Text, in a family of printings.

The Old Testament followed the same pattern. The translators worked from printed editions of the Hebrew text that the Jews had kept, and the Venice edition of Jacob ben Chayyim (1524–

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[339] Bruce M. Metzger and Bart D. Ehrman, *The Text of the New Testament: Its Transmission, Corruption, and Restoration*, 4th ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), 142–52.

25), discussed in an earlier chapter, became the standard printed Hebrew Bible.

This means that a translator in Wittenberg, Geneva, Leiden, or a village in Moravia, sitting down to put the Scriptures into his own language, had the same Hebrew and the same Greek before him. The variety of the Reformation Bibles lay in their languages, not in their texts.

Germany: Luther's September Testament

Martin Luther began translating the New Testament at the end of 1521, while he was hidden in the Wartburg castle. On January 13, 1522, he wrote to his friend Nicholas von Amsdorf: "Meanwhile I am translating the Bible, though I have undertaken a task beyond my strength." The New Testament was in type by September 1522 and was published at Wittenberg without the name of the printer or the translator, which is why it is remembered as the "September Testament." The Old Testament followed in parts, and the first complete Bible appeared in 1534. For the New Testament Luther used the second edition of Erasmus (1519); for the Old Testament he used the Hebrew Bible printed at Brescia in 1494.[340]

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[340] Eberhard Nestle, "Bible Versions: German Versions," in *The New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia of Religious Knowledge*, ed. Samuel Macauley Jackson, vol. 2 (New York: Funk and Wagnalls, 1908), 145. On Luther's use of Erasmus's second edition, see also Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, vol. 7, *Modern Christianity: The German Reformation*, 2nd ed., rev. (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1910), 356.

Luther's Bible did not stay in Germany. Eberhard Nestle, the editor whose name the modern critical text still bears, wrote of it:

> "It formed the basis of the Danish translation of 1524, of the Swedish and Dutch of 1528, of the Icelandic of 1540, and, through the mediation of Tyndale, influenced the English Authorized Version of 1611."[341]

Although Luther did not print 1 John 5:7 in his New Testament, the German Bible, like the English Bible, was not frozen at its first edition, and the churches that used Luther's Bible restored the verse. Nestle records that it "was first introduced into a Frankfort edition of 1575, into a Wittenberg impression in 1596."[342] Within fifty years of Luther's death, the Bible printed in Luther's own city read at 1 John 5:7 as the Received Text and the King James Bible read. The case for that verse, set out in the FAQ section of this book, does not rest on Luther's inclusion or leaving out of this verse. But the German history shows the same refining process this book has traced in English.

France and the Valleys

An earlier chapter told how the Waldenses of the Alpine valleys joined the Reformation in 1532 and resolved to publish a Bible in French. Pierre Robert Olivétan's Bible was printed in 1535 at Serrières, near Neuchâtel, "at the expense of the

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[341] Nestle, "German Versions," 145.

[342] Nestle, "German Versions," 146.

Waldensians."[343] The persecuted line paid for the first Protestant Bible in French out of its own poverty.

That Bible was revised by the pastors of Geneva, with Beza's help, in 1588, and it became the parent of the French Protestant Bibles that followed. The revisions of David Martin (New Testament 1696, whole Bible 1707) and of Jean-Frédéric Ostervald (1724 and 1744) stood in its line, and Ostervald's became the standard French Protestant version, adopted and reissued by the British and Foreign Bible Society.[344] The Geneva Bible Society, which today publishes a modern French version, still says of the Received Text that it "served as the basis of numerous translations, including the English Authorised Version (or King James Version) published in 1611 and, in French, that of Jean-Frédéric Ostervald (1744)."[345]

Spain: The Bible of the Bear

No Reformation Bible was bought at a higher price than the Spanish. Spain was the land of the Inquisition, and in 1551 the Inquisitor-General, Fernando de Valdés, published an index that prohibited "Bibles (New and Old Testaments) in the Spanish or other vernacular." That prohibition stood until 1778.[346]

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[343] Samuel Berger, "Bible Versions: French Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:142.

[344] Berger, "French Versions," 2:142–43.

[345] Société biblique de Genève, "Histoire de la traduction," Univers de la Bible, accessed October 1, 2026, https://universdelabible.net/la-traduction/histoire-de-la-traduction/. The translation from the French is my own.

[346] Georg Rietschel, "Bible Reading by the Laity, Restrictions on," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:87.

Even so, the Word found its way into Seville. In the 1550s small circles of believers met there to study the Scriptures, and one of them was in the Hieronymite monastery of San Isidoro del Campo, just outside the city. Books came to them by smuggling. Julián Hernández, called "Julianillo" because he was small and hunchbacked, carried Protestant books into Spain, and the monastery served as a storehouse for some of them. On October 7, 1557, as he was moving books into Seville, the Inquisition discovered him. Under torture he named many of those who attended the Bible studies of the city, and within months the arrests had broken up the Protestant circles of Seville. On December 22, 1560, after more than three years in the hands of the Inquisition, Julián Hernández was led to the auto-da-fé and burned.[347]

Some of the monks of San Isidoro escaped in time. Between the summer and autumn of 1557, Casiodoro de Reina fled the monastery for Geneva, as many of his companions did.[348] In April 1562 the Inquisition condemned him and burned him in effigy at an auto-da-fé in the main square of Seville.[349] He spent

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[347] Jonatán Orozco Cruz, "Julián Hernández (pp. s. XVI–1560)," La Reforma en Sevilla 1517–2017, Universidad Pablo de Olavide, accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.upo.es/lareformaensevilla/julian-hernandez/.

[348] Jonatán Orozco Cruz, "Casiodoro de Reina (1520–1594)," La Reforma en Sevilla 1517–2017, Universidad Pablo de Olavide, accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.upo.es/lareformaensevilla/casiodoro-de-reina/.

[349] Ruben Dominguez-Martinez, "Casiodoro de Reina, Translator and Publisher of First Complete Spanish Bible," Lutheran Church—Missouri Synod, accessed September 1, 2026, https://resources.lcms.org/reading-study/casiodoro-de-reina-translator-and-publisher-of-first-complete-spanish-bible/.

the rest of his life in exile, in Geneva, London, Frankfurt, Strasbourg, and Antwerp, and he died at Frankfurt in 1594.[350]

At the end of 1569 Reina's Bible was printed at Basel. Its title page carried the picture of a bear reaching for honey, and Spanish speakers still call it the *Biblia del Oso*, the Bible of the Bear. In his preface, the "Amonestación," Reina explained how he had worked. He had not made the Latin Vulgate his rule, "although we consulted it as we did any of the other copies we had." Instead, "we drew as near as we could to the fountain of the Hebrew text (since without any controversy it is the first authority)."[351]

For the New Testament Reina worked from the printed Greek of his day, along with the Latin and vernacular versions he could obtain. Peter Hasbrouck, comparing his readings with the Greek editions then in print, found Reina agreeing almost equally with the Paris and Geneva editions of Colinaeus (1534), Stephanus (1551), and Beza (1565). Hasbrouck cautions that it is "difficult to identify a singular source with a high degree of certainty," but he concludes that "Reina marks a shift from the Erasmine tradition to the Beza text."[352]

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[350] Orozco Cruz, "Casiodoro de Reina."

[351] Casiodoro de Reina, "Amonestación del intérprete de los sacros libros al lector," in *La Biblia del Oso: Según la traducción de Casiodoro de Reina publicada en Basilea en el año 1569*, ed. Juan Guillén Torralba (Madrid: Alfaguara, 1987), 9, quoted in Juan Luis Monreal Pérez, "Biblismo, lengua vernácula y traducción en Casiodoro de Reina y Cipriano de Valera," *Hikma* 13 (2014): 84. The translations from the Spanish of Reina and Valera in this chapter are my own.

[352] Peter W. Hasbrouck, "Enzinas to Valera: Motives, Methods and Sources in Sixteenth-Century Spanish Bible Translation" (PhD diss., Boston University, 2015), 268.

Reina's principles of translation would have satisfied the King James translators. He tied himself to the text: "With all the diligence that has been possible to us we have endeavored to bind ourselves to the text without taking away from it or adding to it." Where words had to be supplied for sense, he marked them so that no reader would mistake them for the text itself. No version he knew, he said, showed "more diligence in having marked them all in a different letter from that of the common text."[353] That is the same principle that gave the King James Bible its italic words. And where the polish of Spanish style and the wording of the Hebrew pulled in different directions, Reina chose the text. He retained the Hebrew forms of speech wherever they could be understood,

> "…even though in this we should sin somewhat against the polish of the Spanish language, holding it a lesser evil to sin against it, even if it were much, than to sin even a little against the integrity of the text."[354]

Reina even proposed how a Bible ought to be made. If kings and pastors wished to give their people the Scriptures, he wrote, the work should be committed "not to one or to a few, but to ten or twelve men chosen from among the most learned and godly of all the universities and churches of the kingdom," who would diligently "consult the Hebrew text in the Old Testament and the Greek in the New, and all the versions that could be had."[355] A generation later King James committed the

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[353] Reina, "Amonestación," 11, quoted in Monreal Pérez, "Biblismo," 86.

[354] Reina, "Amonestación," 18, quoted in Monreal Pérez, "Biblismo," 87.

[355] Reina, "Amonestación," 22–23, quoted in Monreal Pérez, "Biblismo," 89–90.

English Bible to companies of the most learned men of Oxford, Cambridge, and Westminster.

Cipriano de Valera had also been a monk of San Isidoro, and he too fled. After Geneva he settled in England, studied at Cambridge and Oxford, and spent some twenty years revising Reina's Bible. His revision was printed at Amsterdam in 1602.[356] Valera kept the Apocrypha, but he took what Hasbrouck calls "the radical step of placing the Apocryphal books in a section apart after the Prophets," and he moved his New Testament still closer to Beza: in Hasbrouck's sample, Valera agrees with Beza's Greek text of 1590 "a total of twenty-one time[s] indicating a clear shift to the Bezan text."[357] Valera knew what that Bible had cost. In his preface he listed the Spanish Scriptures that had gone before it, among them the New Testament of Juan Pérez:

> "Dr. Juan Pérez, of pious memory, printed the New Testament in the year 1556, and one Julián Hernández, moved with zeal to do good to his nation, carried a great many of these Testaments and distributed them in Seville in the year 1557. Juan Pérez, Casiodoro, and Julián I knew, and dealt with them as friends."[358]

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[356] Natalia Maillard Álvarez, "Cipriano de Valera (¿1532?–16??)," La Reforma en Sevilla 1517–2017, Universidad Pablo de Olavide, accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.upo.es/lareformaensevilla/cipriano-de-valera-1532-16/.

[357] Hasbrouck, "Enzinas to Valera," 153, 268.

[358] Cipriano de Valera, "Exhortación al cristiano lector a leer la sagrada Escritura," in *La Biblia* (Amsterdam, 1602), quoted in Monreal Pérez, "Biblismo," 80.

Valera did not soften his judgment of the system that had burned his friend. In 1588 he grieved that his own nation allowed itself "to be governed, trampled, and tyrannized by the Pope, the man of sin, the son of perdition, the Antichrist."[359] "The man of sin, the son of perdition" are the words of 2 Thessalonians 2:3, and the King James translators would use the first of those titles for Rome in their dedication to the king.[360]

The Reina-Valera Bible, as it came to be called, became the Bible of Spanish-speaking evangelicals and remains the most widely read version among them.[361] Its most widely used modern revision, that of 1960, has not kept the Received Text in every place. At 1 Peter 2:2 it reads "para que por ella crezcáis para salvación," "that by it ye may grow unto salvation," the reading of the Rheims New Testament discussed in an earlier chapter. At Matthew 15:8 it leaves out the words the King James Bible translates, "draweth nigh unto me with their mouth."[362] The heirs of Reina and Valera have not been spared the pressure that produced the English Revised Version.

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[359] Cipriano de Valera, *Dos tratados* (London, 1588), quoted in Maillard Álvarez, "Cipriano de Valera."

[360] 2 Thess. 2:3; "The Epistle Dedicatory," in *The Holy Bible* (London: Robert Barker, 1611), which speaks of a blow given "unto that man of sin, as will not be healed."

[361] Ruben Dominguez-Martinez, "Casiodoro de Reina, Translator and Publisher of First Complete Spanish Bible," Lutheran Church—Missouri Synod, accessed October 1, 2026, https://resources.lcms.org/reading-study/casiodoro-de-reina-translator-and-publisher-of-first-complete-spanish-bible/.

[362] *Santa Biblia: Reina-Valera 1960*, 1 Pet. 2:2; Matt. 15:8, accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.biblegateway.com/passage/?search=1%20Pedro%202%3A2&version=RVR1960; compare KJV, 1 Pet. 2:2; Matt. 15:8.

Italy: Diodati of Geneva

The Italian Protestant Bible was also born in exile. Giovanni Diodati was born at Geneva on June 3, 1576, the son of Carlo Diodati, a patrician of Lucca who had fled to Geneva for the sake of his faith in 1567. In 1597, at the age of twenty-one, he became professor of Hebrew at the Academy of Geneva, and two years later he began teaching theology as well. He published his Italian Bible in 1607 and a revised edition with notes in 1641, and the Italian Reformed churches used it into the twentieth century.[363] Samuel Berger described Diodati's version as "made directly from the original texts" and wrote that it "stands in high esteem for fidelity and has been repeatedly reprinted by different Bible societies." He contrasted it with the Roman Catholic Italian Bible of Antonio Martini, an elegant version but "by no means as faithful because made from the Vulgate."[364]

The Netherlands: A Bible Ordered at Dort

The clearest window into how the Reformation churches thought about the Bible and its translation is the Synod of Dort. The synod met at Dordrecht in the autumn of 1618, with delegates from the Dutch churches and from Reformed churches abroad, to settle the controversy with the Arminians, and it is remembered for the Canons of Dort. But the first business the synod took up was not predestination. It was the

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[363] Emidio Campi, "Diodati, Giovanni," in *Dizionario storico della Svizzera*, version of July 5, 2004, accessed October 1, 2026, https://hls-dhs-dss.ch/it/articles/011103/2004-07-05/.

[364] Samuel Berger, "Bible Versions: Italian Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:149.

Bible. In seven sessions, from November 19 to 27, 1618, it laid the foundation of a new Dutch translation.[365]

The president of the synod, Johannes Bogerman, opened the subject by contrasting the Dutch churches with the churches abroad. Other nations, as C. C. de Bruin summarizes his address, had excellent translations made directly from the original texts, and among them Bogerman praised especially "the English Bible, the Italian of Deodati, and the German of Piscator." The Dutch had only "a defective translation at second hand," a version made from Luther's German rather than from the Hebrew and Greek.[366]

The British delegates understood which English Bible he meant. On the morning of November 20, in the synod's seventh session, they laid before the synod a written account of how the King James Bible had been made, "since honourable mention has been made of the very accurate English translation lately set forth, with great care and at great expense, by the most Serene King James." They described the six companies of translators, the review of the whole by "twelve delegates, chosen from them all," and the final revision before printing. Then they set out the

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[365] C. C. de Bruin, "De totstandkoming en het karakter der Statenvertaling," in *De Statenbijbel en zijn voorgangers* (Leiden: A. W. Sijthoff, 1937), reproduced as "Totstandkoming en karakter Statenvertaling (1)," Statenvertaling.nl, accessed October 1, 2026, https://statenvertaling.nl/geschiedenis/sv-totstandkoming-debruin1.html. The translations from the Dutch in this chapter are my own.

[366] de Bruin, "Totstandkoming en karakter Statenvertaling (1)."

rules the translators had followed. The first is worth reading carefully in a book about purification:[367]

> "In the first place caution was given that an entirely new version was not to be furnished, but an old version, long received by the Church, to be purged from all blemishes and faults; to this end there was to be no departure from the ancient translation, unless the truth of the original text or emphasis demanded."[368]

Other rules kept the margin for parallel passages and alternate renderings rather than commentary, and required "that words which it was anywhere necessary to insert into the text to complete the meaning were to be distinguished by another type, small roman."[369] Among the British delegates who presented this account was Samuel Ward of Cambridge. He had served in the King James translating company, and Pollard identifies him as "one of the revisers."[370] A King James

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[367] *Acta of Handelingen der Nationale Synode . . . te Dordrecht . . . 1618 en 1619*, in modern spelling under the supervision of J. H. Donner and S. A. van den Hoorn, session 7 (November 20, 1618), consulted in the English translation by David Jonescue, accessed October 1, 2026, https://reformedbooksonline.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/10/Acts-of-the-Synod-of-Dort.pdf; Alfred W. Pollard, ed., *Records of the English Bible: The Documents Relating to the Translation and Publication of the Bible in English, 1525–1611* (London: Oxford University Press, 1911), 338. Pollard prints the Latin text of the report (336–37) followed by an English translation (338–39).

[368] Pollard, *Records of the English Bible*, 339.

[369] Pollard, *Records of the English Bible*, 339.

[370] Pollard, *Records of the English Bible*, 56; Alexander W. McClure, *The Translators Revived: A Biographical Memoir of the Authors of the English Version of the Holy Bible* (New York: Charles Scribner, 1853;

translator stood before the Synod of Dort and explained to the Dutch churches how the English Bible had been made.

That afternoon, in the eighth session, the synod resolved that a new translation from the original languages was not only profitable for the Dutch churches but necessary. The rules it gave its translators read like a description of the King James Bible. They were to keep carefully to the original text, retaining the Hebrew and Greek manner of speaking as far as the clarity and character of the Dutch language would allow, and where Dutch idiom required a freer rendering, to give the literal sense in the margin. Words added to complete the sense were to be kept as few as possible and distinguished from the text by brackets and a different type.[371]

The synod also debated the Apocrypha. Franciscus Gomarus wanted the books left out altogether as merely human writings, and the Genevan delegate Diodati took his side, calling the apocryphal books smoking lamps beside the clear light of the canonical Scriptures. The synod compromised. The Apocrypha would be translated, but placed after the New Testament as an appendix, under a separate title page, with a preface warning readers of their errors, in smaller type, and with separate page numbers.[372]

Six translators were chosen: Johannes Bogerman, Willem Baudartius, and Gerson Bucerus for the Old Testament, and Jacobus Rolandus, Hermannus Faukelius, and Petrus Cornelisz

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repr., LutheranLibrary.org, 2020), 100, 102, 113. Page numbers for McClure in this chapter follow the Lutheran Library reprint.

[371] *Acta of Handelingen der Nationale Synode*, session 8 (November 20, 1618); de Bruin, "Totstandkoming en karakter Statenvertaling (1)."

[372] de Bruin, "Totstandkoming en karakter Statenvertaling (1)."

for the New Testament and the Apocrypha.[373] War and politics delayed the work for years, but the translation was finished in 1632, revised, and published in 1637.[374] It is called the *Statenvertaling* or *Statenbijbel*, the States Bible, because it was made under the authority of the States General.

What text did the Dutch translators use? For the Old Testament they worked from the Masoretic Hebrew, probably in one of the Venetian printings that included the comments of the rabbis and the Aramaic paraphrase. For the New Testament they chose as their starting point the Greek New Testament of Beza, in the edition of 1588–89, while remaining free to consult other editions, so that readings from Erasmus and Robert Stephanus also appear.[375] That is exactly how the King James translators worked: from Beza and Stephanus, weighing the editions of the Received Text against one another. And the translators' own working manuscripts, preserved in the synodal archive at The Hague, show what other Bibles they kept beside them. De Bruin lists among them "the English Authorized Version, the French Bible of Geneva, the German translation of Zurich, the Italian of Deodati, the Spanish of Cyprianus de Valera, and the German Bible of Piscator."[376] At the translators' tables in Leiden, the

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[373] de Bruin, "Totstandkoming en karakter Statenvertaling (1)."

[374] Eberhard Nestle, "Bible Versions: Dutch Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:136.

[375] C. C. de Bruin, "De totstandkoming en het karakter der Statenvertaling," reproduced as "Totstandkoming en karakter Statenvertaling (2)," Statenvertaling.nl, accessed October 1, 2026, https://statenvertaling.nl/geschiedenis/sv-totstandkoming-debruin2.html.

[376] de Bruin, "Totstandkoming en karakter Statenvertaling (2)."

King James Bible, the Diodati, and the Reina-Valera lay side by side, because they were translations of the same text.

The States Bible served the Dutch Reformed churches for three centuries. Even the Netherlands Bible Society, which publishes the modern Dutch versions, says plainly today: "That older source text of the States translators is called the Textus Receptus."[377]

Bohemia and Hungary

In Bohemia and Moravia the heirs of John Hus, the Unity of the Brethren, made their own Bible. Jan Blahoslav translated the New Testament "from the original Greek" (1564, 1568), and a company of the Brethren's scholars translated the Old Testament from the Hebrew. The whole was printed in six parts between 1579 and 1593 at Kralice in Moravia and is known as the Kralice Bible. Then the Counter-Reformation came. After the Protestant defeat of 1620, as A. Leskien wrote, "the publication of non-Catholic Bibles in Bohemia and Moravia ceased."[378]

In Hungary, Gáspár Károli, a pupil of Melanchthon and pastor at Gönc, translated the whole Bible and published it at Vizsoly in 1590.[379] In his preface he gave the reason. God wills, he wrote, "not only that the priests read the Holy Scripture and the common people hear it from their mouths, but He also wills

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[377] Nederlands Bijbelgenootschap, "Nieuw: info over de brontekst van het Nieuwe Testament op debijbel.nl," May 15, 2018, accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.debijbel.nl/berichten/nieuw-info-over-de-brontekst-van-het-nieuwe-testament-op-debijbel-nl.

[378] A. Leskien, "Bible Versions: Slavonic Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:154.

[379] F. Balogh, "Bible Versions: Hungarian (Magyar) Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:148.

that the books of the Old and New Testament be in the language of every nation, and that all read them and turn them over—poor and rich, small and great, men and women—for God wills to save men of every rank alike." He would not bind himself to the Latin Vulgate, which Rome had made its official Bible, and where he departed from it he appealed to the Hebrew and Greek texts. Rome, he charged, had "in many places cut the old Bible to fit the papal doctrine, as in Genesis 3, so that they might prove the intercession and invocation of Mary." He gave another example from the next chapter. In Genesis 4:8 the Vulgate has Cain say to Abel, "Let us go out," and Károli objected that "this is not in the true letter," that is, in the Hebrew.[380]

The King James Bible follows the Hebrew there: "And Cain talked with Abel his brother: and it came to pass, when they were in the field, that Cain rose up against Abel his brother, and slew him" (Gen. 4:8). The New International Version has restored the words Károli rejected: "Now Cain said to his brother Abel, 'Let's go out to the field.'" Its own footnote concedes that the "Masoretic Text does not have 'Let's go out to the field.'"[381] A Hungarian Reformer in 1590 recognized a Latin addition that a popular English version prints today.

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[380] Gáspár Károli, preface to the Vizsoly Bible (1590), quoted in "Károli-Biblia," in *Magyar Katolikus Lexikon*, ed. István Diós (Budapest: Szent István Társulat), online edition, accessed October 1, 2026, https://lexikon.katolikus.hu/K/K%C3%A1roli-Biblia.html. The translations from Károli's Hungarian are my own.

[381] *The Holy Bible, New International Version* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2011), Gen. 4:8 and note, accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.biblegateway.com/passage/?search=Genesis%204%3A8&version=NIV.

Writing in 1908, F. Balogh said that the Vizsoly Bible "has remained in use to the present." He also recorded the fate of a later Hungarian Protestant Bible, the translation of György Komáromi Csipkés. In 1718 the city of Debrecen had four thousand copies of it printed at Leiden. When the books reached the frontier, the Jesuits, who had obtained a royal order, seized them. The bishop of Eger later shut them in damp cellars, and on November 1, 1754, he burned them in the courtyard of his palace before a large gathering.[382]

The North and the West

The Scandinavian Bibles came through Luther. Denmark's first complete Bible (1550) followed, by royal instruction, "as much as possible Luther's version." Sweden's Bible of 1540–41, "made after Luther's, was for a long time the church Bible of Sweden," and the Icelandic Bible of Bishop Gudbrand Thorlakson (1584) was likewise translated "after Luther's version."[383] In Finland, Michael Agricola, who had come to know Luther at Wittenberg, published the Finnish New Testament in 1548, and the whole Finnish Bible followed in 1642.[384] Because Luther's New Testament was made from Erasmus, these Bibles of the north rested on the Received Text as well.

Not every churchman welcomed them. When King Gustavus Vasa asked for a Swedish New Testament, Bishop Hans Brask

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[382] Balogh, "Hungarian Versions," 2:148.

[383] J. Belsheim, "Bible Versions: Scandinavian Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:151–52.

[384] J. Belsheim, "Bible Versions: Finnish and Lappish Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:141.

of Linköping objected that "it were better for Paul to have been burned, than to be known by every one."[385]

In Wales, Parliament ordered under Queen Elizabeth that the Bible be translated into Welsh. The New Testament appeared in 1567 and the whole Bible in 1588. Bishop Richard Parry revised it in 1620, and "all later issues follow Parry's revised text."[386] The translator of the 1588 Bible, William Morgan, gave the Welsh people far more than a book. The *Dictionary of Welsh Biography* says of him, "His work marks the real beginnings of the literature and Protestantism of modern Wales."[387]

Portugal and the East Indies

The Portuguese Bible was born farther from home than any other. João Ferreira de Almeida was born about 1628 at Torre de Tavares in Portugal and went out to the East Indies as a boy. In 1642, at about fourteen, he read a Spanish Protestant pamphlet and joined the Reformed church. He soon began translating the New Testament into Portuguese, first from the Spanish versions of Reina and Valera and then from Beza's Latin. Later, as he himself said, he consulted the Dutch States Bible and revised his translation on the basis of the Greek Received Text. He served the Portuguese-speaking congregations of the Dutch Reformed Church in the East and spent his last years as a minister at Batavia, on Java. His New Testament was printed at Amsterdam in 1681. Almeida had translated most of the Old

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[385] Belsheim, "Scandinavian Versions," 2:152.

[386] H. Zimmer, "Bible Versions: Celtic Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:136.

[387] Glanmor Williams, "Morgan, William (1545–1604)," in *Dictionary of Welsh Biography* (1959), accessed October 1, 2026, https://biography.wales/article/s-MORG-WIL-1545.

Testament when he died, and Jacobus op den Akker finished it in 1694.[388] The Trinitarian Bible Society later revised his Bible, and the Trinitarian Bible Society of Brazil completed a further revision, the *Almeida Corrigida Fiel*, in 1994.[389] A Bible begun by a Portuguese boy in the Dutch Indies, made in part from the Spanish of Reina and Valera, checked against the Dutch of Dort, and revised by the Greek Received Text, is as clear a picture as any of one text passing through many tongues.

The Bibles of the Reformation at a Glance

Language	Bible	Translated from
German	Luther: NT 1522; Bible 1534	Hebrew; Greek NT of Erasmus (2nd ed., 1519)
French	Olivétan 1535; revised at Geneva 1588; Martin 1707; Ostervald 1744	Hebrew and Greek
Spanish	Reina 1569; revised by Valera 1602	Hebrew, with the Ferrara Spanish and Pagnino's Latin as aids; printed Greek NT (Colinaeus, Stephanus, Beza)
Italian	Diodati 1607; revised 1641	"Directly from the original texts"
Dutch	States Bible 1637	Masoretic Hebrew; Beza's Greek NT (1588–89), with readings from Erasmus and Stephanus
Czech	Kralice Bible 1579–93	Hebrew; Blahoslav's NT "from the original Greek"

[388] Stefan Halikowski Smith and Luís Henrique Menezes Fernandes, "The Unquiet Religious Backdrop to European East Indies Trade: Christian Polemical Literature and the First Portuguese Translation of the Bible, 1642–1694," *e-Journal of Portuguese History* 13, no. 2 (December 2015): 61–63.

[389] Trinitarian Bible Society, "Portuguese," accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.tbsbibles.org/page/language-portuguese.

Hungarian	Károli (Vizsoly) 1590	Hebrew and Greek, with Latin versions (Pagninus, Tremellius, and others) as aids
Danish, Swedish, Icelandic	1550; 1540–41; 1584	Luther's German (itself from Erasmus's Greek)
Portuguese	Almeida: NT 1681; OT completed 1694	NT first from Spanish and Beza's Latin; revised on the Greek Received Text
English	King James Bible 1611	Masoretic Hebrew; Received Text (Beza and Stephanus)

The list could be extended. The point is not that these Bibles were identical in every word. They differed in language, in style, in marginal notes, and in small textual choices, as the printed editions of the Received Text themselves did. The point is that they stood on the same foundation. Not one of them was translated from Codex Vaticanus. Not one followed the text that Westcott and Hort would publish in 1881. From Seville to Stockholm and from Geneva to Gönc, the churches of the Reformation read the New Testament in the text the King James Bible translates.

Rome's Answer in Every Tongue

The chapter on the two lines of Bibles showed Rome's answer to the Bible in the language of the people: the Council of Toulouse in 1229, Archbishop Arundel's constitutions against Wycliffe's Bible, and the preface of the Rheims New Testament. The same answer was given in every land the Reformation reached. The Index of Pope Paul IV in 1559 prohibited the publication and possession of translations of the Bible "in German, French, Spanish, Italian, English, or Dutch, without the permission of the sacred office of the Roman Inquisition." The Index issued

under Pius IV in 1564 laid down ten rules, of which the fourth reads:[390]

> "Inasmuch as it is manifest from experience that if the Holy Bible, translated into the vulgar tongue, be indiscriminately allowed to every one, the rashness of men will cause more evil than good to arise from it, it is, on this point, referred to the judgment of the bishops or inquisitors, who may, by the advice of the priest or confessor, permit the reading of the Bible translated into the vulgar tongue by Catholic authors, to those persons whose faith and piety they apprehend will be augmented and not injured by it; and this permission must be had in writing. But if any shall have the presumption to read or possess it without such permission, he shall not receive absolution until he have first delivered up such Bible to the ordinary."[391]

Notice the limits. Even with permission, a layman could read only a translation made "by Catholic authors," and only with a license in writing. Every Bible described in this chapter was forbidden by definition. And Rome did more than forbid them. In Seville, Julián Hernández was burned for carrying the New Testament into the city. In Bohemia, the printing of Protestant Bibles ceased. In Hungary, a bishop burned a seized edition of Hungarian Bibles in the courtyard of his palace. The two lines described in the previous chapters met in every language of Europe.

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[390] Rietschel, "Restrictions on Bible Reading," 2:86. Rietschel dates the Index of Pius IV to 1584, an evident misprint for 1564; Pius IV died in 1565.

[391] Rietschel, "Restrictions on Bible Reading," 2:86.

Carried to the Ends of the Earth

Two centuries later, the Bibles of the Reformation were carried around the world. On March 7, 1804, a public meeting at the London Tavern founded the British and Foreign Bible Society. Churchmen and Dissenters joined in it, and, as Henry Otis Dwight wrote, "The sole condition necessary to union of action was that a text accepted by all should be issued without note or comment."[392] In English, the text accepted by all was the King James Bible. In the other languages of Europe, the Society reprinted the Bibles of the Reformation. It adopted Ostervald's French Bible and issued it "from time to time." It printed its first edition of the Dutch States Bible in 1812. The Diodati Italian Bible was "repeatedly reprinted by different Bible societies." The Society often printed revised editions of Almeida's Portuguese, and in the nineteenth century it undertook the revision of Károli's Hungarian Bible.[393] For the Greek New Testament itself, the Society printed the Received Text. As late as 1876 its Greek Testament, printed at the University Press in Cambridge, gave "the text of the Elzevir edition of 1624, which was based on that of Robert Estienne, Paris 1550."[394]

The Society did not stay united. In the 1820s a controversy arose over Bibles that contained the Apocrypha, and in 1827 the

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[392] Henry Otis Dwight, "Bible Societies," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:89.

[393] Berger, "French Versions," 2:143; Nestle, "Dutch Versions," 2:137; Berger, "Italian Versions," 2:149; Samuel Berger, "Bible Versions: Portuguese Versions," in *New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia*, 2:151; Balogh, "Hungarian Versions," 2:149.

[394] "Advertisement," in *Ἡ Καινὴ Διαθήκη: Text with Critical Apparatus* (London: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1904), dated "The Bible House, London, March, 1904."

Society resolved that its fundamental law forbade it to circulate the Apocrypha. In 1831 a further controversy arose over the presence of Unitarians in its management. When the Society refused to change its constitution to exclude those who denied the Trinity, the Trinitarian Bible Society was formed.[395] Its own history records that it was founded in London on December 7, 1831. It states that its translations are "based on the Greek Received and Masoretic Texts and translated using formal (word for word) translation principles," and it publishes Bibles and portions in some forty languages.[396]

Not every missionary translator of that age kept to the Received Text. The critical texts were already at work before 1881. Adoniram Judson, the pioneer missionary to Burma, wrote from Rangoon in 1822, "I translate, as you suppose, from the original, following generally the text of Griesbach."[397] Griesbach's Greek New Testament was a critical edition, not the Received Text. Judson's Burmese Bible, as one recent study notes, "is still the main Burmese version used by Protestants in Myanmar."[398] The line of Alexandria did not wait for 1881 to reach the mission field.

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[395] Dwight, "Bible Societies," 2:90.

[396] Trinitarian Bible Society, "Our History," accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.tbsbibles.org/page/OurHistory.

[397] Adoniram Judson to Ira Chase, Rangoon, April 20, 1822, in Robert T. Middleditch, *Burmah's Great Missionary: Records of the Life, Character, and Achievements of Adoniram Judson*, 3rd ed. (New York: E. H. Fletcher, 1854), 169.

[398] John deJong, "A Nineteenth-Century New England Exegete Abroad: Adoniram Judson and the Burmese Bible," *Harvard Theological Review* 112, no. 3 (July 2019): 319–39, abstract.

When the Bible Societies Changed Their Greek

In March 1904 the British and Foreign Bible Society celebrated its centenary. It marked the occasion with a new Greek New Testament, "Published by the British and Foreign Bible Society in connection with its Centenary." The text was not the Received Text that the Society had printed for a century. It was the text of Eberhard Nestle, first published at Stuttgart in 1898. The Society's own advertisement explained how that text was made. It was "a collation of three of the principal recensions of the Greek Testament which appeared in the latter half of the 19th century," the editions of Tischendorf, of Westcott and Hort, and of Bernhard Weiss, and "the readings adopted in the text are those in which at least two of these editions agree."[399] The Received Text was moved to the apparatus at the foot of the page.

Consider what that means. The Greek text that the Society now printed did not come from the churches' use of the Scriptures. It came from a vote among three nineteenth-century editions, and two of the three belonged to the men most closely tied to the Alexandrian manuscripts: Tischendorf, who brought Codex Sinaiticus to light, and Westcott and Hort, whose text, as earlier chapters showed, was built on Codex Vaticanus. The text that had stood behind the Bibles of the Reformation for nearly four hundred years was set aside by the society that had carried those Bibles around the world.

The United Bible Societies took up the same work on a world scale. Founded in 1946, just after the Second World War, it is today a fellowship of Bible societies working in more than 240

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[399] "Advertisement," *Ἡ Καινὴ Διαθήκη* (1904).

countries and territories.[400] Its own Greek New Testament, first published in 1966, was prepared with translators in view; its editors wrote that "in matters of punctuation the Committee has paid special attention to the problems and needs of translators."[401] And, as we have already seen, its agreement with the Vatican in 1968 and 1987 directed joint translation teams to base their work on that Greek text and to relegate the readings of the Received Text to footnotes.

The result is that the Bibles of the Reformation are being replaced in their own lands. In the Netherlands, the modern versions of the Netherlands Bible Society are translated from the critical text, and the society explains the difference this way: "The SV and HSV are based on a Greek text with all sorts of later additions."[402] The sentence is meant as a criticism. It is also a confession that the Bible of the Synod of Dort and the modern Dutch Bibles do not stand on the same text. The heirs of Luther, Olivétan, Reina, and Diodati face the same choice the English-speaking world faced in 1881.

In Germany the change came through the official revisions of Luther's Bible. The German Bible Society's own history calls the revision of 1912 "the last edition that takes the textus receptus as its basis." By 1928 the revisers had agreed on principles that included a commitment to "reliable text-critical editions of the

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[400] United Bible Societies, "Who," accessed October 1, 2026, https://unitedbiblesocieties.org/who/.

[401] "Introduction," in *The Greek New Testament*, ed. Kurt Aland, Matthew Black, Bruce M. Metzger, and Allen Wikgren (London: United Bible Societies, 1966), "The Text," sec. 8, transcribed at Katapi, accessed October 1, 2026, http://www.katapi.org.uk/UBSGrNT/Intro1.htm.

[402] Nederlands Bijbelgenootschap, "Nieuw: info over de brontekst."

original texts," and the revised New Testament that resulted was approved by the Protestant churches of Germany in 1956.[403] The Bible that had carried the Received Text into Germany, Scandinavia, and the Netherlands has been revised on the basis of the critical text in its homeland.

Yet the Reformation text has not been left without witnesses. In the Netherlands the Herziene Statenvertaling, a revision of the States Bible made in our own century, keeps the Received Text, as the Netherlands Bible Society itself acknowledges. The Trinitarian Bible Society continues to translate from the Masoretic and Received Texts. The text that went out into Europe in the sixteenth century is still going out.

What the Bibles of the Reformation Teach

First, the King James position is not English bigotry. The objection pictures a handful of English-speaking believers clinging to one old translation while the rest of the Christian world reads something else. The history is the reverse. The text of the King James Bible was the New Testament of the Protestant Reformation in every language it reached. The modern critical text is the newcomer, in every language.

Second, the Bibles of the Reformation confirm the argument from reception of God's people. Earlier chapters showed that the text the churches received, read, and used is evidence of God's preservation. The Reformation is that argument on the

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[403] Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, "Die Revisionen 1912 und 1984," accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.die-bibel.de/bibeluebersetzungen/lutherbibel/die-geschichte-der-lutherbibel/die-revisionen-1912-und-1984. The translations from the German are my own.

scale of a continent. Churches that differed on many biblical issues and questions—Lutherans in Germany and Sweden, the Reformed in Geneva and the Netherlands, the Brethren in Moravia, the Waldenses in the valleys—received the same Greek New Testament.

Third, the history shows the same refining process this book has traced in English. Luther's Bible came to include 1 John 5:7. Valera revised Reina. The Dutch synod set aside a second-hand version for one made from the originals. The King James translators did not claim to make a new translation, "nor yet to make of a bad one a good one … but to make a good one better."[404] Across Europe, faithful men were doing the same work on the same text.

Fourth, the history tells us what missionaries and translators should do today. If the believers of every tongue are to have the Word of God in their own language, the question of which Hebrew and Greek to translate is not a technical detail to be left to the Bible societies. The Reformation answered it once, and the answer has not changed.

> "And this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; and then shall the end come." (Matt. 24:14)

In English, God has given us His purified Word in the King James Bible. Across the languages of the Reformation, He gave faithful Bibles translated from the same preserved words. The

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[404] "The Translators to the Reader," in *The Holy Bible* (London: Robert Barker, 1611), under "The Purpose of the Translators, with Their Number, Furniture, Care, etc."

Lord gave the word, and great was the company of those that published it. They published one text in many tongues.

PART IV: OTHER ISSUES

TRANSLATION PRACTICES: DYNAMIC VS. FORMAL EQUIVALENCE: WHY TRANSLATION PHILOSOPHY MATTERS

Remember that English Bibles differ for two basic reasons. In many cases, as we have already seen, the difference comes from the underlying Hebrew or Greek reading being used. At other times, the underlying text may be mixed, but **a different translation method** produces wording that does not accurately reflect that text. In the worst cases, both the underlying text and the translation method are faulty, resulting in a translation that seriously distorts the words of God.

Modern translators, following the lead of **Eugene Nida** in the mid-twentieth century, adopted what is called *Dynamic Equivalence*[405] (sometimes "functional equivalence"). Rather than rendering the precise words of the Hebrew and Greek, this method seeks to communicate what translators believe is the "thought" behind the text, often rephrasing or reshaping verses to make them smoother for modern readers.[406]

By contrast, the King James Bible was produced under the principle of *Formal Equivalence* (often called *verbal equivalence*).[407] This approach insists on preserving the actual words and structures of the original languages, as nearly as possible, in the

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[405] Eugene A. Nida, *Toward a Science of Translating* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1964), 159.

[406] Nida, *Toward a Science of Translating*, 166–68.

[407] "The Translators to the Reader" (1611), in F. H. A. Scrivener, *The Authorized Edition of the English Bible (1611): Its Subsequent Reprints and Modern Representatives* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1884), 296–97.

receptor language. The translators recognized that the Bible claims inspiration down to the very words (**Matthew 4:4**; **Proverbs 30:5**), not merely the general ideas.

Jakob van Bruggen, a Reformed New Testament scholar in the Netherlands, stated the principle clearly:

> "Since God has revealed His Word in a fixed and written form, the translator must be respectful of this form."[408]

He added:

> "Obedience in Bible translating means a careful transmission of what God caused to be written."[409]

Francis R. Steele, a linguist who taught Assyriology at the University of Pennsylvania, defined translation this way:

> "A translation should convey as much of the original text in as few words as possible yet preserve the original atmosphere and emphasis. The translator should strive for the nearest approximation in words, concepts, and cadence. He should scrupulously avoid adding words or ideas not demanded by the text. His

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[408] Jakob van Bruggen, *The Future of the Bible* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 1978), 99, quoted in D. A. Waite, *Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority – Texts, Translators, Technique, Theology*, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 148, e-book.

[409] Van Bruggen, *Future of the Bible*, 99, quoted in Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 149.

> job is not to expand or to explain, but to translate and preserve the spirit and force of the original . . ."[410]

Explanation, Steele said, belongs elsewhere:

> "Such treatment belongs in a commentary, not a translation. . . . We want to know what God said—not what Doctor So-and-so thinks God meant by what he said."[411]

The consequences of these two approaches are stark:

- **Formal/Verbal Equivalence (KJV):** Prioritizes accuracy to the inspired words, allowing the reader to study, interpret, and trust that the rendering reflects the original.

- **Dynamic Equivalence (NIV, NLT, etc.):** Prioritizes readability and cultural adaptation, but introduces the bias and theological assumptions of the translators themselves.

Dr. D. A. Waite summarized the danger well: when men depart from translating the **words of God** and begin paraphrasing ideas, man—not God—becomes the authority.

> "For translation that purports to be a translation of God's Words, to add these words is **absolutely diabolical**. It is adding to the Words of God."[412]

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[410] Francis R. Steele, *Translation or Paraphrase?* (St. Louis, MO: Bible Memory Association International, 1960), 1–2, quoted in Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 135.

[411] Steele, *Translation or Paraphrase?*, 7–8, quoted in Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 135.

[412] Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 151.

Waite characterizes the serpent's tactics in **Genesis 3** as a **dynamic-equivalence** paraphrase of God's words:

> "He used the DYNAMIC EQUIVALENCE method… That is, he made a loose paraphrase of what God's words were…"[413]

This philosophical shift explains why so many doctrinally vital verses are weakened or omitted in modern versions. It is not simply about different manuscripts; it is also about a fundamentally different **view of what the Bible is**: the very words of God, or merely a vehicle for conveying religious ideas.

Waite documented the scale of the problem in three popular modern versions. His comparisons with the King James Bible and its underlying Hebrew and Greek texts recorded over 2,000 examples of dynamic equivalence in the New King James Version, over 4,000 in the New American Standard Version, and over 6,653 in the New International Version.[414] These are not differences in the underlying manuscripts. They are places where translators added to, took from, or changed the words in front of them, regardless of the underlying texts they were using.

Conclusion: The Hideous Dangers of Dynamic Equivalence

The Dynamic Equivalence method is Satanically influenced because of how it works. Consider this: even if the original manuscripts were pure and untainted, this method can corrupt the text ten times over by treating Scripture as "thought-for-thought" instead of word-for-word. When translators take the

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413 Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 119.

414 Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 134.

liberty to restate God's thoughts in their own words, they inevitably mix human reasoning with God's revelation. So, the problem isn't just which manuscripts are used, but also how those manuscripts are used. A faithful translator must not alter a single letter or word (**Matthew 5:18**); however, the Dynamic Equivalence translator is at liberty to change God's words to align with man's interpretations.

So, even if a translation starts with a good text, the "thought-for-thought" approach brings in a much more subtle and harmful corruption that hides behind readability and cultural relevance while undermining the authority of Scripture. It is, in essence, the serpent's time-honored tactic in a fresh linguistic guise: "Yea, hath God said?" When a person thinks they can make something better than what God said, the text stops being the Word of God and becomes the word of man.

THE BIBLE BUSINESS: COPYRIGHT, PUBLISHERS, AND ENDLESS REVISION

Readers often ask whether the King James Bible is under copyright. Outside the special royal patent in the United Kingdom, it is not; anyone may print it, quote it, and give it away. This chapter asks the opposite question. Every modern English version carries a copyright notice. Who owns these Bibles, what does their ownership protect, and why are they revised again and again?

The purpose here is not to accuse every translator, editor, or publishing employee of greed. "The labourer is worthy of his reward" (1 Tim. 5:18), and printing and binding Bibles costs money. The question is what happens to the Word of God when it becomes a product that someone owns, licenses, and must keep selling.

Peddlers and Merchandise

Earlier in this book we looked at Paul's words, "For we are not as many, which corrupt the word of God" (2 Cor. 2:17). The word "corrupt" is *kapēleuō* (καπηλεύω), the work of a peddler, and Thayer notes that such peddlers "were in the habit of adulterating their commodities for the sake of gain." Peter warned that false teachers would arise, and "through covetousness shall they with feigned words make merchandise of you" (2 Pet. 2:3). The phrase "make merchandise" is *emporeuomai* (ἐμπορεύομαι), which Thayer explains as "to use a

thing or a person for gain."[415] Paul told Timothy to withdraw from men "supposing that gain is godliness" (1 Tim. 6:5).

The Lord Jesus sent out His disciples with a different principle: "freely ye have received, freely give" (Matt. 10:8). When Simon the sorcerer offered money for the power of the Holy Ghost, Peter answered, "Thy money perish with thee, because thou hast thought that the gift of God may be purchased with money" (Acts 8:20). The Scriptures are offered to sinners "without money and without price" (Isa. 55:1).

What a Copyright Protects

To understand the modern Bible market, one must understand what a copyright on a translation actually covers. The United States Copyright Office explains that "a derivative work is a work based on or derived from one or more already existing works," and it names translations among the most common examples. It lists "a new edition" of an existing work as another. It then states the rule:

> "To be copyrightable, a derivative work must incorporate some or all of a preexisting 'work' and add new original copyrightable authorship to that work."[416]

The same circular adds that "the copyright in a derivative work covers only the additions, changes, or other new material appearing for the first time in the work," that protection "does

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[415] Joseph Henry Thayer, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (New York: American Book Company, 1889), s.v. "καπηλεύω" and "ἐμπορεύομαι."

[416] U.S. Copyright Office, *Copyright in Derivative Works and Compilations*, Circular 14 (Washington, DC: U.S. Copyright Office, reviewed July 2020), 1.

not extend to any preexisting material," including "works in the public domain," and that "it is not possible to extend the length of protection for a copyrighted work by creating a derivative work."[417]

It is often said that a new Bible version must change a certain percentage of the text in order to be copyrighted. The claim appears in literature at least as early as 1995, when Chick Publications' *Battle Cry* printed an excerpt from Gail Riplinger's *Which Bible Is God's Word?* stating that "words must be changed whether they need to be changed or not."[418] No such percentage exists. The Copyright Office asks only for "new original copyrightable authorship," and its manual of practice requires "something more than a 'merely trivial' variation," enough to make the new work "distinguishable from the [preexisting] work in some meaningful way."[419] But the principle behind the claim is sound, because, as the quote above states, the copyright

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[417] U.S. Copyright Office, *Copyright in Derivative Works and Compilations*, 2.

[418] Gail Riplinger, *Which Bible Is God's Word?*, quoted in "Publishers Must Make New Bibles Harder to Read or Give Up Copyright Dollars," *Battle Cry* (Chick Publications), July/August 1995, https://www.chick.com/battle-cry/article?id=publishers-must-make-new-bibles-harder-to-read-or-give-up-copyright-dollars.

[419] U.S. Copyright Office, *Copyright in Derivative Works and Compilations*, 1; U.S. Copyright Office, *Compendium of U.S. Copyright Office Practices*, 3rd ed. (Washington, DC: U.S. Copyright Office, 2021), § 311.2, quoting *Alfred Bell & Co. v. Catalda Fine Arts, Inc.*, 191 F.2d 99, 102–03 (2d Cir. 1951), and *Schrock v. Learning Curve International, Inc.*, 586 F.3d 513, 521 (7th Cir. 2009). The Copyright Office adds that one "cannot claim copyright to another's work, no matter how much you change it, unless you have the owner's consent." U.S. Copyright Office, "Fair Use (FAQ)," accessed September 30, 2026, https://www.copyright.gov/help/faq/faq-fairuse.html.

covers only what appears in the work for the first time. In the United States the King James Bible belongs to the public. A publisher who reprints it owns nothing in the words of Scripture; his copyright reaches only what he added, such as his notes and introductions.[420] A publisher who revises the King James Bible and wants to own the words must own words that are new, and even then his claim is narrow. One legal study of the New King James Version counted nineteen changed words out of 125 in Acts 1:1–5 and concluded that its copyright is narrowly valid but "will likely protect only against verbatim copying."[421] What can be owned in a revision of the King James Bible is exactly what makes it different. A version translated afresh from the Hebrew and Greek owns its own English, but it cannot stop anyone from printing the words it shares with the King James Bible.

The Revision of 1881 Began the Pattern

The first great revision of the English Bible was owned from the beginning. The preface of the Revised New Testament of 1881 records:

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[420] Jason L. Cohn, "The King James Copyright: A Look at the Originality of Derivative Translations of the King James Version of the Bible," *Journal of Intellectual Property Law* 12, no. 2 (2005): 537. American law does not protect typefaces or the general layout of a book (*Compendium*, § 313.3(D)–(E)). In the United Kingdom, "Rights in The Authorized Version of the Bible (King James Bible) in the United Kingdom are vested in the Crown and administered by the Crown's patentee, Cambridge University Press." Cambridge University Press & Assessment, "Bibles Rights and Permissions," accessed September 30, 2026, https://www.cambridge.org/us/universitypress/bibles/about/rights-and-permissions.

[421] Cohn, "King James Copyright," 533, 538.

> "At an early stage in our labours, we entered into an agreement with the Universities of Oxford and Cambridge for the conveyance to them of our copyright in the work. This arrangement provided for the necessary expenses of the undertaking; and procured for the Revised Version the advantage of being published by Bodies long connected with the publication of the Authorised Version."[422]

The revisers conveyed their copyright to the university presses, and the arrangement paid for their work. The major modern versions since have followed some form of that arrangement.

Who Owns the Modern Versions

The New International Version began, according to its publisher, with a businessman who "viewed the language of the King James Version as an obstacle." The Committee on Bible Translation was formed in 1966, with the New York Bible Society as sponsor, and in 1971 Zondervan was selected as "the sole American licensee." The publisher's history records that "the initial budget for the project was $850,000, but costs spiraled out of control," and that Zondervan "in 1976 saved the NIV by advancing royalties of $250,000." The New Testament appeared in 1973 and the whole Bible in 1978. In 1988 "Harper & Row acquired Zondervan and rights to publish the NIV," and both became part of HarperCollins Publishers.[423] The same

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[422] "Preface," in *The New Testament of Our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, Translated out of the Greek: Being the Version Set Forth A.D. 1611, Compared with the Most Ancient Authorities and Revised A.D. 1881* (New York: American Book Exchange, 1881), 9.

[423] HarperCollins Publishers, "The New International Version of the Bible," HarperCollins 200, accessed September 25, 2026, https://200.hc.com/stories/the-new-international-version-of-the-

publisher credits "Zondervan's bold marketing of the NIV Study Bible (1985)" with helping "the NIV become the top-selling Bible in history."[424]

The New King James Version was commissioned in 1975 by Thomas Nelson, aiming, in the publisher's words, to "retain the purity and stylistic beauty of the original King James produced in 1611." Its New Testament appeared in 1979 and the whole Bible in 1982.[425] In 2011 HarperCollins announced that it would acquire Thomas Nelson. *Publishers Weekly* reported that the move "stunned many in the industry, since Harper already owns Nelson's biggest competitor, Zondervan," adding, "Zondervan publishes the New International Version, the top-selling Bible translation; Nelson comes in third with its New King James Version." The same report noted that HarperCollins's HarperOne division also publishes Bibles, "including the New American Bible Revised Edition for Catholics."[426] HarperCollins itself belongs to News Corporation.[427] HarperCollins now describes the result plainly:

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bible/; and "Publishing Firsts: The NIV and NKJV Bible," HarperCollins 200, accessed September 25, 2026, https://200.hc.com/stories/publishing-firsts-the-niv-and-nkjv-bible/.

[424] HarperCollins, "Publishing Firsts."

[425] HarperCollins, "Publishing Firsts."

[426] "Stunned Reaction to HarperCollins's Acquisition of Thomas Nelson," *Publishers Weekly*, November 7, 2011, https://www.publishersweekly.com/pw/by-topic/industry-news/religion/article/49399-stunned-reaction-to-harpercollins-s-acquisition-of-thomas-nelson.html.

[427] "News Corp Acquires Major Christian Book Publisher Thomas Nelson," *Christian Post*, November 1, 2011, https://www.christianpost.com/news/news-corp-acquires-major-christian-book-publisher-thomas-nelson.html.

"Both Zondervan and Thomas Nelson were later acquired by HarperCollins, and both the NIV and NKJV are still published today as part of HarperCollins Christian Publishing."[428]

Not every modern version belongs to a secular corporation. The English Standard Version is published by Crossway, which describes itself as "a not-for-profit Christian ministry," and the New American Standard Bible by the Lockman Foundation.[429] But every one of these Bibles is owned. Each is copyrighted, licensed, and controlled by its owner. The best-selling modern translation and the version that borrows the King James name belong to the same corporate house, which also sells a Catholic Bible. The market does not ask which line a Bible stands in. It asks whether it sells.

Permission to Quote the Word of God

Because these texts are owned, their owners decide how much of them may be used. Crossway's standard guidelines state that the ESV may be quoted "up to and inclusive of five hundred (500) verses without a formal license or express written permission of Crossway," provided the verses do not amount to more than half of any book of the Bible, do not make up "twenty-five percent (25%) or more of the total text of the work

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[428] HarperCollins, "Publishing Firsts."

[429] Crossway, "Crossway Statement on the ESV Bible Text," September 28, 2016, https://www.crossway.org/articles/crossway-statement-on-the-esv-bible-text/; Lockman Foundation, "The Lockman Foundation History," accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.lockman.org/the-lockman-foundation-history/.

in which they are quoted," and "are not being quoted in a commentary or other biblical reference work."[430]

Consider what that means. A pastor who writes a commentary on the book of Romans, quoting the ESV text as he goes, needs a license from the publisher. The same pastor may quote the King James Bible from Genesis to Revelation without asking anyone. The Bible that belongs to no publisher belongs to every believer.

The Revision Cycle

Owned Bibles are also revised Bibles. The NIV New Testament appeared in 1973 and the whole Bible in 1978. It was revised in 1984, and in 2009 its publishers announced a new revision for 2011, after which, *The Christian Century* reported, publication of the earlier versions of the NIV would be phased out.[431] A believer who had memorized the NIV of 1984 was told by its own publishers that the Bible he memorized would be phased out. The NIV's owners say plainly that the work is never finished: "The Committee on Bible Translation still meets every year."[432]

The New American Standard Bible New Testament appeared in 1963 and the whole Bible in 1971. Its publisher states that it "has been updated several times," in 1977, in 1995, and "most recently in 2020." In 2021 a new version, the Legacy Standard

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[430] Crossway, "ESV Print Permissions," accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.crossway.org/permissions/.

[431] "Zondervan to Publish Updated NIV Bible: Will Discontinue Today's New International Version," *The Christian Century*, October 6, 2009, https://www.christiancentury.org/article/2009-10/zondervan-publish-updated-niv-bible.

[432] Biblica, "NIV Story," accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.biblica.com/niv-bible/niv-bible-story/.

Bible, appeared as "a direct update of the NASB 1995 edition."[433] The English Standard Version appeared in 2001, "with minor revisions being released in 2007, 2011, and 2016."[434] Its stated Greek basis has also changed. It was first based on the Greek editions of 1993; its preface now names the editions of 2012 and 2014, which, as we have seen, are themselves being replaced.[435]

The "Permanent Text" That Did Not Last

In 2016 the publisher of the ESV tried to stop the cycle. In August it announced on its website that "the text of the ESV Bible will remain unchanged in all future editions printed and published by Crossway." At the end of September it reversed itself:

> "We have become convinced that this decision was a mistake.… Our goal at Crossway remains as strong as ever to serve future generations with a stable ESV text. But the means to that goal, we now see, is not to establish a permanent text but rather to allow for ongoing periodic updating of the text to reflect the realities of biblical scholarship such as textual discoveries or changes in English over time."[436]

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[433] Lockman Foundation, "The Lockman Foundation History."

[434] Joe Carter, "9 Things You Should Know About the ESV Bible," The Gospel Coalition, September 30, 2016, https://www.thegospelcoalition.org/article/9-things-you-should-know-about-the-esv-bible/.

[435] Carter, "9 Things"; "Preface," *English Standard Version*, accessed September 25, 2026, https://www.esv.org/preface/.

[436] Crossway, "Crossway Statement on the ESV Bible Text."

The statement is clear, and it is revealing. A publisher that wanted a settled Bible found that it could not promise one, because the Greek text it translates is never settled and the English it uses is always being updated. A Bible built on a reconstructed text must remain open to revision "in principle," as the statement says. That is the honest position of the critical text, and it is the reason no modern version can offer what the King James Bible has offered for four centuries: a text that stays the same.

Why a Moving Text Suits the Market

This book does not claim that any committee revised its Bible just to renew a copyright. But the law and the market reward what is new. A copyright covers only "new material appearing for the first time," and every revision brings a new text edition, new study Bibles, new reading plans, and new material to own. A Bible that is never finished is never without a new edition to sell.

The King James Bible cannot be owned in that way, and it has never needed to be revised to stay in print. Outside Britain it has been printed by any press that wished to print it, and Bible societies, missionaries, and churches have carried it around the world without paying anyone for its words. Its only "update" in the modern sense was the standardizing of its spelling and printing.

A Bible Without a Price

God did not sell His Word to His people, and He did not lease it. The prophet cried, "Ho, every one that thirsteth, come ye to the waters, and he that hath no money; come ye, buy, and eat; yea, come, buy wine and milk without money and without price" (Isa. 55:1). The last invitation of the Bible says the same:

"And whosoever will, let him take the water of life freely" (Rev. 22:17).

Solomon wrote, "Buy the truth, and sell it not" (Prov. 23:23). The believer does well to hold on to a Bible that no corporation owns, no committee is still revising, and no publisher can take out of print. That Bible is already in his hands in the King James Version.

DOCTRINAL ISSUES (WHY THE "SMALL" CHANGES AREN'T SMALL)

We often hear people say, "The differences between Bible versions don't change any doctrines." But when you slow down and actually compare them side by side, you find that these "small changes" add up to very big differences. In fact, some of the clearest teachings about Jesus, salvation, and the Christian life are blurred or weakened in modern versions. Let's walk through some key examples.

1 Timothy 3:16

KJV: "*God was manifest in the flesh.*"

NIV: "*He was manifested in the flesh.*"

In the KJV, Paul is boldly declaring that **God Himself** came down into human flesh. That's one of the strongest confirmations of Jesus' deity in the New Testament. The NIV and other modern Bibles switch it to "He," which is vague. Everyone is "manifested in the flesh." Only the KJV preserves the force of this verse, that Jesus is God made flesh.

The reading "God was manifest in the flesh" is the Traditional Text, supported by Codex A (according to Scrivener), Codex C (according to Hoskier), and early writers including Didymus, Gregory of Nyssa, and Chrysostom.[437] The alternative, "who was manifest in the flesh," leaves Paul's sentence without a

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[437] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 5, "The Facts of New Testament Textual Criticism," under "Other Heretical Readings in the Alexandrian Text," e-book.

subject. When the RSV adopted "who," it translated it "He" and placed beneath it the note "Greek, who." Hills asked:

> "But if the Greek is who how can the English be He? This is not translation but the creation of an entirely new reading."[438]

Philippians 2:5–6

KJV: *"Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus: Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God."*

ESV: *"Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped."*

The difference is subtle but huge. The KJV says Jesus didn't have to grasp for equality with God; it was already His by nature. He was fully God. The ESV makes it sound like Jesus did not think He was or could be equal to God. The KJV defends the truth that Jesus has always been equal with God.

John 1:18

KJV: *"the only begotten Son."*

ESV (2016): *"the only God."*

In 2025 the ESV changed its wording here to "God the only Son." The Greek text it translates still reads "God" where the Received Text reads "Son."

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[438] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "Other Heretical Readings in the Alexandrian Text."

The KJV preserves the unique Father and Son relationship. Modern versions' wording creates confusion: How can the "only God" be "at the Father's side" (as the ESV says) if they are the same Person? The KJV clearly teaches that the Son is distinct from the Father, yet fully God.

The reading "only begotten God" has a troubling history. Dean Burgon traced it to the Gnostic teacher Valentinus. The first known quotation of John 1:18 with the word "God" occurs in the second-century *Excerpts from Theodotus*, in a discussion of the teaching of the Valentinians, who distinguished the Word from the Son.[439] In the abbreviated forms the scribes used, the change from "Son" to "God" is, as Hills notes, "a change of only one letter in Greek."[440]

Romans 14:10

KJV: *"…for we shall all stand before the judgment seat of Christ."*

NASB: *"…for we will all stand before the judgment seat of God."*

The KJV highlights that **Jesus Christ** is the one who will judge all mankind, consistent with **John 5:22**, where the Father has committed judgment to the Son. Modern versions shift the

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[439] Clement of Alexandria, *The Excerpta ex Theodoto of Clement of Alexandria*, ed. and trans. Robert Pierce Casey, Studies and Documents 1 (London: Christophers, 1934), 45; John William Burgon and Edward Miller, *The Causes of the Corruption of the Traditional Text of the Holy Gospels* (London: George Bell and Sons, 1896), 215–18; Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "The Only Begotten Son versus Only Begotten God."

[440] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "The Only Begotten Son versus Only Begotten God."

focus back to "God," which is true, but less specific. It hides the explicit statement that Jesus is the final Judge.

The reading "judgment seat of Christ" is not late. Hills notes that it "is also found in Polycarp, Tertullian, and Marcion." Polycarp was a disciple of the apostle John. The reading also identifies Christ as the LORD of Isaiah 45:23, to whom every knee shall bow, which Paul quotes in the very next verse.[441]

1 Corinthians 10:9

KJV: "*Neither let us tempt Christ, as some of them also tempted.*"

NASB: "*Nor are we to put the Lord to the test, as some of them.*"

At first glance they look the same. But this is really important: Paul is identifying the God of the Old Testament whom Israel tempted in the wilderness as **Christ Himself**. That means Jesus is the God of the Old Testament, the LORD. This strong doctrinal connection disappears in most modern translations that don't keep the precise wording.

Luke 24:52

KJV: "*And they worshipped him, and returned to Jerusalem with great joy.*"

RSV: "*And they returned to Jerusalem with great joy.*"

The KJV confidently states the disciples worshipped the risen Jesus. Some modern versions question or bracket the wording

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[441] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "Other Heretical Readings in the Alexandrian Text."

or remove it altogether. Why downplay one of the clearest moments of the disciples bowing before their Lord?

Acts 20:28

KJV: *"…the church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood."*

ESV: *"…the church of God, which he obtained with the blood of his own."*

The KJV makes the point blunt: it was **God's own blood**, Christ's blood, that bought the church. The ESV rephrases it so the link between God and the blood of Christ is less direct.

1 John 5:7–8

KJV: *"For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one."*

NIV: *"For there are three that testify."*

The KJV includes the classic "heavenly witnesses" verse, which is one of the clearest verses on the doctrine of the Trinity in the Bible. Modern versions drop it completely or put it in the footnotes. This removes one of the strongest proof-texts for the Trinity in the whole Bible.

Luke 2:33

KJV: *"And Joseph and his mother marvelled at those things which were spoken of him."*

ESV: *"And his father and his mother marveled at what was said about him."*

The KJV avoids calling Joseph Jesus' father, which protects the doctrine of the virgin birth. The ESV uses "father," which could give the wrong impression.

Luke 2:22

KJV: *"…the days of **her** purification…"*

CSB: *"…the days of **their** purification…"*

The law of Moses only required the purification of the mother, not both parents. The KJV gets it right.

Matthew 1:25

KJV: *"…and knew her not till she had brought forth her firstborn son."*

ESV: "…but knew her not until she had given birth to a son."

The word "firstborn" matters. It tells us Mary had other children after Jesus, countering the Roman Catholic teaching of her perpetual virginity.

Daniel 3:25

KJV: *"…the form of the fourth is like the Son of God."*

NASB: *"…the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods."*

The KJV points to Christ as the fourth man in the fire. The NASB makes it sound like Nebuchadnezzar just saw a pagan deity.

Colossians 1:14

KJV: *"…redemption through his blood, even the forgiveness of sins."*

NIV: "*…redemption, the forgiveness of sins.*"

Taking out "through his blood" removes the very means of redemption. Without the blood of Christ, there is no forgiveness.

Acts 8:37

KJV: "*…And Philip said, If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and said, I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.*"

CSB: Omitted, footnote only.

This verse contains the Ethiopian eunuch's confession of faith **before** baptism. Leaving it out removes a key testimony that salvation is by faith in Christ before baptism.

Acts 9:6

KJV: "*…Lord, what wilt thou have me to do?*"

ESV: Shorter; Paul's cry is missing.

The KJV records Paul's first words of surrender to the Lord. Without them, the dramatic conversion moment loses some of its impact.

Matthew 18:11

KJV: "*For the Son of man is come to save that which was lost.*"

NASB: Verse omitted.

This is a clear purpose statement of why Jesus came: to save the lost. Why remove it?

John 6:47

KJV: *"…He that believeth on me hath everlasting life."*

NIV: *"…the one who believes has eternal life."*

Dropping "on me" weakens the focus. Faith isn't just a vague belief; it must be in Christ.

Isaiah 14:12 / Revelation 22:16

KJV Isa. 14:12: *"How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning!"*

NIV Isa. 14:12: "How you have fallen *from heaven, morning star, son of the dawn!"*

KJV Rev. 22:16: *"…I Jesus… am the bright and morning star."*

NIV Rev. 22:16: *"…I, Jesus… am the bright morning star."*

By changing "Lucifer" to "morning star," modern versions end up giving the same title to both Satan (**Isaiah 14**) and Jesus (**Revelation 22**). That creates confusion and blurs the line between Christ and the devil.

Also, an interesting experiment to show this issue would be to ask a Christian who uses modern Bible versions, "Where does everything that you believe stem from?" They will likely tell you the Bible unreservedly. Then ask a follow-up, "Who is Lucifer?" They will likely tell you it was the Devil before he fell (almost anyone is familiar with this name). Then a final question, "Where did you learn that from?" They will frantically search their Bibles, only to discover to their amazement that the name does not even appear in their Bibles, unless… they have the King James Bible (the NKJV also

includes the name). They hold a specific belief about a name of the Devil, but that name is not in their Bibles. This presents quite a predicament.

As a side note, who would want to remove that name from your Bible? And why? (Gen. 3)

Genesis 3:16

KJV: *"…thy desire shall be to thy husband, and he shall rule over thee."*

ESV: *"…your desire shall be contrary to your husband, but he shall rule over you."*

The KJV says the woman's desire would be toward her husband (which many understand as a desire for closeness or dependence). The ESV flips it, saying her desire would be "contrary" to him, introducing conflict. That's not a small shift; it is completely contradictory to the King James Bible reading.

Mark 9:29

KJV: *"…by prayer and fasting."*

CSB: *"…by prayer."*

Fasting is one of the disciplines Jesus taught. Dropping it weakens the verse's teaching on spiritual warfare and the need for fasting.

Matthew 17:21

KJV: *"Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting."*

NIV: Omitted.

Again, fasting is gone.

Again, who would want to remove a key verse showing you a key step in "casting out devils"? And why? (**Gen. 3**)

The omission of fasting is not an isolated accident. Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and their allies omit fasting not only in Mark 9:29 but also in Acts 10:30 and 1 Corinthians 7:5. Hills traced these omissions to Alexandria:

> "These omissions are probably due to the influence of Clement of Alexandria and other Gnostics, who interpreted fasting in a spiritual sense and were opposed to literal fasting."[442]

Luke 11:2–4

KJV: "*Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done, as in heaven, so in earth. Give us day by day our daily bread. And forgive us our sins; for we also forgive every one that is indebted to us. And lead us not into temptation; but deliver us from evil.*"

NASB: Shorter form, leaving out "*which art in heaven,*" "*thy will be done,*" and "*deliver us from evil.*"

Jesus gave us a model prayer. Why remove so much of it?

Mark 1:2

KJV: "*As it is written in the prophets…*"

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[442] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "Other Heretical Readings in the Alexandrian Text."

ESV: *"As it is written in Isaiah the prophet…"*

Since Mark quotes both Isaiah and Malachi, the ESV makes it look like Mark misattributed the quote. The KJV avoids the problem with "prophets."

Psalm 12:6–7

KJV: *"…The words of the LORD are pure words… Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever."*

NIV: *"…You, LORD, will keep **the needy** safe and will protect **us** forever from the wicked."*

The KJV says God is preserving **His words**. The NIV shifts it to "us" (the people). This turns a promise about God's words into a promise about protection of the people. Both are true in general, but only one matches the grammar here.

Matthew 9:13 / Mark 2:17

KJV: *"…I am not come to call the righteous, but sinners to **repentance**."*

CSB: *"…I came not to call the righteous, but sinners."*

Leaving out "repentance" changes the very purpose of Christ's call. Repentance is at the heart of the gospel message, and dropping it leaves only half the truth.

Romans 8:1

KJV: *"…There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus, **who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit.**"*

ESV: *"…There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."*

The ESV cuts off the second half of the verse. The KJV keeps Paul's full thought: yes, no condemnation in Christ, but also a reminder that those in Him will walk by the Spirit, not the flesh.

Matthew 6:13 — The Lord's Prayer Ending

KJV: *"…For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen."*

NASB: Leaves this out; footnote only.

The ending and main thrust of the Lord's Prayer, which teach us a key pattern for our prayer lives, are taken out in modern versions.

The evidence for the doxology is ancient and widespread. It is found in all but about ten of the Greek manuscripts collated by S. C. E. Legg, including Codex W (fourth or fifth century); in the Peshitta, Harclean, Palestinian, and Curetonian Syriac; in the Sahidic Coptic; and in five Old Latin manuscripts.[443] The *Didache*, a church manual generally dated to the first half of the second century, gives the Lord's Prayer "as the Lord commanded in His Gospel" and ends it, "for Thine is the power and the glory for ever." Hills asked:

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[443] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 6, under "External Evidence in Favor of Matt. 6:13b" and "The Testimony of the Ancient Versions and of the Didache."

> "Is it not reasonable to believe that he took the whole prayer from Matthew, doxology and all?"[444]

Hills also noted that if Christians had invented the doxology, they would surely have included the name of Christ in it.[445]

Mark 10:24

KJV: "*…Children, how hard is it for them that trust in riches to enter into the kingdom of God!"*

NIV: "*…how hard it is* ***to enter the kingdom of God****!"*

The KJV makes it clear: the problem is trusting in riches. The NIV just says it's hard for anyone to enter God's kingdom. Very different.

John 7:8

KJV: "*…I go not up* ***yet*** *unto this feast…"*

ESV: "*…I am not going up to this feast…"*

In the KJV, Jesus says He is not going up "yet," which matches what happens a few verses later when He does go. The ESV makes it sound like He lied, since He says He's not going at all, then does.

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[444] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 6, under "The Testimony of the Ancient Versions and of the Didache"; see *Didache* 8.2, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 7:379.

[445] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 6, under "Is the Conclusion of the Lord's Prayer a Jewish Formula?"

Luke 4:18

KJV: "*…he hath sent me to heal the brokenhearted, to preach deliverance to the captives, and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty them that are bruised."*

CSB: "*…He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to set free the oppressed."*

The phrase "heal the brokenhearted" is dropped. That's one of Jesus' most famous descriptions of His ministry, and it's missing.

Luke 9:56

KJV: "*…For the Son of man is not come to destroy men's lives, but to save them."*

NASB: Shortened: "*…they went on to another village."*

An entire statement of Christ's saving purpose disappears.

John 3:16

KJV: "*…his only begotten Son…"*

NIV: "*…his one and only Son…"*

Removing "begotten" (which shows Christ's unique eternal relationship with the Father) weakens the verse's theology. Jesus isn't God's "only" son; Adam is called a son of God, and believers are sons of God. But He is the only **begotten** Son.

Matthew 20:20

KJV: "*…the mother of Zebedee's children with her sons, worshipping him…"*

ESV: *"…the mother of the sons of Zebedee came up to him with her sons…"* (*"worshipping him"* omitted).

The KJV shows the disciples' family worshipping Jesus. The ESV leaves it out, lessening a worship moment.

Acts 2:30

KJV: *"…he would raise up Christ to sit on his throne."*

CSB: *"…he would* ***raise up one of his descendants*** *to sit on his throne."*

The KJV points directly to Christ. The CSB dilutes the clarity of Peter's sermon by making it sound more generic.

Acts 3:13

KJV: *"…the God of our fathers, hath glorified his Son Jesus…"*

NASB: *"…has glorified his servant Jesus…"*

The KJV says **Son**, pointing to Christ's unique status. The NASB says **servant**, which is true in a sense, but is much weaker.

Mark 9:44, 46

KJV: *"Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched."* (repeated in vv. 44, 46, 48)

NIV: These lines are omitted in vv. 44 and 46, kept only in v. 48.

Jesus repeated it three times for emphasis. Modern versions reduce it to once, softening one of the Bible's most graphic warnings about hell.

Revelation 1:11

KJV: "*…I am Alpha and Omega, the first and the last: and, What thou seest, write in a book…*"

ESV: "*…Write what you see in a book…*"

The strong self-identification of Christ as Alpha and Omega is cut.

Jude 1:25

KJV: "*…to the only wise God our Saviour…*"

ESV: "*…to the only God…*"

KJV explicitly ties God to being our **Saviour**. The ESV removes the direct reference.

Micah 5:2

KJV: "*But thou, Beth-lehem Ephratah… out of thee shall he come forth unto me that is to be ruler in Israel; whose goings forth have been from of old,* ***from everlasting.***"

NIV: "*whose origins are from of old,* ***from ancient times.***"

The KJV clearly calls Christ eternal; His "goings forth" are from **everlasting**. That points straight to His deity, showing He existed before time and will always exist. No ending and no beginning.

The **NIV** says "from ancient times," which makes it sound like He has a long history, but not necessarily eternal. That could apply to a created being.

2 Samuel 21:19

KJV: "*…Elhanan… slew the brother of Goliath…"*

ESV: "*…Elhanan… killed Goliath the Gittite…"*

If the modern versions' rendering is taken at face value, it directly contradicts **1 Samuel 17**, where David kills Goliath. The **KJV** translators preserved this correctly by including the Hebrew "the brother of Goliath" (compare 1 Chron. 20:5, which clarifies this). Modern Bibles have David killing Goliath in **1 Samuel 17**, and then Elhanan killing Goliath in 2 Sam. 21:19. This is a plain contradiction.

1 Corinthians 9:27

KJV: "*But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection…"*

NIV: "*No, I strike a blow to my body and make it my slave."*

In this verse, the NIV talks about self-harm and making your body into your slave. These are not biblical teachings that you would want anyone to take away from this passage. The KJV makes it clear that Paul is talking about self-control and bringing your body into your control. This is vastly different from the self-harm of the NIV.

Luke 24:51 (cf. Acts 1:1–2)

KJV: "*carried up into heaven…"*

RSV: *This verse ending is omitted in Nestle's Greek Text (text used for modern versions) and has been omitted in multiple editions of the RSV, NASB, and others.*

The issue of modern versions omitting or "footnoting" this part of the verse in **Luke 24:51** is found when it is compared with Luke's other writing in **Acts 1:1–2**. Here he tells Theophilus how he wrote to him before (referring to the Gospel of Luke) and told him all things "of all that Jesus began both to do and teach, *Until the day in which he was taken up.*" Luke's own statement in **Acts 1:1–2** discounts any *"false copy"* of his original *"treatise"* (Gospel of Luke) that does not include the ending where Jesus is *"taken up."* Modern versions and the Greek text on which they are based create a contradiction in their *"bibles"* by omitting this.

The history of Luke 24 shows how unstable the critical text is. Westcott and Hort placed eight readings in the last chapters of Luke in double brackets, including "carried up into heaven" (24:51) and "they worshipped him" (24:52), because a few witnesses, chiefly Western, omit them. The RSV and NEB moved these readings to the footnotes. Then Papyrus 75, one of the oldest manuscripts of Luke, was found to contain all eight. Hills wrote:

> "Because these eight omitted readings have been found to occur in Papyrus 75, critics are now changing their minds about them. Kurt Aland (1966), for example, has restored these Western omissions to the text of the Nestle New Testament. . . . And this rapid shifting of opinion shows us how untrustworthy naturalistic textual criticism is."[446]

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[446] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, sec. 2(b), citing Kurt Aland, "Neue neutestamentliche Papyri II," *New Testament Studies* 12 (1966): 193–210.

The King James Bible never had to restore these words, because it never removed them.

Luke 22:43–44

KJV: *"And there appeared an angel unto him from heaven, strengthening him. And being in an agony he prayed more earnestly: and his sweat was as it were great drops of blood falling down to the ground."*

Modern versions: Westcott and Hort placed these verses in double brackets as a later addition, and modern versions commonly bracket them or add a note that early manuscripts omit them.

These verses are found in the vast majority of manuscripts, including Sinaiticus, Bezae, and L, and in the Old Latin and Curetonian Syriac. Epiphanius reported that some orthodox Christians removed them because the Arians used them. Hills suggested that the docetists, who denied that Christ had a real human body, may have been the first to cut out this account of His agony, because it refuted their teaching.[447] The KJV preserves the full testimony to Christ's true humanity in Gethsemane.

Luke 23:34

KJV: *"Then said Jesus, Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do."*

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[447] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "Christ's Agony and Bloody Sweat."

Modern versions: Westcott and Hort placed this prayer in double brackets, and modern versions commonly bracket it or add a note that early manuscripts omit it.

This prayer is found in the vast majority of manuscripts, including Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus, and Codex C, and it is cited in the second century by Tatian and Irenaeus. Even the liberal scholar Adolf von Harnack insisted:

> "The verse ought in no case to be stricken out of the text of Luke."[448]

To cast doubt on this prayer is to cast doubt on one of the sayings of Christ from the cross.

Luke 23:42

KJV: "*And he said unto Jesus, Lord, remember me when thou comest into thy kingdom.*"

ESV: "*And he said, 'Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom.'*"

The dying thief acknowledged Christ as King. Hills asked:

> "Would it be at all natural for the thief to address his new found King rudely and familiarly as Jesus? Surely

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[448] Adolf von Harnack, *Studien zur Geschichte des Neuen Testaments und der alten Kirche* (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1931), 96–98, as translated in Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "Christ's Prayer for His Murderers."

> not. Surely he must have commenced his dying prayer with the vocative, Lord!"[449]

Hills traced the change to docetists, who taught that the divine Christ departed before the crucifixion, leaving only the man Jesus to die.

John 6:69

KJV: *"And we believe and are sure that thou art that Christ, the Son of the living God."*

ESV: *"and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God."*

Peter's confession here matches his confession in Matthew 16:16. Hills observed that "in the other Gospels only the demons address Jesus as the Holy One of God" (Mark 1:24; Luke 4:34), and that John wrote his Gospel so that men might believe "that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God" (John 20:31).[450] The modern reading replaces Peter's confession of Christ as the Son of the living God with a title that, in the other Gospels, only the demons use.

Conclusion

These aren't just stylistic differences. They touch Jesus' deity, the Trinity, His virgin birth, His saving blood, salvation by faith, the fall of man, spiritual warfare, marriage, and the authority of God's Word itself. The King James Bible preserves

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[449] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "Other Heretical Readings in the Alexandrian Text."

[450] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, under "Son of God versus Holy One of God."

the stronger and clearer readings. Modern versions often dull or remove them completely.

DOCTRINAL ISSUES IN NEW BIBLE VERSIONS

Baptism Before or After Salvation? (Acts 8:37)

KJV:
36 And as they went on their way, they came unto a certain water: and the eunuch said, See, here is water; what doth hinder me to be baptized?
37 ¶ And Philip said, **If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest.** And he answered and said, I believe that **Jesus** Christ is the Son of God.
38 ¶ And he commanded the chariot to stand still: and they went down both into the water, both Philip and the eunuch; and he baptized him.

NIV:
36 As they traveled along the road, they came to some water and the eunuch said, "Look, here is water. What can stand in the way of my being baptized?"
37 **(MISSING)**
38 And he gave orders to stop the chariot. Then both Philip and the eunuch went down into the water and Philip baptized him.

Was Jesus God? (Phil. 2:5-6)

KJV:
Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ **Jesus**: Who, being in the form of God, **thought it not robbery to be equal with God:**

ESV:
Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ **Jesus**, who, though he was in the form of God, **did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped**

Is the Wife supposed to be Against her Husband? (Gen. 3:16)

KJV:
Unto the woman he said, I will greatly multiply thy sorrow and thy conception; in sorrow thou shalt bring forth children; and **thy desire shall be to thy husband**, and he shall rule over thee.

ESV:
To the woman he said, "I will surely multiply your pain in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children. **Your desire shall be contrary to your husband**, but he shall rule over you."

Who is Lucifer? (Isa. 14:12)

KJV:
How art thou fallen from heaven, O **Lucifer**, son of the morning! how art thou cut down to the ground, which didst weaken the nations!

ESV:
"How you are fallen from heaven, O Day Star, son of Dawn! How you are cut down to the ground, you who laid the nations low!

******No other Bible version out there mentions the name "Lucifer" even once (Except for the NKJV) in their entire Bible. The NIV goes even further down a bad path by referring to the Devil and Jesus Christ by the same name "Morning Star".**

NIV: "How you have fallen from heaven, **morning star**, son of the dawn! You have been cast down to the earth, you who once laid low the nations!

NIV in Revelation 22:16: "I, **Jesus**, have sent my angel to give you this testimony for the churches. I am the Root and the Offspring of David, and the bright **Morning Star**."

Is God a Trinity (1 John 5:7)

KJV:
For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one.

ESV:
7 For there are three that testify:
8 the Spirit and the water and the blood; and these three agree.

*****NO MENTION OF THE TRINITY HERE AT ALL IN ANY NEW BIBLE VERSIONS**

EASE OF READING

One of the most repeated objections to the King James Bible is not textual, doctrinal, or historical but practical: *"It's too hard to read."* In the age of "easy-to-understand" versions, the assumption is that seventeenth-century English must be inaccessible to modern readers. But when we step beyond assumption and examine the evidence, a very different conclusion emerges.

What the Numbers Actually Say

Readability is not a matter of personal opinion. Scholars use standardized formulas such as the **Flesch Reading Ease Score** and **Flesch–Kincaid Grade Level** to evaluate text difficulty. These measure average sentence length and syllables per word.

- The KJV consistently scores at or around an **eighth-grade reading level**. For example, **Genesis 1** scores 8.13 (eighth grade), **Romans 3:1–23** scores 5.63 (sixth grade), and **Romans 8** scores 7.72 (eighth grade).

- Peer-reviewed research by Emilio Matricciani (2023) on Matthew's Gospel translations placed the **KJV at approximately eight years of schooling for "easy" reading, compared with more than thirteen for the NASB and approximately six for the New International Reader's Version**, squarely in the middle of the field.[451]

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[451] Emilio Matricciani, "Readability across Time and Languages: The Case of Matthew's Gospel Translations," *AppliedMath* 3, no. 2 (2023): 497–509, table 5, https://doi.org/10.3390/appliedmath3020026.

In other words: the KJV is not the hardest English Bible, and by some measures it is easier than many modern versions.

Archaic Words: A Help, Not a Hindrance

The most common complaint is about words like *thee, thou, ye, thine*. Critics assume these are outdated formalities. In reality, they preserve a distinction between **singular** and **plural** that modern English has lost.

- *Thou/thee/thy* = singular.
- *Ye/you/your* = plural.

This provides clarity. When Jesus said in **Luke 22:31–32**, *"Satan hath desired to have **you** [all the disciples], but I have prayed for **thee** [Peter],"* the KJV makes the switch explicit.[452] Modern versions flatten both to *"you,"* obscuring the point.

Far from making the text less clear, the KJV often makes it **more precise**.

John 3:7 gives another clear example: "Marvel not that I said unto thee, Ye must be born again." The Lord speaks to Nicodemus alone ("thee"), but the requirement He states applies to all ("Ye"). Modern versions use "you" for both and lose the distinction.[453]

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[452] *Oxford English Dictionary*, s.v. "thou, pron.," *OED Online* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2023).

[453] D. A. Waite, *Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority – Texts, Translators, Technique, Theology*, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 308, e-book.

These forms were not simply the everyday English of 1611. Hills pointed out that the King James Bible is written in "biblical English, which was not used on ordinary occasions even by the translators who produced the King James Version." He added:

> "Even in their use of thee and thou the translators were not following 17th-century English usage but biblical usage, for at the time these translators were doing their work these singular forms had already been replaced by the plural you in polite conversation."[454]

The translators kept "thee" and "ye" because the Hebrew and Greek distinguish singular from plural, and a faithful translation had to show it.

Designed for Oral Clarity

Literary historians emphasize that the King James Bible was **crafted for the ear** as much as for the eye. Its cadence, parallelism, and rhythm were designed to be read aloud in church.

- **Gordon Campbell (Oxford)** argues that the KJV's formal idiom is **not obscure but rhetorical**, intentionally suited for public proclamation.[455]

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[454] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 8, "The Textus Receptus and the King James Version," under "Why the King James Version Should Be Retained," e-book.

[455] Gordon Campbell, *Bible: The Story of the King James Version, 1611–2011* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 80, 170.

- **Leland Ryken (Wheaton)** defends the KJV's formal style as an aid to clarity, not an obstacle, insisting that its archaisms are minimal and its diction memorably concrete.[456]

- **David Norton (Cambridge)** notes that while the KJV preserves an elevated register, it has remained **functionally intelligible** for centuries.[457]

When read aloud, the KJV proves remarkably accessible, which explains its enduring role in worship and evangelism.

Readability ≠ Shallowness

Modern claims of "easier reading" often confuse **simplification** with **comprehension**. The Bible was never meant to read like a comic book. It was meant to challenge, to lodge in memory, and to be studied.

- **Psalm 119:130 —** "The entrance of thy words giveth light; it giveth understanding unto the simple."

- **Proverbs 2:4–5 —** understanding comes by searching "as for hid treasures."

The KJV does not obscure truth with jargon. Its plain Anglo-Saxon vocabulary (*sin, blood, law, grace*) is simple. Its cadence and dignity, however, call the reader to seriousness. This balance is one reason it has been memorized by children, preached by evangelists, and used by missionaries for centuries.

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[456] Leland Ryken, "Ten Fallacies about the King James Version," *Southern Baptist Journal of Theology* 15, no. 4 (2011): 11–14.

[457] David Norton, *A Textual History of the King James Bible* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 14–15.

Historical Reality: Ordinary People Read It

The claim that the KJV is "too hard" ignores history. For four centuries it was the **common man's Bible**: plowboys memorized it, mothers taught it, coal miners sang from it, and revivalists preached it across nations.

- **David Crystal (Oxford)** documents in *Begat: The King James Bible and the English Language* that hundreds of KJV phrases entered everyday English precisely because ordinary people grasped and repeated them.[458]

- The great missionary movements of Carey, Judson, and Taylor were carried forward not by "simplified" Bibles but by translations rooted in the KJV's textual line.

If it were truly unreadable, it could not have functioned as the people's Bible for so long.

Conclusion

When the evidence is weighed, the charge that the KJV is "too difficult" collapses.

1. **Objective studies** show the KJV's readability is at or below that of many modern versions.

2. Its so-called "archaic" forms often clarify meaning rather than obscure it; also it was designed for oral clarity, and scholars affirm its continued intelligibility.

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[458] David Crystal, *Begat: The King James Bible and the English Language* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 257–60, especially 258.

3. History demonstrates that it functioned as the Bible of the people for 400 years.

The King James Bible is not harder; it is **sharper, clearer, and more enduring**. Its dignity does not hinder comprehension; it elevates it. As **Psalm 19:7** says: *"The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul: the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple."*

MAJOR FAQS

SECTION I: GENERAL FAQS

When it comes to the King James Bible issue, certain objections appear again and again. Many of these are less about evidence and more about assumptions, but they deserve careful answers. Below are some of the most common questions, along with responses grounded in Scripture, history, and the record of scholarship.

Q1. "How can the King James Bible be the standard, when it's just one translation among many?"

This is often the first objection raised. But the question misses a key point: every generation must have a standard. Remember, the position this book presents is "faith-based." *It is not a blind faith; it begins with faith and finds the answers from there.*

- **Psalm 12:6–7 —** God promised to preserve His words, not just their "general message."
- **Matthew 24:35 —** Christ said His words would not pass away.
- **1 Peter 1:23, 25 —** The Word of God "liveth and abideth for ever."

Somewhere in history, God must have preserved His Word in a form His people could use. The King James Bible became that standard in the English-speaking world for nearly three centuries. Missionaries, pastors, and ordinary believers measured all other translations by it. Even today, new versions constantly compare themselves against the KJV, not against each other.

Q2. "Didn't the translators themselves admit it wasn't perfect?"

It is true that the KJV translators, in their preface, acknowledged that even the "meanest [worst] translation" of the Bible could still be called the Word of God. But this humility does not undermine the providential perfection of their work.

God has often used men who did not fully grasp the scope of His plan. Jeremiah's scribes may not have realized they were producing Scripture (**Jer. 36**), but God declared it so. Similarly, the KJV translators were instruments in God's preservation work whether or not they foresaw its enduring role.

We also see from their notes in "The Translators to the Reader" that the translators were men who realized the weight of their task and had a "faith-based" view of it as well.

> "Truly, good Christian Reader, we never thought from the beginning that we should need to make a new translation, nor yet to make of a bad one a good one; but to make a good one better, or out of many good ones one principal good one, not justly to be excepted against; that hath been our endeavor, that our mark. To that purpose there were many chosen, that were greater in other men's eyes than in their own, and that sought the truth rather than their own praise … And in what sort did these assemble? In the trust of their own knowledge, or of their sharpness of wit, or deepness of judgment, as it were an arm of flesh? At no hand. They trusted in him that hath the key of *David,* opening, and no man shutting; they prayed to the Lord, the Father of our Lord, to the effect that *St. Augustine* did, *O let thy Scriptures be my pure delight; let me not be deceived in*

> *them, neither let me deceive by them.* In this confidence and with this devotion, did they assemble together; not too many, lest one should trouble another; and yet many, lest many things haply might escape them."[459]

A Note about the KJV Translators' Methods

Roughly **fifty-four** scholars were appointed, organized into **six companies** at Westminster, Cambridge, and Oxford. Each company had a defined portion:

First Westminster (Gen–2 Kgs), First Cambridge (1 Chr–Song), First Oxford (Isa–Mal), **Second Cambridge** (Apocrypha), **Second Oxford** (Gospels–Acts–Rev), **Second Westminster** (Romans–Jude).[460]

They followed fifteen translation rules (issued by Bancroft),[461] including: use the **Bishops' Bible** as the base but correct it "where it deviates from the truth of the original," **retain ecclesiastical terms** (e.g., "church," not "congregation"), and **consult earlier English Bibles** (Tyndale, Coverdale, Matthew, Great Bible, Geneva) wherever they helped. The process ran in **stages**: first, each translator worked independently; then **company sessions** compared and reconciled; finally, a **general reviewing committee** (a small group drawn from all

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[459] F. H. A. Scrivener, *The Authorized Edition of the English Bible (1611): Its Subsequent Reprints and Modern Representatives* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1884), 296–97.

[460] "An Order Set Down for the Translating of the Bible," in *Records of the English Bible: The Documents Relating to the Translation and Publication of the Bible in English, 1525–1611*, ed. Alfred W. Pollard (London: Oxford University Press, 1911), 49–51.

[461] "The Rules to Be Observed in the Translation of the Bible," in Pollard, *Records of the English Bible*, 53–55.

companies) harmonized the whole. **Marginal notes** were added sparingly, **not** to subvert authority but to acknowledge transparent alternatives in places of legitimate ambiguity. The end result is a Bible that is **textually careful** and **honest**, and whose English favors **short, concrete Anglo-Saxon diction**, deliberately chosen to lodge in the ear and memory of ordinary hearers.

The Four-Stage Review That Yielded Fifteen Examinations

1. Every translator in a company first translated the same assigned chapters independently.

2. The company met to compare, debate, and agree on its text.

3. When a book was finished by one company, it was **sent to the other companies** for serious review.

4. Unresolved differences were **escalated to a general meeting** of senior revisers drawn from all companies, who produced the final harmonized text.

In practice, this yielded roughly **fifteen examinations** of each passage before press, far beyond the workflow of modern versions.

The Fifteen Rules That Governed the Whole Work (1604)

1. **Bishops' Bible as the base**, altered only where the truth of the originals required it.

2. **Proper names** to be kept as commonly used.

3. **Ecclesiastical terms** retained (e.g., "church," not "congregation").

4. Where a word has several senses, keep the one most used by the ancient fathers, fitting the place and the analogy of faith.

5. **Chapter divisions** not to be changed (or only minimally, if necessary).

6. **No doctrinal marginal notes**; margins only to explain Hebrew/Greek words that cannot be briefly expressed in the text.

7. **Cross-references** placed in the margins as helpful.

8. **Each man to translate the same chapters privately**; then meet, confer, and agree on what shall stand.

9. When a company finishes a book, **send it to the rest** to be considered seriously and judiciously.

10. If companies **differ**, send reasons and notes; if not resolved, **compound the difference at the general meeting** of chief persons at the end.

11. For **hard places**, write to any learned man in the realm for judgment.

12. **Bishops** to notify their clergy, urging the learned to send observations to the companies at Westminster, Cambridge, or Oxford.

13. **Directors** in each company: the Dean(s) (Westminster/Chester) and the King's Hebrew/Greek Professors in each university.

14. Earlier English versions to be **used wherever they agree better with the text** than the Bishops' (Tyndale,

Matthew, Coverdale, Great Bible/Whitchurch, Geneva).

15. Besides the directors, **three or four ancient and grave divines** in each university (not otherwise employed) to act as **overseers** of the Hebrew and Greek, to secure careful observance of Rule 4.

THE SUPERIOR TRANSLATORS OF THE KJV

Lancelot Andrewes



• During his 1-2 month vacations with his family, he would find a master of a language he did not know and learn the language before returning home
• He studied Oriental Languages and Divinity at Cambridge
• He became the Lecturer of Divinity at Cambridge
• **At 24** he became the Master at Pembroke Hall
• He left the college to be the chaplain in ordinary to Queen Elizabeth, and then later he would become the Dean of Westminster
• Concerning his translation work, his work was the best among the others in his company
• He wrote all his **personal devotions in Greek**
• It was said of him that he was so skilled and versatile in languages that if he was present during the tower of Babel he could have served as interpreter general

John Bois



• **At 5 yrs old** he read through the Hebrew Bible
• **At 6 yrs old** he was able to write the Greek language in a "fair and elegant manner"
• **At 15 yrs old** he was enrolled at St. John's College in Cambridge, and at the halfway mark of his first year he was writing letters in Greek to his Masters
• While studying under one of his Masters, he had read through **12 Greek authors** in verse and prose in the most difficult dialects and phrases that could be found
• It was common for him to go to the Library at 4am and stay until 8pm
• At old age he still studied for **8 hours a day**, reading and correcting ancient authors
• He would preach without notes because he wanted to be heard and understood by the most humble and ignorant hearers

Henry Savile



• He was educated at Brasenose College in Oxford, and then soon after travelled to France to perfect himself in literature
• His specialty was **Greek and Math**, and he would end up becoming the tutor of these subjects to Queen Elizabeth; his tutoring was so successful that her study habits were clearly seen into her old age
• He was the first person to completely translate the entire work of Chrysostom (**8 huge folios**); he translated many works into Latin and English
• He served as the Warden of Merton College, Provost of Eton College

***These are just a few of the 54 outstandingly qualified translators of the KJV

THE SUPERIOR TRANSLATION METHODS OF THE KJV

1. The basic text shall be that of the Bishop's Bible, with as little altered as the truth of the original will permit.
2. People's names, including those of the authors of Biblical books, shall be retained in the ordinary spelling as far as might be.
3. The old ecclesiastical words shall be retained (ex: "church").
4. Words of more than one meaning shall be used in the sense found in most of the ancient fathers, appropriate to the context and consistent with the analogy of the faith (In addition, to avoid any formalistic, stilted literary style, a variety of English words were used to render the same Hebrew or Greek word).
5. The chapter divisions shall follow those of the Bishop's Bible.
6. No marginal notes shall be added, except for the explanation of the Hebrew or Greek words which cannot be briefly and fitly expressed in the text.
7. Cross-references shall relate to the relevant passages elsewhere in Scripture.
8. Translations and revisions were to be done first by individual, then submitted to the whole company for scrutiny, criticism, and final approval.
9. As each section of Books are completed, they shall be submitted to the other companies, "to be considered of seriously and judiciously, for his Majesty is very careful in this point."
10. If any company, upon reviewing a Book, doubt or differ upon any place, they shall notify the original company. If their objection is declined, the matter shall be settled at a general meeting.
11. In cases of special obscurity the translators shall be entitled to request assistance from any learned man in the land.
12. Each bishop shall seek the judgment of those among his clergy who are "skillful in tongues" upon the work at hand.
13. The directors of each company shall be Deans of Westminster and Chester, and the Regius Professors of Oxford and Cambridge universities.
14. The following translations shall be used when they agree better with the text than the Bishop's Bible - Tyndale, Coverdale, Matthew, the Great Bible, and the Geneva Bible.
15. Three or four of the most ancient and grave divines, from either of the universities and not employed in the translating, shall be overseers of the work.

THE UNIQUENESS OF THE KJV

It was authorized by a King (1 Peter 2:17; Ecc. 8:4)
No Copyright (2 Tim. 2:9)
Scientific (Lev. 15:13; Job 25:5; 37:7; 38:19; Ps. 75:5; 119:70)
Use of Italics (The only honest translation because it marks all connective language additions needed when making any translation.)
Self Defining (Mt. 10:1-5; Gen. 8:1-5; 17:10-11; Judges 9:24, 56; 2 Samuel 12:3)

The time in history of its translation

(A major, yet often dismissed, factor concerning the KJV is the time in history when it was translated. There are many schools of thought today that deeply affect our mindset concerning life's issues. These schools of thought affect us every day and cause different outcomes to take place in a plethora of circumstances and situations. For example: **Atheism, Rationalism and Deism** affect the decisions our government and business leaders make concerning a whole host of issues (abortion, homosexuality, prayer in schools, domestic laws, availability of anti-biblical products, etc.). At the time of the writing of the King James Bible none of these things were established arenas of thinking. **French Atheism** was not in vogue, **German Rationalists** did not exist, therefore had no influence on anyone's thinking. **English Deism** was not around so no one thought that God was "dead" or absent from his creation. Thus men could produce a Bible that without objection, a Bible that could be believed by the common man!)

The preeminence it gives to the Lord Jesus Christ

Verses kept intact - Jo. 1:18; Lk. 2:33; 1 Ti. 3:16; Acts 4:27; 8:37; 1 Jo. 5:7 (to name a few)

Signs and Maps

(The use of key words and phrases and other built-in study tools)

- That Day/The Day of the Lord
- Those Days
- Serpent; Beast; Dragon
- Sword
- Selah
- Third Day / Three Days
- The use of Numerology
- The Law of First Mention
- The use of Repetition
- Self-defining / Built-in Dictionary



The geographic location from whence it came

England is the standard for world time and direction

The fruit it has borne

- Greatest time in world missions
- More folks get saved under its preaching; more sustained growth is measured
- The fear it creates
- The enemies it has made and the controversy always surrounding it (like none other)
- Its popularity

Q3. "Isn't the language too archaic for modern readers?"

This has already been addressed at length in the previous chapter. The evidence shows the KJV is written at an eighth-grade level on average, often easier than modern versions. Its so-called "archaic" pronouns actually add precision, and its rhythm aids comprehension.

Regarding the language of the KJV compared with that of modern versions, Dr. Edward Hills had the following to say:

> "In the fourth place, modern-speech Bibles are unhistorical and irreverent. The Bible is not a modern, human book. It is not as new as the morning newspaper, and no translation should suggest this. If the Bible were this new, it would not be the Bible. On the contrary, the Bible is an ancient, divine Book, which nevertheless is always new because in it God reveals Himself. Hence the language of the Bible should be venerable as well as intelligible, and the King James Version fulfills these two requirements better than any other Bible in English. Hence it is the King James Version which converts sinners soundly and makes of them diligent Bible students. In the fifth place, modern-speech Bibles are unscholarly. The language of the Bible has always savored of the things of heaven rather than the things of earth. It has always been biblical rather than contemporary and colloquial."[462]

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[462] Edward F. Hills, *The King James Version Defended: A Christian View of the New Testament Manuscripts*, 5th ed. (Des Moines, IA: Christian Research Press, 2006), chap. 8, "The Textus Receptus and

He also stated,

> "In regard to Bible versions many contemporary Christians are behaving like spoiled and rebellious children. They want a Bible version that pleases them no matter whether it pleases God or not. 'We want a Bible version in our own idiom,' they clamor. 'We want a Bible that talks to us in the same way in which we talk to our friends over the telephone. We want an informal God, no better educated than ourselves, with a limited vocabulary and a taste for modern slang.' And having thus registered their preference, they go their several ways. Some of them unite with the modernists in using the R.S.V. or the N.E.B. Others deem the N.A.S.V. or the N.I.V. more 'evangelical.' Still others opt for the T.E.V. or the *Living Bible.* But God is bigger than you are, dear friend, and the Bible version which you must use is not a matter for you to decide according to your whims and prejudices. It has already been decided for you by the workings of God's special providence…"[463]

The Bible is not written in the language of "modern man," and it is also not written in old Elizabethan language.[464] It is written

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the King James Version," under "Why the King James Version Should Be Retained," e-book.

[463] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 9, under "Why Believing Bible Students Must Use the King James Version—A Recapitulation."

[464] *The Bible in Its Ancient and English Versions*, ed. H. Wheeler Robinson (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1954), 37.

in the language and speech of God Himself, the very words of God.

Far from being inaccessible, history proves it was the Bible of plowboys, sailors, and mothers teaching their children.

Q4. "What about the errors in the KJV? Doesn't it contradict itself?"

Critics often point to numerical differences (e.g., Ahaziah's age in **2 Kings 8:26** vs. **2 Chronicles 22:2**; Jehoiachin's age in **2 Kings 24:8** vs. **2 Chronicles 36:9**). These supposed "errors" have reasonable explanations:

- In ancient monarchies, sons often began to reign under their fathers before taking full kingship. Thus different numbers can refer to different phases of reign.

- **Numbers 25:9** lists 24,000 deaths; **1 Corinthians 10:8** says 23,000. The difference is easily explained: 23,000 in a single day, 24,000 total.

These are not contradictions but only "apparent" contradictions. They do not hold up once further investigation is done.

Q5. "Didn't the original 1611 KJV include the Apocrypha?"

Yes, the 1611 edition contained a section labeled "The Books Called Apocrypha," but crucially, they were not intermingled with the Old and New Testaments. They were set apart between Malachi and Matthew, and never treated as canonical.

By contrast, Alexandrian manuscripts such as Vaticanus and Sinaiticus do include the Apocrypha mixed in with Scripture. Origen's Hexapla did the same. The KJV translators followed

the historic Protestant practice: including Apocrypha for historical reference but marking it as non-Scriptural.

This view of the Apocrypha was stated clearly in two separate confessions around the time of the KJV translation:

> "The books commonly called Apocrypha, not being of divine inspiration, are no part of the canon of the Scripture, and therefore are of no authority."[465]

> "The Books commonly called Apocrypha not being of Divine inspiration, are no part of the Canon (or rule) of the Scripture, and therefore are of no authority to the Church of God."[466]

Q6. "Haven't there been many revisions? Which KJV is perfect?"

This objection plays on confusion between revisions and editions.

- The differences between the 1611 and modern KJV are mostly spelling and typography (e.g., sonne → son, musick → music, the "long s" that looked like "f").
- A few printing errors were corrected (e.g., the infamous "Wicked Bible" of 1631 that accidentally omitted "not" from "Thou shalt not commit adultery").
- No doctrinal or substantive changes were made.

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[465] Westminster Assembly, *The Westminster Confession of Faith* (1647), 1.3.

[466] *The Second London Baptist Confession of Faith* (1689), 1.3.

Thus, when critics claim "thousands of changes," they inflate minor printing updates. The KJV today is the same Bible as 1611, with spelling modernized.

Edward Hills titled his answer to this objection "A Feeble Rebuttal." He wrote:

> "All the editions of the King James Version from 1611 onward are still extant and have been examined minutely by F. H. A. Scrivener and other careful scholars. Aside from printers errors, these editions differ from each other only in regard to spelling, punctuation, and, in a few places, italics."[467]

The Reformers understood that correcting a printer's oversight is not tampering with God's Word. As Benjamin Wilkinson wrote, they "recognized that to reform any manifest oversight was not placing human hands on a divine work and was not contrary to the mind of the Lord."[468]

Q7. "Isn't it divisive to insist on the KJV? Shouldn't we focus on unity and love?"

Unity must be built on truth. If the Bible is our foundation, then the question of which Bible is not "minor." The apostle Paul warned that false teachers would "corrupt the word of God" (**2 Cor. 2:17**). To dismiss the issue as irrelevant is to dismiss the very source of doctrine, reproof, correction, and instruction (**2 Tim. 3:16**).

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[467] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "Which King James Version?—A Feeble Rebuttal."

[468] Benjamin G. Wilkinson, *Our Authorized Bible Vindicated* (Washington, DC: n.p., 1930), 100.

The KJV debate only feels divisive because it forces us to ask: Has God kept His promise to preserve His words? If He has, then there must be a standard text. If He has not, then all unity is built on shifting sand.

Q8. "What about people in other languages? Did God only preserve His Word in English?"

This question mixes together **two different issues:**

1. God's preserved/purified/perfect word that we can find and hold
2. Reliable translations

First, God's preserved/purified/perfect word. God promised to keep His words pure forever (**Psalm 12:6–7**). That promise applies to the Hebrew Old Testament and the Greek New Testament, faithfully preserved in the Masoretic Text and the Textus Receptus, all the way through to the English KJV. This is the promised word we can hold today, 100 percent perfect.

Second, reliable translations. When translators **faithfully** use and translate from those preserved/pure texts from Antioch, the Jewish Masoretic Text, or the KJV, people around the world can read the true Word of God in their own tongue. These Bibles are not corrupt; they give God's Word accurately and faithfully. They are reliable translations, not corruptions.

These translations may also be described as "***perfect***" in the biblical sense of the word. Remember the definition of *perfect* from the glossary:

> "From the Latin *perficere*, meaning 'complete.' The biblical definition follows the same meaning: complete,

entire, and lacking nothing needed (e.g., **Job 1:1, 8**; 2:3; **2 Tim. 3:17**)."

In other words, a faithful translation does not have to be identical in wording to the King James Bible in order to be complete and sufficient for the people who read it. If it faithfully represents the preserved Word of God in their own language, it gives them what they need to know and obey God's Word.

But Why English?

That touches on another topic for another book, but consider this: English has become the universal language of the modern world. It is the language of commerce, technology, diplomacy, and missions. More missionaries carry English Bibles than any other. English is the language of the end times. English possesses an extraordinarily large vocabulary and has been described by scholars as having the largest vocabulary among the major languages of the world.[469] One language scholar states simply, "English has the largest vocabulary of any language."[470] This extensive vocabulary allows such a remarkable ability to express fine distinctions in meaning, description, and nuance. It makes sense, then, that God would bring His purified Word into the language that would be universal.

Here's the bottom line:

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[469] Peter Hu, "Adapting English into Chinese," *English Today* 20, no. 2 (April 2004): 34, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0266078404002068.

[470] James B. Carter, "English Spelling Reform," *Prometheus* 24, no. 1 (March 2006): 83, https://doi.org/10.1080/08109020600563952.

- In many languages today, we have **reliable, accurate, uncorrupted Bibles** when they are translated from the preserved Hebrew and Greek texts and the KJV.

- But in English, God has given us the **purified Bible**, His words refined and perfected in the King James Bible.

This isn't "English-only salvation." It is simply recognizing that God made a promise to preserve His words and to purify them, and that promise found its final home in the English KJV.

Also, consider that just as God used the New Testament priesthood of the believers to confirm the preserved text throughout church history (leading to the TR and Majority Text), He also did the same thing with the King James Bible.

Many other English translations existed before the King James, and there were also other translations into other languages. Despite this, the King James Bible was more widely received by the church as a whole than any other translation effort. It was confirmed by the people of God, through the Spirit of God indwelling His people.

The King James Bible was taken around the world, was used to help others learn English, and became a basis for modern missions on a scale the world had never seen. It was "Authorized" by the people of God for hundreds of years as the standard Bible. This reception of the King James Bible is another great evidence for God's hand on it. Its reception exceeded that of earlier English translations and other-language translations produced at the time or since.

The historical record confirms this reception. Kenyon noted that between 1611 and 1644 the *Historical Catalogue* of the British and Foreign Bible Society lists fifteen editions of the Geneva Bible

and 182 of the Authorized Version. He also noted that the King James Bible's victory became complete "just at the time when Church and State were overthrown, and when the Puritan party was dominant." In other words, it did not win by government force. Kenyon concluded:

> "It was its superior merits, and its total freedom from party or sectarian spirit, that secured the triumph of the Authorised Version."[471]

Hills added that the King James Bible "has been used by many missionaries as a basis and guide for their own translation work and in this way has extended its influence even to converts who know no English," and he concluded:

> "Surely this is a God-guided translation on which God working providentially, has placed the stamp of His approval."[472]

Q9. "Aren't today's scholars better equipped than those in 1611?"

The KJV translators were among the most skilled linguists ever assembled. Many spoke 8–15 languages fluently.[473] They had access to all the major manuscripts in existence at the time,

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[471] Frederic G. Kenyon, *Our Bible and the Ancient Manuscripts: Being a History of the Text and Its Translations*, 4th ed. (London: Eyre and Spottiswoode, 1903), 232.

[472] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "The King James Version Translators Providentially Guided—Preface to the Reader."

[473] At his funeral Lancelot Andrewes was said to have been "conversant with fifteen languages." Alexander W. McClure, *The Translators Revived: A Biographical Memoir of the Authors of the English Version of the Holy Bible* (New York: Charles Scribner, 1853), 87.

including those still used today. They worked in teams, cross-checking one another's work in ways modern committees rarely match.

Modern technology has given us searchable databases, but truth is not found in computers; it is found in the words God preserved. The translators of 1611 were not hindered by lack of technology; they were aided by unparalleled scholarship and divine providence.

Q10. "If the KJV is perfect, why not call it inspired?"

We do not say the KJV was newly inspired in 1611. We say it is preserved and purified providentially by God. Just as God told Jeremiah to rewrite His words after Jehoiakim destroyed the original scroll (**Jer. 36**), even adding "many like words," so God has preserved and purified His Word through history. Inspiration is the initial giving; preservation is the keeping; purification is the providential refining and settling.

The KJV is the fruit of God's promise to keep His words pure for every generation (**Ps. 12:6–7**).

Q11. "Why does the KJV say 'Easter' in Acts 12:4? Isn't that a mistake?"

Not at all. This is actually one of those places where the King James translators showed real discernment. The Greek word *pascha* can mean "Passover," but it can also mean the larger festival season that followed. Verse 3 has already told us "then were the days of unleavened bread," which means the Jewish Passover had already happened. If you try to force "Passover" into verse 4, it makes no sense; Herod would be planning Peter's execution *after* a feast that was already over. This places

a flat-out contradiction into modern versions that use "Passover" here instead of "Easter."

The calendar of the law confirms this. Leviticus 23:5–6 sets the Passover on the fourteenth day of the first month and the feast of unleavened bread on the fifteenth. D. A. Waite drew the conclusion:

> "If it was already the 'days of unleavened bread' or the 15th of the month, how could the 14th of the month come after the 15th?"[474]

The King James translators were not innovating here, either. As Waite notes, they "followed Tyndale and many other translations in rendering this 'Easter' in Acts 12:4."[475]

On top of that, remember who we're dealing with: **Herod was a pagan king.** He wasn't a God-fearing Jew who cared about honoring Passover. He would have no reason to arrange his schedule around a Jewish holy day. What he *would* have cared about was avoiding trouble with the crowds during a major festival period. At that time, the spring festival season was commonly called "Easter" in English. That word referred to the broader pagan holiday season that overlapped with the Jewish calendar.

The King James translators used "Easter" here to show exactly that: Herod wasn't waiting for a Jewish feast to end, but for the whole pagan festival season to pass before bringing Peter out.

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[474] Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 300.

[475] Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 299–300.

That way he could avoid a riot and still look like he was acting decisively.

So rather than being an error, "Easter" in **Acts 12:4** is the **precise word choice**. It reflects both the context (the Jewish Passover had already passed) and the character of Herod (an "Edomite" by ancestry but a pagan ruler by practice who would think in terms of pagan holidays, not Jewish ones). Modern versions that change it to "Passover" actually create a contradiction and miss the historical situation Luke is describing.

Q12. "Why does the KJV use italicized words?"

When you see *italicized* words in the KJV, the translators aren't sneaking in doctrine; they're being upfront with you. Biblical Hebrew and Greek often leave out little words that English requires for a smooth, grammatical sentence (think of the linking verb "is," a supplied subject, or a helper like "there is/are"). To make the English read naturally **without** changing the meaning, the KJV team supplied those necessary words and then **flagged them in italics** so you can see exactly what was added for clear English.

Keep these three points in mind:

- **What italics do mean:** a word has been **supplied** in English because the sense is implied in the original languages.

- **What italics do not mean:** they are **not** signals of doubt, error, or guesswork. The translators are simply showing their work.

- **Other Bibles do this too:** every translation supplies words to make the English translation make sense. *Most modern versions just don't mark them.*

SECTION II: TECHNICAL FAQS

Q13. "Did Erasmus 'add' the Johannine Comma (1 John 5:7–8) to please critics? Isn't it late?"

The claim: Erasmus supposedly gave in to pressure and inserted "in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one," even though the reading was late.

The record with dates: the Greek manuscript support is late, but the reading was known much earlier in Latin writing, Scripture quotation, and church use.

Greek Manuscript Evidence

- GA 629 (Ottobonianus), A.D. 1362–1363: the earliest dated Greek manuscript with a Comma form in the main text.
- GA 61 (Montfortianus), c. A.D. 1495–1521: contains a Comma form in the biblical text.
- GA 918, c. A.D. 1573–1578: contains a Comma form in the biblical text.
- GA 2473 (A.D. 1634) and GA 2318 (eighteenth century) also contain main-text forms. Five other Greek manuscripts contain later marginal forms.

Early Witnesses Before A.D. 550

Early supporting witnesses include:

- Tertullian, c. A.D. 210, Against Praxeas 25: related three-one language joining the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

- Cyprian, c. A.D. 250, *On the Unity of the Church* 6: introduces the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit wording with "it is written" and concludes, "And these three are one."[476]

- *Expositio Fidei*, A.D. 367–400: an explicit Father, Word, and Spirit three-one form.

- Priscillian, c. A.D. 380, Liber Apologeticus 1.4: an explicit full Latin heavenly-witness formula.[477]

- Codex Speculum, fifth century: contains the Comma in a collection of Latin Scripture quotations.

- *Contra Varimadum*, c. A.D. 450: contains an explicit heavenly-witness form.

- The confession of the African bishops at Carthage under Huneric, A.D. 484: contains an explicit heavenly-witness form.[478]

- Fulgentius of Ruspe, c. A.D. 527: supports the reading in Contra Arianos, Contra Fabianum, and De Trinitate ad Felicem.

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[476] Cyprian, *On the Unity of the Church* 6, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 5:423.

[477] Priscillian, *Liber Apologeticus* 1.4, in *Priscillian of Avila: The Complete Works*, ed. and trans. Marco Conti (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 36.

[478] Victor of Vita, *History of the Vandal Persecution* 2.82, trans. John Moorhead (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 1992), 56. The passage belongs to the confession of faith that the African bishops presented at Carthage in A.D. 484.

Cassiodorus is also an early-sixth-century supporting witness, though his work is broadly dated A.D. 501–600 and cannot be placed securely before A.D. 550.

Printed Editions and Erasmus

- The Complutensian Polyglot printed the Comma in its Greek New Testament in 1514, before Erasmus's third edition appeared.

- Erasmus's first two editions omitted the Comma. His third edition of 1522 included it, and it continued through Stephanus and Beza into the Received Text.

Henk Jan de Jonge showed that there is no evidence Erasmus promised to insert the Comma if shown a Greek manuscript. That story developed later.[479] [480]

Q14. "Is the Longer Ending of Mark (16:9–20) a later addition?"

The claim: Critics argue that Mark's Gospel originally ended at 16:8 and that verses 9–20 were a later church addition.

The record with dates: **Mark 16:9–20** is the reading in approximately 1,653 Greek manuscripts and more than 1,000 Greek lectionaries. The principal Greek manuscripts ending at 16:8 are **Sinaiticus, Vaticanus**, and minuscule 304.

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[479] Henk Jan de Jonge, "Erasmus and the Comma Johanneum," *Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses* 56, no. 4 (1980): 381–85, 389.

[480] Bruce M. Metzger and Bart D. Ehrman, *The Text of the New Testament: Its Transmission, Corruption, and Restoration*, 4th ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), 146–48, especially 147.

Greek Manuscript Evidence Before A.D. 550

- Codex Alexandrinus (A), fifth century: contains the longer ending.
- Codex Ephraemi Rescriptus (C), fifth century: contains the longer ending.
- Codex Bezae (D), fifth century: contains the longer ending.
- Codex Washingtonianus (W), fourth or fifth century: contains the longer ending.

Supporting Literary and Patristic Witnesses Before A.D. 550

- *Epistula Apostolorum*, before A.D. 150: reflects awareness of the longer ending.
- Justin Martyr, second century: uses language connected with **Mark 16:20**.
- Tatian and the Diatessaron, c. A.D. 170: include material from **Mark 16:9–20**.
- Irenaeus, c. A.D. 180, *Against Heresies* 3.10.5: directly quotes **Mark 16:19** near the conclusion of Mark's Gospel.[481]
- Asterius, fourth century: gives a close quotation connected with **Mark 16:17**.

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[481] Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 3.10.5, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 426.

- Ephrem Syrus, c. A.D. 360: uses **Mark 16:15** in connection with Tatian's Diatessaron.

- *Apostolic Constitutions*, A.D. 367–400: directly uses material from **Mark 16:9** and 16:15–19.

- Macarius Magnes, A.D. 367–433: directly uses **Mark 16:9, 15**, 17, and 18.

- Ambrose, A.D. 374–397: uses resurrection and commission material from the longer ending.

- Epiphanius, c. A.D. 377: directly quotes **Mark 16:19**.

- Augustine, c. A.D. 400: receives and discusses the longer ending.

- Jerome, A.D. 401–433: uses the passage in Epistle 120.3.

- Philostorgius, fifth century: gives a close quotation connected with **Mark 16:17**.

- Nestorius, fifth century: uses material connected with **Mark 16:20**.

- Cyril of Alexandria, fifth century: uses material connected with **Mark 16:20**.

Early Versions Before A.D. 550

- Old Latin, second to fourth centuries: contains the longer ending.

- Vulgate, c. A.D. 400: contains the longer ending.

- Syriac Peshitta and the surviving Curetonian Syriac: preserve the longer ending or its final verses.

- Gothic version, fourth century: contains the longer ending.

The longer ending was therefore known in the second century, transmitted in major fifth-century Greek codices, and received across the Greek, Latin, Syriac, and Gothic traditions. For a full-length defense, see John Burgon's The Last Twelve Verses of the Gospel according to S. Mark.[482]

Q15. "Why does the KJV have Acts 8:37 (the eunuch's confession) when many modern versions omit it?"

The claim: **Acts 8:37**, with Philip's requirement of faith and the eunuch's confession that Jesus Christ is the Son of God, is absent from many early Greek manuscripts, so modern versions omit it or place it in a footnote.

The earliest surviving Greek witness with the verse is Codex Laudianus (E), broadly dated c. A.D. 550–650, so no surviving Greek support can be placed securely before A.D. 550. The confession is nevertheless witnessed earlier in Christian quotations and the Latin tradition.[483]

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[482] John William Burgon, *The Last Twelve Verses of the Gospel according to S. Mark Vindicated against Recent Critical Objectors and Established* (Oxford: James Parker and Co., 1871).

[483] On Codex Laudianus (E, sixth century), see Metzger and Ehrman, *Text of the New Testament*, 74.

Supporting Witnesses Before A.D. 550

- Irenaeus, c. A.D. 180, Against Heresies 3.12.8: records the confession, "I believe Jesus Christ to be the Son of God."
- Irenaeus, c. A.D. 180, Against Heresies 4.23.2: gives an additional allusion to the confession tradition.
- Cyprian, c. A.D. 250: quotes the baptismal condition, "If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest."[484]
- Pacian of Barcelona, c. A.D. 370: uses the eunuch's confession tradition.
- Ambrose, c. A.D. 380: uses the eunuch's confession tradition.
- Augustine, c. A.D. 400: uses the eunuch's confession tradition.
- The Old Latin tradition contains the verse, and the Vulgate preserves it in the Latin biblical stream.

Conclusion

Acts 8:37 was therefore known in substance by A.D. 180 and was present in the Latin church long before Erasmus. Its early history does not depend on a medieval Greek manuscript.

The Greek manuscript support is later and varied, but the confession itself is ancient. The Received Text and the King

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[484] Cyprian, *Three Books of Testimonies against the Jews* 3.43, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, 5:545.

James Bible preserve a reading already known in early Christian teaching and baptismal practice.

Q16. "Didn't Erasmus insert commentary or back-translate into Revelation? Doesn't that prove corruption in the Textus Receptus and the KJV?"

Manuscript and Historical Evidence

When Erasmus prepared his first Greek New Testament in 1516, his only Greek manuscript of Revelation, Codex 1r, lacked the final leaf. He supplied **Revelation 22:16–21** by translating from the Latin biblical tradition. Critics cite this as proof of corruption, but the evidence shows otherwise: the Latin wording preserved a genuine reading that was not available in his incomplete Greek copy.[485] [486] [487]

- Erasmus did not add personal commentary. He supplied biblical text already found in the Latin tradition.

- Some of his reconstructed expressions have parallels in later-known Greek manuscripts, though not every exact form does.

- At **Revelation 22:19**, no surviving Greek manuscript reads the exact Received Text form βιβλου ("*book*"). Minuscule 61

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[485] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "The Human Aspect of the Textus Receptus."

[486] Jan Krans, "Erasmus and the Text of Revelation 22:19: A Critique of Thomas Holland's *Crowned with Glory*," *TC: A Journal of Biblical Textual Criticism* 16 (2011): 3–5, 14–15.

[487] See Samuel Prideaux Tregelles, *An Account of the Printed Text of the Greek New Testament* (London: Samuel Bagster and Sons, 1854), 21.

and a corrector of 2067 have the related form βιβλίου, while Latin witnesses preserve *"book of life"* much earlier.

Witnesses Dated Before or Around A.D. 550

Supporting and competing witnesses include:

- Acts of Saturninus, A.D. 300–499: supports "book of life."
- Ambrose of Milan, A.D. 339–397: supports "book of life."
- Bachiarius, late fourth century: supports "book of life."
- Tyconius, A.D. 380–385: supports "tree of life."
- Primasius of Hadrumetum, c. A.D. 540–560: supports "book of life."
- Apringius of Beja, c. A.D. 540–560: supports "tree of life."

Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus, fourth and fifth centuries, read "tree of life." The earliest "book of life" support is therefore Latin rather than an exact surviving Greek manuscript.

The Faith-Based Purification Perspective

From the faith-based position of this book, Erasmus's use of the Latin tradition is not treated as permission to invent Scripture. It is understood as one way God used more than one line of transmission to preserve the received reading.

- God allowed Erasmus's Greek manuscript to end before the close of Revelation.
- Erasmus supplied the missing verses from a biblical Latin text already used in the church.

- The reading then passed through the Received Text and into the King James Bible.

The evidence should be stated plainly: the exact Greek word βιβλου is first found in Erasmus's printed text, while earlier Latin witnesses support "book of life" and later Greek manuscripts preserve related "book" forms. Within this book's position, that combined history is understood as providential preservation.

God's Word did not depend on the survival of one final Greek leaf. The reading was carried through the church's textual history and received in the King James Bible.

> *For further study and additional evidence concerning disputed KJV readings, including manuscripts, ancient translations, and early Christian writers, visit my website* ***OldestAndBest.com.***

Q17. "What did Erasmus and the King James translators know about Codex Vaticanus?"

Part 1. Did Erasmus ever see or use Codex Vaticanus?

Erasmus never handled Codex Vaticanus himself, but he was not ignorant of it. During the heat of the controversy over **1 John 5:7–8**, the famous *Comma Johanneum*, he wrote to friends in Rome asking whether that verse appeared in the Vatican manuscript. The Vatican librarian, **Paulus Bombasius**, answered him in a letter dated June 18, 1521. In that reply, Bombasius copied out the verses from **1 John 4–5** straight from

Vaticanus, and the passage confirmed that the words defending the Trinity were not present in that manuscript.[488]

More than a decade later, in **1533**, the Spanish scholar **Juan Ginés de Sepúlveda** wrote Erasmus from Rome and sent him a lengthy report of variant readings drawn from the Vatican codex. The letter supposedly contained hundreds of places where Vaticanus differed from Erasmus's printed Greek text.[489] Even apart from correspondence, Erasmus shows in his own **Annotations** that he knew Vaticanus existed and that he sometimes checked its readings. A good example appears in his notes on **Acts 27:16**, where he refers directly to "*the Vatican* manuscript" and records its reading of *Cauda* instead of the more familiar *Clauda*.[490]

So while Erasmus never possessed a full copy of Vaticanus, the evidence is clear: he knew of the manuscript, he requested and received its readings, and in at least one place he cited it by name in his own published notes.

Part 2. Did Erasmus deliberately reject the readings of Vaticanus?

Erasmus often knew about Vaticanus readings, but he almost always left them aside. He had only a few manuscripts in Basel at his disposal when he produced his editions, and those manuscripts belonged to the Byzantine tradition. When

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[488] Tregelles, *Account of the Printed Text of the Greek New Testament*, 22.

[489] Kenyon, *Our Bible and the Ancient Manuscripts*, 133.

[490] Desiderius Erasmus, *Erasmus' Annotations on the New Testament: Acts–Romans–I and II Corinthians*, ed. Anne Reeve and M. A. Screech (Leiden: Brill, 1990), 931.

Vaticanus disagreed with the bulk of evidence he could see, Erasmus considered it untrustworthy. In fact, he even complained that Vaticanus seemed to have been influenced too heavily by the Latin tradition, which made it suspicious to him.[491]

The note on **Acts 27:16** illustrates his approach. He faithfully reports that Vaticanus reads *Cauda*, but he did not change his printed text. The same pattern appears elsewhere. Even when he was shown a long list of differences in 1533, he did not alter the foundation of his text. It wasn't ignorance, and it wasn't laziness; it was a conscious judgment call. Erasmus believed the manuscripts in his hands represented the text of the New Testament more accurately than a single manuscript in Rome, no matter how ancient it might have been.

In the end, his editions became the backbone of what was later called the **Textus Receptus**. That text, in turn, was the foundation that guided the English translators in 1611.

Part 3. Did the King James translators have access to Vaticanus or Sinaiticus?

The short answer is yes and no. **Codex Sinaiticus** was not discovered until the 1800s by Tischendorf, so it had no influence on the King James Bible at all.

Codex Vaticanus is a more complicated story. Direct access to the manuscript itself was extremely limited in the early seventeenth century, and no team in England had the ability to

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[491] F. H. A. Scrivener, *A Plain Introduction to the Criticism of the New Testament for the Use of Biblical Students*, ed. Edward Miller, 4th ed., 2 vols. (London: George Bell and Sons, 1894), 1:119–20.

sit down with the actual codex in the Vatican Library. However, the translators did encounter Vaticanus in two important ways.

First, they worked with the best printed Greek editions of their day, especially those of Beza. Beza's editions occasionally mention variant readings taken from older manuscripts, including Vaticanus, even when he refused to put them into the text. Through Beza's notes, the English translators would have been aware that Vaticanus sometimes supported different readings from those in the Textus Receptus.

Second, and even more directly, the Old Testament translators used the **Sixtine Septuagint of 1587**. This was the official Roman Catholic edition of the Greek Old Testament, and it was based almost entirely on Codex Vaticanus.[492] We know from the notes of **John Bois**, one of the KJV translators, that he worked carefully through this printed LXX while revising the Apocrypha.[493] That means, at least on the Old Testament side, the King James translators held a Vaticanus-based text in their hands and made use of it during their work.

So, while the translators did not sit with Codex Vaticanus open on the table, they were not strangers to it either. They knew its readings through the printed editions they relied upon, and in the Old Testament they worked directly from a published text drawn straight from Vaticanus. Their decision to rest on the

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[492] Henry Barclay Swete, *An Introduction to the Old Testament in Greek* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1900), 174–78.

[493] Nicholas Hardy, "Revising the King James Apocrypha: John Bois, Isaac Casaubon, and the Case of 1 Esdras," in *Labourers in the Vineyard of the Lord: Erudition and the Making of the King James Version of the Bible*, ed. Mordechai Feingold (Leiden: Brill, 2018), 266–327.

Hebrew text in the Old Testament and the Received Text in the New Testament was not because they had never heard of Vaticanus, but because they believed the texts they chose represented the Bible more faithfully and more securely than the alternatives.

Q18. "Is the King James Bible (KJV) copyrighted?"

This is one of the most common questions about the King James Bible, and it's important to answer it precisely. The short answer is no: the original 1611 **King James Version** is **not under modern copyright protection** in most of the world, but there are a few **historical and legal nuances** that explain why some printed editions still show a copyright notice.

The Original 1611 Text Is in the Public Domain

The text of the KJV completed in **1611 under King James I** was published more than four centuries ago. All copyright terms have long expired, and therefore the original text, the words themselves, are in the public domain worldwide, except in a few limited cases related to royal charters in the United Kingdom. Anyone can freely print, publish, quote, or distribute the KJV text without paying royalties or obtaining permission.

The "Crown Copyright" in the United Kingdom

In England, Scotland, and Wales, a unique historical arrangement known as **Crown Copyright** (or more precisely, the **Royal Letters Patent**) still governs the *authorized publication* of the King James Bible. When the KJV was first produced, it was printed "by His Majesty's special command." The exclusive right to print the Bible in the United Kingdom was granted by royal charter to specific presses, most notably **Cambridge**

University Press, **Oxford University Press**, and **Collins (HarperCollins UK)**.

That royal privilege remains in force even today. The **British Crown** technically still holds control over who may print the KJV for sale *within the United Kingdom* (under the supervision of the **Queen's Printer** or **King's Printer**). However, this is a *legal privilege*, not a creative copyright. It does **not** extend to the text itself, and it does **not** apply outside the UK and certain Commonwealth territories.

Modern Printings and Layout Copyrights

While the words of the KJV are public domain, modern publishers sometimes hold copyright on **their specific editions**, such as:

- Typesetting, formatting, and design (font, layout, pagination)
- Study notes, cross-references, headings, concordances, and introductions
- Spelling modernization or minor editorial standardizations

For example, the **Cambridge Paragraph Bible (1873, ed. F. H. A. Scrivener)** is public domain, but a modern reprint of it by Cambridge University Press may be copyright-protected because of the page design and supplementary materials. Similarly, digital formats like those used by Bible apps may carry a copyright on the electronic data file, not on the Scripture itself.

What This Means Practically

- **You may freely quote, reproduce, and publish the KJV text** in print or digital form, so long as you are using a public-domain edition and not copying a publisher's proprietary formatting or notes.

- **Within the United Kingdom**, only the authorized publishers may legally print entire KJV Bibles for sale under the Crown Letters Patent.

- **Outside the UK**, the King James Bible is entirely in the **public domain**, and no permissions or royalties are required.

SECTION III: ANSWERING THE LEADING CRITICS

The questions in the first two sections are the ones ordinary readers ask. This section answers the objections as leading critics of the King James position have stated them in their own published words. Wesley Huff's arguments have been answered throughout this book. Here the objections come from Daniel Wallace, James White and the ministry he directs, and Mark Ward, together with the revisers of 1881, whose preface set the terms of the debate. Each critic is quoted from his own writing, so that the answer addresses what he actually said.

Q19. "Isn't the King James position 'based more on tradition, misinformation, and conspiracy' than on scholarship?"

This charge was made in an article published by Alpha and Omega Ministries, the ministry of James White. Its author, Colin Smith, wrote that those who hold the King James position "cannot be considered among rational, textual scholars," and that the position "is, therefore, based more on tradition,

misinformation, and conspiracy than on real scholarly textual research."[494]

A conspiracy is a secret plan. Nothing in this book depends on a secret. What this book says about the two lines of Bibles and the Revision of 1881 rests on published documents: the decrees of the Council of Trent, the preface of the Rheims New Testament, the letters of Westcott and Hort published by their own sons, the preface of the revisers, the tract of a Unitarian reviser, the agreement between the Vatican and the United Bible Societies, and the introductions written by the editors of the modern Greek text. Readers can check every one of them. When a critic calls the quotation of such documents "conspiracy," he is not answering the documents.

The charge of "tradition" is closer to the mark, though not in the way the critic intended. This book does hold that the text God's people received and used is a witness to what God preserved. That is not a weakness. It is the principle Scripture itself gives: "unto them were committed the oracles of God" (Rom. 3:2). And the scholarship behind the Received Text is not insignificant. Dean Burgon's index of the New Testament quotations in the Fathers filled sixteen thick volumes, now in the British Museum.[495] F. H. A. Scrivener, whose *Plain Introduction to the Criticism of the New Testament* is still consulted

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[494] Colin Smith, "An Introduction to Textual Criticism: Part 8—'Traditional Text' Positions: Textus Receptus and Majority Text Only," Alpha and Omega Ministries, April 19, 2008, https://www.aomin.org/aoblog/textual-issues/an-introduction-to-textual-criticism-part-8-traditional-text-positions-textus-receptus-and-majority-text-only/.

[495] John William Burgon, *The Traditional Text of the Holy Gospels Vindicated and Established*, ed. Edward Miller (London: George Bell and Sons, 1896), vi.

by textual critics, gave a chapter to Hort's theory, which his table of contents summarizes as "Hort's theory examined and condemned."[496] The disagreement between this book and its critics is not between scholarship and ignorance. It is between two starting points: a text received by faith in God's promise, and a text reconstructed by methods that set that promise aside.

The same article described the King James position as positing "a 17th century English version as the only infallible Word of God." This book teaches that the inspired words were preserved in the Hebrew and Greek texts God's people received, that faithful translations of those texts are the Word of God in other languages, and that in English those words have been purified and settled in the King James Bible.

Q20. "Isn't preservation a late doctrine that the Bible doesn't really teach?"

Daniel Wallace, one of the best-known evangelical textual critics, has argued exactly this. He wrote that "the doctrine of preservation was not a doctrine of the ancient church. In fact, it was not stated in any creed until the seventeenth century (in the Westminster Confession of 1646)." He went further, contending that "not only is the majority text argument for preservation entirely wrong-headed, but so is any doctrine of preservation which requires that the exact wording of the text be preserved at all."[497]

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[496] Scrivener, *Plain Introduction*, 2:vi, 274.

[497] Daniel B. Wallace, "Inspiration, Preservation, and New Testament Textual Criticism," *Grace Theological Journal* 12, no. 1 (1991): 41–42.

Consider first the argument from the creeds. Wallace's complaint is that preservation "was not stated in any creed until the seventeenth century." But a Bible believer does not settle a doctrine by asking whether a creed stated it. He asks whether the Bible teaches it. A creed can only repeat, well or badly, what God has already said. "All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works" (2 Tim. 3:16–17). The Bereans were called noble because they "searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so" (Acts 17:11), and they tested the preaching of an apostle that way. "To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them" (Isa. 8:20). So the question is not whether Wallace's statement agrees with the creeds. The question is whether it agrees with the Bible.

The Bible gives no reason to set the councils of men above the Word of God, and it often shows them set against it. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD, and against his anointed" (Ps. 2:2). The blessed man "walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly" (Ps. 1:1). When the chief priests and the Pharisees gathered a council against the Lord Jesus, "from that day forth they took counsel together for to put him to death" (John 11:47, 53). At His trial "the chief priests, and elders, and all the council, sought false witness against Jesus" (Matt. 26:59). The same council "commanded them not to speak at all nor teach in the name of Jesus," and the apostles answered, "We ought to obey God rather than men" (Acts 4:18; 5:29). The Lord charged the religious leaders of Israel with "teaching for doctrines the commandments of men" and with "making the word of God of none effect through your tradition" (Matt. 15:9; Mark 7:13).

Even the one council the New Testament approves, at Jerusalem, settled its question by the Scriptures: "to this agree the words of the prophets; as it is written" (Acts 15:15).

The Scriptures themselves are the first witness to their own preservation. When the Lord Jesus stood up in the synagogue at Nazareth, He read from the book of Isaiah that was handed to Him and said, "This day is this scripture fulfilled in your ears" (Luke 4:21). Isaiah had been dead for centuries. The scroll in that synagogue was a copy, and the Lord called it scripture. Timothy had known "the holy scriptures" from a child (2 Tim. 3:15), and the very next verse says that all scripture "is given by inspiration of God." The Bible does not save the name of Scripture for autographs no one could read. It gives that name to the copies God's people held in their hands.

The case for preservation does not depend on creeds or church fathers. But since Wallace appealed to history, history answers him, and this book has already shown how ancient the testimony of God's people is. In the first century Josephus wrote of the Jewish Scriptures that "during so many ages as have already passed, no one has been so bold as either to add any thing to them, to take any thing from them, or to make any change in them."[498] In the second century Irenaeus wrote that "the Scriptures are indeed perfect, since they were spoken by the Word of God and His Spirit," and he warned that "there shall be no light punishment upon him who either adds or subtracts anything from the Scriptures."[499] Dionysius of Corinth complained that men had attempted to corrupt the writings of

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[498] Josephus, *Against Apion* 1.8 (Niese 1.42).

[499] Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 2.28.2; 5.30.1, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, 1:399, 558–59.

the Lord, and Gaius named the heretics who prepared corrupted copies of the Scriptures.[500] In A.D. 367 Athanasius closed his list of the books of Scripture with the words, "Let no man add to these, neither let him take ought from these."[501] Men do not guard against the corruption of a text they believe was never kept. The doctrine of preservation did not begin in 1646. It is as old as the Scriptures themselves.

The more serious claim is that the Bible does not teach preservation. Wallace argued that the texts usually cited for it are better read as "statements concerning either divine ethical principles (i.e., moral laws which cannot be violated without some kind of consequences) or the promise of fulfilled prophecy." He also pointed out that 1 Peter 1:23–25, quoting Isaiah 40:8, uses *rhēma* rather than *logos*, "a term which typically refers to the spoken word."[502]

But the Lord Jesus used *rhēma* of the written Word. When He answered the devil He said, "It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God" (Matt. 4:4). The word "word" there is *rhēma* (ῥήματι), and Christ introduced it with "It is written," quoting Deuteronomy 8:3 from the written law. Peter himself identifies the *rhēma* that endures for ever: "And this is the word which by the gospel is preached unto you" (1 Pet. 1:25). The preached word is the Scripture preached.

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[500] Dionysius of Corinth, quoted in Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 4.23.12; Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 5.28.13–19; both in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., 1:201, 248.

[501] Athanasius, *Letter* 39.6, 552.

[502] Wallace, "Inspiration, Preservation," 42.

And some of the promises cannot be turned into "ethical principles" at all. "Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law" (Matt. 5:18). A jot is the smallest letter of the Hebrew alphabet, and a tittle is a small stroke of the pen. The Lord was speaking of written marks on a page. "The words of the LORD are pure words… Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever" (Ps. 12:6–7). These promises speak of words, and they speak of keeping them.

Q21. "Isn't the desire for a certain text just 'psychological insecurity'?"

In the same article Wallace wrote that the search for a certain text, "though often masquerading as a legitimate epistemological inquiry, is really a presuppositional stance, rooted in a psychological insecurity."[503]

But God Himself wrote so that His people could be certain. Solomon asked, "Have not I written to thee excellent things in counsels and knowledge, That I might make thee know the certainty of the words of truth; that thou mightest answer the words of truth to them that send unto thee?" (Prov. 22:20–21). Luke wrote "that thou mightest know the certainty of those things, wherein thou hast been instructed" (Luke 1:4), and the Greek speaks of the certainty (*asphaleia*) of the words (*logōn*).[504] Peter called the Scripture "a more sure word of prophecy;

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[503] Wallace, "Inspiration, Preservation," 38.

[504] Joseph Henry Thayer, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (New York: American Book Company, 1889), s.v. "ἀσφάλεια."

whereunto ye do well that ye take heed" (2 Pet. 1:19). John wrote "that ye may know that ye have eternal life" (1 John 5:13).

A believer who wants to know the certainty of the words of truth is not showing psychological insecurity. He is doing what the Scripture says it was written for. Faith rests on what God has said, and God has said that He would keep His words. The uncertainty lies on the other side, with a Greek text whose editors now describe their work as a "hypothesis" and mark places where they cannot decide what the apostles wrote.

Q22. "Don't the textual differences leave every doctrine untouched?"

This is the most common reassurance given to believers. Wallace put it this way: "the variations between the majority text and modern critical texts are qualitatively very minor; most would say that no doctrine is affected by such differences." For support he cited D. A. Carson's *The King James Version Debate*.[505]

One of the revisers of 1881 disagreed. George Vance Smith, the Unitarian member of the New Testament company, wrote in the year the Revised Version appeared that the claim that "the great doctrines of popular theology remain unaffected" was, "in the most substantial sense contrary to the facts of the case." He noted that 1 John 5:7 had been removed and that the word "God" had been removed from 1 Timothy 3:16, and he asked whether these changes were not "wholly unfavourable to the

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[505] Wallace, "Inspiration, Preservation," 34, citing D. A. Carson, *The King James Version Debate: A Plea for Realism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1979), 56.

popular theology."[506] A man who denied the Trinity knew which changes helped him.

Wallace himself, one page later in the same article, described the differences between the Received Text and the Majority Text and said, "Many of these passages are theologically significant texts," citing 1 John 5:7–8 and Revelation 22:19.[507] If textual differences can touch theologically significant texts in that comparison, they can do so in others, and this book has shown where they do.

There is also a deeper answer. Even where a doctrine is taught elsewhere, the removal of a verse removes a witness to it. The Lord did not say that man lives by the doctrines of Scripture in general. He said that man lives "by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God" (Matt. 4:4).

Q23. "Aren't the fuller readings of the Received Text just an 'expansion of piety' by later scribes?"

James White is known for this explanation. Replying to a critic of his book, he wrote, "In discussing the differences between the later Byzantine texts and the earlier Alexandrian manuscripts, I discussed, rather fully, the concept of the 'expansion of piety.'" He summed up the issue as "what did the apostles and prophets write under the inspiration of the Holy

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[506] G. Vance Smith, *Texts and Margins of the Revised New Testament Affecting Theological Doctrine Briefly Reviewed* (London: British and Foreign Unitarian Association, 1881), 45–47.

[507] Wallace, "Inspiration, Preservation," 35 and n. 49.

Spirit," not "what a pious scribe thought a thousand years later."[508]

This book agrees that the question of what the apostles and prophets wrote is a valid question. But the theory of "expansion of piety" assumes the answer before it looks at the evidence. It assumes that the Byzantine readings arose "a thousand years later." But readings once dismissed as late have been found in papyri older than Vaticanus and Sinaiticus. Günther Zuntz found that "a number of Byzantine readings, most of them genuine, which previously were discarded as 'late', are anticipated by P46," and Harry Sturz catalogued about 150 distinctively Byzantine readings with early papyrus support.[509]

The theory also assumes that scribes tended to add. The evidence points the other way. James Royse found that the scribes of the early papyri he studied omitted more often than they added, and E. C. Colwell said the scribe of Papyrus 45 "wielded a sharp axe."[510] If early scribes more often shortened

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[508] James White, "A Colorful Response to *The King James Only Controversy* Falls Way Short—James White Responds to Dr. Thomas Holland," Alpha and Omega Ministries, July 8, 1997, https://www.aomin.org/aoblog/king-james-onlyism/a-colorful-response-to-the-king-james-only-controversy-falls-way-short-james-white-responds-to-dr-thomas-holland/.

[509] G. Zuntz, *The Text of the Epistles: A Disquisition upon the Corpus Paulinum* (London: Oxford University Press, 1953), 55; Harry A. Sturz, *The Byzantine Text-Type and New Testament Textual Criticism* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 1984), 61, 145–59.

[510] James R. Royse, *Scribal Habits in Early Greek New Testament Papyri*, New Testament Tools, Studies and Documents 36 (Leiden: Brill, 2008), 734–35; E. C. Colwell, "Method in Evaluating Scribal Habits: A Study of P45, P66, P75," in *Studies in Methodology in Textual Criticism of the New Testament*, New Testament Tools and Studies 9 (Leiden: Brill, 1969), 118–19.

the text, then a shorter reading is at least as likely to be a loss as a longer reading is to be an addition.

Finally, the theory runs in one direction only. It imagines pious scribes who added the titles of Christ. It does not imagine impious men who removed them. Yet the Scripture warns of both: "If any man shall add unto these things… And if any man shall take away from the words of the book of this prophecy" (Rev. 22:18–19). Rome's own scholars at Rheims published a list of words they wanted out of the Greek text, and the modern critical text removed them.[511] Removal is as much a human act as addition, and it is not always pious.

Q24. "Which Textus Receptus?"

The same Alpha and Omega article asked, "Since the term Textus Receptus has been applied to a variety of Greek New Testament texts over the years, it could be legitimately asked, 'which Textus Receptus?'"[512]

The question is fair, and this book has answered it. The Received Text is a family of closely related printed editions, from Erasmus through Stephanus, Beza, and the Elzevirs. They differ in small matters. Beza's text departs from Stephanus's fourth edition only thirty-eight times by Reuss's count, and Scrivener found 252 places where the printed sources differ enough to affect the English rendering.[513] The King James translators weighed those differences and settled them, and in

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[511] "Preface to the Reader," *Rheims New Testament*, 17 (sec. 29).

[512] Smith, "Introduction to Textual Criticism: Part 8."

[513] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "Theodore Beza's Ten Editions of the New Testament" and "The King James Version a Variety of the Textus Receptus."

English the answer to "Which Textus Receptus?" is the text the King James Bible translates, because that is where we see the evidence of God's providence and preserving work.

The question has far more force when it is turned around. Which critical text? The twenty-sixth edition of the Nestle–Aland text introduced more than five hundred changes. The twenty-eighth changed the Catholic Letters in about three dozen places. The *Editio Critica Maior* changed Acts in fifty-two places. The sixth edition of the United Bible Societies' text differs from the fifth "in well over 100 places," and the twenty-ninth Nestle–Aland edition will follow it. And the modern versions do not always follow any of these; at 2 Peter 3:10 the ESV follows neither the Received Text nor the Nestle–Aland text it names as its base. The differences among the editions of the Received Text were settled four hundred years ago. The differences among the editions of the critical text are still being produced.

Q25. "Wasn't the Received Text built on a handful of late manuscripts?"

The revisers of 1881 said so in their preface. The printed editions behind the King James Bible, they wrote, "were founded for the most part on manuscripts of late date, few in number, and used with little critical skill."[514] The Alpha and

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[514] "Preface," in *The New Testament of Our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, Translated out of the Greek: Being the Version Set Forth A.D. 1611, Compared with the Most Ancient Authorities and Revised A.D. 1881* (New York: American Book Exchange, 1881), 3–4.

Omega article repeats the claim: the Received Text "is based on a relatively small collection of manuscripts."[515]

It is true that Erasmus found only a few Greek manuscripts ready for his use when he arrived at Basel in 1515. But Edward Hills showed that this is not the whole story. Erasmus "looked for manuscripts everywhere during his travels," borrowed them "from everyone he could," and probably brought notes from his earlier study, so that the Received Text "also included readings taken from others to which he had access." Hills added that "almost all the important variant readings known to scholars today were already known to Erasmus more than 460 years ago," and discussed in his notes.[516]

More important, the number of manuscripts on an editor's desk matters far less than the readings of those manuscripts. Hills concluded that "in all essentials the New Testament text first printed by Erasmus and later by Stephanus (1550) and Elzevir (1633) is in full agreement with the Traditional Text providentially preserved in the vast majority of the Greek New Testament manuscripts."[517] Consider what that means. Erasmus had only a handful of copies, but they were ordinary copies of the text the churches had been reading for centuries. When the manuscripts of the world were later gathered and counted, the readings of his few copies proved to be the readings of the many, in that they represented the Majority Text readings. As we have already shown, the Institute for New Testament

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[515] Smith, "Introduction to Textual Criticism: Part 8."

[516] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 8, under "The Greek Manuscripts Used by Erasmus" and "Erasmus' Notes—His Knowledge of Variant Readings and Critical Problems."

[517] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 4, under "The Preservation of the New Testament Text."

Textual Research in Münster now catalogues about 5,700 Greek manuscripts of the New Testament, and 80 to 95 percent of their readings agree with the Byzantine text that stands behind the Received Text.[518] Erasmus did not have thousands of manuscripts in his hands, but he had the readings and text of the thousands in his hands.

The modern critical text stands in exactly the opposite position. Its editors have the thousands in their hands, yet they lean on the readings of a few. By Gregory Lanier's count, the current Nestle–Aland text agrees fully with Codex Vaticanus about 96 percent of the time.[519] Kurt and Barbara Aland, whose names stood on that text for decades, placed the great mass of Byzantine manuscripts (Majority Text) in their Category V, "purely or predominantly Byzantine," and called them "irrelevant for textual criticism, at least for establishing the original form of the text."[520] So this is the contrast. Erasmus had few manuscripts but printed the text of the many. Modern editors have many manuscripts but print the text of the few. One manuscript that the churches did not use outweighs thousands that they did.

That is why a statement like the one Wesley Huff made in a 2026 interview is so misleading. He said the editions of Erasmus behind the King James Bible were "primarily built on 31 approximate manuscripts" that "go back to approximately the 11th century," while scholars today have "just over 5,000 more

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[518] INTF, "The Greek Manuscripts of the New Testament"; Pickering, *Identity of the New Testament Text IV*, 114–15; Hodges and Farstad, *Greek New Testament According to the Majority Text*, v–vi.

[519] Lanier, "Critical Editions of the Greek NT and OT," 62.

[520] Aland and Aland, *Text of the New Testament*, 106, 142.

Greek manuscripts," so that modern translations "take into account the breadth of the evidence." He then added, "And something like the Dead Sea Scrolls, right? . . . those were discovered between 1946 and 1957. And so, we just know more now."[521] What he says may not technically be a lie, yet still the listener walks away believing the opposite of the truth. He pictures thirty manuscripts behind the King James Bible and five thousand behind his modern version. In fact, most of those five thousand agree with the readings of the King James Bible, and the modern text sets them aside. The breadth of the evidence stands with the Received Text and KJV.

The appeal to new discoveries also leaves out the end of the story. The Dead Sea Scrolls are perhaps the greatest manuscript discovery since the King James Bible was translated, and, as we have already shown, they confirmed the Masoretic Hebrew text the King James translators used. Gleason Archer found the two Isaiah scrolls from the first cave word for word identical with our standard Hebrew Bible in more than 95 percent of their text, and Gregory Lanier, who does not hold the King James position, said of the Great Isaiah Scroll that there are a few differences, "but none of them are significant."[522] The very discovery offered as proof that "we just know more now" is one of the strongest witnesses that the Hebrew text behind the King

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[521] Wesley Huff, interview by Mikhaila Peterson, "Best Historical Argument for the Resurrection and Why Scholars Can't Dismiss It | Wesley Huff Ep 232," YouTube video, 10:22–10:38; 10:55–11:10; 11:38–11:46; 12:22–12:28, posted by Mikhaila Peterson, May 6, 2026, accessed September 30, 2026, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KSumq-kIlqg. Quotations follow YouTube's automatically generated transcript.

[522] Archer, *Survey of Old Testament Introduction*, 29; Lanier, "What the Septuagint Is and Isn't," 38:04–38:08.

James Old Testament was already there, carefully kept, before Christ was born. Yet it is the modern versions, not the King James Bible, that depart from that Hebrew text, as we have already seen, in favor of the Septuagint, a few divergent scrolls, other ancient versions, and at times pure conjecture.[523]

The New Testament discoveries tell the same story. As we have already shown, the papyri found in the last century, copies older than Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, have again and again carried readings the critics had thrown out as late. Zuntz found Byzantine readings "which previously were discarded as 'late'" already in Papyrus 46, and Sturz catalogued about 150 distinctively Byzantine readings with early papyrus support.[524] Papyrus 75, copied about A.D. 200, contains eight readings in Luke's closing chapters that Westcott and Hort had set aside as later additions, and the editors of the critical text afterward put them back.[525] The papyri did not leave the King James Bible behind. They caught the critics up to it.

This is the part left out when critics speak of how much more we have now. We do have more. But more manuscripts have meant more witnesses to the text of the King James Bible, and the greatest discovery of all confirmed its Old Testament. To tell believers that the King James Bible rests on thirty manuscripts while modern Bibles rest on the breadth of the evidence, and to stop there, is not merely incomplete; it is misleading and it

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[523] Waite, *Defending the King James Bible*, 59–60; New International Version, preface, viii–ix.

[524] Zuntz, *Text of the Epistles*, 55; Sturz, *Byzantine Text-Type*, 61, 145–59.

[525] Hills, *King James Version Defended*, chap. 5, sec. 2(b).

presents the evidence in a way that shows the opposite of what is true.

Q26. "Isn't the King James Bible full of 'false friends' that modern readers misunderstand?"

Mark Ward has made this argument widely known. He writes that "the biggest problem in understanding the KJV comes from 'false friends,' words that are still in common use but have changed meaning in ways that modern readers are highly unlikely to recognize." His leading example is Elijah's question, "How long halt ye between two opinions?" (1 Kings 18:21). Ward says that for years he assumed "halt" meant "stop," until the ESV's rendering, "How long will you go limping between two different opinions?" showed him that in 1611 "halt" meant "lame."[526]

Here is a simple way to handle a hard word, using "halt" in 1 Kings 18:21. First, read the whole verse and the verses around it. Second, look for the same word elsewhere in the King James Bible. Luke 14:21 puts "the halt" beside "the maimed" and "the blind," and Genesis 32:31 says Jacob "halted upon his thigh." Third, check a dictionary that gives older English meanings. Fourth, ask your pastor or Sunday school teacher. Often the first two steps are enough, and the Bible itself becomes the dictionary.

It is a good example, because the King James Bible explains the word itself. Ward himself points to the parable of the great

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[526] Mark Ward, *Authorized: The Use and Misuse of the King James Bible* (Bellingham, WA: Lexham Press, 2018), excerpted in "False Friends and Dead Words in the KJV," *Logos* (blog), February 16, 2018, https://www.logos.com/grow/false-friends-dead-words/.

supper, where the servant is to bring in "the poor, and the maimed, and the halt, and the blind" (Luke 14:21). The same word appears when the Lord says it is better "to enter into life halt or maimed" (Matt. 18:8), and when Jacob, after wrestling with the angel, "halted upon his thigh" (Gen. 32:31). The reader who reads his King James Bible through learns what "halt" means from the King James Bible. The cure for a false friend is more Bible reading, not a different Bible.

Every translation needs to be read carefully and taught faithfully. When Ezra read the law to the people, the Levites "read in the book in the law of God distinctly, and gave the sense, and caused them to understand the reading" (Neh. 8:8). When Philip found the Ethiopian reading Isaiah, he asked, "Understandest thou what thou readest?" and the man answered, "How can I, except some man should guide me?" (Acts 8:30–31). Modern versions do not remove this need. The ESV still asks its readers to understand "propitiation" (Rom. 3:25). As this book has shown, the King James Bible is not the obstacle its critics claim, and its plain, short words have served ordinary readers for four centuries.

A word whose meaning has shifted is a reason to teach the Bible, not a reason to replace it. A text whose words have been changed is another matter entirely.

CONCLUSION: THE WORD OF GOD ENDURETH FOREVER

Every controversy in church history ultimately returns to the question of authority. *By what standard do we measure truth?* In our generation, the battle over Bible versions is no different. On the surface it appears to be a debate about manuscripts, translations, and readability. But beneath all of that lies the fundamental issue: *Has God kept His promise to preserve His words?*

From the very beginning, the serpent's question has been the same: "*Yea, hath God said?*" (**Gen. 3:1**). The war on words did not begin in Alexandria, nor in the Reformation, nor in the nineteenth century; it began in Eden. And every time Satan raises that question, he seeks to drive a wedge between the believer and the Book upon which his faith rests.

A Faith That Begins with Scripture

Our faith is not founded on textual criticism, nor on the shifting sands of academic consensus. It is founded on the words of God.

- "*The words of the LORD are pure words… Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever*" (**Ps. 12:6–7**).
- "*Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away*" (**Matt. 24:35**).
- "*The word of the Lord endureth for ever*" (**1 Pet. 1:25**).

If these promises mean anything, they mean that the inspired words have not vanished. They remain, preserved, purified, and available for the people of God today.

The Two Lines in History

History confirms what Scripture declares: there are two streams of Bibles.

- The **line of Antioch**: the Received Text, the Masoretic Hebrew, the Byzantine Greek, quoted by the fathers, carried by the churches, preached in revival, and used by missionaries.

- The **line of Alexandria**: the speculative texts of Origen, the eclectic philosophies of the schools, manuscripts kept unused in libraries, riddled with contradictions and omissions.

The fruit of each line tells the story. Antioch's Bibles brought reformation, evangelism, and doctrinal clarity. Alexandria's manuscripts brought confusion, rationalism, and endless revision. By their fruits ye shall know them.

The second line did not stop at Alexandria. As this book has shown, it passed through Jerome to Rome, was defended at Trent and at Rheims, returned through Westcott and Hort and the Revision of 1881, and now stands in a Greek text edited with Rome's participation and read in Rome's Mass.

Doctrine at Stake

Time and again, the Alexandrian line diminishes Christ's deity, His blood, His virgin birth, His uniqueness as Saviour. Even when doctrine survives elsewhere, the cumulative pattern

erodes faith by subtraction. The Bible does not simply need to teach a doctrine somewhere; it needs to preserve *every word* God gave (**Matt. 4:4**).

The Myths Removed

- *Readability?* Proven false. The King James Bible averages an eighth-grade reading level, often lower than modern versions, with cadence designed for public clarity.

- *The Apocrypha?* The KJV set it apart as history, never as Scripture—unlike Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, which mingled it into the canon.

- *Revisions?* Only spelling and printing corrections. The text is the same today as it was in 1611.

- *Erasmus's so-called blunders?* Where critics claim he "added" to Revelation or "inserted" the Comma, history in fact shows preservation and purification, by faith. The church already used those readings, and later manuscript discoveries confirmed them.

Every major objection collapses under scrutiny.

God's Providence in English

The King James Bible is not inspired anew; it consists of inspired words that were preserved and purified. As God preserved His words through the Levites (**Rom. 3:2**), and as He multiplied and purified His Word through centuries of use, He has given us in English a Bible that carries forward the Masoretic Old Testament and the Received New Testament.

It is no accident that for nearly three centuries it was the one Bible God used to spark revival, plant churches, send missionaries, and shape the modern world. Other versions rise and fall in popularity, but the King James remains because the hand of God is upon it.

A Call to Confidence

The issue is not preference. It is faith. Either God preserved His words, or He did not. Either He purified them, or He abandoned them. Either we have a sure foundation, or we are left to the shifting theories of scholars.

The King James Bible stands as a testimony that God kept His promises. Its text is not the work of chance or mere scholarship; it is the fruit of God's guiding hand through history. It is the Bible that bears the marks of inspiration, preservation, purification, and power. With the principles laid out in the Bible itself, we are not left to guess; by faith, we can find that perfect Word of God today.

And so we say with David:

> *"Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever"* (**Ps. 119:160**).

Here, then, we rest: not on man's shifting opinions, but on the unchanging words of the living God.

The men who gave us the King James Bible understood why this matters. In their preface they wrote of the Scriptures:

> "If we be ignorant, they will instruct us; if out of the way, they will bring us home; if out of order, they will reform us; if in heaviness, comfort us; if dull, quicken

> us; if cold, inflame us. Tolle, lege; tolle, lege. Take up and read, take up and read the Scriptures."[527]

They closed with a warning that still speaks to every reader of this book:

> "Ye are brought unto fountains of living water which ye digged not; . . . do not cast earth into them . . . neither prefer broken pits before them. . . . Others have laboured, and you may enter into their labours. O receive not so great things in vain: O despise not so great salvation."[528]

We are not called to be textual critics but **Bible believers**. We believe not in the theories of men, but in the promise of God to preserve and purify His Word for every generation.

The Story's End

The young man in the pew began his journey confused and unsettled. He had heard the preaching of his pastor's conviction but then discovered the chilling disclaimer, "*in the originals.*" His heart ached: how could he build his life on a book he was told was no longer here?

But as his journey unfolded, he began to search the Scriptures themselves. There he found promise after promise: "*The words of*

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[527] "The Translators to the Reader" (1611), under "The Praise of the Holy Scriptures," in F. H. A. Scrivener, *The Authorized Edition of the English Bible (1611): Its Subsequent Reprints and Modern Representatives* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1884), 273.

[528] "The Translators to the Reader," under "Reasons Inducing Us Not to Stand Curiously upon an Identity of Phrasing," in Scrivener, *Authorized Edition*, 303.

the LORD are pure words… Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever" (**Ps. 12:6–7**). *"For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven"* (**Ps. 119:89**). *"Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away"* (**Matt. 24:35**). The Bible did not only speak of inspiration in the past; it declared preservation and purification in the present. God tied His own character to His words, magnifying His Word above His name (**Ps. 138:2**). The young man realized the Bible itself teaches that God's words still live, still endure, still remain pure.

The next question naturally followed: if God promised to preserve His words, *where* could they be found? History answered. He traced the line of faithful transmission through Antioch, the missionary hub of the early church, through the Byzantine manuscripts copied and used by believers for centuries, through the Masoretic tradition of the Old Testament, through the Received Text of the New Testament, and finally into the English of the King James Bible. He saw the contrast with Alexandria, where philosophy and textual tampering bred doubt and omissions. By their fruits he discerned the difference. By applying, in faith, the principles from the Word of God itself, he found the book he could trust.

His journey brought him to peace. The Bible in his lap was neither missing essential parts nor a puzzle only scholars could reconstruct. It was the purified, preserved Word of God. What began in confusion ended in clarity; what began in doubt ("Yea, hath God said?") ended in faith.

The young man could now say with confidence: *"This is the Word of God. Every word, every promise, every truth, kept by God Himself. I can live by it, raise my family by it, and trust my eternity to it."*

The journey ends where it must, with the believer living by faith ("the just shall live by faith"), able to please God ("without faith it is impossible to please him…"), resting in the living, preserved Word of the living God—to have and to hold.

"The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever." (**Isa. 40:8**)

ADDENDUM: OTHER DOCTRINALLY SIGNIFICANT CHANGES IN MODERN VERSIONS VS. THE KJV

Why This Addendum Is Included

The earlier chapter, "Doctrinal Issues (Why the 'Small' Changes Aren't Small)," presented several clear examples of differences between the King James Bible and modern versions. The purpose of this addendum is to provide a broader reference list.

This list is only a sample. Jack Moorman's *Early Manuscripts and the Authorized Version: A Closer Look* examines, with the manuscript evidence, 356 doctrinal passages affected by the differences between the Received Text and the Greek texts of Westcott and Hort and Nestle–Aland. D. A. Waite selected 158 of these for his own study of the doctrinal superiority of the King James Bible.[529]

It is sometimes said that no doctrine is affected by the differences between Bible versions, but that statement avoids the real issue. A doctrine may continue to be taught somewhere else while a particular verse's testimony to that doctrine is weakened, shortened, questioned, or removed. God did not merely promise to preserve enough verses for every major doctrine to survive somewhere. Man is to live "*by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God*" (**Matt. 4:4**).

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[529] D. A. Waite, *Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority – Texts, Translators, Technique, Theology*, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 167–68, e-book.

The Person and Work of Jesus Christ

Matthew 25:13

KJV:
"Watch therefore, for ye know neither the day nor the hour wherein the Son of man cometh."

NIV:
"Therefore keep watch, because you do not know the day or the hour."

Matthew 27:34

KJV:
"They gave him vinegar to drink mingled with gall: and when he had tasted thereof, he would not drink."

ESV:
"*They offered him wine to drink, mixed with gall…"*

Matthew 27:35

KJV:
"And they crucified him, and parted his garments, casting lots: that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophet, They parted my garments among them, and upon my vesture did they cast lots."

ESV:
"*And when they had crucified him, they divided his garments among them by casting lots.*"

Mark 6:11

KJV:
"And whosoever shall not receive you, nor hear you, when ye depart thence, shake off the dust under your feet for a testimony against them.

Verily I say unto you, It shall be more tolerable for Sodom and Gomorrha in the day of judgment, than for that city."

NIV:
The sentence concerning Sodom and Gomorrah and the day of judgment is omitted.

Mark 13:14

KJV:
"But when ye shall see the abomination of desolation, spoken of by Daniel the prophet, standing where it ought not…"

NIV:
"*When you see 'the abomination that causes desolation' standing where it does not belong…"*

Mark 15:28

KJV:
"And the scripture was fulfilled, which saith, And he was numbered with the transgressors."

NIV:
Verse omitted from the main text.

Mark 16:9–20

KJV:
Verses 9–20 appear as the continuous conclusion of the Gospel of Mark.

ESV:
The passage is set apart in brackets with a note stating that some of the earliest manuscripts do not include **Mark 16:9–20.**

Luke 4:4

KJV:
"*And Jesus answered him, saying, It is written, That man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word of God.*"

NIV:
"*Man shall not live on bread alone.*"

Luke 4:8

KJV:
"*And Jesus answered and said unto him, Get thee behind me, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve.*"

NASB:
The words "*Get thee behind me, Satan*" are omitted.

John 3:13

KJV:
"*And no man hath ascended up to heaven, but he that came down from heaven, even the Son of man which is in heaven.*"

ESV:
The words "*which is in heaven*" are omitted.

John 7:53–8:11

KJV:
The account of the woman taken in adultery appears as part of the continuous text.

ESV:
The passage is separated from the surrounding text with a note questioning its inclusion.

John 9:35

KJV:
"Jesus heard that they had cast him out; and when he had found him, he said unto him, Dost thou believe on the Son of God?"

ESV:
"*Do you believe in the Son of Man*?"

Entire Verses Omitted

Acts 28:29

KJV:
"And when he had said these words, the Jews departed, and had great reasoning among themselves."

NIV:
Verse omitted from the main text.

Romans 16:24

KJV:
"*The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen*."

NIV:
Verse omitted from the main text.

Christ's Sacrifice and Salvation

1 Corinthians 5:7

KJV:
"*Purge out therefore the old leaven, that ye may be a new lump, as ye are unleavened. For even Christ our passover is sacrificed for us.*"

ESV:
"*For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed.*"

1 Corinthians 11:24

KJV:
"*And when he had given thanks, he brake it, and said, Take, eat: this is my body, which is broken for you: this do in remembrance of me.*"

NASB:
"*This is My body, which is for you…*"

Galatians 3:17

KJV:
"*And this I say, that the covenant, that was confirmed before of God in Christ, the law, which was four hundred and thirty years after, cannot disannul…*"

ESV:
The words "*in Christ*" are omitted.

Galatians 4:7

KJV:
"Wherefore thou art no more a servant, but a son; and if a son, then an heir of God through Christ."

CSB:
"So you are no longer a slave but a son, and if a son, then God has made you an heir."

Ephesians 3:9

KJV:
"And to make all men see what is the fellowship of the mystery, which from the beginning of the world hath been hid in God, who created all things by Jesus Christ."

ESV:
"…God, who created all things."

Colossians 1:2

KJV:
"To the saints and faithful brethren in Christ which are at Colosse: Grace be unto you, and peace, from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ."

ESV:
"Grace to you and peace from God our Father."

Hebrews 1:3

KJV:
"…when he had by himself purged our sins, sat down on the right hand of the Majesty on high."

ESV:
"After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

1 Peter 2:2

KJV:
"*As newborn babes, desire the sincere milk of the word, that ye may grow thereby*."

NIV:
"*…so that by it you may grow up in your salvation*."

1 Peter 4:1

KJV:
"*Forasmuch then as Christ hath suffered for us in the flesh, arm yourselves likewise with the same mind…*"

ESV:
"*Since therefore Christ suffered in the flesh, arm yourselves with the same way of thinking…*"

1 John 4:3

KJV:
"*And every spirit that confesseth not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is not of God…*"

ESV:
"*…every spirit that does not confess Jesus is not from God…*"

Prophecy and the Last Things

2 Peter 3:10

KJV:
"*But the day of the Lord will come as a thief in the night; in the which the heavens shall pass away with a great noise, and the elements shall melt with fervent heat, the earth also and the works that are therein shall be burned up*."

NIV:
"*…the earth and everything done in it will be laid bare*."

Old Testament Differences

Psalm 8:5

KJV:
"*For thou hast made him a little lower than the angels, and hast crowned him with glory and honour*."

NASB:
"*Yet You have made him a little lower than God…*"

Additional Differences in Revelation

Revelation 2:15

KJV:
"*So hast thou also them that hold the doctrine of the Nicolaitans, which thing I hate*."

NASB:
"*So you too, have some who in the same way hold to the teaching of the Nicolaitans*."

Revelation 21:24

KJV:
"*And the nations of them which are saved shall walk in the light of it: and the kings of the earth do bring their glory and honour into it.*"

CSB:
"*The nations will walk by its light…*"

Revelation 22:14

KJV:
"*Blessed are they that do his commandments, that they may have right to the tree of life, and may enter in through the gates into the city.*"

ESV:
"*Blessed are those who wash their robes…*"

Revelation 22:19

KJV:
"*And if any man shall take away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God shall take away his part out of the book of life, and out of the holy city, and from the things which are written in this book.*"

NASB:
"*…God will take away his part from the tree of life and from the holy city…*"

Conclusion of the Addendum

Again and again, the King James Bible preserves:

- The full titles of Jesus Christ
- Direct statements of His deity

- References to His blood
- The substitutionary direction of His sacrifice
- Calls to repentance
- Instructions concerning prayer and fasting
- Fulfillment formulas connecting prophecy with history
- Explicit statements concerning judgment, hell, and eternity
- Complete narrative explanations
- The believer's duty to obey the words of God

The argument is not that a modern-version reader can learn nothing about these doctrines. Many modern versions teach them in other passages. The issue is that these exact words and passages belong where God placed them.

If God inspired every word, then every word matters.

If God promised to preserve His words, then their removal cannot be dismissed as inconsequential.

PROMISES OF SCRIPTURE

Psalm 12:6–7 — *The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever.*

Psalm 78:1–8 — *Give ear, O my people, to my law: incline your ears to the words of my mouth. I will open my mouth in a parable: I will utter dark sayings of old: Which we have heard and known, and our fathers have told us. We will not hide them from their children, shewing to the generation to come the praises of the LORD, and his strength, and his wonderful works that he hath done. For he established a testimony in Jacob, and appointed a law in Israel, which he commanded our fathers, that they should make them known to their children: That the generation to come might know them, even the children which should be born; who should arise and declare them to their children: That they might set their hope in God, and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments: And might not be as their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation; a generation that set not their heart aright, and whose spirit was not stedfast with God.*

Psalm 105:8 — *He hath remembered his covenant for ever, the word which he commanded to a thousand generations.*

Psalm 119:89 — *For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven.*

Psalm 119:111 — *Thy testimonies have I taken as an heritage for ever: for they are the rejoicing of my heart.*

Psalm 119:152 — *Concerning thy testimonies, I have known of old that thou hast founded them for ever.*

Psalm 119:160 — *Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever.*

Proverbs 22:20–21 — *Have not I written to thee excellent things in counsels and knowledge, That I might make thee know the certainty of the words of truth; that thou mightest answer the words of truth to them that send unto thee?*

Matthew 5:17–18 — *Think not that I am come to destroy the law, or the prophets: I am not come to destroy, but to fulfil. For verily I say unto you, Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled.*

John 10:34–36 — *Jesus answered them, Is it not written in your law, I said, Ye are gods? If he called them gods, unto whom the word of God came, and the scripture cannot be broken; Say ye of him, whom the Father hath sanctified, and sent into the world, Thou blasphemest; because I said, I am the Son of God?*

Psalm 82:1–6 — *God standeth in the congregation of the mighty; he judgeth among the gods. How long will ye judge unjustly, and accept the persons of the wicked? Selah. Defend the poor and fatherless: do justice to the afflicted and needy. Deliver the poor and needy: rid them out of the hand of the wicked. They know not, neither will they understand; they walk on in darkness: all the foundations of the earth are out of course. I have said, Ye are gods; and all of you are children of the most High.*

1 Peter 1:23–25 — *Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever. For all flesh is as grass, and all the glory of man as the flower of grass. The grass withereth, and the flower thereof falleth away: But the word of the Lord endureth for ever. And this is the word which by the gospel is preached unto you.*

John 12:48 with Revelation 20:11–13 — *He that rejecteth me, and receiveth not my words, hath one that judgeth him: the word that I have spoken, the same shall judge him in the last day. And I saw a*

great white throne, and him that sat on it, from whose face the earth and the heaven fled away; and there was found no place for them. And I saw the dead, small and great, stand before God; and the books were opened: and another book was opened, which is the book of life: and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works. And the sea gave up the dead which were in it; and death and hell delivered up the dead which were in them: and they were judged every man according to their works.

Psalm 102:12 — *But thou, O LORD, shalt endure for ever; and thy remembrance unto all generations.*

Isaiah 59:21 — *As for me, this is my covenant with them, saith the LORD; My spirit that is upon thee, and my words which I have put in thy mouth, shall not depart out of thy mouth, nor out of the mouth of thy seed, nor out of the mouth of thy seed's seed, saith the LORD, from henceforth and for ever.*

Psalm 105:5 with John 17:17 — *Remember his marvellous works that he hath done; his wonders, and the judgments of his mouth; Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth.*

Luke 21:33 — *Heaven and earth shall pass away: but my words shall not pass away.*

Luke 16:16–17 — *The law and the prophets were until John: since that time the kingdom of God is preached, and every man presseth into it. And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass, than one tittle of the law to fail.*

Isaiah 40:8 — *The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever.*

Psalm 33:11 — *The counsel of the LORD standeth for ever, the thoughts of his heart to all generations.*

Psalm 117 — *O praise the LORD, all ye nations: praise him, all ye people. For his merciful kindness is great toward us: and the truth of the LORD endureth for ever. Praise ye the LORD.*

Deuteronomy 7:9 — *Know therefore that the LORD thy God, he is God, the faithful God, which keepeth covenant and mercy with them that love him and keep his commandments to a thousand generations;*

Psalm 135:13 with 138:2 — *Thy name, O LORD, endureth for ever; and thy memorial, O LORD, throughout all generations. I will worship toward thy holy temple, and praise thy name for thy lovingkindness and for thy truth: for thou hast magnified thy word above all thy name.*

1 Chronicles 16:14–15 — *He is the LORD our God; his judgments are in all the earth. Be ye mindful always of his covenant; the word which he commanded to a thousand generations;*

Proverbs 4:1–11 — *Hear, ye children, the instruction of a father, and attend to know understanding. For I give you good doctrine, forsake ye not my law. For I was my father's son, tender and only beloved in the sight of my mother. He taught me also, and said unto me, Let thine heart retain my words: keep my commandments, and live. Get wisdom, get understanding: forget it not; neither decline from the words of my mouth. Forsake her not, and she shall preserve thee: love her, and she shall keep thee. Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding. Exalt her, and she shall promote thee: she shall bring thee to honour, when thou dost embrace her. She shall give to thine head an ornament of grace: a crown of glory shall she deliver to thee. Hear, O my son, and receive my sayings; and the years of thy life shall be many. I have taught thee in the way of wisdom; I have led thee in right paths.*

Psalm 19:7–11 — *The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul: the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple. The*

statutes of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart: the commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes. The fear of the LORD is clean, enduring for ever: the judgments of the LORD are true and righteous altogether. More to be desired are they than gold, yea, than much fine gold: sweeter also than honey and the honeycomb. Moreover by them is thy servant warned: and in keeping of them there is great reward.

Psalm 18:30 — *As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all those that trust in him.*

Proverbs 30:5–6 — *Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him. Add thou not unto his words, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar.*

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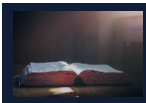
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